PATROLOGIA

BEITRÄGE ZUM STUDIUM
DER KIRCHENVÄTER

XXXIII

MAURICIO SAAVEDRA MONROY

THE CHURCH OF SMYRNA

HISTORY AND THEOLOGY OF A PRIMITIVE CHRISTIAN COMMUNITY



PETER LANG
EDITION

This book deals with the theology of the Church of Smyrna from its foundation up to the Council of Nicaea in 325. The author provides a critical historical evaluation of the documentary sources and certain aspects particularly deserving of discussion. He makes a meticulous study of the history of the city, its gods and institutions, the set-up of the Jewish and Christian communities and the response of the latter to the imperial cult. Finally, he undertakes a detailed analysis both of the reception of the Hebrew Scriptures and the apostolic traditions, as well as examining the gradual historical process of the shaping of orthodoxy and the identity of the community in the light of the organisation of its ecclesial ministries, its sacramental life and the cult of its martyrs.

Mauricio Saavedra Monroy is an Augustinian priest. He holds a doctoral degree in Theology and Patristic Studies. He teaches Patristics in the Institutum Patristicum Augustinianum of Rome and Saint Augustine Cervantina University of Bogota.

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The Church of Smyrna

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BEITRÄGE ZUM STUDIUM DER KIRCHENVÄTER

Herausgegeben von
Andreas Spira†, Hubertus R. Drobner, Christoph Klock

Band XXXIII

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Preface

Early Christian Studies have suffered considerably from a tendency to regards texts as culturally insulated from their social and intellectual environments in Hellenistic culture. The witness of the early Fathers and Martyrologies, such as those of Polycarp and of Pionius, and the surviving Ignatian and Polycarpian texts, in combination with fragments in Irenaeus, has long been treated as a development sui generis with little relationship to cultural background. Mauricio Saavedra, in this ground breaking study arising from his work and collaboration at the Augustinian Patristics Institute in Rome, has crucially challenged this failure of previous research.

Saavedra painstakingly reconstructs from earlier sources both the literary Christian and Pagan background to Smyrna, and proceeds to integrate that literature within a comprehensive and perceptive picture of the general development of Smyrna as a Hellenistic and then Roman city. His work, as a young scholar of the highest promise, cannot be underestimated in its ability to lead us in new directions in the study of Early Christian History.

Allen Brent
King's College, London

Acknowledgments

My interest in the Church of Smyrna was first aroused following a suggestion made by the man who is now Cardinal Prosper Grech, OSA, who some years ago offered me his support and great academic experience in the study and exploration in depth of a theme related to the rich cultural and religious world of Asia Minor in the early centuries of Christianity. Thus it is that, after reading the book by Paul Trebilco on the Christians of Ephesus up to the time of Ignatius, the idea came to me of studying the history and theology of the Christian community of Smyrna in depth, which acted as a sister and on occasion even rivaled of Ephesus itself. To Cardinal Prosper Grech, I owe all the company provided throughout this rigorous itinerary of research, and I wish to express to him in a special way my gratitude for these years of academic and spiritual guidance.

This academic work has benefited inestimably from the opportune and substantial contributions of Professor Manlio Simonetti, who very generously decided to put his vast academic experience in the field of the history and literature of early Christianity at my disposal, and who with thoughtful diligence revised all my notes, making adequate corrections and suggestions. My sincere gratitude and admiration go to him.

Likewise, from my very first steps in the research, Professor Emanuela Prinzivalli evinced her generous interest in helping me throughout this whole process, offering me her invaluable academic experience, reading my notes with attention, and suggesting a vast updated bibliography to me. May I extend to her my sincere thanks for these years of committed academic guidance.

I am extremely grateful to all the academic community of the Institutum Patristicum, and first and foremost to the person of its President Fr. Robert Dodaro, Fr. Juan Antonio Cabrera, Fr. Antonio Gaytan of the library service, and Fr. Amado Llorente of the General Secretariat. In the same way I am especially grateful to the community of the Saint Monica International College which over the years has offered me its fraternal and spiritual space in order to carry out my academic work.

My personal gratitude goes to the Order of Saint Augustine, and especially to the Province of Nuestra Señora de Gracia of Colombia, for having generously subsidised all my studies and my stay in Rome during these years.

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Mauricio Saavedra, OSA
Rome 2015

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Abbreviations

CCL	*Corpus Christianorum, Series Latina*
CIG	*Corpus inscriptionum Graecarum*
ed.	edited by
ed. Tr.	translated edition
et. al.	*et alii*
GCS	*Die Griechischen Christlichen Schriftsteller*
GLNT	*Grande Lessico del Nuovo Testamento*
NDPAC	*Nuovo Dizionario Patristico e di Antichità Cristiane*
PL	*Patrologia Latina*
PG	*Patrologia Graeca*
praef.	preface
SCh	*Sources Chrétiennes*
s(s).	et seq(q)
v(v).	verse(s)
v. gr.	*verbi gratia*

Introduction

The in-depth study of a local historical reality has proven to be extremely useful for a better understanding of a broader and more complex universe, such as the spread of Christianity in the early centuries of its history. A revealing particular of this conviction has been the recent study of the Christian community of Ephesus carried out by Paul Trebilco, *The Early Christians in Ephesus from Paul to Ignatius* (2004), who, undertaking an analysis of the sources reporting on the Christian presence in Ephesus from the times of Paul up to Ignatius of Antioch, has succeeded, not only in highlighting the weaknesses and strengths of many of the earlier theories on the spread of Christianity[1], but above all offered scholars, a detailed description of the Christian community in the Roman capital of Asia Minor.

So that, on noting the importance of a study of this kind and clearly showing that on the city of Smyrna, the second city in importance of the Roman province of Asia in the early centuries of Christianity, and in many ways an evident rival of Ephesus both at civil and ecclesiastical level, no publication exists similar to that undertaken by P. Trebilco for the city of Ephesus, it is my intention to make a historical and theological study of the community of Smyrna from its foundation up to the Council of Nicaea.

Moreover, a study of historical nature only, omitting the theological aspect of the city of Smyrna, from its foundation in an age dating back to before the Hittites until the beginning of the fourth century, was carried out as far back as 1938 by P. Cadoux in *Ancient Smyrna*. The study by this author, although conscientious with regards to the historical aspects, concentrated on the history of the city prior to the Christian era, and of course without considering all the discoveries and debates, which during the twentieth century and the beginning of the twenty-first have enriched the history and theology of early Christianity. For the rest, of course many studies exist, both ancient and more recent, on the sub-apostolic age in general and on certain sources related to the Church of Smyrna in particular. Nevertheless, there is no detailed monographic study which makes direct and in-depth reference to the community of Smyrna in the first centuries of Christianity. So that this is the investigative contribution which we wish to make to the academic community dealing with the history and theology of very early Christianity.

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1 More especially P. Trebilco revised the thesis of W. Bauer, *Orthodoxy and Heresy in Earliest Christianity,* Philadelphia 1971.

On the basis of a preliminary study of the sources, it is clear that the Christian community of Smyrna is an important community of early Christianity. In fact, it is to Smyrna that one of the letters in the *Revelation* is addressed insofar as it boasts an apostolic origin connected with the figure of John, counts on the great figure of her martyred bishop Polycarp, the significant stay of Ignatius of Antioch on his way to Rome, being the native city of Irenaeus' mother, its important relations with other communities of the Christian world in Asia, Greece, Gaul and Rome, and its defence of the Quartodecimanist Easter, the interesting copyist and textual production effected by the community, with its important role in the controversy with Docetism, Marcionism, the New Prophesy, and the Patripasian doctrine of Noetus, among many other particulars.

The historical delimitation of this study on Smyrna, from the foundation of the Christian community up to the Council of Nicaea, in addition to being taken as a usual limit in patristic studies, in the case of Smyrna, also becomes a documentary limit since subsequent to the Council in the year 325 no further information is forthcoming on this community.

For this study on the community of Smyrna we have identified a considerable number of direct and indirect sources which will be presented and analysed in the first part, together with the presentation of a number of sources and themes deserving of particular discussion. In this study we do not claim to deal exhaustively with the discussion of the authenticity, transmission and textual criticism of each one of the sources themselves, since, as mentioned earlier, abundant commentaries are available on most of them, and accordingly we will point out in due course critical editions and particular studies. Our aim here will be to indicate only the broader consensus about the era, the author, the occasion and the content of these, with a view to their further use for the reconstruction of the history and theology of the Christian community.

In the second part of our research, it is our intention to study the history of the community in the framework of the city which at the beginnings of the Christian era, was a part of the all-important province of Asia, known for being the most populous and richest of the Roman provinces and which enjoyed a vibrant literary and cultural experience famous for the Second Sophistic. Together with the formation of the pagan roots of the city and the important role in the social life of the Jewish community, we will especially study the way in which the Christians of Smyrna relate to these two realities and the configuration of the leaders of the Christian community. Then, lastly, we will study the history of the latter in the face of the imperial cult and the persecutions.

In the third part of our study, we propose to analyse the presence and appraisal of Scripture in the sources presented in the first part, especially those

concerning the period prior to the fixing of the canon and to full acceptance of the Hebrew Scriptures as heritage of the church, that is to say, up to the end of the second century. So that, we will study the reception of the Hebrew Scriptures and of the apostolic tradition, in particular the Pauline, the synoptic and the Johannine, by Ignatius, Polycarp and the author of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp*.

Lastly, in the context of the formation of orthodoxy in the face of various groups and trends, we will analyse the gradual process whereby the content of the faith of the Church of Smyrna is precisely formulated and made binding starting from the development of the *lex orandi* and the *lex credendi*. Finally, we will study the sacramental and spiritual life of the community, concerning ourselves more particularly with the gradual development of the conception that the community of Smyrna forms of itself as a particular Church and in relation to the other church communities, the configuration of its hierarchical and ministerial structure, the development of reflection on penance, the sacrament of the Eucharist, the celebration of Easter and the cult of its martyrs.

One limit of our research has to do with the relative scarcity of sources, as in part is usual in studies of early Christianity. With regard to the sources, it is necessary to point out that, although we possess a fair number of documents providing information on the history and Christian theology on the Aegean coast of Asia Minor in the first half of the second century, this documentation diminishes considerably in the second half of that century, and is truly scarce for a large part of the third century. Nevertheless, in the midst of this generalised documentary penumbra in Asia Minor in the third century, we possess some sources of great value on Smyrna in this century, which enable us to at least make certain considerations, clearly taking care not to make erroneous generalisations. Even so, the absence of Asian literature for almost the whole of the third century does not signify that in those communities, including Smyrna, discussion on doctrinal, exegetic, ecclesial and other matters did not continue, although certainly this absence may in part signify an important decrease in the cultural propensity of the region prior to the Council of Nicaea.

We hope that the study of all these different historical, theological and ecclesial aspects will permit us to perceive in some way the particular appearance of the Christian community of Smyrna in the first few centuries of its existence and its importance in the history of early Christianity.

Part One
Presentation of the Sources

Introduction

For the study of the community of Smyrna in the early centuries of the Christian era, we have identified a sufficient number of direct and indirect sources deserving to be presented and analysed in this first part. We make no attempt to undertake an exhaustive discussion of these with regard to their authenticity, transmission and textual criticism, for which we refer the reader directly to the critical editions cited in the footnotes. Our aim is merely to situate the period, the author, the occasion and the content of the latter with a view to their further use for the reconstruction of the history and theology of the Christian community of Smyrna. We will also make an appraisal of individual texts which have been related recently to the Church of Smyrna, and finally we will analyse the possibility of the existence of one or more literary undertakings in the early centuries which attempted to gather together the writings of the community, especially those connected with the figure of Polycarp[2].

2 The enunciation of the authors and Christian sources will be presented in this first part adopting the Latin terminology of the *Clavis Patrum.* Whereas the abbreviations have been taken from G. Lampe, *A Patristic Greek Lexicon,* Oxford 1961, for the Greek Christian authors; from H. Liddell – R. Scott – H. Jones, *A Greek-English Lexicon,* Oxford 1996, for the classic Greek authors; and from the *Thesaurus linguae Latinae,* Leipzig 1990, for the Latin authors. The biblical quotations are given using the Latin abbreviations.

Chapter I: Analysis of the direct sources

We have singled out 13 sources which we consider direct in the sense that they are privileged first-hand testimonies which inform us on the situation of the community of Smyrna in the early centuries of the Christian era.

1. Epistula ad ecclesiam Smyrnaeam (Rv 2, 8–11)

This letter is the second and shortest of the seven messages which the revealer communicates to John the Seer in his epiphany[3]. It is improbable that these messages at some time existed in an independent form as authentic letters, since they do not assume the literary form of ancient letters. Rather, they are in the nature of prophetic discourses describing the reality of each church, included within the general plan of the *Revelation,* in the midst of a liturgical context.

Like all of the seven messages, the letter to the Church of Smyrna begins with a formula of prophetic commission and a knowledge of the situation of the community by the revealer. It appears clear in the message that the recipients were in danger of being imprisoned by the Roman authorities. The letter makes reference to the poverty of the community in contrast with its spiritual wealth. The reference to the local Jewish community as "synagogue of Satan" probably indicates the hostility and local conflict existing between Jews and Christians[4]. Verse ten suggests that the Jews had accused John's followers before the Roman authorities[5]. At the end the letter affirms that those who persevere despite persecution will not suffer the "second death"[6].

---

3 The seven places mentioned (Ephesus, Smyrna, Pergamum, Thyatira, Sardis, Philadelphia and Laodicea) are situated correlatively to one of the principal highways of the Roman Empire. So that this *Apocalpsis,* in the form of a circular letter, could perhaps have been easily carried from one place to another, cf. W. Ramsay, *The Letters of the Seven Churches of Asia,* New York 1904, 12.

4 There is also mention of some who "call themselves Jews but are not". This expression may be understood as a reference to judaising Christians or a rhetorical argumentation whereby doubt is thrown on the right of the local Jewish community to call itself "Jewish". Basically the idea is that from now on the true Israel is the Church of Christ, cf. *Gal* 6, 16; *Rom* 9, 8, cf. A. Runesson, *The Ancient Synagogue from its Origins to 200 C.E.,* Leyden 2008, 146–147.

5 As we also see in *Ac* 17, 1–9.

6 *Rv* 2, 11. Probably this expression makes reference to the death of the soul, or to eternal punishment, cf. *Mt* 10, 28.

This text is undoubtedly the first direct source we possess of the history of the Christian community in Smyrna at the end of the first century or beginning of the second century[7].

2. Ignatius Antiochenus, Epistula ad Smyrnaeos[8]

It is not our intention in this part of the study to deal with the problem of the transmission of the *corpus Ignatianum*[9]. We will be developing the question of Ignatius when speaking of the indirect sources in the second chapter of this part. Here we will merely deal with the circumstance of the composition of this letter *To the Smyrnaeans.* This may be found in the middle review[10], considered to be

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7 For a detailed study of the letter in the biblical and extrabiblical context, cf. C. Hemer, *The Letters to the Seven Churches of Asia in their Local Setting*, Michigan 2001, 57–77; P. Pringent, *L'Apocalypse de Saint Jean,* Geneva 2001, 125–129; D. Aune, *Revelation 1–5* (World Biblical Commentary 52) Waco 1997, 156–176.

8 The letters of Ignatius (Ign.), together with the letter of Polycarp (Polyc.) *To the Philippians* (*ep.*) and the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* (*M. Polyc.*) have been ed. Th. Camelot, *Ignace d'Antioche, Polycarpe de Smyrne, Lettres. Martyre de Polycarpe* (SCh 10), Paris 1969[4], offering the text of the edition of F. Funk, Tübingen 1924[4]. Recently M. Simonetti and E. Prinzivalli have published an edition together with the translation and commentary in Italian of the letters of Ignatius. We have used this edition for the Greek text of all the letters of Ignatius, M. Simonetti – E. Prinzivalli, *Seguendo Gesù, Testi Cristiani delle Origini,* vol. 1, Rome 2010.

9 The letters of Ignatius were appreciated and circulated in the first three centuries of Christianity, but with the more solid and refined heritage of the fourth century these letters were progressively forgotten or modified in accordance with new requirements. The Middle Ages knew a falsified Ignatius rather than an authentic Ignatius. The Reform of the sixteenth century had as referential pre-Nicene authors only: Tertullian, Irenaeus and Origen, ignoring, among others, the Ignatian writings, which were rediscovered and edited later as from the sixteenth to the nineteenth century. In discussions over these centuries, the letters of Ignatius, due to their insistence on the bishop's authority, were a source of debate between Catholics and Protestants, with both groups assuming positions on the different reviews to favour their respective approaches. As from that century, the letters of Ignatius came to form part of the subsequent editions which gathered the writings of the so-called "Apostolic Fathers", an editorial construction of artificial nature since from the outset writings expressing completely different positions were present on central themes such as Judaism. For a more detailed study on the history of the reception of the Ignatian letters, cf. M. Simonetti–E. Prinzivalli, *Seguendo Gesù,* XII–XV, 279–291.

10 The middle review contains seven letters: *To the Magnesians, To the Trallians, To the Philadelphians, To the Smyrnaeans, To Polycarp, To the Ephesians* and *To the Romans.*

that which offers us the authentic letters of Ignatius of Antioch, and which is testified to by Eusebius of Caesarea in his *Historia Ecclesiastica*[11].

This letter may be found among the seven letters written by Ignatius, bishop of the Christian community of Antioch in Syria, a community which already as from the *Acts of the Apostles,* already appears as an important centre of irradiation of Christianity in the first century[12]. Ignatius was already considered famous in Antiquity not only for his Antiochean episcopate, his letters, and his martyrdom in Rome, but also for his relationship with the apostles[13].

According to the testimony of Eusebius[14] and of Ignatius himself,[15] this letter was written from Troas,[16] having recourse to the deacon Burrhus[17] as his secretary.

All of them with a more concise text than that of the long review. In order to examine in detail the characteristics of the short, middle and long reviews, cf. J. Ayán Calvo, *Ignacio de Antioquía, Policarpo de Esmirna, Carta de la Iglesia de Esmirna*, Madrid 1999, 40–44.

11 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 3, 36, 5–6. All the texts in Greek of the *Historia Eclesiástica (h.e.)* have been taken from the edition of G. Bardy, SCh 41, 1955.

12 Cf. *Act* 11, 26. For an important study on Ignatius and the Church of Antioch, cf. V. Corwin, *St. Ignatius and the Christianity in Antioch,* New Haven 1960, 31–51.

13 Both Origen and Eusebius give us the news that Ignatius was the second to obtain the succession of Peter in the episcopate of Antioch, cf. Or., *hom.,* 6 in *Lk* 4 (SCh 87, 144); cf. Eus., *h. e.* 3, 36, 1–2. The *Apostolic Constitutions,* a late and not very reliable collection of traditions, give a different picture, since in them Peter expresses himself in the following way: "In Antioch Evodius [was established] by me, Peter, and Ignatius [was established] by Paul", *Const. App.* 7, 46 (SCh 336, 108).

14 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 3, 36, 2. Eusebius tells us that he also wrote a letter from Troad *To the Philadelphians* and *To Polycarp,* bishop of Smyrna.

15 Cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 12, 1.

16 We must take care not to confuse Troad, which is the northern region of the Roman province of Asia whose central town is Troas, with the city of Tralles in this same Roman province, to which a letter is addressed by Ignatius (*To the Trallians)* which later took the name of Caesarea and is the present-day Turkish city of Aydin.

17 In *Eph.,* 2, 1, Ignatius refers to Burrhus as deacon, companion in slavery (σύνδουλος). In *Philad.,* 11, 2, Ignatius states that Burrhus has been sent by the community of Ephesus and Smyrna to serve as his travel companion. Σύνδουλος is a term that Ignatius uses to designate deacons, cf. *Magn.,* 2; *Philad.,* 4; *Smyrn.,* 12, 2. This has led some to consider Ignatius as a deacon and not as a bishop. Cf. E. Bruston, *Ignace d'Antioche: ses épîtres, sa vie, sa théologie,* Paris 1897, 31–35. J. Ruis-Camps, *The Four authentic Letters of Ignatius the Martyr,* Rome 1979 35–37. In particular, J. Ruis-Camps has elaborated a curious hypothesis on the basis of this term, but has been vigorously contested by certain scholars, cf. J. Ayán Calvo, 60–64. We do not believe that Ignatius was merely a deacon when he passed through Asia Minor for the following reasons: In *Rom.,* 2, 2, Ignatius presents himself as a bishop; in *Trall.*, 2, 3, he does not

Bearing in mind the date of the martyrdom of Ignatius in Rome[18], this letter, like the other six, must have been written more or less in the second decade of the second century[19].

The relationship of Ignatius with the community of Smyrna would appear to have been very close. In fact, in his long journey from Antioch to Rome, Smyrna was the city in Asia Minor in which Ignatius spent the longest time. If we accept the authenticity of the middle review, the periplus of the martyrial journey of Ignatius could be as follows: First, he took a boat from Antioch in Syria to a port on the south-east coast of Asia Minor, undoubtedly as was usual in this route to Rome, the stop would have been at Ephesus, capital of the Roman province, and from there he would have embarked for the capital of the Empire[20]. But the group[21] crossed towards the north, skirting the crests of the mountains of Tmolus, passing by the community of Philadelphia[22] and probably arriving in Smyrna towards the month of August[23]. Once in Smyrna, Ignatius received the solidarity and support of the community and of its bishop Polycarp. There he received the visit of Christians coming from Ephesus, Magnesia and Tralles, who undoubtedly had hoped

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seem to identify himself with the deacons, but speaks of them in the third person; it would be difficult to think that an Ignatius deacon would write the letter *To Polycarp,* a bishop, in the almost authoritarian terms in which he writes. Besides, the expression σύνδουλος admits of other explanations bearing in mind the spiritual inclination of Ignatius who at all times presents himself as the last of them all, cf. *Eph.,* 21, 2: *Magn.,* 11, *Philad.,* 11, 2; for the rest, Paul had used the term in this sense, cf. *Col.,* 1, 7: 4, 7.

18 Today the general consensus tends to accept that the days of Ignatius coincided more or less with the government of Trajan (98–117), cf. R. Grant, *The Apostolic Fathers. A New Translation and Commentary. I: An Introduction,* New York 1964, 48.

19 Cf. M. Simonetti – E. Prinzivalli, *Seguendo Gesù,* XII–XV, 290–291.

20 It is also possible that the itinerary from Antioch in Syria to Smyrna was overland, bearing in mind that when Ignatius writes to the community of Philadelphia in Lydia, which is an inland city of Asia Minor, he also let it be understood that in his itinerary he passed through that city. The possibility has also been proposed of a journey from Antioch to a southern port of Asia Minor, then from there by land to Smyrna, cf. W. Schoedel, *Ignatius of Antioch,* Philadelphia 1985, 11.

21 Ignatius was accompanied by Zosimus and Rufus, future martyrs, cf. Polyc., *ep*., 9, 1. From Syria, Ignatius is attached day and night to "ten leopards". In other words, to a platoon of soldiers, cf. Ign., *Rom.,* 5, 1. Philo and Rheus Agathopus were also possibly with Ignatius for a large part of the journey, cf. Ign., *Philad.,* 11, 1.

22 There Ignatius had the opportunity of meeting up with Christians from the city, cf. Ign., *Philad.,* 1, 1.

23 He states that he is writing to the Romans from Smyrna nine days before the calends of September, according to our calendar 24th August, Ign., *Rom.,* 1, 3.

to offer him hospitality on his way through those communities, accordingly from Smyrna he sent letters with them for the three communities. At this same time, he wrote to the church of Rome. After leaving the city, his next stop was at Troas, a seaside town to the north of Smyrna, where he apparently stayed only a short time[24]. In Troas, he heard that the church of Antioch had achieved peace so that later he wrote from there *To the Philadelphians, To the Smyrnaeans* and *To Polycarp* to thank them for the welcome he had received on passing through those lands and to ask them to send out a messenger to the Church of Antioch[25]. After that the group of prisoners continued by sea, stopping off at Neapolis, a Macedonian port not far from Philippi. From then on we know nothing more about the itinerary of Ignatius[26]. He probably died a martyr in the capital of the Empire, as he himself hoped; however, we do not have any certain knowledge of this event[27].

So that, as we may observe from the itinerary described, the community of Smyrna finds itself at the centre of his journey, for the time he spends in it, for the profound friendships he establishes with its members, and for the opportunity he has from there of coming into personal and written contact with Christians of other communities.

In the text addressed to this community we find fundamentally two motivations for writing this letter: the first has to do with the instruction of Ignatius to the community to not receive or to enter into contact with a certain group of Docetists[28]. The second reason, as referred to earlier, is to ask the community to

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24 His stay in Troas ended abruptly since he had to leave for Neapolis, the port of Philippi in Macedonia, cf. Ign., *Polyc.,* 8, 1.

25 An interesting commentary states that Ignatius wrote these three letters in a single day, cf. G. Joussard, *Les épîtres expédiées de Troas par saint Ignace d'Antioche ont-elles été dictées le même jour en une série continue?,* in *Memorial, J. Chaine,* Lyons 1950, 213–221.

26 Presumibly the group took the *Via Egnatia* to Dyrrachium and from there one of the usual routes to Rome, cf. W. Schoedel, *Ignatius of Antioch,* 11.

27 Polycarp presumes that Ignatius died a martyr, cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 9, 2. The same supposition existed in the times of Eusebius, who reports the news, cf. Eus., *ep.,* 3, 36, 3.

28 Cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 4, 1. The Docetists are the obvious and public enemies of Ignatius. From the sources there is no reason to think that he also attacks the Valentinians. If he had done so, he would have acted in an explicit way, in accordance with his personality, and not in a cryptic way as R.M. Hübner maintains, *Thesen zur Echtheit und Datierung der sieben Briefe des Ignatius von Antiochen,* in *Zeitschrift für Antikes Christentum,* I, Berlin 1997, 44–72. M. Simonetti makes a blunt criticism of Hüber's thesis, cf. M. Simonetti – E. Prinzivalli, *Seguendo Gesù,* 288–290.

send out an ambassador of God (θεοπρεσβύτην)[29] with a letter congratulating the brothers and sisters of Antioch for having achieved peace[30].

The structure of the letter may be the following:

- Confession of the orthodox faith: 1, 1–3, 3.
- Putting on guard against Docetism: 4, 1–7,
- Authority of the bishop: 8, 1–9, 1.
- Thanks for hospitality: 9, 2–10, 2.
- Request and greetings: 11, 1–13, 2.

Now is not the time to consider in detail all the abundant elements we can recover from this text. Suffice it to point out that this letter, on account of everything referred earlier from the point of view of the context in which it was written and the themes glimpsed in this structure is a source of first order for establishing the characteristics of the community of Smyrna at the beginning of the second century.

3. Ignatius Antiochenus, Epistula ad Polycarpum

The letter *To Polycarp,* which is also found in the middle review, is the only one addressed to one person in particular[31]. This letter addressed to the bishop of the community of Smyrna, was written by Ignatius shortly after having written *To the Smyrnaeans*. Clearly, Ignatius desired to address the whole community once more, this time through its bishop. This clearly emerges in paragraph six, when Ignatius does not address only Polycarp but the whole community once more. Undoubtedly Ignatius hoped that this "personal" letter to the bishop of the city

29 Cf. Ign., *Smyrn.*, 11, 2. Ignatius explains that the ambassador must be a deacon and reports that other churches closer at hand have sent bishops, presbyters and deacons, cf. *Philad.,* 10, 1; Ignatius considers it advisable for the bishop to choose someone who could be called God's postman (θεοδρόμος), cf. *Polyc.,* 7, 1–2.

30 Some think that this refers to a persecution against the Christian community, cf. B. Lightfoot, *The Apostolic Fathers, Part II: St. Ignatius, St Polycarp,* vol. I, New York 1989, 319. Others propend for such a confrontation between charisms and ministries that the civil authority decided to detain Ignatius to put an end to the conflict, cf. C. Trevett, *Ignatius "To the Romans"* and *I Clement LIV–LVI,* in *Vigiliae Christianae* 43 (1989), 37–43. *The Restoration of Peace in Ignatius' Antioch,* in *Journal of Theological Studies* 35 (1984), 465–469.

31 In the long review we find the spurious letter from Ignatius to Mary of Cassobola, composed between the sixth and the ninth century, cf. B. Lightfoot, *The Apostolic Fathers,* 125–126.

would be read out in public[32]. The reason why Ignatius should address a second communication to the Church of Smyrna was probably in order to avoid any falling off in the support for his request made earlier to send out an ambassador of God to the Church of Antioch. This time, he asks not only to send a delegate from Smyrna to Antioch, but in addition, to write to the Churches which are before Smyrna[33] so that they too do the same. Those that can, should send messengers, those that cannot, should at least write a letter and send it with the messenger from Smyrna[34].

Another motivation for writing this letter, in addition to that already reported in connection with the mission to Antioch, is without doubt the personal and communitarian exhortation that Ignatius wishes to make to the bishop of the community. This heartfelt exhortation[35] in which the profound personal ties between the two bishops cannot be denied[36], has counsel regarding the various

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32 Cf. W. Schoedel, *Ignatius of Antioch,* 274.

33 The spatial meaning of the adverb ἔμπροσθεν (before or in front of) allows us to conclude that he is referring to the Churches located between Smyrna and Antioch: Ephesus, Magnesia and Tralles, cf. *ibid.,* 280.

34 Cf. Ign., *Polyc.,* 8, 1. Certainly within the dynamics of the journey undertaken by Ignatius, it is not strange to find a request of this kind, since there is a long list of situations and persons who in one way or another have established around the person of Ignatius, a whole network of communications between the churches for the purpose of communicating news, carrying letters, and maintaining unity between the communities. Some messengers were sent to Rome from Syria to inform the Romans of the arrival of bishop Ignatius, cf. Ign., *Rom.,* 10, 2, another carried to Rome the letter written by Ignatius in Smyrna, cf. Ign., *Rom.,* 10, 1; on the way to Asia Minor yet another went to Ephesus, Magnesia, and Tralles, to notify the Christians of those communities of the coming of Ignatius to Smyrna; they, in their turn, sent representatives to greet the prisoner (five from Ephesus, four from Magnesia, and one from Tralles); the Ephesians and the Smyrnaeans cooperated by ministering to the deacon Burrhus, who accompanied Ignatius as far as Troas, cf. Ign., *Eph.,* 2, 1; Philo from Cilicia and Rheus Agathopus served as liaison between Ignatius and Antioch; they followed him through Philadelphia, cf. Ign., *Philad.,* 11, 1 and Smyrna, cf. Ign., *Smirn.,* 10, 1, and reached him in Troas, where Philo apparently accompanied him for a short while longer, cf. Ign., *Smirn.,* 13, 1.

35 Ignatius begins his advice to Polycarp with the formula παρακαλῶ. The basic context of the exhortation is that Polycarp, counting on the grace with which he has been invested, should carry on his ministry vigorously, cf. Ign., *Polyc.,* 1, 2; cf. W. Schoedel, *Ignatius of Antioch,* 146, 259.

36 We cannot establish whether Ignatius and Polycarp knew each other prior to their meeting in Smyrna. What is certain is that as from that moment both bishops expressed

responsibilities that the bishop should have as its aim, such as above all the salvation of the members of the community and its unity[37] by means of care of the "pestilent"[38], of widows[39], of slaves,[40] and of married couples[41]: in addition, the warning made previously to the whole community[42] to be wary of false masters[43].

The letter is shorter[44] and the style more abrupt than usual[45], perhaps due to the short time Ignatius had at his disposal[46]. Nevertheless, the heartfelt farewells in which he repeats greetings to individuals and families[47] indicate the affection and closeness of Ignatius, not only to the bishop, but also to members of the community.

The structure of the letter may be the following[48]:

- Praise of Polycarp: 1, 1.
  - Exhortation to Polycarp.
- His responsibilities: 1, 2–3, 2.
  - His dealings with the weakest members of the community.
  - His resistance to false masters.

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in their writings the good impression that each left on the other. Ignatius bears witness to the charity with which he was welcomed by the bishop of Smyrna, cf. Ign., *Eph.,* 21, 1; *Magn.,* 16, 1. Polycarp in his letter *To the Philippians* speaks of Ignatius and his companions as images of true love (τὰ μιμήματα τῆς ἀληθοῦς ἀγάπης), placing them at the same level as Paul and the other apostles, cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 1, 1; 9, 1.

37 Cf. Ign., *Polyc.,* 1, 2.

38 The expression τοὺς λοιμοτέρους should be understood in the light of the medical metaphors used throughout the paragraph, cf. *Polyc.,* 2,1; cf. W. Schoedel, *Ignatius of Antioch,* 262.

39 Cf. Ign., *Polyc.,* 4, 1.

40 Cf. Ign., *Polyc.,* 4, 3.

41 Cf. Ign., *Polyc.,* 5.

42 Cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 4, 1–7, 2.

43 Cf. Ign., *Polyc.,* 3, 1.

44 The greeting is the shortest of all the letters.

45 The language and style of Ignatius is considered by scholars to be a passionate rhythmic prose. In his imagination a fundamental place is occupied by hellenistic culture and the *corpus Paulinum.* Nevertheless, his style is Asian or Syrian, cf. W. Schoedel, *Ignatius of Antioch*, 7–8.

46 All of a sudden he had to set sail from Troas to Neapolis, cf. Ign., *Polyc.,* 8, 1.

47 In a single sentence there are two farewells and various salutations including one repeated to Alce, cf. Ign., *Polyc.,* 8, 2–3; *Smirn.,* 13, 2.

48 In a similar way we follow the structure adduced by A. Hamman, *Les évêques apostoliques: Clément de Rome, Ignace d'Antioche, Polycarpe de Smyrne,* Paris 2000, 151.

- The different situations: 4, 1–5, 2.
  - Care of widows.
  - Dealings with slaves.
  - Advice to married couples.
- Exhortation to the community: 6.
- Mission to Antioch: 7, 1–8,1.
- Greetings: 8, 2.

This letter is a source of first order. In it, Ignatius, by means of his advice, makes an X-ray of the responsibilities of Polycarp's episcopate and of the possible tensions and vicissitudes affecting the community of Smyrna at the beginning of the second century.

4. Polycarpus Smyrnensis, Epistula ad Philippenses

Of all those known as "Apostolic Fathers", Polycarp is the author on whom we have most information regarding his activity. We will content ourselves, in this first part, with a concise biographical note on the bishop of Smyrna based on the data passed down by tradition and which we will further analyse in greater detail.

Polycarp was born in about the year 80, probably of a Christian family. Irenaeus states that he was instructed by the apostles and that he was in direct contact with John[49], while Tertullian furthermore states that he was made bishop of Smyrna by the apostle John himself[50]. Polycarp is presented as a privileged witness of apostolic preaching and according to the testimonies of Ignatius and Irenaeus, he was a defender of this tradition[51]. Towards the year 155, Polycarp visited Rome, where he discussed various subjects with Pope Anicetus, principally the date for the celebration of Easter[52]. Shortly after these events he suffered martyrdom in his own city at 86 years of age[53].

Irenaeus testifies that Polycarp wrote many letters, either to neighbouring Churches, or to particular individuals[54]. However, only the one addressed to the Church of the Philippians in Macedonia has incontrovertibly come down to us. The handwritten tradition of the letter has, largely, been linked with the

49 Cf. Iren., *haer.,* 3, 3, 4.
50 Cf. Tert., *praescr.,* 32, 2 (CCSL 1, 212).
51 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 20, 7.
52 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 4, 14,1.
53 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 9, 3.
54 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 20, 8.

transmission of the Ignatian letters[55], although his theology and style are far removed from those of the martyr of Antioch[56].

This letter was written for three fundamental reasons. On the one hand, the Church of Philippi had requested Polycarp to write about justice[57] and, perhaps in relation to this, to give advice for solving the case of a presbyter whose name was Valens, who had abandoned his ministry because of shady pecuniary dealings[58]. Lastly, it has the aim of sending the Church of Philippi a collection of letters from Ignatius that they had entrusted to Polycarp[59].

As a result of the history of the transmission and content of this letter, scholars have come to state that we are in fact confronted here with two subsequently combined letters. So that, chapter 13 and perhaps also 14 date from before Ignatius' death, while the rest of the letter was probably written in about the year 135[60].

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55 The Greek text has come down to us through eight manuscripts, all of the same family. All these manuscripts break off at 9, 2. However, the Greek text of chapters 9 and 13 (with the exception of the last sentence) has been transmitted to us through Eusebius of Caesarea, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 3, 36, 13–15. We know the rest of the letter thanks to a Latin version which presents considerable differences, cf. J. Ayán Calvo, 207–208.

56 The writings of both have been combined in the vicissitudes of research, since chapter 13 of this letter gives authenticity to the *corpus Ignatianum,* cf. J. Ayán Calvo, 193.

57 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 3, 1.

58 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 11.

59 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 13, 2. This is an exceptional witness to the authenticity of the Ignatian letters, so that those who persisted in denying their authenticity were immediately obliged to consider chapter 13 of this letter as interpolated. For example, J. Rius-Camps believes that the only true reason for the letter is to present Crescentius as successor to the fugitive Valens, who not only would seem not to be a presbyter but the bishop of Macedonia; accordingly, he declares that chapter 13 is an interpolation, cf. J. Rius-Camps, *The Letter of Polycarp to the Philippians: endorsement of the "Polycarpian" compilation, or credentials of the new bishop Crescentius?*, in *Pléroma, Salus carnis, Homenaje a Antonio Orbe, S. J.,* ed. E. Romero-Pose, Santiago de Compostela 1990, 158–160. For a vigorous contestation of the thesis of Rius-Camps, cf. J. Ayán Calvo, 199–200.

60 For a history of the research on this letter, cf. J. Ayán Calvo, 198–205. M. Simonetti has a simpler solution for the problem regarding chapters 9 and 13 of the letter, which is that the name of Ignatius in chapter nine was added subsequently by a copyist who, induced by the suggestion in chapter 13, decided to place the martyr's name, already well known by that time, together with the names of the martyrs Zosimus and Rufus, cf. M. Simonetti – E. Prinzivalli, *Seguendo Gesù,* 287. K. Berding, embracing the theory

The structure of the letter may be the following:

- Memory of the passing of the martyrs through Philippi: 1.
- Discourse on God's justice[61]: 2.
- Memory of Paul's teaching: 3.
- Advice for various conditions of life:
  - Married women and widows: 4.
  - Deacons and young men: 5.
  - Presbyters: 6.
- Those faithful to Christ on the model of the martyrs: 7–10.
- Defection of Valens and attitude of the community: 11–12.
- The impositions and letters of Ignatius: 13 (inserted).
- Recommentations and greetings: 14.

This letter is an eminent source since it enables us to recognise the disposition of the bishop of the Smyrna community. In the counsels and exhortations given to the community of Philippi, Polycarp highlights situations probably similar to those experienced in his own community.

5. Ecclesia Smyrnensis, Epistula de martyrio s. Polycarpi[62]

This text is fruit of the interest of the Church of the Philomelians (in a Phrygian city), which wanted to know the fate of the famous bishop of the Church of Smyrna. So that the community of Smyrna shortly after the martyrdom of its pastor produced this writing, which as time went on, became known as the *Martyrdom*

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of two letters, proposes the year 120 as date of the composition of chapters 1–12, cf. K. Berding, *Polycarp and Paul. An analysis of their literary and theological relationship in light of Polycarp's use of biblical and extra-biblical literature,* Boston 2002.

61 Other authors have labelled this paragraph "Fidelity to the Gospel", cf. A. Hamman, *Les évêques apostoliques,* 171; or "Exhortation to Christian life", cf. D. Ruiz Bueno, *Padres Apostólicos y apologistas griegos s. II,* Madrid 2002, 499. Here we call it "Discourse on God's justice" following the indication of Polycarp himself at the beginning of the following paragraph, cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 3, 1.

62 For an article which gathers the novelties of an important Slavic version of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp*, cf. *Martirio de Policarpo*, cf. T. Khomych, *A Forgotten Witness: Recovering the Early Church Slavonic Version of the* Martyrdom of Polycarp in *Martyrdom and Persecution in Late Antique Christianity*, ed. B. Dehandschutter, Leuven 2010, 123–134.

of Polycarp and was assimilated to the genre of acts of martyrdom. Notwithstanding, today scholars vindicate its character of circular letter[63], while seeing in it the rule and model for the subsequent genre of acts and passions of martyrs.

As regards the author, from chapter 20 alone, we may infer that someone called Marcion was the writer of the letter while Evaristus acted as scribe[64].

Because of the handwritten transmission[65] and the versions given by Eusebius of Caesarea[66] many discussions have taken place around this letter: the apparent interpolation of the last two chapters[67], the suspicion aroused by the similarities with the passion of Jesus Christ, the date of the martyrdom[68], etc. Nonetheless, its

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63 The character of letter has been defended by G. Buschmann and B. Dehandschutter. The former also considers the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* as an anti-montanist writing, essentially kerigmatic and edifying, but without historical value, cf. G. Buschmann, *Martyrium Polycarpi. Eine formkritische Studie,* Berlin-New York 1994, 77–107 and 320–321. On the historic value of the document, cf. B. Dehandschutter, *The Martyrium Polycarpi: A Century of Research,* in *Aufstieg und Niedergang der römischen Welt*, II, 27/1, Berlin-New York 1993, 492–497.

64 Some experts maintain that Evaristus was the author of the letter and that Marcion was merely an eye-witness, cf. B. Dehandschutter, *Martyrium Polycarpi. Een literair-kritische studie,* Leuven 1979, 280.

65 The Greek text has been conserved in six manuscripts. Versions of the work have likewise come down to us in Latin, Syriac, Coptic, and Slavic, cf. J. Ayán Calvo, 242–243.

66 Eusebius of Caesarea transmits the different dates given for the martyrdom of Polycarp. The first some time during the government of Marcus Aurelius (161–180), cf. Eus., *h. e.* 4, 14, 10–15, 1, and the second in the seventh year of Marcus Aurelius' reign together with the martyrs of Vienne and Lyons in Gaul, that is to say in 167, cf. *Die Chronik des Hieronymus,* ed. R. Helm (GCS 24, 205). Nevertheless, the *Historia Ecclesiastica* states very precisely that the martyrdom of these Gauls occurred in the seventeenth year of the reign of Marcus Aurelius, that is, in the year 177. An explanation of the contradiction between these two versions has been that, as a result of a *lapsus calami* of Eusebius himself, in the *Chronicle* he wrote seventh instead of seventeenth. In this way, he situates the date of Polycarp's martyrdom at 23 February of the year 177, cf. J. Ayán Calvo, 240. For a study on the relationship of Montanism with the possible dating of the document, cf. M. Simonetti, *Alcune osservazioni sul martirio di S. Policarpo*, in *Giornale Italiano di Filologia* 4 (1956): 332–340.

67 It would seem that its natural conclusion would be at the end of chapter 20 with the greetings of the scribe and his whole family to the Philomelians. Nonetheless, the document goes on with two chapters more, a fact that has frequently aroused suspicion in scholars, since these offer a series of chronological facts and a short history of the transmission of the text, the dates of which are questionable, cf. J. Ayán Calvo, 234.

68 All scholars agree on accepting 23 February (the second day of the month of Xhanthicus) as the day of the martyrdom, cf. *M. Polyc.,* 21. As regards the year, most scholars

importance in the history of Christian hagiography is unquestionable[69]. Likewise for our theme, it is a document of inestimable value since it enables us to draw closer to the memory that the Smyrnaeans had of their pastor and of the environment of persecution lived in second-century Smyrna.

The structure of the letter may be the following:

- Greeting.
- Considerations on persecution and martyrdom: 1–4.
  - Courage of Germanicus: 3.
  - Cowardice of Quintus: 4.
- Passion of Polycarp: 5–16.
  - Betrayal, capture and path of martyrdom,: 5–8.
  - Dialogue with the proconsul in the stadium: 9–12.
  - Preparation of the stake: 13.
  - Prayer of the martyr: 14.
  - Prodigies during his death: 15–16.
- Veneration of the martyr's mortal remains: 17–18.
- Glory of Polycarp: 19.
- Farewell: 20.
- Date of the martyrdom: 21 (inserted).
- Appendix, history of the textual transmission: 22 (inserted).

6. Irenaeus Lugdunensis, Ad Florinum de monarchia

Irenaeus of Lyons is, perhaps, the most important theologian of the second century. The exact date of his birth is unknown, but it was probably between 135 and 155[70]. His native city is in Asia Minor and according to the fragment of this letter

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incline for 155, while others for 167. Two important commentaries on the theme, cf. J. Ayán Calvo, 241–242; cf. R. Cacitti, *Grande Sabato, Il contesto pasquale quartodecimano nella formazione della teologia del martirio,* Milan 1994, 38.

69 For a *status quaestionis* on the validity and authenticity of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* cf. V. Saxer, *L'authenticité du "Martyre de Polycarpe": Bilan de 25 ans de critique,* Rome 1982 (Mélanges de l'Ecole française de Rome 94), 979–1001.

70 Eusebius states that Irenaeus in one of his works gives us to understand that he himself received the first succession of the apostles, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 20, 1. This statement implies that he was born in the first years of the second century, however this version does not fit in well with what is said in the epistle *To Florinus,* cf. J. Salaverri, *La sucesión apostólica en la "Historia Eclesiástica" de Eusebio de Cesarea,* in *Gregorianum* 14 (1993) 220–247.

to the Roman presbyter Florinus, his early youth was spent in Smyrna where he listened to Polycarp's sermons.

For reasons unknown to us, Irenaeus left Asia Minor and settled in Gaul. In the year 177, as presbyter of the Church of Lyons, he was sent by the future martyrs of that city to Pope Eleuterius to act as a mediator in a question regarding Montanism[71]. When Irenaeus returned from Rome, the elderly Photinus had died a martyr, and Irenaeus was appointed his successor. In his writing, he used his closeness to the apostolic tradition to make a systematic attack on the gnostic doctrine and on the doctrine of Marcion. We do not know exactly when he died, but presumibly it was around 202 or 203.

The fragment of five short paragraphs from the epistle *To Florinus* is conserved through a quotation made by Eusebius in his *Historia Ecclesiastica*[72].

The content of this fragment of the letter may be summarised as follows: Irenaeus reproaches Florinus for the opinions he holds[73] and which differ from the feeling of the Church. He reminds him that these do not belong to the teaching that they both received from the apostolic tradition and from bishop Polycarp when they used to meet in Smyrna. He goes on to remind him of the kind of life lived by Polycarp, his discourses, and how he described his relations with the apostle John and with the other disciples of the Lord. Finally, he states that if Polycarp had heard any such ideas as those maintained by Florinus, he would have stopped his ears and clapped his hands over his ears and rushed

71 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 4, 2.

72 The epistle *To Florinus (ep. Flor.)* by Irenaeus has been transmitted in Eus., *h. e.* 5, 20, 4–8 (SCh 1,61–63). Eusebius informs us that Irenaeus composed several letters, v. gr. *To Blastus, on schism*. Eusebius also mentions that Irenaeus wrote two works in which he deals with the teachings of a man named Florinus, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 20, 1–2. A letter was addressed to this same Florinus and another work called *On the Ogdoada*, according to a fragment preserved in Syriac in the Nirian collection of the British Museum, and another to Victor, bishop of Rome, cf. C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp,* Tübingen 2006, 12.

73 Florinus was a Roman presbyter who, together with Blastus, had distanced himself from the communion, it would appear on the question of the date of Easter and perhaps due to some Montanist influence, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 23–25. We also know from Eusebius himself that the letter which Irenaeus addressed to this person is also called *On the monarchy* or *On God who is not the author of demons.* C. Hill argues that these titles and other correspondences clearly indicate that Florinus also defended the Marcionist theme since Irenaeus states that the blasphemy of the Marcionist heresy is to declare that God is the author of demons, cf. Iren., *haer.,* 1, 27, 2; 3, 12, 12; cf. C: Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp,* 12–17.

away. He ends by stating that Polycarp wrote many letters to the neighbouring Churches.

This fragment from the epistle *To Florinus* reveals a close acquaintance by Irenaeus with the bishop of Smyrna and the vigour with which he upheld the apostolic tradition in the environment of Smyrna where the author of the letter grew up.

7. Irenaeus Lugdunensis, Epistula ad Victorem papam Romanum de festo paschali[74]

Eusebius in his *Historia Ecclesiastica* transmits some extracts from a letter from Irenaeus to Pope Victor concerning the date of Easter. This letter has the aim of persuading Pope Victor not to withhold en masse communion from all the communities of Asia Minor which continue to celebrate Easter on 14 Nisan (Quartodecimanists) according to an ancient custom, and not according to the Roman and Alexandrian tradition of the Sunday following 14 Nisan (Dominicals)[75].

The content of these seven extracts from the letter may be summarised as follows: Irenaeus, on behalf of the brethren from Gaul, whose head he was, reminds Pope Victor of the behaviour of his predecessors (Soter, Anicetus, Pius, Hyginus, Telesphorus and Sixtus) and how everyone showed great tolerance on this point and on the form of fasting[76]. In particular he makes mention of the journey to Rome by Polycarp in the times of Anicetus[77], when both maintained their previous positions backed up by the tradition which each of them had received from his predecessors, and even thus they communicated with each other, and in the church Anicetus conceded celebration of the Eucharist to Polycarp.

We consider this testimony important for our study on account of the facts regarding the liturgical tradition of the Church of Smyrna and the journey of its pastor to the capital of the Empire in the middle of the second century.

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74 Irenaeus' letter was transmitted in Eus., *h. e.* 5, 24, 12–17 (SCh 41, 70–71).

75 For a clearer idea of the Easter controversy, cf. R. Cantalamessa, *La Pasqua nella Chiesa antica,* Turin 1978.

76 By "form" is meant the days on which this fasting should apply. In the case of the Easter controversy, both Polycrates of Ephesus and Ireneaus fail to see a question relative to faith in the different practices of fasting, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 35, 24, 2–8; 12–17.

77 Epiphanius of Salamis in his *Panarion* also makes a passing reference to the administration of Polycarp, though he places him as contemporary to Pope Victor, cf. Epiph. *haer.,* 70, 9, 8 (MG 42, 356) (ed. F. Williams, *The Panarion of Epiphanius of Salamis II–III,* New York 1994, 411).

8. Polycrates Ephesinus, Epistula ad Victorem papam Romanum[78]

Polycrates was bishop of Ephesus towards the end of the second century, approximately 40 years after Polycarp's death, during the empire of Commodus and the papacy of Victor in Rome. Only his letter, dated about 190 to 200, addressed to Pope Victor on the occasion of the controversy regarding the date for the celebration of Easter, has survived. This letter has been conserved in the *Historia Ecclesiastica* of Eusebius in two quotations:

The first quotation (Eus., *h. e.* 3, 31, 3) is the shortest, when Eusebius is alluding to the history of the apostles and where these have been buried. There he speaks of Philip and his daughters of whom both lie beside their father in Hierapolis and another one in Ephesus, and of John the apostle of whom he mentions that he leant his head on the Lord's breast, that he was a priest wearing the petalon[79], martyr and master, who is buried in Ephesus.

The second quotation (Eus., *h. e.* 5, 24, 2–8) is more complete, when Eusebius refers the dissent of the bishops of Asia regarding the date of Easter adopted by the churches of all the rest of the world. There Eusebius once more cites the part where Polycrates speaks on the apostles Philip and John, and goes on to draw up a list of the luminaries[80] of Asia: Polycarp bishop and martyr of Smyrna, Strataeas bishop and martyr coming from Eumenia and laid to rest in Smyrna, Sagaris bishop and martyr buried in Laodicea, the blessed Papirius, and Melito the eunuch buried in Sardis. Polycrates goes on to state that all of them celebrate Easter on the fourteenth day of the moon, in accordance with the Gospel, and this was no transgression, but followed the rule of faith. Polycrates, in order to give even greater weight to his reasoning declares that he received this same tradition from the members of his family, of whom seven were bishops, that he has spoken on this question with brothers coming from all over the world, that he has studied

78 Cf. Polyc., *Ep. Vict.*, in Eus., *h. e.* 3, 31, 3; 5, 24, 2–7.

79 τὸ πέταλον was an insignia of the Jewish high priest, cf. *Ex* 28, 36–38*; Lv* 8, 9. A description of the same and its symbolic interpretation is given in Clement of Alexandria, ed. Clem., *str.,* 5, 38, 5–40, 4 (SCh 278, 87–91), cf. J. Andersen, *L'apôtre Saint-Jean grand prêtre* in *Studia Theologica* 19 (1965) 22–29.

80 The word στοιχεῖα in its literal sense of "elements" was in great vogue in philosophy, where it was used to refer to the celestial bodies. Likewise in 2 *P* 10–20 the Christian author uses it in this same sense which undoubtedly is the metaphorical meaning that Polycrates wished to give to this word.

all of Holy Scripture, and that there are many bishops in agreement with him at the time of writing this letter on behalf of them all.

This letter is fundamental for our study on the community of Smyrna since it informs us of the position of the community regarding the celebration of Easter, enables us to compare the appraisal that a bishop of Ephesus makes of Polycarp compared to the apostle John 40 years after the former's death, makes reference to Strataeas and Papirius[81] as bishops in some way linked with the community of Smyrna in the period immediately following Polycarp, and enunciates difficulties due to the absence of the name of Paul or members of his group, such as Timothy, who carry out an important task in the spreading of Christianity in Asia[82].

9. Hippolytus, Adversus Noetum[83]

This homiletic writing[84], whose origin is in the area of Roman Asia, has Hippolytus as its author in about the year 210[85]. The writing gives us news of Noetus, a figure in the community of Smyrna after the time of Polycarp and up to the end of the second century on whom we possess little information[86]. Hippolytus affirms that

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81 Papyrius is probably the same person as is briefly mentioned in the *Life of Polycarp* as the successor of Polycarp. Polycrates makes reference to Παπίριον, the author of the *Life of Polycarp* and to Παπίριον, cf. *V. Polyc.,* 27 (ed. A. Stewart-Sykes, *The Life of Polycarp,* Sydney 2002, 130).

82 M. Simonetti has underlined the absence of Paul from the list given by Polycrates and the problems existing concerning the Pauline tradition in Asia Minor throughout the second century, cf. M. Simonetti, *Paolo nell'Asia cristiana dell II secolo,* in *Vetera Christianorum* 27 (1990), 123–144.

83 Edition of M. Simonetti, Ippolito, *Contro Noeto,* Biblioteca Patristica, Bologna 2000. In this study we will cite this work of Hippolytus as *CN* considering the manner of citing the edition of M. Simonetti.

84 M. Simonetti concludes that the text is a homily rather than a heresiological text due to the similarities in the literary character it presents with the Quartodecimanist Easter homilies, cf. M. Simonetti, *Contro Noeto,* 32.

85 This Hippolytus, Asian bishop, exegete and defender of the christological doctrine of the Logos, is distinct from the author of the *Elenchos (El:* from now on). In order to further explore the question of the two Hippolytuses, cf. M. Simonetti, *Ippolito,* in *Nuovo Dizionario Patristico e di Antichità Cristiane* (from now on: NDPAC), Genoa 2007, 2584–2600.

86 Epiphanius in his *Panarion* also gives news of Noetus, repeating in general the information of the *Contro Noeto* but states that he comes from Ephesus and not from Smyrna, going on to give news of his death and that of his brother, cf. Epiph. *haer.,* 52, 1 (PG 41, 993–996).

he was the first propagator of the Patripasian doctrine, who for this reason was condemned by the presbyters of Smyrna. Hippolytus reports that Noetus, who was probably a cleric[87] of the city, declared himself to be Moses and his brother Aaron. Undoubtedly the not very detailed news at least suggests that Noetus was convinced of enjoying a particular divine inspiration, which Hippolytus considers to be produced by a malevolent spirit. The doctrine of Noetus is presented by Hippolytus as "of someone who declared that Christ was the Father himself and that precisely the Father was generated, suffered and died" and is accompanied by various texts from Scripture on which Noetus based himself: *Ex* 3, 6; 20, 3; *Is* 44, 6; *Ba* 3; *Io,* 10, 30; 14, 9–10.

This work has been the object of debate, since various scholars have seen subsequent interpolations proper to the Apollinarian controversy in it. However, M. Simonetti affirms in his edition of the work that this text corresponds almost completely with the genuine version, which when dealing with the relationship between humanity and divinity in Christ anticipated concepts and terms which were later taken up at the time of the Apollinarian controversy, and precisely in order not to align it completely with either an Apollinarian position nor with the contrary. Finally, the text was used both by the Monophysites and by the Diphysites. So that this text is the product of a theology well in advance of the Apollinarian controversy, the one characterising the Monarchian controversy of the end of the second century and beginning of the third.

The structure of the homily is as follows:

- Introduction to the acts and doctrine of Noetus: 1, 1–2, 8.
- Confrontation of the doctrine of Noetus based on texts from Scripture: 2, 9–8, 4.
- Expounding of the Trinitarian and Christological doctrine of Hippolytus: 9,1–18, 9.

This text is fundamental for our study of the Christian community of Smyrna at the end of the second century and beginning of the third, above all with regard to the Christological doctrine which was developed around Noetus and against him by the presbyters of the city.

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87 The news of *CN* 1, 3 on Noetus ἔκβλητος γεγένηται κλήρου ἁγίου would seem to back up the idea that Noetus was a member of the clergy; however, the term κλῆρος at the beginning of the third century, while it could well have the present meaning in the Christian environment, could also have the traditional meaning of inheritance, or the part due, cf. M. Simonetti, *Contro Noeto*, 40.

10. Fragments on Polycarp[88]

These four fragments (nos. 55, 56, 63 and 64), written on both sides, are a part of the Harris collection of Coptic papyruses OR. 7561 of the British Library of London found in the mid-nineteenth century. These fragments are a Coptic translation of a composition in Greek, probably written in the second century.

The historical importance of these fragments is considerable since they offer a version parallel to the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* presented heretofore, but which differs from this witness in significant details.

The *Fragments on Polycarp (FgrPol)* which have come down to us lack the beginning and end of this version on the martyrdom of Polycarp[89]. The text that we possess begins with the assignment of missionary areas to the disciples of Jesus, after which it presents Polycarp and offers a testimony to his activity and his arrest as a prelude to his death in the tribunal, which is not narrated to us in the extant fragments.

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88 F. Weidmann has made a transcription, translation, and study of these fragments on Polycarp to which he has given the abbreviation *FgrPol* or *Harris Fragments*, cf. *The Harris Fragments: OR. 7561, nos. 55, 56, 63, 64*, ed. and tr. F. Weidmann in *Polycarp and John: The Harris Fragments and Their Challenge to the Literary Tradition*, University of Notre Dame Press 1999. This work contains a good study at paleographic, textual, literary, and historical level. Following a physical description of the fragments, it also provides a transcription of the text fragment by fragment accompanied by two systems: one of parallelisms with canonical and non-canonical Christian literature, and the other with notes of textual criticism, which include possible reconstructions of the text. In Chapter II, he makes the translation into English of each fragment, in most cases in a very careful way. The study continues with a general view of the literary character of the piece and its relationship with the other literature which has come down to us on Polycarp, ending up with some fine photographic reproductions of each fragment. Although F. Wiedmann's commentaries are extremely useful, occasionally they go too far, since despite affirming the evident fragmentation of the text, he draws conclusions on Polycarp's thought and conduct very difficult to establish on the basis of so little information; in the same way, he takes even further the positions of Kummel and McNeille regarding the New Testament. The academic community has received with appreciation the contribution by F. Weidmann to this *editio princeps* of the *Fragments of Polycarp*: M. Holmes, reviews F. Weidmann, in *Journal of Early Christian Studies* vol. 8, no. 1 (2000) 117–118; cf. J. Duff, reviews F. Weidmann, in *Journal of Ecclesiastical History Studies* 52 (2002).

89 The fragments do not provide the beginning of the testimony, so that it is impossible for us to specify how much and what more preceded the report coming down to us. In the same way, they do not narrate the martyr's death.

This version of the martyrdom of Polycarp differs from the other one in significant details: the bishop's age at the time he is judged is 104, in contrast to the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* which gives his age to be 86[90], the charge made against him is practising magic, in contrast to the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* where he is accused of atheism[91]. Herod, head of the police, is presented as furious and with the firm desire to kill the bishop, in contrast to the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* where, together with his son Nicetas, he merely insults him when they do not succeed in persuading him to apostatise[92].

The detail of particular importance offered by this version is the author's intention to show that Polycarp died violently by martyrdom instead of or in an alternative way to the natural death of old age of the apostle John, his master and mentor. In truth, the text states that Polycarp's followers had heard him (Polycarp) say many times that it was necessary for him to die in the tribunal in order to die an alternative death, since the Lord had allowed John to die in his bed.

F. Weidmann takes this theme of the alternative and violent death of Polycarp compared to the natural death of John as the most important characteristic of the narration, proposing an interesting thesis according to which the text should have been read in the context of the rivalry between the two cities, Ephesus (associated with John) and Smyrna (associated with Polycarp). This thesis consists of affirming that struggles for status in the civic sphere extended within the circles of the Christian communities and that the antique tradition whereby John lived to a ripe old age was used as an argument by the Smyrnaeans for

90 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 9, 3. In this source, Polycarp on being interrogated before the pro-consul says that he has spent 86 years in Christ's service, which may be interpreted as an allusion to his birth or as an allusion to his conversion. Possibly, in this second interpretation the two testimonies could match, although at such an advanced age it would be difficult to explain the recent journey that Polycarp had made to Rome, as also the surprising activity he displays in the martyrdom, cf. J. Ayán Calvo, 193–194.

91 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 3, 2; 9, 1. As a consequence, Polycarp is also accused of teaching not to sacrifice to or worship the gods, cf. *M. Polyc.,* 7, 2.

92 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 8, 2–3. F. Weidmann states that this allusion to the fragments is taken from *Mt* 2, 1–18 where Herod in a rage seeks to kill the child. However, another possible source of inspiration, which does not exclude the first one but may be complementary to it, is the narration of the passion of Jesus in the *Gospel of Peter,* in which as the text refers, it is Herod who orders his execution, cf. B. Ehrman, review on F. Weidmann, in *Review Biblical Studies* 7, 11 (2000).

underlining the fact that their own bishop was obliged to take John's place on the bench of martyrdom[93].

Despite its fragmentary nature, this source offers us another hagiographic reading of Polycarp and is important for any study of the creation of the identity of the Christian community of Smyrna. F. Weidmann's contribution, over and above the theses formulated which need to be discussed when the time comes, is an important one for the purposes of our research.

11. Martyrium Pionii[94]

Pionius was a Christian of Smyrna martyred in the middle of the third century. The text of the *Martyrdom of Pionius* is a writing ed. an anonymous author who probably used an autobiographical document written by Pionius himself. According to the text which has come down to us in Greek, Latin and other Oriental languages, the martyrdom took place during the persecution of Decius[95] in about 250. However, the testimony of Eusebius in his *Historia Ecclesiastica*[96] affirms that the martyrdom occurred on 12 March shortly after the martyrdom of Polycarp during the persecution of Marcus Aurelius from 156 to 165. Some scholars incline for the date given by Eusebius[97], however today the majority accept the date given in the *Martyrdom of Pionius*[98] as more probable.

Despite the additions present in certain parts of the text, this is considered by scholars to be an ancient and truthful document, written only a few years after

93 This thesis is interesting and deserving of further discussion regarding the reasons for which the cities of Asia Minor competed for status as witnessed by Aelius Aristides in his *Discourse on the concord of the Asian cities* and as may be perceived in the witness provided by Polycrates, bishop of Ephesus, in his letter to Victor bishop of Rome, 40 years after Polycarp's death, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 3, 31, 3; 5, 24, 2–8. To reinforce his thesis, F. Weidmann likewise reports certain epigraphical findings in Ephesus dating from the time of Justinian, cf. F. Weidmann, 144–145.

94 Ed. R. Knopf – G. Krüger, *Ausgewählte Märtyrerakten*, Tübingen 1929[3], 45–57; A. Hilhorst, *Martyrium Pionii* in *Atti e Passioni dei martiri*, ed. A. Bastiaensen, *et al.*, Rome 1987, 150–191, 453–477.

95 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 2, 1.

96 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 4, 15, 47.

97 Cf. H. Gregoire, *La véritable date du martyre de S. Polycarpe, 23 février 177, et le "corpus Polycarpianum" in Analecta Bollandiana* 69 (1951) 1–38, cf. M. Simonetti, *Studi Agiografici*, Rome 1955, 9–51.

98 Cf. H. Marrou, *La date du martyre de S. Polycarpe,* in *Analecta Bollianda* 71 (1953) 5–20; cf. J. Carlton Paget, *Jews, Christians and Jewish Christians in Antiquity,* Tübingen 2010, 56.

the martyrdom of Pionius[99]. It is interesting that among those to whom the document refers as confessors in the prison apart from Pionius, we find Sabina and Asclepiades, a Montanist called Eutiques[100] and a Marcionist presbyter named Metrodorus[101]. The reference to these heretics persecuted and martyred for their faith together with Pionius is considered as proof of the antiquity and authenticity of the document. Furthermore, it testifies to the presence in Smyrna, already at the beginning of the third century, though differentiated, of a unity in the same witness of Christian faith.

As regards the structure of the text, E. Schwartz considers that it can be divided into 23 chapters of varying size, distinguishing successive stratifications of authenticity and dating[102].

Chapters 1 to 8 seem to contain a larger quantity of interpolations or amplifications such as the great discourses of Pionius in chapters 4 and 5.

Chapters 9 to 18 contain the autobiographical report by Pionius supposedly used by the author of the *Martyrdom* as his main text. It would appear to be the most authentic part of the writing.

Chapters 19 to 23 refer to the last interrogation of Pionius before the proconsul and the narration of the death of Pionius crucified and burned. These chapters, though clearly not a part of the autobiographical account, maintain a substantial character of authenticity according to H. Delahaye[103].

So that, although the source should be used bearing in mind the possible interpolations and the veracity of each chapter, it constitutes a direct source for our study since it tells us about the environment of persecution in Smyrna and the presence of different groups of Christians in the middle of the third century.

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99 The writer reveals a precise knowledge of the topography of Smyrna, such as the sanctuary of the goddess Nemesis, among others. The dates supplied by the *Martyrdom of Pionius* coincide with the dates given by modern archaeology, cf. L. Robert, *Le martyre de Pionios prêtre de Smyrne. Édité, traduit et commenté,* Washington 1994, 2–9.

100 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 11, 2.

101 Cf. *ibid.,* 21, 5.

102 The division is offered by M. Mara, *Dalla* "Passio Pionii" *un cristianesimo differenziato a Smirne* in *Atti del X Simposio di Efeso su s. Giovanni Apostolo,* ed. L. Padovese, Rome 2005, 175. M. Mara follows the division of E. Schwartz, *De Pionio et Polycarpo,* Göttingen 1905.

103 Cf. H. Delahaye, *Les passions,* 35.

12. Vita Polycarpi[104]

This somewhat late life of Polycarp tells of the saint's coming from Syria to Smyrna when still a young child, his rise in the ecclesiastical hierarchy and a long series of miracles done by him before his martyrdom.

The text presents gaps and defects although certain parts may be historical. The general consensus of scholars referred to it as a writing produced only towards the middle of the fourth century[105]. However, recent studies have considered at least part of this text as a pre-Nicene writing, that is, dating from the third century. The reasons for this earlier dating may be found in the parallels of the *Life of Polycarp* with the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* and in the controversy regarding the date of Easter present in the text and accordingly possibly prior to the resolution of the Council of Nicaea[106].

The text is of singular interest for three fundamental reasons: first of all, it transmits to us the liturgical practices of the community in which it was produced[107]. In addition, it testifies to the adoption by the Christians of a genre of intellectual biography following the model of the Greek philosophers[108]. Lastly, it shows us the manner in which Christianity relates up to other religious systems in Smyrna,[109] whether in the third or in the fourth century.

Quite apart from the problem of the dating and the mixture of truth and fantasy, this source proves to be important for our study, since it not only refers us to the time before and during Polycarp, but also to the context of Smyrna in subsequent periods.

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104 Ed. A. Stewart-Sykes, *The life of Polycarp: an anonymous vita from third-century Smyrna*, Sydney 2002, 90–143. An earlier edition is that of L. Duchesne, *Vita Sancti Polycarpi*, Paris 1881. This work was preserved in a single manuscript of the tenth century, where it is preceded by a copy of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp.*

105 For a summary on the discussion of the dating of the text, cf. C. Schmidt, *Gespräche Jesu mit seinen Jüngern nach der Auferstehung,* Leipzig 1919.

106 For a fuller reasoning behind this dating, cf. A. Stewart-Sykes, *Vita Polycarpi: A Third Century Vita* in *Augustinianum* 40 (2000) 21–33.

107 Cf. B. Lightfoot, *The Apostolic Fathers,* 431.

108 Cf. A. Schwartz, *De Pionio et Polycarpo,* 24.

109 Cf. A. Stewart-Sykes, *The life of Polycarp,* 4.

13. Index Patrum Nicaenorum[110]

The lists of the signatories of the Council of Nicaea in 325 have come down to us very much mutilated and disfigured by the errors of the copyists. Nonetheless, these lists may be considered as authentic. With the information deriving from these, it is possible to arrive at a count of 232 or 237 conciliar fathers.

Of particular interest to us is the news confirmed by all the versions of the lists regarding the name of the bishop of the community of Smyrna who took part in the Council of Nicaea. His name is Eutiques[111]. Together with him in fourth place, as signatories for the province of Asia, a further five bishops appear, with their respective cities and in the following order: *Theonas Cyzicenus, Menofantus Ephesius, Orion Eliensis, Mithres Paponensis and Marinus of Elio (Liolypontium)*[112].

Without doubt, this source, concise in the information provided, is fundamental for establishing that the community of Smyrna, at least until the Council of Nicaea had a visible head in 325.

110 The lists of participants in the Council of Nicaea are ed. C.H. Turner, *Ecclesiae occidentalis monumenta iuris antiquisima: canonum et conciliorum Graecorum interpretationes Latinae,* Oxonii 1899–1913. Also ed. H. Gelzer, *Patrum Nicaenorum nomina Latine, Graece, Coptice, Syriace, Arabice, Armeniace,* Leipzig 1995. The lists have come down to us in the Latin, Greek, Syriac, Coptic, Arabic and Armenian versions.

111 Εὐτύχιος Σμύρνης or *Euticius Zmyrnensis* in the Latin version.

112 Names taken from the Latin version, cf. H. Gelzer, 32.

Chapter II: Brief study of the indirect sources

Hereafter we will make a brief study of a number of indirect sources giving news of the city of Smyrna or of the Christian community in particular.

1. Ignatius Antiochenus, Epistulae genuinae ad Ephesinos, ad Magnesios, ad Trallianos, ad Romanos[113]

For many scholars the letters of Ignatius, on account of their theological and spiritual content, are the most important documentation of the first half of the second century which has come down to us. For this reason, these letters have been the object of abundant studies and no few controversies[114]. However, over

113 The middle reception, except for the letter *To the Romans,* has come down to us in the Codex Mediceus Laurentianus 57, 7 of the eleventh century, which also contains certain texts of the long reception and of which a number of apographs were transcribed. The letter *To the Romans,* incorporated in the *Martyrdom of Ignatius,* a totally legendary writing, is contained in the Codex Parisinus Graecus 1451 of the tenth and eleventh centuries. For further information on the middle reception and the Ignatian question, cf. M. Simonetti – E. Prinzivalli, *Seguendo Gesù,* 279–291.

114 As regards the *corpus Ignatianum,* we can identify two big controversies in the last few centuries. The first has to do with the appraisal of the three reviews of the *corpus Ignatianum:* long, middle, and short. In this debate, the protagonists have been W. Curreton, Th. Zahn, B. Lightfoot, A. Harnack, and F. Funk. From the end of the nineteenth century scholars have come to a certain degree of unanimity in accepting the middle review as the most authentic. The long reception is clearly made starting from the fourth century in view of the clear interest in the Arian and Apollinarian controversies, the wealth of quotations from Scripture, the dependence on Origen, on Eusebius and on the *Apostolic Constitutions, and* the proliferation of lesser ecclesiastical offices such as lectores, cantores and subdeacons, knowledge of which texts dates only from authors of the sixth century, cf. M. Simonetti – E. Prinzivalli, *Seguendo Gesù*, 283–284.
The second controversy already in the second half of the twentieth century concerned the authenticity of the letters and their dating later than the second century. Authors such as J. Rius-Camps and R. Joly have formulated different theories around this question, making an excessive use of the *argumentum ex silentio* and the supposed interpolations of the texts in order to deny their authenticity. These three authors have been hotly contested by scholars such as J. Ayán Calvo, A. Di Berardino, and M. Simonetti. Today in general, the authenticity of the letters and their dating to the beginning of the second century is accepted. For a good synthesis

and above the objections and nuances for which account must be made in any analysis of the letters of Ignatius, their authenticity is a fact recognised by the academic world[115]. These letters enable us to reconstruct the environment of the Christian communities of Asia Minor in the first half of the second century based on the experience of a bishop coming from Syria and on his way to Rome, path of martyrdom. Many details found in the letters written by Ignatius from Smyrna (*To the Ephesians, To the Magnesians, To the Trallians,* and *To the Romans*) and the letter *To the Philadelphians* written from Troas, corroborate or complement the fundamental facts found in the letters *To the Smyrnaeans* and *To Polycarp.* Our interest is especially concentrated on the greetings and farewells in the letters, since these give interesting information on the members of the community, especially on persons present in Smyrna at the time when Ignatius wrote these letters.

2. Acta Ioannis[116]

These *Acts* considered as apocryphal by the antique Church[117], belong to the series of traditions[118] regarding the apostle John, which most have already circulated with a certain consistency[119] at the end of the second century. Over the

of the Ignatian question regarding these two controversies, cf. J. Ayán Calvo, 39–74; and M. Simonetti – E. Prinzivalli, *Seguendo Gesù*, 283–291.

115 Cf. A. Di Berardino, *Tendenze attuali negli studi patristici* in *Complementi interdisciplinari di Patrologia,* ed. A. Quacquarelli, Rome 1989, 59.

116 Ed. M. Bonnet, *Acta Ioannis,* in Lipsius-Bonnet, *Acta Apostolorum Apocrypha*, II/1, Darmstadt 1959, 151–216. Ed. Th. Zahn, *Acta Joannis*, Erlangen 1880. Critical edition and translation into Spanish by A. Piñero and G. del Cerro, *Hechos de Juan* in *Hechos Apócrifos de los Apóstoles I*, Madrid 2004, 304–481.

117 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 3, 25, 6–7.

118 To this should be added the traditions gathered by Irenaeus, by Clement of Alexandria and by Tertullian regarding the apostle John, evangelist and apocalyptic, cf. Iren., *haer.,* 5, 30, 3; 3, 3, 4; cf. Clem., *q.d.s.,* 42 (SCh 537, 208–223); cf. Tert., *praescr.,* 36, 3 (CCSL 1, 212 et seqq.).

119 The date of composition is established on the one hand based on the testimony of Eusebius at the end of the third century which is the oldest external testimony on the text, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 3, 25, 6–7. On the other hand, however, the manner of the theology in the text, diffuse and not very precise, points to the second half of the second century. In fact, the modalist and docetist tendencies of the author, as likewise his encratism, though not totally rigid, would seem to confirm this.

centuries, certain sections of the original work have been lost, and the surviving fragments have had to be re-organised on the basis of various hypotheses on the missing fragments[120].

The *Acts of John* begin for us abruptly with the decision of the apostle, inspired by a vision, to go to Ephesus. There the episode of the married couple Lycomedes and Cleopatra occurs with the veneration they profess through a portrait of the apostle after he miraculously brings them back to life (18–37). After a long gap, comes the apostle's profound explanation regarding the polymorphic appearances of Christ and a fragment of gnostic-valentinian style[121] regarding the true suffering of the Redeemer (87–105). Subsequently comes the confrontation of John in the temple of Artemis with the pagans and the destruction of the temple (37–47), and the tragic episode of a father and son for whom John performs prodigious miracles (48–55).

Of especial interest to us is the news regarding John's journey through various cities of Asia Minor. Above all, his activity in Smyrna where he frees a notable's sons from the power of the Devil (56–62). Thereafter comes the story of encratistic inspiration of Drusiana and Callimachus and the miraculous acts of John in bringing them back to life (63–86). Finally, John takes leave of the brethren in a homily within a liturgical celebration in which he explains his divine vocation as concretely expressed in his virginity and apostolate, going on to celebrate the breaking of bread, after which he makes his way outside of the city where he has a grave dug in which he expires tranquilly after proclaiming the marvels of the divine economy for the last time (106–115).

These *Acts* are a complex work which cannot be easily classified in a precise literary genre. First of all, this is a tendentious writing which seeks to divulge a rigorously ascetic religious point of view. It would seem to be intended for propagandistic, and not polemical use, by a vast and not very cultured public. The text also seeks to lay stress on the grand and miraculous acts of John. The text contains an abundance of miracles, resurrections and extraordinary happenings,

120 The order in which we present the synthesis of the *Acts* follows the proposal of K. Schäferdick endorsed by E. Junod – J. Kaestli, who on this aspect, have corrected the edition of M. Bonnet. This new order is that followed for the edition and translation into Spanish by A. Piñero – G. del Cerro, *Hechos de Juan* in *Hechos de los Apóstoles,* Madrid 2004, 247.

121 For a doctrinal analysis of the text, cf. A. Piñero – G. del Cerro, *Hechos de Juan,* 260–275.

from which the author always attempts to draw a doctrine edifying for the reader. In addition, the text has a "novelistic" tint highlighted in the narrations, having an erotic-love component.

On the basis of the discourses, it is clear that the author must have possessed a solid rhetorical training and in each one of the episodes we find a structure suggestive of a well conceived literary plan. Although the author does not base himself explicitly on scriptural texts, we cannot help think that he must have been acquainted at least with the Gospel of John since he makes obvious references to passages found only in that gospel[122].

The place of the writing throughout the studies has been established as Asia Minor, in Egypt, or Syria. Although the whole narration takes place in Ephesus, Smyrna and the immediate neighbourhood, the author seems not to have a precise acquaintance with the area, especially the sanctuary of Artemis in Ephesus. The fact that in any case the author has situated the actions of the apostle in that region suggests that the tradition that John based his operations on Asia Minor was already widely accredited at the time when this text was written, but does not necessarily mean that the work was of Asian origin. Speculation has centred on Egypt on the basis of hints alone, since this region was the cradle of the Hellenistic novel which would seem to have greatly influenced the text. Besides which there are certain features in the theology of the text which would seem to fit in with the theology of Clement and Origen; nevertheless, this does not appear sufficient to establish its origin as Egyptian. For its part, Syria has acquired a greater consensus of plausibility due to Syriac words found in the text, the affinity of certain elements with the Johannine tradition originating in the Syro-Palestinian region, and with the verosimilitude of a very antique Syriac version of all of the *Acts of John*[123].

The city of Smyrna is mentioned in paragraphs 37, 45, 55, and 62, when a group of citizens invites John to move to this city and there he brings about the release of a devil. Due to the numerous fanciful happenings, but above all to the fact that the most probable place for the writing of this text is Syria and not Asia Minor, we have considered this as an indirect source.

122 Cf. A. Piñero – G. del Cerro, *Hechos de Juan,* 258–260.

123 Cf. A. Piñero – G. del Cerro, *Hechos de Juan,* 288–290.

3. Acta Pauli[124]

The apocryphal *Acts of Paul* have a clear parallelism with the acts narrated in the canonical book of the *Acts of the Apostles*. The journeys and his preaching are the leitmotif.

The three central parts of these *Acts* are the narration of Tecla, the correspondence of Paul with the Corinthians from Philippi, and the martyrdom of the apostle, and all of which have the geographic range of his journeys based on various stays as their context: Damascus, Jerusalem, Antioch in Syria, Iconium, Myra, Sidon, Tyre, Ephesus, Philippi, Corinth, and Rome. Even though the author of the *Acts of Paul* seeks to edify and entertain the reader, it is also clear that the text reflects bitter theological debates which situate us in the context of an open struggle against certain facets of gnosticism. The author, despite the fantasy of certainty of the happenings narrated, seems to keep within the parameters of relatively orthodox theses. The quotation of biblical facts from both Testaments clearly shows that the author considers them as a historical unit, and admits them as his principle of authority. However, as in many of the apocryphal *Acts*, encratism is not absent from this work. For the most part, the author is not a systematic and organised writer, but a compiler who finds oral and written legends in tradition, which he gathers together with his own inventions.

These *Acts of Paul* were known and documented only a few years after their composition[125], due to the undisputed importance of the personage, the doctrinal

124 Ed. M. Bonnet, *Acta Pauli,* in *Acta Apostolorum Apocrypha*, vol. I, ed. R. Lipsius – M. Bonnet, New York 1972, 235–272. Critical edition and translation into Spanish by A. Piñero – G. del Cerro, *Hechos de Pablo,* in *Hechos Apócrifos de los Apóstoles II*, Madrid 2005, 730–859.

125 The text soon became known in Rome and Carthage. It aroused concern in Tertullian and in Rome and was used by Hippolytus at the beginning of the third century as an argument of authority. Origen also cites this text on at least two occasions. For his part, Eusebius considered these *Acts* as false and accordingly not accepted in the canon, together with the *Shepherd of Hermes,* the *Apocalypse of Peter,* the *Epistle of Barnabas* and the *Didache*, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 3, 25, 6. The reasons for its probable repudiation by the Church, despite being cited on occasion by ecclesiastical authors, might have been due to passages such as the self-baptism of Tecla, the story of the baptism of the lion, its encratistic tendencies, and the publication of an apocryphal letter of the Apostle *(3 Cor)*.

situation at a time of confrontation with the gnostics, and the attractive personality of characters such as Tecla, virgin, confessor, and martyr[126].

Tertullian, when speaking of the author of the *Acts,* states that he was "a presbyter from Asia" desirous of adding something of his own to the Apostle's prestige. But after being convicted and having confessed, he was dismissed from his ecclesiastical office, despite his confession that he had done it *amore Pauli*[127]. This information by Tertullian coincides with the relatively detailed treatment he makes of the happenings in that region. The date of composition of the work has Tertullian's work dated about the year 200 as a reference. Conscious that the work, if it was written in Asia Minor, took time to spread around Africa, certain scholars think that it was composed in the middle to the end of the second century.

Of particular interest to us is the fact that Paul arrived in Ephesus coming from Smyrna where he supposedly had carried out some activity[128]. This news is transmitted by the Bodmer Papyrus and coincides with the narration in the *Life of Polycarp* which states that Paul passed through Smyrna where he lodged in the house of Strataeas, brother of Timothy.

C. Schmidt pointed out, in a marginal note to a study on the *Acts of Paul,* the fact that a large part of the names appearing in this text can also be found on inscriptions encountered in Smyrna, such as: Hermogenes, Hermocrates, Hermipus, Dion, Apollophanes, Hieronymus, Treptus, Triphena, Stratonice, and Artemis. For this reason, C. Schmidt suggested that the author of the *Acts of Paul* was a presbyter of the church of Smyrna. This scholar also drew attention to a possible common encratism between Polycarp's letter *To the Philippians* and the *Acts of Paul,* as also the similar treatment by both writings of terms such as ἐγκράτεια[129], ἁγνεία[130] and δικαιοσύνη[131]. He also noted the common formula in the heading of the apocryphal epistle of the Corinthians to Paul and that of Polycarp *To the Philippians:* Στέφανος καὶ οἱ σὺν αὐτῷ πρεσβύτεροι[132] and Πολύκαρπος καὶ οἱ σὺν αὐτῷ πρεσβύτεροι[133]. Just as C. Schmidt noted these coincidences, he also drew

126 The figure of Tecla went down well with authors such as Methodius of Lycia, Gregory Nazianzen, John Chrysostom, Ambrose, Zeno of Verona, Augustine, etc.

127 Cf. Tert., *bapt.,* 17 (CCSL 1, 291–292).

128 Cf. *Acta Pauli,* Pap. Bodmer (ed. A. Piñero – G. del Cerro, Madrid 2005, 782).

129 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 4, 2; 5, 2.

130 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 5, 3; 12, 2.

131 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 3, 1; 4, 1; 5, 2; 8, 1; 9, 1, 2.

132 *Acta Pauli* (ed. A. Piñero and G. del Cerro, Madrid 2005, 804).

133 Polyc., *ep.,* praef.

attention to the apparent lack of geographic acquaintance of the author of the *Acts* with Smyrna[134].

In a subsequent study, C. Schmidt once more noted the apparent coincidence between Paul's visit to the house of Strataeas, who appears at the beginning of the *Life of Polycarp,* in an episode similar to that of Paul's visit to the house of Onesiphorus in *The Acts of Paul.* In the former, Paul speaks to the community about Easter and Pentecost, in the latter Paul before the community, of continence and resurrection[135]. Regarding this and other small similarities C. Schmidt affirms that the *Life of Polycarp,* the letter *To the Philippians,* and even the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* have taken elements from the *Acts of Paul.* Moreover, he launched the hypothesis that the ancient archives (ἀϱχαῖα ἀντίγϱαφα) which the author of the *Life of Polycarp* states he has found in the Church of Smyrna and in which he tells the news of Paul's visit to that city at the time of Strataeas, were the *Acts of Paul.*

With regard to this thesis of C. Schmidt who places the *Acts of Paul* as the source of certain texts related to the Church of Smyrna and who identifies its author as coming from that city, we must say that it has not been accepted in subsequent studies and on the contrary has been practically ignored.

In fact, the thesis is very weak since in the multiplicity of locations in which the history of the *Acts of Paul* unfolds, the city of Smyrna appears mentioned only once and in a marginal way as mentioned earlier. Whereas the names which appear on the inscriptions of Smyrna likewise appear on inscriptions from other cities in Asia Minor and in an equivalent proportion. The similarities and treatment that C. Schmidt finds of certain theological concepts may simply be attributed to the common environment of Christian writings of Asia Minor in the second century.

In conclusion, we consider that this text should be classified as an indirect source, since it can only offer us the mention of Paul's passing through Smyrna and an idea of the popular missionary preaching of the Pauline teaching in the framework of Asia Minor at the end of the second century[136].

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134 Cf. C. Schmidt, *Acta Pauli, Übersetzung, Untersuchungen und Koptischer Text* Leipzig 1905, 205, note 1. The thesis of C. Schmidt has been repeated on subsequent occasions but without further development, cf. A. Souter, *The Text and Canon of the New Testament,* London 1960[r], 72.

135 Cf. C. Schmidt, *Gespräche Jesu mit seinen Jüngern nach der Auferstehung,* Leipzig 1919, 714.

136 Cf. O. Pasquato, *Predicazione missionaria in Asia Minore nel II secolo. In margine agli atti di Paolo,* in *Augustinianum* 23 (1983) 337–347.

4. Irenaeus Lugdunensis, Adversus Haereses 3, 3, 4[137]

In this fragment of his work Irenaeus gives us news of Polycarp as bishop of Smyrna established by the apostles themselves, narrates the journey he made to Rome to meet Pope Anicetus and discuss on the date of Easter. With regard to his activity in Rome against heresies, he transmits the famous episode in which Polycarp meets up with Marcion in Rome and recognises him as "son of Satan". He also reports that Polycarp wrote various letters including *To the Philippians.* He likewise gives witness of the Pauline and Johannine apostolic tradition in Ephesus.

This portion of book three is an important source from which Eusebius himself in the fourth century extracted abundant information, as we noted earlier.

5. Tertullianus, De praescriptione haereticorum 32, 2[138]

Tertullian transmits to us a brief report on the ordination of Polycarp as bishop of Smyrna by the apostle John and of the ordination of Clement as bishop of Rome by the apostle Peter.

6. Eusebius Caesariensis, Historia Ecclesiastica

There are different fragments of Eusebius which testify to certain situations relating to Polycarp or to Smyrna[139]. Many of these news have been extracted from book 3 of *Against heresies* by Irenaeus or from the letters of Ignatius; however, importance is attached to the transmission and interpretation of the texts undertaken later by Eusebius which, as we have seen, to a large extent, condition studies on the direct sources.

7. Hieronymus presbyter, De Viris Illustribus 17[140]

Polycarp belongs to the illustrious men to whom Hieronymus dedicates a chapter of his work. Apart from the information transmitted by the other sources, it is interesting that Hieronymus identifies Polycarp as leader of the whole of Asia and affirms that still at the time of writing, the letter *To the Philippians* is

137 Cf. SCh 211, 39–45. The text has come down to us in a complete Latin version and in fragments in Greek given by Eusebius in the *Historia Ecclesiastica*.

138 Cf. CCL 1, 212–213.

139 Eus., *h. e.* 3, 28, 6; 3, 36, 1–15; 4, 14, 1–5; 4, 15, 1–48; 5, 5, 8; 5, 20, 1–8; 5, 24, 1–18.

140 Cf. Ed. T. Halton, *St. Jerome. On Illustrious men*, Washington 1999, 35–36.

read throughout that region. For the rest, he transmits the same information as Irenaeus and Eusebius.

8. Aelius Aristides, Sacrorum Sermonum: Ἱερῶν λόγων[141]

Aelius Aristides was born in a rural area of the region of Eastern Mysia, probably in the future Hadriani[142] in the year 117[143]. His father was called Eudaemon and was probably a priest of Zeus and a philosopher, he financed Aristides' excellent education and his citizenship of Smyrna. Aristides linked himself with this city from the time of his birth[144], so that subsequent authors in the Byzantine age called him "Smyrnaean", since a large part of his life and work will appear associated with this populous, prosperous, and cultured city which offered one

141 *Sacrorum Sermonum,* 47–52, (*Aelii Aristidis Smyrnaei quae supersunt omnia,* ed. B. Keil, vol. II: *Orationes XVII–LIII*, Berlin 1958). *Sacrorum Sermonum*, are also cited as: *orationes* (*or*). The work by Aristides in critical edition was undertaken by B. Keil, but he only published the second volume (17–53) in Berlin, 1898. His work remained unfinished. At last, F. Lenz and C. Behr took over the task begun by B. Keil. Whereas C. Behr undertook the project of publishing Aelius Aristides in three volumes (I: 1–16, II: 17–53, and III: Scholia), of which only the first has appeared in four fascicules. He also published in *Loeb Classical Library* a first volume in 1973 of the four planned. We only possess the complete translation of the whole work into a modern language, Spanish, in Editorial Gredos in five volumes ed. F. Gascó, A. Ramírez de Verger, J. Cortés Copete and L. Llera Fueyo. The Latin titles of the works we use in this presentation of the sources are taken from the edition by B. Keil.

142 This city erected in the year 124 as also Hadrianutherae and Hadrianea owe their existence and name to the emperor Hadrian who visited this area in the year 123, encouraging a new urban development there, cf. W. Ramsay, *The historical geography of Asia Minor,* London 1990, 157 and 457.

143 We know the year of his birth thanks to a series of horoscopes that he himself offers, cf. Aristid., *or.,* 47, 31; 48, 16; 50, 57; 51, 20.

144 Smyrna granted Aelius Aristides higher prerogatives than those granted to him by his native city in the region of Mysia, cf. Aristid., *or.,* 50, 73. Mysia was an ancient region situated in the north-west of the Anatolian peninsula. It had an outlet on the coast of the Sea of Marmara and one on the Aegean Sea. It bordered with the region of Troad to the north-east, Phrygia and Bithynia to the east, and Lydia to the south. The most important cities of the region were Pergamum, Cyzicus, Lampsacus, and Nicomedia. Its territory corresponds approximately to the present-day Balikesir Province, in Turkey.

of the best frameworks for the activity of a sophist such as he was[145]. There he met personages like Epagathus and Zosimus who introduced him to the world of dreams as a medium to communicate with the gods, and in particular as a fervent worshipper of the god Asclepius[146]. He studied grammar with Alexander of Cotiaeus, master of Marcus Aurelius, in this way acquiring a good knowledge of Plato. From the hand of Aristocles in Pergamum and of Polemon in Smyrna he learnt the art of sophistry, subsequently resided for a time in Athens and Alexandria, perfecting his studies and making important friendships. On his return to Smyrna, in the midst of a tempest at sea and in exchange for having survived it, he promised the god Serapis to compose a hymn in his honour, which came to be the first writing that we possess from a long list of hymns and discourses. He also undertook a famous journey to the capital of the Empire seeking the favour of the emperor for himself and for the city of Smyrna. Due to his ruined health, each time his was works addressed to the god Asclepius, *Sacred Discourses,* will be more intense and frequent. After living for two years in the Asclepeion of Pergamum, he recovered his health and returned to Smyrna at the end of the year 147 where despite continuous pressure by his fellow citizens to hold public posts or of religious worship he never accepted, pleading his poor health as an impediment[147]. His fame as an orator and his political influence grew throughout the region of Asia to the point that Marcus Aurelius in his official visit to the city of Smyrna asked him to declaim in his presence. Following the earthquake which shook the city in about 177 or 178, Aristides, in the best Sophist tradition, used his talent and the consolidation of his relationship with Marcus Aurelius in favour of the reconstruction of the city[148]. The last writing of

145 For a good description of the cultural environment of Smyrna at the time of Aelius Aristides, cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna. A History of the City from the Earliest Times to 324 A.D.,* Oxford 1938, 247–248.

146 Cf. Aristid., *or.,* 50, 54; 47, 27, 40.

147 For a general vision of the institutions and civic life in Asia Minor at the time of Aelius Aristides, cf. D. Magie, *Roman Rule in Asia Minor to the End of the Third Century a. Chr.,* New York 1975, 639–658, cf: A. Macro, *The Cities of Asia Minor under the Roman Imperium,* in *Aufstieg und Niedergang II 7, 2* (1980) 658–697: cf. Mr. Rosser, *Asiarchen und Archiereis Asias* in *Studii Clasice* 16 (1974), 101–111.

148 Regarding the relationship of Aelius Aristides with Marcus Aurelius, cf. A. Birley, *Marcus Aurelius: A Biography,* London 2004, 262 et seqq.; cf. R. Pack, *Two Sophists and Two Emperors,* in *Classical Philology* 42 (1947).

this great sophist may be dated to about the year 180 shortly before his death in the Laneion, the country estate which he never left in the last years of his life[149].

The *Sacred Discourses* are quite rightly the most famous and interesting work of Aristides. Despite the complexity of the work on account of its fragmentary nature, these discourses are a highly personal witness of a singular nature of the pagan response in Asia Minor to the spiritual crisis of the second century which would come to a head in the third century, known as the Age of Anxiety[150]. This is a spiritual autobiography also destined to exalt the miracles of the god Asclepius. According to the sophist, it was Asclepius himself who in about the year 143 ordered him to make a record of the divine dreams in which the sick man should transcribe each and every one of the divine apparitions. After one year of convalescence in the sanctuary of Pergamum, when the god had healed his physical health, he also began to recuperate his intellectual powers and thus began to write. A large part of these *Sacred Discourses* lack temporal references and internal organisation, since Aristides understood the god's order as a therapeutic practice and not as the basis for a subsequent work of exaltation of Asclepius. Accordingly, the final writing of these six *Sacred Discourses* will only take place some time later between the years 170 and 175.

I *Sacred Discourse*: Aristides begins his work of introspection, speaks on the diary of dreams, narrates the healing of the tumour, and relates the death of Zosimus in which he believes he took part in a decisive way.

II *Sacred Discourse*: he exalts the figure of Asclepius as legislator of destiny, narrates how Asclepius saved him from death, makes a catalogue of marvellous baths, and relates his journey to Rome where he suffered the severe illness which cut short his career as a public orator.

III *Sacred Discourse*: he makes a catalogue of twelve anecdotes without any transcendency except the narration on the earthquake of Smyrna and tells of his return to political activity.

IV *Sacred Discourse*: he recounts the new situations confronting him on his return to political activity such as the legal problems, his journeys, public declamations, and sophist rivalries. In particular, he relates the journey to Aesepus and the recovery of his health, explains the possession of a series of juridical benefits, and tells of the numerous controversies he had with Julius Severus, governor of the province of Asia in the years 151 and 152.

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149 After the year 180, no further news is forthcoming on the life of Aelius Aristides, thus it is presumed that he died during the reign of Commodus.

150 Cf. E. Dodds, *Pagans and Christians in an Age of Anxiety,* Madrid 1975.

V *Sacred Discourse*: he narrates the continuous journeys to Smyrna and justifies the position of withdrawal in which he has been living with from the winter of the year 170 as a result of the order of the god Asclepius. Accordingly, he relates his last stage as a public orator and attributes to orders of the divinity his last public acts which were, without any doubt, reprehensible for one political faction of society[151].

VI *Sacred Discourse*: this is a discourse even more fragmentary than usual and following the same line as the V.

These *Sacred Discourses* offer for our study on the Christian community of Smyrna, a reflection on how the relationship of the pagans around the worship of Asclepius was lived, offering valuable elements in the field of the conception of medicine, health, and the healing rites which will be subsequently compared with the Christian proposal. Besides this, they offer a panorama on public activity, the Sophist efforts, the habits of Smyrna, and details on the dietetical regime of the city.

9. Aelius Aristides, Oratio de concordia ad civitates Asiaticas: Περὶ ὁμονοίας ταῖς πόλεσιν[152]

This work on the concord between the cities of Ephesus, Pergamum, and Smyrna is the most political writing we have of Aristides. This discourse was pronounced early in the year 167 in the meeting-hall of the Council of the city of Pergamum within the framework of celebrations for the new year. These celebrations were organised by the assembly of cities of the Asian province, or Asiatic *koinón*[153]. Aristides denounces the danger that the last redoubt of Greek freedom from Rome risks being lost precisely on account of the rivalry between the cities of the province for holding the primacy or pre-eminence over the

151 Aelius Aristides had aligned himself with the politics of Lucius Verus which consisted of a promotion of Hellenism marginally to the authority of Rome, but when Marcus Aurelius came to power those who had adopted this attitude were viewed with suspicion, cf. J. Cortés Copete, *Aristides,* Madrid 1999, 271.

152 Cf. Aristid., *or*., 23, (*Aelii Aristidis,* ed. B. Keil, vol. II: *Orationes XVII–LIII*, Berlin 1958).

153 For a full study on this institution, cf. M. Campnile, *I sacerdoti del koinòn d'Asia (I sec. a. C.– III sec. d. C.): contributo allo studio della romanizzazione delle élites provinciali nell'Oriente greco*, Pisa 1994.

others[154]. This situation forced the imperial governors to a possible intervention outside of their functions in order to guarantee the order and stability of the region. Aristides' proposal consists of reinforcing the structure of the provincial assembly, the *koinón,* so as to cease constituting the framework of rivalry, to become instead a strong institution with a personality of its own within the Empire. Aristides appeals to the very desire of emperor Hadrian to encourage the cities in the region to do more to foster a climate of inter-city relations rather than seeking particular privileges[155]. The work may be organised as follows:

1–7: Preface.
8–26: Praise of the Province and its cities.
27–40: Concord and faction.
41–53: Historical examples.
54–58: War and faction.
59–80: The situation under the Empire and advantages of union.

This work offers us a complete overview of relations between the cities of Asia Minor in the early centuries of Christianity, giving us a description of its civil institutions and of political emulation between the cities of Ephesus, Pergamum, and Smyrna.

10. Aelius Aristides, In smyrnam oratio: Σμυρναϊκὸς πολιτικὸς[156]

This discourse on Smyrna (*In Smyrnam oratio)* was composed in that city between the years 157 and 176, probably on the occasion of the arrival of the emperor Marcus Aurelius and his son Commodus[157] or the arrival of the governor

154 The elements in dispute included the honorific designations such as the "Foremost in Asia", obtaining permission from the Romans to raise a temple in honour of the emperor, etc.

155 It would seem that already during the reign of Marcus Aurelius that coins were struck figuring the motto "Concord" referring to Ephesus and Smyrna. In the first few years of Commodus, other coins bearing the same motto incorporated that of "*Koinón*", cf. M. Cortés Copete, *Aristides,* 104, cf. R. Pera, *Homonoia sulle monete da Augusto agli Antonini,* Genova 1984, 105–109.

156 Cf. Aristid., *or.,* 17, *In Smyrna oratio* (*Aelii Aristidis,* ed. B. Keil, vol. II: *Orationes XVII–LIII*, Berlin 1958).

157 The two emperors, father and son, following the revolt of Avidius Cassius, made a journey through the East which brought them to Cilicia, Antioch, Egypt, Smyrna, Ephesus, and Athens, cf. A. Boulanger, *Aelius Aristide et la sophistique dans la province*

of the province of Asia. The author limits himself to giving a portrait of the city with the clear intention of encouraging and exciting the desire not only to visit it but to stay in it for some time. Thus, after a brief introduction of a historical nature reflecting the three mythological stages in the foundation of the city[158], and the memory of the celebration of the Sacred Boat during the Dionysia, the author makes a tour around the city and its surroundings recalling the extraordinary beauties possessed by Smyrna. Being a discourse addressed to an authority, the work departs from the typical canons of a harangue of welcome, since it does not contain the praise of the addressee as required by the rules.

11. Aelius Aristides, Monodia de Smyrna: Ἐπὶ Σμύρνῃ μονῳδία[159]

This brief and singular work which departs from the traditional Atticism of the sophist and instead uses Asiatic rhythms[160] is a product of his sadness at the destruction of the city of Smyrna by an earthquake in about the year 178. The genre used is the monody, a type adequate in literature for a funeral discourse in which the author recriminates destiny, laments the irrecuperable past and weeps for the present. The discourse is replete with exclamatory and powerfully rhythmic phrases. He wrote this monody from Laneion, his country property in Mysia, after hearing of the terrible event.

12. Aelius Aristides, Oratio de Smyrna ad Reges Romanorum: Ἐπιστολὴ περὶ Σμύρνης πρὸς τοὺς βασιλέας[161]

This letter to the emperors is the second literary document that Aristides writes following the devastating earthquake of the year 178. This time it is not a

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d'Asie au IIe siècle de nostre ère, Paris 1923, 384–387. On the foreign policy of Hadrian, cf. M. Rizzi, *Hadrian and the Christians,* Berlin 2010; A. Brent, *Ignatius of Antioch and the Second Sophistic,* Tübingen 2006.

158 The three foundations of Smyrna are attributed to Tantalus or to Pelops the first, to Theseus the second, and to Alexander the Great the third, cf. Aristid., *or.,* 21, 3–4, 10.

159 Cf. Aristid., *or.,* 18, *Monodia de Smyrna* (*Aelii Aristidis,* ed. B. Keil, vol. II: *Orationes XVII–LIII*, Berlin 1958).

160 Cf. A. Boulanger, *Aelius Aristide et la sophistique dans la province d'Asie au IIe siècle de notre ère*, Paris, 1923, 325–328.

161 Cf. Aristid., *or.,* 19, *Oratio de Smyrna ad Reges Romanorum* (*Aelii Aristidis,* ed. B. Keil, vol. II: *Orationes XVII–LIII*, Berlin 1958).

lamentation or a funeral dirge but an appeal by the orator, who appoints himself minister and decides to act as ambassador of the city to the emperors Marcus Aurelius and Commodus for the reconstruction of Smyrna. The arguments handled by Aristides are three: the fact that the emperors were acquainted with what had been destroyed since they had visited the city in the year 176; the perception that the reconstruction of the city with imperial funds would be a clear demonstration to the whole Empire of the character and virtues of the two emperors, since building activity constituted one of the essential elements of the imperial function; and thirdly, he recalls the services the city had offered to the Roman cause during the Republic, when the latter was struggling in vain against the Hellenistic kings, now being the opportunity for such favour to be recognised[162]. Aristides wrote this letter from Laneion, his country estate in Mysia, where he happened to be when the tragic earthquake struck.

This letter proved highly effective, the emperors convoked the Senate and obtained its approval for the reconstruction of the city by a senator of pretorian rank, money in cash was granted, with a temporary exemption from taxes and the granting of honours and privileges which also served to mobilise private initiative for the cause. Aristides' prestige grew in the face of such a positive reaction of the Empire to his petition, until he came to be considered the "founder" of the new city, a title of almost divine character[163].

13. Aelius Aristides, Palinodia de Smyrna instaurata: Παλινῳδία ἐπὶ Σμύρνῃ καὶ τῷ ταύτης ἀνοικισμῷ[164]

Aristides writes this small work a few years after the tragedy and the effective help of the emperor and the Greek citizens, both Continental and Asian, for the rebuilding of the city which without a doubt was already going ahead at a good pace so that its first-fruits could be seen. Although the work is known as a retractation or palinode[165] of Aristides from his *Monody on Smyrna* in which he used

162 Cf. J. Cortés Copete, *Aristides,* 42.

163 Cf. J. Cortés Copete, *Aristides,* 43.

164 Cf. Aristid., *or.,* 20, *Palinodia de Smyrna instaurata* (*Aelii Aristidis,* ed. B. Keil, vol. II: *Orationes XVII–LIII*, Berlin 1958).

165 A palinode is an ode in which the author retracts from a point of view or opinion expressed in an earlier poem. The first use conserved of a palinode is a poem by Stesichorus in the seventh century B.C., in which he retracts from his earlier affirmation that the Trojan War was exclusively the fault of Helen. The word comes from the Greek πάλιν, "once more", and ᾠδή, "song". Its Latin equivalent is *recantio, recantus* or *retractatio.*

a funereal and pessimistic language, in actual fact there are very few passages which constitute a retractation of his opinion on the terrible fate of the city following the earthquake. On the contrary, this is a discourse of political nature in which he attempts, first of all, to justify his absence from the city at a time of such great difficulty as the earthquake[166]; accordingly, he makes up for this shortcoming by emphasising his role as ambassador to the emperors, which to his mind, was transcendental for the reconstruction of Smyrna. Finally, he thanks both the emperors and the Greeks for their prompt succour and support of the city.

14. Aelius Aristides, Gratulatio Smyrnaea (ad Commodum): Σμυρναϊκὸς προσφωνητικός[167]

This work written in about the year 180 to the son of a provincial governor or perhaps the emperor Commodus, is the last writing in which Aristides makes mention of the earthquake and reconstruction of Smyrna, and probably also the last one by the sophist to go down in history. The work greets this lofty personage who is preparing to visit the city probably within the *conventus iuridicus,* and to whom Aristides promises a worthy show in view of the advancement of the works of rebuilding the city.

In conclusion, all these works regarding the city of Smyrna before, during and after the earthquake, unlike the sophist's other works which have come down to us, are not rhetorical exercises or works destined to sustain disputes with other members of the profession, but are directly linked with the spheres of power, whether municipal, provincial, or imperial[168]. These writings give us a good account of the landscape of the city of Smyrna and the public places it possessed, they speak to us of its history and of its gods, transmit its idiosyncrasy, report on the fame of the city throughout the Empire and of the even exacerbated hellenism to be found in the popular imagination, at the same time as its profound relationship of friendship and fidelity with the capital of the Empire. Accordingly, all the various works by Aelius Aristides presented here constitute an important

166 Regarding earthquakes and civic conscience in the ancient world, cf. J. Cortés Copete, *Ciudad y terremotos,* in *Ritual y conciencia cívica en el Mundo Antiguo,* ed. J. Alvar – C. Blánquez – C. Wagner, Madrid 1995, 171–179.

167 Cf. Aristid., *or.,* 21, *Gratulatio Smyrnaea ad Commodum* (*Aelii Aristidis,* ed. B. Keil, vol. II: *Orationes XVII–LIII*, Berlin 1958).

168 Cf. J. Cortés Copete, *Aristides,* 9.

source for study of the historical and social situation of the Christian community of Smyrna in the midst of the institutions and the pagan world surrounding it.

15. Constitutiones apostolorum 7, 46, 8[169]

The *Apostolic Constitutions* are a compilation of written and oral traditions in Antioch in Syria dated around the year 380 made. We are interested in particular in the lists of the first bishops of the principal cities of Christianity which appear to be compiled here. Several of these lists also make reference to the apostle who "established" these first three bishops. None of them appears on the list as having a direct relationship with the apostles: "In Smyrna the first was Ariston, followed by Strataeas, son of Lois, and the third, Ariston".

In particular, our attention is drawn to the absence of Polycarp and the repetition of the name of Ariston and also that the name of Strataeas appears with the specific mention of a family relationship.

The information given by the *Apostolic Constitutions* is not entirely worthy of credit, in particular the lists of bishops may be seriously influenced by a vision of anachronistic episcopal succession. However, the names of "Ariston" and "Strataeas" do not appear in the New Testament, as do many of the names appearing in the episcopal lists of other churches reported by this source. If we say that undoubtedly the criterion of placing well known names in the episcopal lists was one intention pursued, the names of "Ariston" and "Strataeas" acquire a certain degree of credibility, since they do not follow this criterion. Still, we are at all times moving on the plane of hypotheses.

It will be up to us to appraise this written tradition in the light of other traditions in the second part of this research when attempting to pinpoint the possible apostolic origins of the community of Smyrna and the configuration of its first leaders. Provisionally then, on account of the lateness of this source and its possible anachronisms, we have situated it among the indirect sources.

16. Pseudo-Dionysius, Epistula ad Polycarpum[170]

There is still no certain knowledge of the identity of the person who under the name of Dionysius Areopagite recorded in *Ac* 17, 34, composed towards the end

169 Cf. SCh 336, 108–112.

170 Cf. PG 3, 1077C–1081C. The translation into Spanish and the commentary are by T. H. Martín–Lunas, *Obras Completas del Pseudo Dionisio Areopagita*, Madrid 1995², 387–390.

of the fifth century the various writings grouped in the *corpus Dionysiacum*. It would appear safe to state that the author of this *corpus* was probably a Christian of Syriac origin who had stayed a long time in the school of Athens as disciple of the neoplatonist philosopher Proclus. Among the ten letters contained in the *corpus Dionysiacum* is also no. seven addressed supposedly to Polycarp in answer to a letter sent by the bishop of Smyrna, who seems to have intimated that he was involved in a controversy with the sophist Apollophanes.

The content of the letter is a statement that the demonstration of truth is sufficient on its own to confute contrary theses, and then goes on to speak of the sophist Apollophanes, who does not appear to recognise the presence of divine law in the universe, and of the solar eclipses which occurred on the death of Jesus and were observed by Pseudo-Dionysius in Heliopolis.

The later date of the letter compared to the time which concerns us is apparent, as also is the literary fiction of addressing it to Polycarp due to its claimed setting in the apostolic age which the author desires to give to his work. Accordingly, this source merely reflects the echo produced by the figure of Polycarp in subsequent centuries.

17. Gregorius episcopus Turonensis, Historiarum libri decem[171]

This work, better known as *Historia Francorum,* is an important work by Gregory of Tours elaborated in the sixth century, which attempts to fill in the vacuum of information on Gaul in its time. In the first of the ten books, the bishop of Tours deals with the beginnings of creation and ends up with the story of the life and mission of Martin of Tours. Although the whole work is of vital importance for our knowledge of Merovingian Gaul, the sources of Gregory in the first books are principally the chronicles of Eusebius, Hieronymus, and Orosius.

In particular, we are interested by the news that Gregory, in the first book, gives to Polycarp and also his relationship with the Church of Gaul.

In 1, 28, he gives news on Polycarp, in the reign of Antoninus: "In Asia persecution broke out and the blessed Polycarp was consecrated to God in the fire, as a very pure holocaust, in the eightieth year of his age, a disciple of John the apostle and evangelist".

171 Cf. *Gregorii episcopi Turonensis historiarum libri X*, in *Monumenta Germaniae Historica, Scriptores Rerum Merovingicarum*, ed. B. Krusch, Hanover 1937–1951. The translation from Latin has been made based on this edition.

In 1, 29, speaking of the persecution in Gaul in the reign of Antoninus, he states that:

> Photinus, first bishop of the Church of Lyons, who, in the fullness of his days, punished with innumerable tortures, suffered martyrdom in the name of Christ. Likewise, the very blessed Irenaeus, successor of this martyr, who was sent by the blessed Polycarp to this city, shone for his marvellous virtues, who in a short time won over the whole community to Christianity, above all through his preaching. However, on the arising of persecution, the devil through the tyrant stirred up these wars and thus, in that place, a multitude of Christians were sacrificed for having confessed the name of God, and rivers of Christian blood flowed through the squares of the city. Of these Christians I was unable to determine either the number or the names, but God has recorded them in the book of life. And the executioner, in his presence, dedicated Irenaeus to Christ the Lord, after having afflicted him with innumerable tortures. And after him, another forty-eight martyrs were sacrificed, among whom I have read that Vetius Epagathus was the first.

Although this work is certainly a late one, it first of all consolidates the tradition that Polycarp was a disciple of the apostle and evangelist John. Secondly, it states that Irenaeus was sent to Lyons (*Lugdunum*) by Polycarp and that his mission there was successful. However, both news taken from a work remote from the events narrated in it by at least 350 years and with an anachronistic vision of the apostolic succession, on their own cannot be considered by us as worthy of credit.

18. Chronicon Paschale[172]

This is a document by an anonymous author which has come down to us thanks to a single manuscript of the tenth century. The prologue which dates from the first half of the seventh century deals with the theological foundation of the determination of the date of Easter in conformity with the Alexandrian tradition and the decisions of the Council of Nicaea, and announces a mathematical method to make theological truth coincide with historical exactitude for the purpose of demonstrating the harmony between the two. Hereafter, we give the chronological tables from the creation of the world up to the year 628. This calculation bears in mind the Olympic Games and the consular celebrations. The two items of news on the Church of Smyrna are of particular interest to us:

172 Ed. L. Dindorf, *Chronicon Paschale*, Bonn 1832. PG 92. M. Whitby, *Chronicon Paschale* 284–628 A.D., Liverpool 1989.

The first has to do with the story told by Clement of Alexandria in *Qui dives salvetur?*[173] on the conversion of a misguided young man in the days in which John visited cities around Ephesus following his return from Patmos. Clement does not specify the name of the city, although he remarks that some people in his time mention its name. In the *Chronicon Paschale* it appears that this city was Smyrna and that the date of this happening was the year 101[174]. The lateness of this link merely demonstrates the recurrent tradition of associating John with Asia Minor and the importance of Smyrna in the region.

The second is that the name of Apelles appears, who is greeted by Paul in *Rom* 6, 10 as one of the 72 disciples mentioned in *Lk* 10, 1–17 and appointed bishop of Smyrna[175]. The lateness of these records which assign episcopal sees to the 72 disciples and the absence of the name of Apelles from all the ancient documents shows the purely conjectural nature of this news.

19. Metrophanes, Panegyricum Polycarpi Smyrnensis[176]

Metrophanes, bishop of Smyrna, was a Byzantine author towards the middle of the ninth century and a bitter opponent of Phocaea. Following the Synod in the year 859, together with other companions, he was sent into exile to Chersonesus. On his return from exile, he took part in the anti-Phocaean Council of the year 869–870, only to suffer exile once more and died towards the year 912. Within the multiple works still existing by this author, in special canons and hymns, we find this panegyric to Polycarp of Smyrna pronounced on his feast day, 23 February.

The authenticity of this text is beyond doubt. The two surviving manuscripts affirm that Metrophanes is its author and the characteristics of language coincide with the other works by the bishop and Byzantian theologian.

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173 Cf. Clem., *q.d.s.,* 42, 1–15 (SCh 537, 209–221); this story is also told in Eus., *h. e.* 3,5–19.

174 Cf. *Chron. Pasch.,* 251 (ed. Dindorf, Bonnae 1832).

175 Cf. *Chron. Pasch.,* 214, 255. Apelles had already been linked as one of the 72 disciples of the Lord by Epiphanius in about the year 375, cf. H. Delahaye, *Les passions des martyrs et les genres littéraires,* Brussels 1933².

176 Cf. *The Panegyric of Polycarp of Smyrna Attributed to Metrophanes of Smyrna (BHG 1563),* ed. P. van Deun, – I. De Vos, in *Martyrdom and Persecution in Late Antique Christianity*, ed. J. Leemans, Leuven 2010, 311–332. The text is preserved in two manuscripts: *Athous, Lavra* Δ 62 of the XIII or XIV cent. and *Constantinopolitanus, Chalcensis Schola Theologica* 39 of the XVI cent.

On account of it being of late date and having the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* as its only source, this text cannot play an important role in the hagiography on Polycarp, since it gives no fresh news. Accordingly, we have considered this text as an indirect source.

Chapter III: Historical and literary appraisal of certain sources and particular problems

Hereafter we will make an appraisal of certain sources which in recent studies have been related with the Church of Smyrna and which call for a particular study on our part. Such are two fragments from Irenaeus in his work *Against heresies,* the *Letter to Diognetus,* and the *Pastoral epistles.* Finally, we will analyse the possibility of one or several attempts by the Church of Smyrna in its early centuries to group together in a collection the writings related with its martyred bishop known by scholars as the *corpus Polycarpianum.*

1. The teaching of the presbyter[177]

The text of this chapter of Irenaeus in *haer.,* 4, 27–32, has come down to us in a complete Latin version and in fragments in Greek given by Eusebius in the *Historia Ecclesiastica.* We also possess an Armenian version which makes a very literal translation from the original Greek.

For the purposes of our study, this considerable fragment of the work by Irenaeus requires a commentary on the thesis launched in a recent book by C. Hill according to which the presbyter to whom Irenaeus refers is Polycarp[178].

In this fragment, Irenaeus places special emphasis on one presbyter in particular whom he recognises as a disciple in the apostolic line[179] and attributes to him a teaching and several sayings[180], all framed within the confrontation with Marcionism. In referring to the presbyter, the text uses the words: *presbyter, senior* and ὁ πϱεσβύτεϱος[181], and for Irenaeus the category of "presbyter" would seem to be the key to the transmission of the faith from the apostolic era to the time in which he writes his work[182].

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177 The title of this part of the work of *Against heresies* is offered by the edition of SCh. Iren., *haer.,* 4, 27–32 (SCh 100, II, 729–800).

178 C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp,* Tübingen 2006.

179 Cf. Iren., *haer.,* 4, 27, 1.

180 Cf. Iren., *haer.,* 4, 27, 2; 30, 1; 31, 1.

181 Cf. Iren., *haer.,* 4, 27, 1; 27, 2; 28, 1; 39, 1; 33, 1; 32, 1.

182 Cf. C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp,* 7; cf. W. van Unnik, *The Authority of the Presbyters in Irenaeus' Works,* in *God's Christ and His People: Studies in*

The structure of the fragment on the teaching of the presbyter may be as follows[183]:

- God in Scripture corrects the faults of the ancients, he presents above all the case of David and Solomon: 4, 27,1.
- The ancients were saved by Christ through his descent to the lower realms of the earth: 4, 27, 2.
- The correction of the ancients by God teaches us a lesson: 4, 27, 3–4.
- In the New Testament justice is made manifest in a real way and for ever, and not figuratively or to a limited extent: 4, 28, 1–2.
- Heretics contradict themselves when they accuse the Lord who acted through Scripture: 4, 28, 3–31,3[184]
- The case of the Egyptians who harden their hearts: 4, 28, 3–29, 2.
- The case of the theft that the Hebrews committed: 4, 30, 1–4.
- The case of Lot and his daughters with child by their father: 4, 31, 1–3.
- Conclusion of the presbyter's teaching when he affirms that the two Testaments originate from the same single God: 4, 32, 1–2.

One difficulty of the Latin version of the text is that in 4, 27, 1, it presents this presbyter as someone who has heard from those who had seen the apostles (*ab his qui Apostolos viderant*) and in 4, 32,1, it presents the presbyter as a disciple of the apostles *(senior Apostolorum discipulus*). This apparent inconsistency regarding the relationship of the presbyter with the apostles, which in the former case seems to be one generation removed and in the second case appears direct, according to C. Hill has been overcome with the contribution of the literal Armenian version in 4, 27, in which, instead of saying that the presbyter listened to a tradition from those who had seen the apostles *(ab his qui Apostolos viderant)* and from their disciples, affirms that the presbyter heard this from the apostles whom he had seen and from

Honour of Nils Alstrup Dahl, ed. J. Jervell and W. Meeks, Oslo-Bergen-Tromso 1977, 248–260.

183 I propose a different structure to that of the edition of SCh, trying to be more explicit in the titles so that they are more descriptive in their content.

184 I suggest this subdivision because these three episodes are examples of situations unacceptable and difficult to justify by the faith and morality that the Marcionites found in the Scriptures. The presbyter's teaching accuses these heretics of ignoring the judgments (*iustificationes,* τὰ δικαιώματα) and the economies (*dispositiones,* τὰς οἰκονομίας) of God (Iren., *haer.,* 4, 30, 1), since they are unable to interpret these episodes in light of the New Testament.

their disciples[185]. Similarly, the difficulty of the Latin version of 4, 28, 1, where we find *presbyteri* in the plural with its respective verb in the plural, when in all the other parts of this fragment there is talk of a single presbyter, has been clarified according to C. Hill by the Armenian version which gives the noun and the verb in the singular, so that a transcriptional error of the Latin version may be postulated.

A. Rousseau has drawn attention to the literal nature of the Armenian version compared to the Latin translation of the original Greek. The Latin translation, although literal on many occasions, also makes the effort to rethink the original Greek on others. On the contrary, the Armenian version seems to have no other ambition than to offer a literal translation[186]. Nonetheless, another great scholar of Irenaeus such as A. Orbe, thinks that the Armenian version is in actual fact a simplification of the difficult text of Irenaeus on many occasions while at other times it sacrifices nuances of interest of the Latin version. For this reason, he very often avoids using it, which to his mind is excessive on the part of A. Rousseau[187].

Even so, in the case of the help of the Armenian version being acepted to establish the unity of this teaching transmitted by a single presbyter who finds himself in the apostolic line and who provided Irenaeus with a teaching to refute heresies such as that of Marcion, the need arises to establish the identify of the said presbyter.

First of all, there apparently are not many candidates capable of meeting the chronological criteria laid down by Irenaeus. That is, a presbyter whom Irenaeus considers as someone who heard the apostles and who is known to us through other testimonies of Irenaeus himself, who in his lifetime combated the errors of Marcion appears to be Polycarp.

The connections that Irenaeus makes of Polycarp with the apostles are clear, over and above the discussion regarding the categories that the author establishes on the apostolic succession[188]. Irenaeus said in *haer.,* 3, 3, 4, that Polycarp was not only instructed (μαθητευθείς) by the apostles but that he conversed (συναναστραφείς) with many of those who saw the Lord, that he was also made

185 A. Rousseau gives the expression of the Armenian version in Greek: τοῦ ἀκηκοότος παρὰ τῶν ἀποστόλων αὐτούς τε ἑωρακότος, cf. A. Rousseau, *Contre les Hérésies*, Paris, 1965 (SCh 100, 1), 263.

186 Cf. *ibid.,* 129.

187 Cf. A. Orbe, *Introducción a la teología de los siglos II y III,* Roma 1987, 454, 487, 488, 538, 794. Compare especially the long note of criticism on A. Rousseau regarding the use of the Armenian version, cf. A. Orbe, *La Teología del Espíritu Santo,* Roma 1966, 467–471.

188 We will be dealing with this discussion in the second part of this study, cf. 167–183.

bishop of the Church of Smyrna by the apostles in Asia, and that he always taught the doctrine that he had learned (ἔμαθεν) from the apostles. In his letter *To Florinus* as we have pointed out, Irenaeus calls Polycarp "blessed and apostolic presbyter" and invites Florinus to remember how Polycarp was accustomed to describe his "relations with John and with the others who had seen the Lord and how he remembered (ἀπεμνημόνευεν) the words of some or other of them" and "how Polycarp had received it from these eye-witnesses of the life of the Word"[189].

The confrontation of Polycarp with Marcion and his doctrine is likewise a fact that Irenaeus stresses in other texts. Irenaeus affirms that Polycarp had at least one personal meeting with Marcion, whom he called "firstborn of Satan"[190]. Here Irenaeus also states that Polycarp, on account of his greater authority, "converted to the Church of God many of the heretics", followers of Cerinthus and of Marcion[191]. Once more, we do not deal here with the veracity of these happenings narrated by Irenaeus, but with the relationship that Irenaeus establishes between Polycarp and Marcion in these texts.

And lastly, the personal experience of Irenaeus reported in the fourth book, who presents himself as a receiver of the oral instruction of the presbyter, comes within the framework of the relationship of excess acknowledged between Irenaeus and Polycarp. In *haer.,* 4, 32, 1, Irenaeus gives an understanding that he himself was present when the presbyter disciple of the apostles discussed (*disputabat*) the origin of both testaments starting off from the same and single God. In the letter *To Florinus,* Irenaeus states that he himself listened diligently to the teachings of Polycarp, noting them down not on paper, but in his heart (Ταῦτα… γεγονὸς σπουδαίως ἤκουον, ὑπομνηματιζόμενος αὐτὰ οὐκ ἐν χάρτῃ, ἀλλ᾽ ἐν τῇ ἐμῇ καρδίᾳ)[192]. He also states that he could even remember the place where Polycarp used to sit and dialogue, as well as the discourses he made to the people[193].

One other affirmation, according to C. Hill, linking the name of Polycarp to the presbyter author of the teaching transmitted by Irenaeus is the fact that Irenaeus, according to the testimony of Eusebius, had written to the heretic Florinus not only the aforementioned letter, but also a work entitled *On the monarchy* or *That God is not the author of evils*[194]. So that from the names of this work, today lost, we might deduce that the accusation made by Irenaeus

189 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 20, 6–7.
190 Iren., *haer.,* 3, 3, 4.
191 Cf. Iren., 3, 3, 4.
192 Eus., *h. e.* 5, 20, 7.
193 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 20, 6.
194 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 20, 1.

against Florinus was to defend a Marcionite teaching of two supernatural powers (δύο ἀρχάς)[195] or of a god author of evil. Arguments which the presbyter rightly combats in the anti-Marcionite teaching of *haer.,* 4, 27–32. So that it would appear logical to state that the teaching which Irenaeus in his letter *To Florinus* reproached the latter with having forgotten was precisely the teaching of Polycarp against the Marcionite ideas appearing in the text of *haer.,* 4, 27–32.

So now, if truly Polycarp is the presbyter author of the teaching transmitted by Irenaeus, it is only right to wonder why he did not explicitly mention his name in this part of his work. The reasoning of C. Hill is as follows: First of all, Irenaeus seems not to be accustomed to quoting ecclesiastical authorities when the reader is sufficiently acquainted. This is the case of when he cites, without mentioning their names, Ignatius of Antioch[196], Hermas[197] and various others[198].

Secondly, he stresses above all the fact that Irenaeus presupposes that the reader of his work will make the due and evident connection of the presbyters whom he mentions with those to whom reference has been made earlier in *haer.,* 3, 3–4: Linus, Anacletus, Clement of Rome, and Polycarp of Smyrna, and above all that the reader will relate the individual presbyter author of the teaching of 4, 27–31 with the last of these, on the basis of the personal contact that Irenaeus himself says he has had with Polycarp alone. It is probable, according to C. Hill, that the name of Polycarp could have been attested in the anti-Marcionite work of Irenaeus against Florinus that we have mentioned earlier, and accordingly, it was easy for the reader who knew this work to identify the presbyter as Polycarp.

Thirdly, it may be that the ultimate intention of Irenaeus in this fragment of the *Against heresies* is that the audience reading it will be able to identify itself with the character of the presbyter as a faithful disciple of the apostles rather than merely to exalt the figure of Polycarp.

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195 The testimony of Eusebius is clear in affirming that the doctrine of the two principles was introduced above all by Marcion, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 13, 3–4.

196 "Accordingly tribulation is necessary for those who save themselves; so that, as it were crushed, ground, and dispersed by the power of the Word of God, they serve cooked for the King's banquet. One of our people who, condemned to martyrdom, was flung to the wild beasts expressed himself thus: "I am corn of Christ, and the teeth of the wild beasts will chew me up, so that I find myself as corn of God", Iren., *haer.,* 5, 28, 4, cf. Ign., *Rom.,* 4. 1.

197 As the Scripture says: "First of all he believes that there is a single God who has created, made and carried through all things starting off from nothing in order for them to exist. He contains everything and nothing can contain him", Iren., *haer.,* 4, 20, 2, cf. Herm., *mand.,* 1.

198 Cf. Iren., *haer.,* 1, 13, 3; 3, 17, 4; 3, 23, 3; 5, 17, 4; 1, 15, 6.

All of these arguments have been expounded in some detail by C. Hill[199] and have received a positive appraisal on the part of various authors such as R. Bauckham[200], J. Carleton-Paget[201], M. Holmes[202], P. Hartog[203], L.H. Cohick,[204] and E. Norelli[205]. However, they were received with suspicion by M. Simonetti above all on account of the unreliability of the Armenian version affirmed by A. Orbe and the difficulty of giving an identity to this presbyter whom Irenaeus never mentioned explicitly by the name of Polycarp.

Thus, then, we may conclude that this fragment of *Against heresies* is testimony of an oral teaching by a presbyter to Irenaeus, whose identity is probably that of Polycarp although we cannot be perfectly sure of this, and accordingly we cannot consider it for the purposes of our study as a direct source.

2. The ancestors of the Valentinians[206]

In this section of his work (*haer.,* 1, 23–27), Irenaeus presents a catalogue that he calls forebears of the Valentinians. The dependence of Irenaeus on a more ancient source writing on heresies is usually accepted. Certain scholars such as

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199 Cf. C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp,* 8–24. It should be noted that the thesis proposed by C. Hill had in some way been propounded by P. Beatrice, *Der Presbyter des Irenäus, Polykarp von Smyrna und der Brief an Diognet*, in *Pléroma,* ed. M. Romero Pose, 179–202. However, already in 1999, J. Ayán Calvo considered the thesis of P. Beatrice which identified Polycarp with the presbyter of whom Irenaeus speaks in *haer.,* 4, 27–32 to be very slightly grounded, though he does not state the reasons for his disagreement, cf. J. Ayán Calvo, 194.

200 Cf. Cf. R. Bauckham, review on: C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp* in *Journal of Theological Studies* 60 (2) (2009) 674–676.

201 Cf. J. Carleton-Paget, review on: C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp,* in *Journal of Ecclesiastical History* 58 (2007) 294–295.

202 Cf. M. Holmes, review on: C. Hill, *From the Lost teaching of Polycarp* in *Religious Studies Review* 34, 4, (2008) 305.

203 Cf. P. Hartog, review on: C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp* in *The Westminster Theological Journal,* 71, 1 (2008) 221.

204 Cf. L. Cohick, review on: C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp,* in *Bulletin for Biblical Research* 18, 2 (2008) 359–360.

205 E. Norelli conveyed this to me personally in the headquarters of the Institutum Patristicum Augustinianum.

206 The title of this part of the work of Irenaeus is offered by the edition of SCh, ed. A. Rousseau, Paris 2008 (SCh 264, II), 312–356. The text of this section has also come down to us in a complete Latin version and in fragments in Greek given by Eusebius in his *Historia Ecclesiastica* and in the Armenian version.

R. Lipsius have thought of the lost *Syntagma* of Justin since Irenaeus gives information on Simon Magus, Menander, Saturninus, and Basilides (Iren., *haer.* 1, 23–24) who are mentioned in the *Dialogue with Trypho* and in the *Apologies*[207]. But, for their part, other scholars such as A. Harnack have pointed out that the personages of Carpocrates, Cerinthus, the Ebionites, the Nicolaitans and Cerdo, who likewise appear in this catalogue (Iren., *haer.,* 1, 25, 1–27, 1), are not found in Justin[208]. Finally, taking as the supposed great influence of Polycarp in the source on which I drew (Iren., *haer.,* 4, 27–32), C. Hill states that the source from which Irenaeus drank for this catalogue of heresies was undoubtedly Polycarp[209] and accordingly we are interested in making due commentary here.

According to C. Hill, textual evidence would appear to prove that the source used by Irenaeus for this catalogue of heresies is the same presbyter of the teaching of *haer.,* 4, 27–32. In *haer.* 4, 32, 1, the presbyter disciple of the apostles teaches that the two Testaments originate from the same single God, since the doctrines of those who affirm that this world of ours was made either by the angels, or by some other power, or by some other God (*aut per angelos aut per aliam quamlibet virtutem aut ab alio Deo factum esse hunc mundum*)[210] are groundless. We find this clear enumeration and tripartite distinction of the types of heretical doctrines regarding creation developed exactly in the same order in this catalogue of heresies as in *haer.,* 1, 23–27. The doctrine of creation by the angels (*per angelos*) is attributed in this text to Simon, Menander, Saturninus, Basilides, and Carpocrates and their followers[211]; the doctrine of creation by some other power (*per quamlibet virtutem*) is attributed to Cerinthus[212]; while a doctrine of creation by

207 Cf. R. Lipsius, *Die Quellen der aeltesten Ketzergeschichte,* in *The Early Christian Church,* vol. 2: *The Second Christian Century,* ed. P. Carrington, Cambridge 1957, 311.

208 Cf. A. Harnack, *Zur Quellenkritik der Geschichte des Gnosticismus,* Leipzig 1873.

209 C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp,* 25.

210 Cf. Iren., *haer.,* 4, 32, 1. In this tripartite cataloguing Irenaeus does not allude to the doctrine of the creation held by the Valentinians, which affirms that the world was created as the outcome of penury, as is clearly mentioned in other parts of his work, cf. Iren., *haer.,* 2 praef. 1; 2, 1, 1; 2, 2, 4; 3 praef. 1; 3, 10, 1; 4, 33, 3.

211 Cf. Iren., *haer.,* 1, 23, 2; 1, 23, 5; 1, 24, 1; 1, 24, 4; 1, 25, 1. Irenaeus affirms that Simon was the first to promulgate this doctrine, cf. Iren., *haer.,* 2, 9, 2. Geographically, Simon and Menander are believed to have taught this doctrine in Samaria, Saturninus in Syria, and Basilides and Carpocrates in Alexandria, cf. R. Perrotta, *Hairéseis. Gruppi, movimenti e fazioni del giudaismo antico e del cristianesimo (da Filone Alessandrino a Egesippo),* Bologna 2008, 626.

212 Cf. Iren., *haer.,* 1, 26, 1.

some other God (*ab alio Deo)* is attributed to Cerdo and Marcion[213]. The only exception to this correspondence between *haer.,* 4, 31, 1 and *haer.,* 1, 23–27 regarding the ternary classification of the heretical doctrines on creation is constituted by the mention of the Ebionites and the Nicolaitans[214] who appear mentioned after the mention on Cerinthus and before the mention of Cerdo and Marcion. The mention of these two groups, according to C. Hill, may be a supplement by Irenaeus himself following the same organising principle in presentation of the heretics, that is to say, the vision of creation which these heretical groups have, since Irenaeus affirms that the Ebionites confess that the world was made by God[215]. However, it should be noted that Irenaeus does not allude to the opinion held by the Nicolaitans on the creation of the world[216]. So that, for C. Hill, it is possible simply that both the Ebionites and the Nicolaitans were an appendix of Cerinthus for Irenaeus since all three sects were active above all in the region of Asia Minor[217]. It should also be stressed, as another argument for correspondence between *haer.,* 4, 27–32 and 1, 23–27, that the final *words* of the presbyter in 4, 32, 1 ends with the doctrine of Marcion teaching that the world was made by some other god, omitting any allusion to the Valentinian doctrine of creation, which Irenaeus tends to synthesise in other parts of his work as that which affirms that the world was created as the outcome of penury *(defectionis fructus* or ὑστερήματος καρπός)[218]. In the same way, in the catalogue of heresies in *haer.,* 1, 23–27, he also omits any mention of the doctrine of Valentine on creation.

According to C. Hill, another probable evidence, which would make it possible to identify the author of the catalogue of heresies in *haer.,* 1, 23–27 directly with Polycarp arises from a particularity of the prayer by the bishop of Smyrna that we find in the *Martyrdom of Polycarp*. In this prayer, Polycarp addresses God as "God of the angels, of the powers and of the whole of creation (ὁ θεὸς ἀγγέλων

213 Cf. Iren., *haer.,* 1, 27, 1; 27, 2.

214 Cf. Iren., *haer.,* 1, 26, 2; 26, 3.

215 Cf. Iren., *haer.,* 1, 26, 2.

216 Together with the antique heresiologists, we share in the ignorance regarding the Nicolaitans, whom we only know on the basis of the testimony of the author of the *Revelation* to the churches of Asia Minor, cf. *Rv* 2, 6; 2, 15.

217 Cf. Iren., *haer.,* 1, 26, 1. Justin, who converted to Christianity in Ephesus, makes clear allusion to the doctrine of the Ebionites in his *Dialogue with Trypho* shortly after the year 150, distinguishing two categories of Judeo-Christians: those who share the common faith, while remaining faithful to the Jewish practices and who are the descendants of the community of James; and others "who recognise Jesus as Christ, but say that he was a man among men", cf. Just., *dial.,* 47–48 (PG 6, 575–581).

218 Cf. Iren., *haer.,* 2, praef. 1; 2, 1, 1; 2, 2, 4; 3, 10, 1; 4, 33, 3.

καὶ δυνάμεων καὶ πάσης τῆς κτίσεως παντός)[219]. C. Hill states that even if we cannot be sure that every sentence of this prayer is *ipsissima verba* of Polycarp, this exclamation while not precisely heard by an eye-witness, was perhaps in fact drawn from a discourse habitually commented on by the bishop. The particularity of this expression in relation to the figure of Polycarp and also to the teaching of the presbyter in *haer.,* 4, 27–32 and the heresiological catalogue of *haer.,* 1, 23–27 could be highlighted even more clearly since this sentence lacks any parallel, either biblical[220] or from any other liturgical or martyrial source[221], thus permitting us to conclude that this is an authentic idiom of Polycarp[222].

Once more, all of these arguments have been expounded in detail by C. Hill[223] and have received a positive appraisal in different reviews by authors such as R. Bauckham, J. Carleton-Paget, M. Holmes, P. Hartog, L. Cohick and E. Norelli[224]; however, the very objections expressed by M. Simonetti to the identification of Polycarp as the presbyter of the teaching in *haer.,* 4, 27–32 make us extremely cautious about seeking to use this as a direct source for our study.

Even so, recognising the possibilities likewise as the difficulties of establishing the origin and influence of Polycarp on the heresiological catalogue of Irenaeus in this section, we prepare to present its structure on the basis of the data analysed:

- Doctrine of creation by the angels:
  - Simon Magus: 1, 23, 1–4.
  - Menander: 1, 23, 5.
  - Saturninus: 1, 24, 1–2.
  - Basilides: 1, 24, 3–7.
  - Carpocrates: 1, 25, 1–6.
- Doctrine of creation by some other power:

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219 *M. Polyc.,* 16, 1.

220 Neither in the LXX nor in the New Testament do we find a parallel expression. In the LXX we only find κύριος τῶν δυνάμεων in *1 K* 18, 15 and throughout the psaltery; less frequently we find κύριος ὁ θεὸς τῶν δυνάμεων in *1 K* 17, 1; *2 K* 19, 20; Ps 59, 6, but never ὁ θεὸς ἀγγέλων καὶ δυνάμεων καὶ πάσης τῆς κτίσεως. "Angels" and "powers" appear together in the New Testament only in *Rom* 8, 38–39 in the midst of a list of things which cannot separate us from the love of God, and in *1 P* 3, 22 where Christ appears on the right hand of God in heaven "now that he has made the angels and Dominations and Powers his subjects: ἀγγέλων καὶ ἐξουσιῶν καὶ δυνάμεων".

221 Cf. J. Robinson, *Liturgical Echoes in Polycarp's Prayer,* in *Expositor* 9 (1899), 63–72.

222 Cf. C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp,* 27–28.

223 Cf. C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp,* 24–31.

224 Cf. Notes 24–29.

  - Cerinthus: 1, 26, 1.
  - Ebionites: 1, 26, 2. (Inserted by Irenaeus).
  - Nicolaitans: 1, 26, 3. (Inserted by Irenaeus).
- Doctrine of creation by some other god:
  - Cerdo: 1, 27, 1.
  - Marcion: 1, 27, 2–4.

The consequences of any identification of the apostolic presbyter of whom Irenaeus speaks with Polycarp of Smyrna could be significant. This would establish a more substantial personal link between Irenaeus and Polycarp, which would permit us to affirm that Irenaeus did not receive all this information while still a young child in Smyrna, but on the contrary received a teaching from the master at an age when he was capable of learning it with sufficient assimilation.

He could have received this teaching from Polycarp in the city of Smyrna, as he recalls in his letter *To Florinus.* Even when he says that he was only a child, he also claims that he could learn all things by memory when the bishop spoke. There also exists the probability that Irenaeus had received this teaching years later in Rome when towards the year 154 Polycarp visited that city to deal with the question of Easter with bishop Anicetus. This second possibility would appear more plausible since Irenaeus states that Marcion flourished at the time of the episcopacy of Anicetus[225], reports a meeting of Polycarp, by this time an old man with Marcion in Rome, and affirms that Polycarp at this time was engaged in combating the Marcionite teaching[226].

For the rest, during his life as bishop of Lyons, Irenaeus seems never to have lost sight of his relationship with his native Smyrna. In fact, he manages to obtain a copy of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp*[227], testifies to the churches of Asia and to Polycarp's successors the orthodoxy of the Church in the face of the errors of Marcion and Valentine[228], successfully defends the Quartodecimanist tradition

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225 Iren., *haer.,* 3, 4, 3. We know that Marcion arrived in Rome in about the year 144, during the reign of Antoninus Pius, and that he was excommunicated some time in July in the year 144, a date that the Marcionite Church set up by him, with a hierarchy of bishops, presbyters and deacons, celebrated as the day of its foundation.

226 Cf. Iren., *haer.,* 3, 3, 4. We know that together with the death of Polycarp, according to the testimony of Eusebius "Metrodorus too, who it is thought was presbyter of the sect of Marcion, was delivered to the flames", Eus., *h. e.* 4, 15, 46. This means that, at least towards the end of Polycarp's episcopacy the presence of the Marcionite Church was a reality in Smyrna.

227 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 22, 2.

228 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 4, 14, 5.

of the Asian churches before pope Victor[229], and permits the report on the persecution suffered by the Christians in Gaul being sent to them[230].

In conclusion, all of these facts permit us to deduce that the relationship of Irenaeus with Polycarp and with Smyrna, was not limited to the first years of his life, as one might think on the basis of the letter *To Florinus* alone, but this relationship was probably prolonged over time in various ways, permitting him to solidly inherit a teaching of Polycarp regarding the Christian truth and the errors of other groups, especially that of Marcion[231]. It would perhaps be possible to arrive at this conclusion even without accepting the thesis of C. Hill on the basis of the other evidence presented; although certainly if this thesis of C. Hill were to be accepted this conclusion would be considerably reinforced; but unfortunately here we continue to move on the plane of hypothesis.

3. Epistula ad Diognetum[232]

This writing,[233] emblematic of antique Christian literature for the beauty of its style and its protreptic character,[234] is an anonymous work addressed to a certain

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229 Cf. Iren., *ep. Vict.,* in Eus., *h. e.* 5, 24, 12–17.

230 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 1, 1–63.

231 Although the news of Gregory of Tours, according to which Iranaeus was sent to Lyons on purpose by Polycarp, would appear to confirm the content of these paragraphs, we do not consider this a source of first order due to its late dating, cf. Gr. Tur., *h.,* 1, 29.

232 *A Diognète*, ed. H. Marrou, Paris 1965 (SCh 33, bis), and *The Epistle to Diognetus*, ed. J. Thierry, Leyden 1964. The text has come down to us in a thirteenth- or fourteenth-century codex in which it was attributed to Justin Martyr, together with four more works, likewise placed under his name: *De Monarchia, Cohortatio ad gentes, Expositio fidei* and *Oratio ad Graecos*. This codex was burned in 1870; however, a number of copies remained, one of which may be found in the University Library of Tübingen and was that used by F. Funk for the edition of his *Patres Apostolici I*, Tübingen 1901.

233 Traditionally the category of epistola has been given to it since it is addressed to a particular personage called Diognetus. However, it is not a letter as it has been classified repeatedly starting from its first edition in 1592, cf. C. Moreschini – E Norelli, *Patrología: Manual de literatura cristiana antigua y griega,* Salamanca 2009, 105.

234 The work has been traditionally catalogued as apologetic on account of its impassioned tone, its harmony and its stylistic clarity, its modulated style, and the skilful arrangement of the content. However, the critics today see its character as more protreptic than apologetic, since it aims at bringing the recipient to adopt a decision or an action, cf. M. Jordan, *Ancient Philosophic Protreptic and the Problem of*

Diognetus, a pagan personality of exalted condition desirous of knowing the Christian faith. To date, many attempts have been made to identify the environment of origin of this text traditionally linked with Alexandria on account of its concept of true gnosis so close to the theology of Clement and Origen[235]. Notwithstanding, the debate continues to be open and the tendency today is to situate it in an Asian[236] or Roman[237] environment between the second half of the second century and the beginning of the third century.

Above all its structure presents drawbacks with regard to the doubt as to whether the last two chapters are really a part of the work, as a result of the multiple allusion to scriptural texts that contrast with the rest of the work.

- Exordium: 1.
- Refutation of idolatry: 2.
- Refutation of Jewish ritualistic practices: 3–4.
- Christians in the world: 5–6.
- Divine origin of Christianity: 7.
- The manifestation of God through the incarnation: 8.
- The divine economy: 9.
- Charity, essence of the new religion: 10.
- Discourse on the Logos: 11–12.

After having conscientiously studied C. Hill's approach with regard to the letter *To Diognetus,* already proposed in some way by P. Beatrice[238], and the vigorous

Persuasive Genres, in *Rhetorica* 4 (1986), 314–327; cf. M. Simonetti – E. Prinzivalli, *Letteratura cristiana antica: Profilo storico, antologia di testi, e due saggi inediti in appendice,* Casale Monferrato 2007, 140.

235 However, the disowning of this work by Clement, Origen, Dionysius of Alexandria, and Eusebius of Caesarea make it difficult to situate the origin of the work in the Alexandrian milieu as proposed by H. Marrou, *A Diognète,* 242–243.

236 C. Hill situates *To Diognetus* in Asia Minor on account of the supposed reception which this work is thought to have in the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* in Irenaeus disciple of Polycarp, and in the author of the *Elenchus* which was in part influenced by the work of Irenaeus.

237 For E. Norelli, the arguments in this respect presented by C. Hill of the Asian origin of the writing are not convincing and, for his part, he affirms the Roman origin of the text, cf. E. Norelli, *A Diogneto. Introduzione, traduzione e note,* Milan 1991, 56–61.

238 P. Beatrice, *Der Presbyter des Irenäus, Polykarp von Smyrna und der Brief an Diognet* in *Pléroma; Salus carnis. Homenaje a Antonio Orbe, S. J.,* ed. E. Romero Pose, Santiago de Compostela 1990, 179–202.

reply made by E. Norelli[239], we expound briefly the fundamental points on which C. Hill bases his approach and in the footnotes, the confutations to the same generally formulated by E. Norelli. It should be noted that C. Hill himself counsels prudence regarding his hypothesis of relating this writing directly with the Christian community of Smyrna and even with Polycarp, his secretary Crescentius or the author of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* as its possible author.

In the first instance, the unity[240] of the whole writing is defended bearing in mind the nature of the work which allows the possibility of a change of style at the end, passing from an almost apologetic genre to a parenetic style with an important use of citations from Scripture, which is in line with the protreptic character of the work aimed at bringing the reader or listener to the adoption of a new point of view, in this case conversion[241]. However, starting off from a study of textual criticism,[242] the common opinion accepted is that part of the writing has been lost, in view of the gaps at the end of 7, 6 and 10, 8. So that we are faced with a work interrupted by two important blanks[243].

Secondly, emphasis is laid on the idea that the first writing was of an oral nature, of which subsequently a written version was made by the same author or by some disciple close to him. This is shown by the use of verbs proper to oral communication (λέγω, ἀκούω, ὁμιλέω) and the change of the singular to the plural in the addressee. Diognetus seems to have been a man of high social standing who almost certainly held public office. It is probable that the environment in which this work was gestated was a discourse addressed by an important member of

239 Cf. E. Norelli, *Ramener l'A Diognète en Asie Mineure? Une discussion de la thèse de Charles E. Hill,* in *A Diognète. Visions chrétiennes face à l'empire romain. Actes de la journée d'étude du GSEP du 24 novembre 2007,* ed. G. Aragione – E. Norelli – F. Nuvolone, Lausanne 2012, 91–117.

240 The debate on the unity of this text is a *vexata quaestio,* C. Hill on this point situating himself in the line represented by authors such as H. Marrou and M. Rizzi. For his part, E. Norelli maintains that these are two separate works, the first covering paragraphs one to ten and the second covering eleven to twelve, cf. E. Norelli, *Ramener l'A Diognète*, 93–94.

241 For a detailed study on the unity of vocabulary, style and content of the work, cf. C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp,* 114–127.

242 For a detailed study of textual criticism, cf. *ibid.,* 107–114.

243 The possibility that the last two chapters 11 and 12 belong to another work but still by the same author is likewise accepted, cf. Norelli, *Ramener l'A Diognète,* 93–94, Cf. C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp,* 167; cf. Barnard, *The Enigma of the Epistle to Diognetus* in *Studies on the Apostolic Fathers and Their Backgrounds,* Oxford 1966, 165–173.

the Christian community to a principal official who administered justice in a Roman basilica[244] and where not only the official, in this case Diognetus, but also a wider public were present, including various Christians who worked there[245], which moreover made it possible to better appreciate the catechistic style of the end of the work[246]. For the rest, thanks to an inscription now lost, we know that in Smyrna, between the second and third centuries, there existed a prominent family of which some of its members bore the unusual name of Diognetus and at least one of them was a magistrate of the city[247].

Against the argument that the oratorial richness and the literary style of this work is very different from Polycarp's letter *To the Philippians,* the only writing by the bishop of Smyrna that has come down to us, C. Hill attempts to demonstrate how the letter *To Diognetus* must be situated in a period long after the writing of Polycarp, almost 40 years later, towards the end of his life, also alluding to Polycarp's fame as an orator that the sources quoted earlier transmit to us[248], as well as the centrality of Smyrna for the rhetorical movement of the Second Sophistic[249]. It is this same fame as an orator which is recorded in the *Martyrdom*

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244 For an interesting excursus on the Royal Court and the Roman basilicas in Asia Minor, especially on the basis of the testimony of Irenaeus in his letter *To Florinus,* cf. C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp,* 17–21.

245 Such for example as Florinus of Smyrna of whom Irenaeus informs us that he met him in such an environment when he listened to Polycarp's teaching: ἐν τῇ βασιλικῇ αὐλῇ, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 20, 5.

246 A study contextualising in a detailed way oral teaching outside of the judicial context of the persecutions, cf. C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp,* 101–106.

247 This plaque was an inscription dedicated to the god Asclepius and read: ΑΣΚΛΕΠΙΩ ΠΑΙΗΩΝΗ – ΔΙΟΓΝΗΤΟΣ ΑΠΟΛΛΩ – ΝΙΟΥ ΤΟΥ ΔΙΟΓΝΗΤΟΥ ΑΡ – ΧΩΝ ΚΑΘΙΕΡΩΣΕ: DEDICATED TO ASCLEPIUS HEALER, DIOGNETUS, SON OF APOLLONIUS SON OF DIOGNETUS, ARCHON, cf. C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp,* 160–165. However, as C. Hill himself admits in note 113, other inscriptions of the palaeo-Christian Age have been found in Asia Minor which make reference to other Diognetuses. This fact together with the refutation of various arguments of a textual nature propounded by C. Hill make E. Norelli sceptical about the approach whereby *To Diognetus* and *To the Philippians* are the work of the same author.

248 Cf. C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp*, 128–133.

249 It is difficult to believe that the bishop of Smyrna, who for the rest, as we noted, enjoyed widespread fame for rhetoric, was foreign to the movement of the Second Sophistic headed by Aelius Aristides and was not capable of dealing with the circumstances and the intellectual medium in which he was required to expound the Christian faith to everyone, cf. C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp*, 164–165.

of Polycarp[250], a writing which for C. Hill appears to be very close in its theology and style to the letter *To Diognetus.* So that it would date from about the year 150, before the bishop's martyrdom, just before the persecution of Marcus Aurelius was unleashed, during a period of peace corresponding to the government of Antoninus Pius or the first peaceful years of Marcus Aurelius, accordingly when it was still possible to defend and expound publicly the Christian message in an imperial setting as is the case of a basilica in the presence of an official receptive to the Christian message, as Diognetus would appear to be[251].

In C. Hill's opinion, the personal characteristics that the author of this writing *To Diognetus* displays in chapters eleven and twelve correspond with Polycarp. The orator affirms that he himself has come to be a master of the Gentiles[252], which conveys a singular point in common with the testimony offered by the *Martyrdom of Polycarp*[253]. The orator also identifies himself as a "disciple of the apostles[254], which is a repeated testimony of Irenaeus regarding Polycarp[255]. The line of reasoning of the author of *To Diognetus* corresponds to the characteristics of the teaching of Polycarp who, also quoting *1 P* in his letter *To the Philippians,* develops his understanding of the nature of the redeeming death of Jesus for sinners[256]. Likewise, significance is attached by C. Hill to the singular correspondences between the teaching of Polycarp transmitted by the *Martydom*

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250 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 12, 2.

251 Cf. C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp,* 133.

252 Cf. *Diogn.,* 11, 1. E. Norelli, contrary to the thesis of C. Hill, points out that this text is clearly inspired by *1 Tm* 2, 7 and does not necessarily have any direct connection with the similar texts which appear in the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* cf. E. Norelli, *Ramener l'A Diognète,* 97–98.

253 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 12, 2; 16, 2; 19, 1. E. Norelli, contrary to the thesis of C. Hill, points out that both texts are inspired by *1 Tm* 2, 7.

254 (ἀποστόλων γενόμενος μαθητὴς), cf. *Diogn.,* 11, 1.

255 For an excursus over the apostolicity of Polycarp in Irenaeus, cf. C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp,* 133–136.C.

256 Cf. The expiatory death of Christ in *1 P* 2, 22–24; 3, 18 with Polycarp *ep.,* 1, 2; 8, 1; 9, 2, with *M. Polyc.,* 17, 2, and with *Diogn*., 9, 2–5. In this respect, E. Norelli points out that although both the letter of Polycarp *To the Philippians,* and the writing *To Diognetus* have had a certain reception from *1 P:* in the case of *To the Philippians* this is evident and abundant, while in *To Diognetus* this reception does not appear so clear or striking. For the rest, these two texts do not have the same mode of reception of *1 P,* since they do not quote the same asides nor is this New Testament writing the same, thus casting doubt on the hypothesis of C. Hill that *To the Philippians* and *To Diognetus* are in fact by the same author, cf. E. Norelli, *Ramener l'A Diognète,* 101–105.

of Polycarp and the writing *To Diognetus,* such as: the distinction between the temporal fire to which the martyr is indifferent in order to escape the eternal fire which is never quenched and to which the persecutors are destined[257], the introduction to the eternal kingdom through the only begotton Son[258], the centrality of Christ as place of the divine revelation[259], the various idiomatic expressions in common, and the stylistic parallelisms[260]. Likewise for C. Hill, the letter *To Diognetus* shows parallelisms with the supposed oral teaching of Polycarp which we find set down by Irenaeus in *Against heresies*[261] and with the epistle *To Florinus*[262].

Once the approach of C. Hill has been expounded, with the corresponding replies of E. Norelli in footnotes, there are yet other reasons that the Italian takes into consideration to refute the authorship of *To Diognetus* by Polycarp.

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257 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 2, 3; 11, 2; *Diogn.,* 10, 7–8. For the particularity of this distinction between the two fires which these writings make compared to the rest of the preceding or contemporanous literature, cf. C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp,* 141–143. Once more, E. Norelli casts doubt on the interpretation of C. Hill, affirming that the theme of the two fires, the temporal and the eternal, belongs to the martyrial tradition prior to both writings, v. gr. the *Acts of Justin, the Martyrdom of Isaiah and 4 Maccabaeans,* so that the coincidence in this respect cannot lead to the supposition that both texts have any direct relationship, cf. E. Norelli, *Ramener l'A Diognète,* 107–108.

258 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 20, 2; *Diogn.,* 10, 2, Cf. C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp,* 143. Once more E. Norelli questions the relationship made by C. Hill on this in asides on both texts and casts doubts on the statistical basis on which C. Hill finds this theme in the Apostolic Fathers of the second century, cf. E. Norelli, *Ramener l'A Diognète*, 109–112.

259 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 14, 1; *Diogn.,* 8, 1, cf. C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp,* 143–145. Once more E. Norelli confutes the arguments outlined by C. Hill based on disparity of the expressions in the two writings, cf. E, Norelli, *Ramener l'A Diognète,* 113–114.

260 Cf. C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp,* 145–147. These stylistic parallelisms, which C. Hill presents as singular idiomatic expressions in many cases and only common to these two writings, E. Norelli shows are recurrent in a large part of the non-Christian and Christian literature of the early centuries, *Ramener l'A Diognète,* 114–115.

261 The use by God of persuasion and not force, cf. Iren., *haer.,* 4, 37; 5, 1, 1 and *Diogn.,* 7, 3–5; the revelation of God through his incarnate Son, cf. Iren., *haer.,* 5, 1, 1 and *Diogn.,* 8, 1, 9, 11; the presentation of the Church as paradise, cf. Iren., *haer.,* 5, 20, 2 and *Diogn.,* 12, 1; and the analogy of the presence of the soul in the body, cf. Iren., *haer.,* 2, 19, 6 and *Diogn.,* 6, 2, cf. C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp,* 150–156.

262 Cf. C. Hill, *From the Lost Teaching of Polycarp,* 145–147.

First of all, if the letter *To Diognetus* were a work of Polycarp, this would be surprising because neither the author of *Martyrdom of Polycarp* nor Irenaeus make any allusion to this important literary work so meaningful in theological terms. It might be objected that the aim of the author of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* was to exalt above all the figure of Polycarp as a martyr and not as an author; however, quite rightly the idea of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* is to present a martyr who is educated, of high rank, and capable of introducing Christianity to the high magistrates, as C. Hill himself observes. In which case, it makes no sense not to acknowledge Polycarp as the author of this work.

And secondly, while in this hypothesis, one could justify not mentioning the letter of Polycarp *To the Philippians* in the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* as being a work addressed to the members of the Christian community and which accordingly does not help justify the aim of the author of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* who attempts to extol the figure of the bishop of Smyrna to non-Christians. Then how should we understand the omission of the letter *To Diognetus,* especially when, if really this figure were Polycarp, undoubtedly his martyrdom would have been witnessed by persons likewise present when the bishop pronounced this supposed discourse to Diognetus.

Thirdly, if Polycarp had pronounced this discourse to Diognetus, it is not clear why Irenaeus, who prided himself in his work on telling important anecdotes from the life of Polycarp both in Asia and in his journey to Rome, has not mentioned the famous discourse of the bishop of Smyrna before the magistrate and other eminent citizens. Besides, Irenaeus only mentions a single work of Polycarp, the letter *To the Philippians,* of which he states that it is "all-important, whereby those who so desire and who are concerned for their own salvation may learn the nature of his faith and his message of truth"[263].

So that this work is not accepted by us as a source, and accordingly, we have placed it as an appendix due to the debate around its relationship with Smyrna. Nonetheless this writing may throw light on the characteristics of the explanation of the Christian faith to pagans of a certain cultural level by the members of a Christian community in the Roman or Asian environment in a period preceding the persecution of Marcus Aurelius.

4. Epistulae ad Timotheum I et II, Epistula ad Titum

In recent centuries, the letters of Paul addressed to Titus and Timothy have been treated as a theological and literary unit known as *"Pastoral epistles*" since

263 Eus., *h. e.* 4, 14, 8.

they deal with the "pastoring" of the Church. This expression was coined in the German New Testament studies of the eighteenth century[264]. In the second century, the *Muratorian Fragment* justified its position in the Christian canon by its contribution to ecclesiastical discipline in the universal Church and attributed their authorship to Paul.

In accordance with the testimony of the letters, Paul is quite probably the author. However, both the language and the names of persons and places are different from those of the other Pauline writings, including the letter *To Philemon,* and on the contrary, more similar to that of Luke in the *Acts of the Apostles*[265]. A number of authors such as J. Kelly, S. Lestapis, and B. Reicke, among others, have suggested the possibility that these letters were written by a member of Paul's circle and sent under his authority in the early 50s and 60s[266].

On the contrary, other authors think that the differences between the *Pastoral epistles* and the rest of Paul's writings, are not only of language but also of topics and circumstances revealing at least one generation of Christians after that of Paul. In this case, these writings "under his authority" are by a second[267] or even third[268] generation of Christians.

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264 Thomas Aquinas had already characterised *1 Tm* as "a rule for pastors".

265 These three letters, together with the letter to Philemon, are the only ones addressed to individual persons in the NT. The vocabulary of the *Pastoral epistles* makes reference to models to be followed such as ethics or conduct and their terminology to distinguish good acts from bad ones. Another model reflects particular interest in Christian ministers, and the vocabulary designating those who bear the responsibility for the community of believers. More recent studies would seem to ascribe to Luke the most important influence over the *Pastoral epistles.*

266 In this hypothesis, Paul is the author of the *Pastoral epistles* since those writing them were authorised by the apostle during his own ministry, cf. J. Kelly, *A Community on the Pastoral Epistles,* London 1963; cf. S. Lestapis, *L'énigme des Pastorales de Saint Paul,* Paris 1976; cf. B. Reicke, *Chronologie der Pastoralbriefe,* in *Literaturzeitung* 101 (1976), 81–93.

267 W. Bauer is in favour of the hypothesis that the letters were written in a second generation, he even thinks they were written as a response to Marcion, cf. W. Bauer, *Orthodoxy and Heresy in Earliest Christianity,* Philadelphia 1971. M. Simonetti situates them chronologically between the end of the first century and the beginning of the second century, cf. M. Simonetti, *Paolo nell'Asia cristiana del II secolo,* 127.

268 Whereas others, such as P. Harrison, C. Barret, and H. von Campenhausen have proposed a later dating in a third generation, that is to say, between the years 100 and 130, cf. P. Harrison, *The Problem of the Pastoral Epistles,* London 1921; cf. C. Barret, *The Pastoral Epistles in the New English Bible,* Oxford 1963; cf. H. von Campenhausen, *Polykarp von Smyrna und die Pastoralbriefe,* Heidelberg 1951.

H. von Campenhausen wrote a long work which discusses the many similarities between the letter of Polycarp *To the Philippians* and the *Pastoral epistles.* These include the spirit and construction of the letters, the respect for tradition, their anti-Docetist and anti-Gnostic nature, their concern for the poor, powerful morality, and the supposition of ecclesiastical ministries. Both the letter of Polycarp and the *Pastoral epistles* lack eschatological motivation for the Christian ethical behaviour which they insist on. In early Christian literature, the term μεταιολογία only appears in the *Pastoral epistles* (*1 Tm* 1, 6*; Ti* 1, 10) and in Polycarp (*ep.,* 2, 1); the verbs προάγειν and ἐπακολουθεῖν are only found together in the *Pastoral epistles* (*1 Tm* 5, 24) and in Polycarp (*ep.,* 3, 3). *Ep.,* 5, 2 contains a series of words which are only found in the *Pastoral epistles*: ἐν τῷ νῦν αἰῶνι (*1 Tm* 6, 17; *2 Tm* 4, 10); διάβολος as an adjective; δίλογος; ἐγκρατής. On the basis of these similarities, H. von Campenhausen maintains that Polycarp wrote the *Pastoral epistles,* or that perhaps he commissioned someone in his circle to write the letters. Furthermore, he states that any superficial difference with the letter *To the Philippians* may be explained by the intention of wanting to pass the *Pastoral epistles* off as in fact written by Paul[269].

H. Koester affirms that the arguments of H. von Campenhausen are convincing and worthy of consideration. He also states that the author of the *Pastoral epistles* was, without doubt, a lucid and influential leader of the Church who sought the consolidation of Christianity as an organised religion acceptable to the culture of his time, and who defended it against false masters, especially the Gnostics, whose propaganda tried to separate Christianity from the world and moral obligations in society. In the first half of the second century, only one leader of this stature is known by his name: Polycarp of Smyrna[270].

However, on the basis of a textual analysis, W. Schoedel[271] affirmed the notable fact of the absence in the letter *To the Philippians* of important christological terms from the *Pastoral epistles* such as ἐπιφάνεια, σωτήρ; D. Rensberger[272] notes a similar absence of πιστὸς ὁ λόγος, and P. Hartog[273] also notes the absence in

269 Cf. H. von Campenhausen, *Polykarp von Smyrna und die Pastoralbriefe,* 25–26.

270 Cf. H. Koester, *Introduction to the New Testament,* vol. II, Philadelphia 1982, 305.

271 Cf. W. Schoedel, *Polycarp's Witness to Ignatius of Antioch,* in *Vigiliae Christianae* 41 (1987), 1–10.

272 Cf. D. Rensberger, *As the Apostle Teaches: The Development of the Use of Paul's Letters in Second-Century Christianity,* Yale 1981, 122.

273 Cf. P. Hartog, *Polycarp and the New Testament: the occasion, rhetoric, theme and unity of the Epistle to the Philippians and its allusions to New Testament literature,* Tübingen 2002, 229.

Polycarp of the terms εὐσέβεια/εὐσεβῶς, διδασκαλία and φιλανθρωπία present in the *Pastoral epistles.*

From a historical analysis, various objections also exist. P. Meinhold affirms that if the theory of H. von Campenhausen were certain, it is surprising that the early ecclesiastical tradition could have completely ignored the role of Polycarp, who was a figure of authority, in the writing of the *Pastoral epistles.* Secondly, if Polycarp wrote the *Pastoral epistles,* we would expect to also find a Pauline theology more taken over by the author in his letter *To the Philippians*, which is not the case. In fact, in his letter *To the Philippians,* Polycarp cites the authority of Paul, whereas in reality, he would seem to be unacquainted with his theology. In addition, R. Grant[274] states that Polycarp insists on his own inferiority compared to the authority of Paul and on the generational difference between the apostolic age and his time, which seems to exclude the possibiliity that he had written on behalf of Paul.

Two such important scholars on the relationship between Polycarp and Paul, as P. Hartog and K. Berding,[275] have reported that the *Pastoral epistles,* together with the rest of the *corpus Paulinum,* were a source of authority for Polycarp which is reflected in the abundant citations or allusions to them in his letter *To the Philippians.* For both scholars, the *Pastoral epistles* should not be dated in the late second century, while the theory of H. von Campenhausen who considers Polycarp as their author is even less acceptable.

I completely agree with what has been said thus far. Even so, I would like to complete the ideas expounded up to now, harmoniously summarised by P. Hartog[276], and complement above all the point underlined by P. Meinhold regarding the silence of the early ecclesiastical tradition on Polycarp as author of the *Pastoral epistles.*

The words used by Irenaeus in his letter *To Florinus*, speaking of the attitude of Polycarp against heretics, where he says: "This may also be proved by the letters that he (Polycarp) wrote, whether to the neighbouring Churches, comforting

274 Cf. R. Grant*, The Formation of the New Testament,* New York 1965, 104.

275 Cf. K. Berding, *Polycarp and Paul. An analysis of their literary and theological relationship in light of Polycarp's use of biblical and extra-biblical literature,* Boston 2002, cf. The review of the work by P. Hartog and K. Berding by B. Dehandschutter in *Vigiliae Christianae* 58 (2004), 101–107.

276 Cf. P. Hartog, *Polycarp and the New Testament: the occasion, rhetoric, theme and unity of the Epistle to the Philippians and its allusions to New Testament literature,* Tübingen 2002, 228–231.

them, or to certain brethren admonishing them and exhorting them"[277], has given rise to various writings attributing to the bishop of Smyrna in addition to the letter *To the Philippians.* Notwithstanding, Irenaeus himself mentions only the letter *To the Philippians* in another passage as if this was the only one he was acquainted with[278]. While on the contrary, it is significant that Irenaeus was the first author to testify to the existence of the *Pastoral epistles* towards the end of the year 180, and furthermore in a natural way to attribute them to Paul[279].

It might be objected that undoubtedly in case the *Pastoral epistles* should in fact be pseudo-epigraphical, it is obvious that, if Polycarp had been their author, he or his circle of collaborators have never explicitly affirmed their role in the redaction of these letters. So we should not be surprised at the silence of Irenaeus and the many others like the author of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* or the author of the *Life of Polycarp.*

As regards the latter, it is interesting that the *Life of Polycarp* when he speaks about his "ordination as bishop", says explicitly that the letters of *Timothy* and *Titus* are by the Apostle. The text says:

> After prolonging for a long time, as was his custom, the prayers and prostration of Saturday, he got up to read, while the eyes of everyone were fixed on him. The reading was from the epistles of *Timothy* and *Titus,* in which the Apostle says that a bishop should possess certain qualities, and the passage fitted him so wondrously that everyone said among themselves that Polycarp lacked none of the things that Paul requires of the person who is to take care of the Church. After the reading and the exhortation of the bishops and the address of the presbyters, the deacons were sent out to ask the people who they wanted, and they all answered as one: "Let Polycarp be our pastor and master". And with the whole eclesiastical assembly coming to this determination, they elevate him to the dignity of bishop, despite his many supplications and determination to forego that honour[280].

On reading this text, it is impossible not to find similarities in it with the reading of the roll of *Isaiah* proclaimed by Jesus in the synagogue in *Lk* 4, 16–30. There too the day is Saturday, the reader gets up to read, the eyes of all the listeners are fixed on him, and the passage read is fulfilled by the presence of the person

277 Eus., *h. e.* 5, 20, 8.

278 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 4, 14, 8.

279 Iren., *haer.,* 1, praef. 1. Clement of Alexandria and the *Muratorian Fragment* around the year 200 likewise attribute the authorship of the *Pastoral epistles* to Paul. Polycarp almost certainly cited *1* and *2 Timothy* in his letter *To the Philippians* towards the year 120. Whereas the citation and knowledge of the *Pastoral epistles* displayed in the letters of Ignatius and in *1 Clement* is not so clear.

280 *V. Polyc.,* 22.

who proclaims it. The reader and the text are mutually identified. With his life, the reader becomes the best interpreter and incarnation of the text. Jesus fulfils the prophecy of Isaiah with his life and Polycarp "fits perfectly" the profile of the bishop traced by Paul. At the same time, of course both texts have their differences, especially and paradoxically in the ending. Jesus is the victim of the crowd's anger, he is dragged out of the town and they do their best to incite him, but he manages to make his way out from among them. On the contrary, Polycarp is unanimously recognised by the crowd as their "pastor and master", being raised to the dignity of bishop by the ecclesiastical assembly, despite his wish to decline. Accordingly, the question could be: Is this version not a way by the author of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* to indirectly affirm Polycarp's paternity of the *Pastoral epistles*? At least the question is legitimate. It may also be conjectured that this text is a further demonstration of the authority of the *Pastoral epistles* over the ministry and doctrine of Polycarp.

Personally, I believe that the *Pastoral epistles* are not the work of Polycarp or his school. Nevertheless, it seemed important to me to reflect on this text which has not been present in the debate on the authorship of the *Pastoral epistles.* Certainly the *Pastoral epistles* share the same ecclesiastical environment as the letter *To the Philippians,* which helps us understand their similarities, and the origin of all these letters is very likely Asia Minor. However, the fact that two of them are addressed to *Timothy,* would suggest, further, that their place of origin or of destination was the ecclesial community of Ephesus and not of Smyrna, which on the contrary appears connected in the *Life of Polycarp,* with the figure of Strataeas[281], Timothy' brother.

5. Corpus Polycarpianum

a. The beginning of a hypothesis

Since the beginning of the twentieth century, authors such as B. Lightfoot, E. Schwartz, P. Corssen and A. Hilgenfeld have reflected on the idea that already in ancient times, in about the third or fourth century, one or more editorial attempts were made by some member or members of that community to collect together and edit the works of Polycarp or those referring to him. In fact, this hypothesis which coined the expression "*corpus Polycarpianum*", is based especially on the prologues and epilogues of different works which suggest an ambitious editorial plan comprising literary pieces which have not come down to us.

281 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 2, 2.

Appendix A of the *M. Polyc.,* 22, 2–1 (a short appendix which accompanies all the copies of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* except that of the manuscript Mosquensis 390 which contains a longer and later appendix B) gives a textual history of the document which was first of all copied by Gaius on the basis of a manuscript by Irenaeus, then later Socrates, who speaks in the first person, transcribed it in Corinth from the copy made by Gaius. Finally Pionius, likewise speaking in the first person, states that he once more copied the earlier manuscripts, almost destroyed by the passing of time, after searching them out. Pionius also gives us an understanding that the discovery of those manuscripts was thanks to an apparition of the blessed Polycarp in a revelation which he promises to tell thereafter. This promised narration by Pionius has not come down to us.

For its part, the anonymous document *Life of Polycarp,* the Greek text of which was not published until 1881 almost simultaneously by L. Duchesne and F. Funk on the basis of a single manuscript (*Parisinus Graecus* 1452), was together with the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* in this same manuscript. Both the beginning and the end of the *Life of Polycarp* are abrupt. In the beginning, it appears that the author has been speaking on other themes, in addition to which the author states that he discovered the visit of Paul to Smyrna in "ancient manuscripts" which he proceeds to narrate, not without first having observed that he will then continue his discourse in an orderly way with the narration of the life of Polycarp. Having ended the narration of Paul's passing through Smyrna, the author promises to make a list of the successors of Strataeas, who inherited the charge of teaching from Paul, all of a sudden decides to proceed without delay to deal with Polycarp. We do not know if the author actually drew up at some time this promised list of the successors of Strataeas, a sort of list of bishops and prominent leaders of Smyrna, perhaps adding it to the *Life of Polycarp,* but in any case such a document has not come down to us.

In other sections of this same *Life of Polycarp,* he also promises to put the letter *To the Philippians* (*V. Polyc.*, 12, 3) and how Polycarp interpreted the Scriptures (*V. Polyc.,* 20, 1) in an appropriate place. However, the letter *To the Philippians* has come down to us together with the letters of Ignatius and not with the *Life of Polycarp,* while the exegetical teaching of Polycarp has never reached us.

Thus then, for B. Lightfoot, taking as reference the manuscript Parisinus Graecus 1452, the editorial undertaking of this anonymous personage in the *Life of Polycarp,* but who is presented as in appendix A to the *Martyrdom of Polycarp*, would include at least seven or eight writings around the figure of Polycarp:

– The *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* which would go at the head of the whole collection, written by Marcion or Evaristus shortly after the martyrdom, in the manner of a circular letter to the churches, starting off with that of the Philomelians.

- Appendix A of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* the last part of which written by Pionius.
- The narration around the supposed apparition of Polycarp in a revelation to Pionius.
- The passing of Paul through Smyrna, which as the author of the *Life of Polycarp* affirms, was taken from "ancient archives" and in fact does not belong to the general plan of the *Life of Polycarp* in the strictest sense, but which is marked by an abrupt beginning of the work.
- A list of prominent personages of the Church in Smyrna, beginning with Strataeas.
- The *Life of Polycarp* as such, probably beginning and ending in a less abrupt way.
- A copy of Polycarp's letter *To the Philippians*, the only writing of the bishop, comprising homilies and letters, which according to the author of the *Life of Polycarp,* survived the pillage in the persecution which broke out at the time of his martyrdom *(V. Polyc.,* 12, 3*)*.
- An explanation of the way in which Polycarp undertook the exegetical teaching of Scripture (*V. Polyc.,* 20, 1). Although as E. Schwartz pointed out, it might possibly be considered that the author was referring to this same letter *To the Philippians*[282].

For those scholars of the beginning of the twentieth century, apart from the textual evidence presented earlier, the attempt of one or more members of the Church of Smyrna to compile a series of writings around Polycarp was certainly plausible.

On the one hand, the Church of Smyrna, precisely at the time of its bishop and martyr, carried out a similar work with the letters of Ignatius, copying and organising them in a short time and sending them to the Church of Philippi. In the same letter which accompanies this dispatch, Polycarp shows that he is acquainted with various New Testament writings, especially the letters of Paul. So that, already at the time of Polycarp the incipient *scriptorium*[283] of the church of Smyrna displayed notable activity.

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282 E. Schwartz, *De Pionio et Polycarpo,* 30.

283 Here we understand the concept of *scriptorium* at its most basic level, that is to say, a community where texts are copied by different scribes. This type of experience could be gained early on in communities such as Rome, Antioch, and Smyrna itself. On the contrary, for a *scriptorium* as a more ordered structure, operating for example in specific premises projected and adequate for such a purpose, it will be necessary to wait until the time of Origen, cf. H. Gamble, *Libri e lettori nella chiesa antica*, Brescia 2006, 165.

Besides, we clearly already see from the composition of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* the veneration in which the community held its bishop, whose bones "nobler than precious stones" were deposited in an appropriate place where the community met to celebrate the anniversary of his martyrdom[284]. This same veneration appears strengthened over time, one 100 after the facts of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp.* In fact the tale goes that precisely as they were celebrating the feast of the blessed martyr Polycarp, Pionius, and his companions were arrested[285].

Accordingly, both the textual evidence, such as the history of the *scriptorium* of Smyrna and the devotion for Polycarp, made an editorial undertaking on the writings around the figure of the bishop and martyr feasible already in the second century.

One fundamental point in the attempt to consider the hypothesis of a *corpus Polycarpianum* was undoubtedly trying to establish the identity of the director of such an undertaking.

Without doubt, the hypothesis most widely accepted by scholars of the beginning of the twentieth century was that the Pionius who appears in appendix A of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* should be identified with the protagonist of the *Martyrdom of Pionius,* that is, the presbyter who is presented in this story as a vigorous unmarried Christian having a very considerable activity and influence, possessing great rhetorical skills, legal knowledge, and a piety that gave credit to the premonitory visions, Christian exorcism, and other marvellous happenings. But above all, a Christian highly devoted to the memory of Polycarp and who met up with others to commemorate his *dies natalis*[286]. So that it would appear probable that such a personage named Pionius might have been the one who procured a copy of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* and that at the same time had made one of his own.

In the same way, it appeared feasible that this same Pionius was the author of the *Life of Polycarp,* since he fitt the profile of one inclined to give credit to these very marvellous happenings and was obviously a great admirer of the bishop and martyr. This is what E. Schwartz, thought affirming that the writing (τὸ σύγγραμμα) left by Pionius, to which the prologue of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp*

284 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 18, 2–3.

285 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 2, 1.

286 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 2, 1. M. Simonetti is of the opinion that perhaps the author of the *Martyrdom of Pionius* set the arrest of Pionius and his companions in the context of this feast with hagiographical intent and not necessarily in accordance with historical truth.

alludes corresponds to *The Life of Polycarp*[287]. Besides, both the Pionius of Appendix A to the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* and the author of the *Life of Polycarp* are admired by the bishop of Smyrna and promise their readers further writings. For the rest, the textual evidence of the Parisinus Graecus 1452 manuscript which places both works together appeared to support such a hypothesis.

So that the hypothesis in its general profile was that Pionius, an important presbyter of the Church of Smyrna, before 250, the year of his martyrdom, compiled at least seven or eight writings around the figure of Polycarp. Some of these texts were written by Polycarp himself, others by other authors and some by Pionius himself.

b. Criticism during the twentieth century

Nonetheless, throughout the twentieth century, doubt has been cast on certain parts of this scenario, thus threatening to spoil the unity and accordingly the validity of this theory.

The first objection was made by H. Delahaye who considered that the Pionius of the appendix to the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* could not be identified with the presbyter Pionius[288]. For H. Delahaye, this identification could be due to a falsification by the copyist of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* desirous of making use of the pseudoepigraphy to give the copy greater value[289]. This Pseudo-Pionius would thus have been an author of the fourth or fifth century. Although this option is probable, H. Delahaye never offers convincing arguments to back it up.

Another objection was that of identifying the presbyter Pionius as the author of the *Life of Polycarp.* In fact, the author of the *Life of Polycarp* remains anonymous and this relationship appears gratuitous at first sight, except for the fact that in Appendix A of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* it is found together with the *Life of Polycarp* in the single manuscript we have of the latter. However, it is also true that the text of the *Life of Polycarp* begins and ends in an abrupt way and at times present gaps so that the author's identity might have been established in those parts that are missing. Furthermore, P. Corssen, maintaining the idea that Pionius was the author of the *Life of Polycarp,* searched for parallels between the *Martyrdom of Pionius* and the *Life of Polycarp*[290], bearing in mind that a

287 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 1, 2; cf. E. Schwartz, *De Pionio et Polycarpo,* 30.

288 H. Delahaye, *Les passions,* 43.

289 B. Lightfoot, *The Apostolic Fathers,* 641–643.

290 P. Corssen, *Die Vita Polycarpi,* in *Zeitschrift für die Neutestamentliche Wissenschaft* 5 (1904), 266–302.

large part of the *Martyrdom of Pionius* is accepted as a work by Pionius himself, such as the discourses of the martyr[291], to which later another author added the narration of the martyrdom. P. Corssen established parallels between names of the personages, concrete references to the environment and institutions of the city, and a similar belief regarding miracles and visions. However, such parallels suggestive of the same setting for the *Martyrdom of Pionius* and the *Life of Polycarp* did not appear entirely conclusive to scholars such as A. Hilgenfeld[292] and C. Schmidt[293].

Perhaps the biggest difficulty in linking Pionius as the compiler of the *corpus Polycarpianum* has arisen from the conclusion that, if this were so, Pionius would have been the author of the *Life of Polycarp* and accordingly this would date from a very early period, at most the year 250. This theory of situating the *Life of Polycarp* in the mid-third century and of relating it to Pionius has been defended by P. Corssen and by E. Schwartz[294]. On the contrary later scholars have situated it in the fourth century, establishing a *terminus ad quem* in the year 400 when Macarius Magnes made allusion to two miracles which appear in the *Life of Polycarp*[295]. In addition, those who situate the *Life of Polycarp* in the fourth century base themselves on the great quantity of marvellous happenings[296], on the possible encratism,[297] and on a strong ecclesial structure which appear in the work. Aspects which, according to these scholars, would appear more proper to the hagiography of the fourth rather than of the third century.

Now, as regards the question of the marvellous happenings, the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* itself in the third century also transmits various fantastic happenings. As for encratism, already in the second century, Melito of Sardis was recognised as a eunuch,[298] and various texts appear in both the letter of Polycarp *To the Philippians* and in the *Martyrdom of Pionius* which could be judged by some as

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291 This may already be glimpsed in the prologue of the *Martyrdom of Pionius* when it states that Pionius left his followers a writing (σύγγραμμα) before dying, cf. *M. Pion.,* 2, 1.

292 Cf. A. Hilgenfeld, *Ein dreiste Fälschung in der alter Zeit und deren neueste Verteidigung,* in *Zeitschrift für Wissenschaftliche Theologie* 48 (1905), 444–458.

293 C. Schmidt, *Gespräche Jesu,* 706–725.

294 Cf. E. Schwartz, *De Pionio et Polycarpo,* 31.

295 Cf. C. Schmidt, *Gespräche Jesu,* 706–725.

296 Cf. H. Delahaye, *Les passions,* 24.

297 Cf. C. Schmidt, *Gespräche Jesu,* 709–711.

298 This is how Polycrates of Ephesus identifies him, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 24, 5.

encratistic[299]. As regards the powerful church structure apparent from the *Life of Polycarp,* whereby Polycarp passes through the different degrees of the priestly order (diaconate, presbyterate, and episcopate), each one accompanied by its respective liturgy, while this is undoubtedly exaggerated for the times of Polycarp and the author may commit various anachronisms, this strong ecclesial structure which presents Bucolus (Polycarp's predecessor) and Polycarp himself as a bishop with monarchical power is not alien to the third century where we find a strong ecclesial structure in other parts of the Empire such the Rome of Pope Calixtus. For the rest, the *Life of Polycarp* is absent from the cristological debates proper to the fourth century. In short, these arguments for situating the *Life of Polycarp* in the fourth century are not totally convincing either.

Nonetheless, there is one more point on which modern criticism has debated the dating of the *Life of Polycarp* and with it the existence of a *corpus Polycarpianum* in an early age. This is the anti-Quartodecimanism which appears above all in the abrupt beginning of the *Life of Polycarp,* that as we have said earlier, the author affirms that he found in "antique manuscripts". This abrupt beginning narrates the visit of Paul to Smyrna which consisted of the apostle's passing through the house of Strataeas, Timothy's brother, and the catechesis which Paul addressed the following day in that same place to the whole community in which he spoke to them of Easter and Pentecost, telling them that it was absolutely necessary to celebrate Easter in the days of unleavened bread, but to maintain the new mystery of the passion and resurrection. Of this fact found in the "antique archives", the author of the *Life of Polycarp* makes his interpretation: "In fact, here the Apostle appears teaching that Easter should not be celebrated outside the time of the unleavened bread, as heretics do, especially the Phrygians, nor necessarily on the 14th, since no specific mention was made of the fourteenth day, but only of the Unleavened bread, Easter and Pentecost, confirming the Gospel".

Celebrating Easter outside of the time of unleavened bread, as the heretics do, particularly the Phrygians, probably refers to the quartodecimanist practice of the Montanists in Asia Minor. These, finding it difficult to calculate the 14th of the Jewish lunar month, in a Hellenistic environment in which the solar calendar

299 C. Schmidt has judged as Polycarp an encratist on account of the numerous exhortations he makes to preserve chastity, cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 3, 3; 4, 2; 12, 2. In the same way, he maintains that the *Life of Polycarp* is encratistic, associating it with the monastic temperament of the fourth century; cf. C. Schmidt, *Gespräche Jesu,* 709–711. On the possible encratism in the *Martyrdom of Pionius,* P. Corssen has given his opinion, *Die Vita Polycarpi,* 293.

was in use, fell back on the 14th of the solar month of *Xanthicus* which did not coincide with the ancient date of Easter[300]. Witness to this Montanist practice dates back to the fourth century and resisted up until the sixth century. Although there is no reason why this practice should not have developed at the critical point in the history of Montanism during the third century.

The statement that it is not necesary either to celebrate it on 14 Nisan, in a writing remote from Montanist and orthodox practice such as the *Life of Polycarp,* places us in the environment of the Easter controversy of the second and third centuries up to the definitive sanction by orthodoxy in the Council of Nicaea in 325 of the dominical Easter. So that the debate around the dating of the *Life of Polycarp* of late consists in wondering at what time a Christian from Smyrna, a great admirer of Polycarp, decides to make an interpretation of the apostle Paul's possible visit to Smyrna, to affirm that the Quartodecimanism so consolidated in Smyrna at the time of Polycarp should no longer be practised.

Those in favour of the fourth-century dating of the *Life of Polycarp* affirm that this interpretation must have been given after the resolution of Nicaea, since the author does not desire that the community, or at least part of it, should continue to celebrate the Quartodecimanist practice, remaining outside of orthodox practice. In the same way, he seeks to maintain his distance from the orthodox memory of Polycarp of the Quartodecimanist practice condemned in Nicaea and accordingly makes no mention of Polycarp's journey to Rome towards the end of his life nor of his relationship with Irenaeus or with John, the apostle who represents that tradition[301].

Those in favour of an earlier dating of the *Life of Polycarp* (towards the middle of the third century, with Pionius or some other later Christian as author), affirm that for the Council of Nicaea, the Quartodeciman practice was already in disuse in many parts of the Empire including in the Asiatic diocese, as conveyed explicitly by Eusebius in his *Life of Constantine,*[302] and that the Church of Smyrna

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300 Ps. Chrys., *In s. Pascha, hom.* 7, 9 (SCh 46, 119), cf. R. Cantalamessa, *La Pasqua della nostra salvezza,* Città del Castello 2007, 119.

301 Cf. C. Schmidt, *Gespräche Jesu,* 715.

302 "Accordingly, since it was appropriate for the question to be redefined in such a way that there no longer existed any custom in common with those who killed our Father and Lord, and seeing that the most suitable system is that already observed by all the Churches… and I myself have submitted it to your attention in order for you to approve it and so that your judgment too may accept with good grace the rule which is respected with a single and concordant disposition of soul in the city of Rome and in Italy, throughout Africa, in Egypt, in Spain, in Gaul, in Britannia, in

could soon give up this practice. Proof of all this would be that it is Polycrates of Ephesus in the year 190 who speaks on behalf of the churches of Asia, and not the bishop of Smyrna at that time, and moreover that Polycrates says nothing about the fact that people in Smyrna are still continuing with the liturgical tradition defended by Polycarp 50 years earlier. In addition, another possible proof would be the fact that in the *Life of Polycarp* there is bare mention in a single line of the Quartodeciman bishop Papinius (Polycarp's successor, according to the testimony of the *Life of Polycarp* and of Polycrates), whereas various paragraphs are dedicated to Camerius, successor of Papinius, whom Polycrates does not name in his list of Asiatic Quartodecimanists. Now, although these may constitute important clues, we must point out at the same time that Polycrates only makes mention of personages that where already dead and was not necessarily obliged to explicitly state that people in Smyrna continued with the liturgical practice that he defended.

In short, for those who maintain the dating of the *Life of Polycarp* in the third century, it is important to note that towards the end of the second century the Church of Smyrna began to abandon the Quartodecimanist practice and accordingly, it is quite possible that a Christian who admires Polycarp would intentionally detach his memory intentionally from the Quartodecimanist practice already in the third century. For the rest, for those who maintain the hypothesis of an early dating, it would be difficult for a fourth-century author intentionally not to make some mention of Polycarp's visit to Rome, and the relationship of Polycarp with Irenaeus and with John, when already in the first part of the fourth century the *Historia Ecclesiastica* of Eusebius, where this news is found, had been written and disseminated. So that only an author from before the fourth century could have dared to ignore the Quartodecimanism of Polycarp.

c. The thesis of A. Stewart-Sykes

Stewart-Sykes, in his recent critical edition of the *Life of Polycarp*[303], maintains that the abrupt beginning of the *Life of Polycarp* which deals with Paul's visit to Smyrna and with the prescription on the date for the celebration of Easter, does

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Libya, in all of Greece, in the dioceses of Asia and Pontium and in Cilicia", Eus., *v. C.,* 3, 19, 1, (PG 20, 1077).

303 A. Stewart-Sykes, *The Life of Polycarp. An anonymous vita from third-century Smyrna,* Sydney 2002. Before Stewart-Sykes, the critical edition of the work was undertaken by B. Lightfoot in 1889, cf. B. Lightfoot, *The Apostolic Fathers, Part II: Ignatius and Polycarp,* vol. 1 New York 1989[3] 432–465.

not belong to the general plan of the work since it does not meet the canon of Βίος with which other works of intellectual biographical nature of this time begin, such for example as the *Life of Apollonius* by Philostratus, or the *Lives of the Philosophers* by Diogenes Laertius[304]. In fact, the opening of the work is strange since it suddenly plunges us *in medias res.* Accordingly, since the opening of the *Life of Polycarp* is not the original one, it cannot be used to determine the dating of the writing. However, such a beginning may in fact be seen as a prescript having literary motivations, but of later date.

So that, regarding the *corpus Polycarpianum*, Stewart-Sykes states that at a first stage, the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* and the *Life of Polycarp* enjoyed independent existences. At a second stage, a copyist who is identified as Pionius (Pseudo-Pionius) added Appendix A to the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* and the abrupt beginning of the *Life of Polycarp*, thus joining up the two writings. Accordingly, both the epilogue of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* and the abrupt beginning of the *Life of Polycarp* would seem to date from the fourth century, while the rest of the *Life of Polycarp* would seem to date from the third century[305].

This theory seems to overcome the problem around the mention of the Easter of the Phrygians (the solar calendar of the Montanists), the first attestations of which date from the fourth century. In addition, the fact that he should also show himself recalcitrant to the Quartodecimanist discipline would mean that the author of the abrupt beginning of the *Life of Polycarp* accepted the provision of the Council of Nicaea in 325, although this in no way denies the fact that the custom of celebrating the Quartodecimanist Easter in Smyrna had fallen off before the Council of Nicaea. Besides, without this abrupt beginning, the *Life of Polycarp* would conform to the habitual canons of the Βίος form so that it could be dated without much difficulty from the third century.

Stewart-Sykes offers other points in favour of dating the *Life of Polycarp* from the third century such as the inclusion of visions, as opposed to the trances of the Montanists, the true Catholic visionary in contrast with the enthusiastic prophecy of the Montanists, the *regula fidei* which appears in the text to be closer to Irenaeus than to the subsequent developments at Nicaea.

This hypothesis by Stewart-Sykes also appears to overcome the difficulty implied by the *Life of Polycarp* making no mention of Polycarp's Quartodecimanism

304 The abrupt beginning of the *Life of Polycarp,* not consequent with the plan of the work and with the literary style of Pionius, was noted earlier by E. Schwartz, *De Pionio et Polycarpo,* 31.

305 A. Stewart-Sykes, *Vita Polycarpi: A Third Century Vita,* in *Augustinianum* 40 (2000) 21–33.

and his relationship with Irenaeus and John. Since by separating both literary pieces (the abrupt beginning from the rest of the *Life of Polycarp*), the explicitly anti-Quartodecimanist part remains dated from the fourth century, probably after the condemnation of Nicaea, while the rest of the *Life of Polycarp,* which although it makes no mention of Polycarp's Quartodecimanism or of his relationship with John, at least does not explicitly deny it, and remains dated from the third century. For the rest, bearing in mind that the *Life of Polycarp* in various parts presents gaps and that its ending is also abrupt, the thought arises that in those places the author may have made mention of these happenings, but that a later copyist, perhaps the author of the abrupt anti-Quartodecimanist beginning, edited the *Life of Polycarp* eliminating these happenings and even further news on Quartodecimanist personages such as Papinius or Strataeas, though admittedly on this point we are merely in the realm of conjecture.

Finally, coming back to the theme of the *corpus Polycarpianum,* this hypothesis on the *Life of Polycarp* allows us to think, according to Stewart-Sykes, that the author of the work may have been a member of the group of Christians of the community of Smyrna which wrote the *Martyrdom of Pionius* and preserved the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* at the end of the third century. Indeed, it is feasible that already at the time when the *Martyrdom of Pionius* was written, a first attempt may have been made to collect works around the figure of Polycarp, seeing that the devotion to his memory had become widespread.

The thesis of Stewart-Sykes has been well received in various reviews by scholars such as J. Paget[306], W. McDonald,[307] and B. Dehandschutter[308], although doubts always remain regarding any hypothesis taking its place within a broader problem on which so many opinions have been expressed. M. Simonetti points out, precisely in a review on another academic work by Stewart-Sykes, that the procedure of basing a new hypothesis on another preceding one, appears, as a principle, not very correct methodologically, although widely adopted by various

306 Cf. J. Carleton Paget, review on: A. Stewart-Sykes: *The Life of Polycarp. An anonymous vita from third-century Smyrna*, Sydney 2002, in *Journal of Ecclesiastical History* 54 (2003), 737–738.

307 Cf. W. McDonald, review on: A. Stewart-Sykes: *The Life of Polycarp., An anonymous vita from third-century Smyrna,* Sydney 2002, in *Church History: Studies in Christianity and Culture,* 72 (2003), 643–644.

308 Cf. B. Dehandschutter, review on: A. Stewart-Sykes: *The Life of Polycarp. An anonymous vita from third-century Smyrna,* Sydney 2002, in *Vigilae Christianae* 58 (2004), 209–214.

scholars, resulting in building castles in the air and thus increasing the patrimony of pseudo-knowledge[309].

d. Conclusion

Things being thus, and bearing in mind the lengthy discussion around the *corpus Polycarpianum,* we may straightway affirm that there is strong evidence for thinking that the will existed to compile writings around Polycarp in an early period. Making allowance for how difficult it was to arrive at final conclusions, it may at least be concluded that this *corpus Polycarpianum* underwent a long process of edition, furthermore undertaken by more than one person, implying the following possible steps:

In a first stage, at the end of the third century, there existed as independent works, the letter *To the Philippians by* Polycarp, the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* and the *Life of Polycarp.* The *Martyrdom of Polycarp* was written about the middle of the second century and the *Life of Polycarp* about the middle of the third century, at the same time as the writing of *The Martyrdom of Pionius.*

In a second stage, a copyist who is identified as Pionius (Pseudo-Pionius), added Appendix A to the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* and the abrupt beginning of the *Life of Polycarp,* thus joining up the two writings. This author had already abandoned the Quartodecimanist practice, making this edition during the first decades of the fourth century (before the work of Eusebius was widely known). Perhaps this same author was able to change part of the content of the *Life of Polycarp* and may have provided a list of prominent personages in the community from the time of Strataeas onwards and (whether real or ficticious). An echo of this list may be the list of bishops in which we find Ariston, Strataeas, and Ariston of the *Apostolic Constitutions* 7, 46, and 8 dating from the year 380. This author may also have added the narration of the supposed revelation of Polycarp for finding the *Martyrdom of Polycarp.*

In a third stage, another copyist already acquainted with the work of Eusebius, from the fourth century onwards, retouched the epilogue of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* (Appendix B, manuscript Mosquensis 390) which gathers together the whole tradition regarding the relationship of Irenaeus with Polycarp. This author probably was not from Smyrna, since he insists on Rome being the city where Irenaeus developed a large part of his orthodox doctrine and probably did not possess all of the earlier *corpus Polycarpianum,* since otherwise it would seem

309 M. Simonetti, review on A. Stewart-Sykes, *Hippolytus, On the Apostolic Tradition,* in *Augustinianum* 43. 2 (2003), 508.

strange that, having extended the appendix of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* he did not edit the *Life of Polycarp* with mentions of Polycarp's relationship with Ireanaeus and with John.

Finally, we cannot precisely determine in what period the once existing *corpus Polycarpianum* was dispersed. Seeing that Polycarp's letter *To the Philippians* reached us together with the letters of Ignatius, the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* reached us through two branches, one for the parts contained in the *Historia Ecclesiastica* and the other independently with appendices A and B. The *Life of Polycarp* only arrived in a Parisinus Graecus 1452 manuscript together with a copy of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* with Appendix A. As for the *Martyrdom of Pionius,* this has come down to us together with another series of martyrial acts. Of the other possible writings which may have been contained in the *corpus Polycarpianum,* we have no certain news.

All of the connections between these different writings throughout the stages of their composition and edition are indicative of a fervent literary activity in the Christian community of Smyrna, as could be expected in a city, centre of rhetoric and of literary production, also comprising pagan circles during the early centuries of the Christian era.

The possibility of the existence at some time of a *corpus Polycarpianum* is highly probable, although the texts available do not provide us with all the necessary elements for determining its history with greater exactitude.

Conclusion

In favour of the authenticity of the direct sources presented, we may conclude as follows: The letter to the Church of Smyrna in the *Revelation* is the first direct source on the history of the Christian community of that city towards the end of the first century. Subsequently, the letter by Polycarp *To the Philippians,* the letters of Ignatius to the community and bishop of Smyrna and the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* offer an internal coherence which make them a reliable instrument for a historical and theological reconstruction of the community of Smyrna during the beginning and middle of the second century. Equally valuable are all the testimonies of Irenaeus and of Polycrates as representatives of the generation following Polycarp at the end of the second century. For its part, the *Against Noetus* by Hippolytus, above all in its first section, gives us abundant information on the underlying theology in part of the community at the end of the second century and the beginning of the third. The *Index Patrum Nicaenorum,* while concise in the information supplied, proves fundamental for establishing that the community of Smyrna, at least up to the Council of Nicaea in 325, had a visible head in the person of Eutiques. As regards the *Martyrdom of Polycarp*, the *Life of Polycarp,* and the *Fragments on Polycarp*, despite their mixture of reality and legend, their fragmentary nature, or their final redaction possibly even subsequent to the Council of Nicaea, these sources enable us to reconstuct the hagiographical tradition and the other series of features of the community of Smyrna throughout the third century and the beginning of the fourth century.

As regards the indirect sources, their value is very considerable. Many of them, as also the other letters constituting the *corpus Ignatianum*, have the same characteristics as those noted already in respect of the direct sources. For the rest, authors like Tertullian, Eusebius and Hieronymous have transmitted facts and texts of that time to us, often echoing information given by Irenaeus. As for the writings of Aelius Aristides, these prove indispensable for making a historical and theological reconstruction of the pagan environment in which the Christian community of Smyrna developed. For reasons of space, we have not presented other indirect sources such as the New Testament writings around the figure of the apostle John, the *corpus Paulinum,* the homilies of Melito of Sardis, the testimony of Papias of Hierapolis, and all the other antique literature concerning Asia Minor, which will necessarily be contemplated in the following chapters on the community of Smyrna inasmuch as it is natural that a large part

of the local realities of Ephesus, Sardis and Hierapolis were similar to those of their neighbour Smyrna.

In the particular case of the epistle *To Diognetus,* despite the attempt by C. Hill to link it directly with the community of Smyrna, we may only accept the information that this can offer us with extreme prudence, exclusively as a source of a Roman or Asiatic community before the persecution of Marcus Aurelius. Likewise, as regards the *teaching of the presbyter* and the *catalogue of heresies* transmitted by Irenaeus in *Against Heresies,* although it seems most plausible to link them with Polycarp, no total certainty is forthcoming, and accordingly we prefer to consider them once more as indirect sources only.

In the case of the *Pastoral epistles,* despite the environment these share with the only known writing of Polycarp, we cannot be sure that their author was in fact Polycarp.

Finally, as regards the *corpus Polycarpianum,* it is highly probable that this existed at one time, although the textual elements do not provide all the information necessary for determining its history to a greater degree of certainty.

With the presentation of these sources it is possible to conclude that on the community of Smyrna in the early centuries of Christianity, despite the particularly scarce documentation that we possess on the end of the third century and the beginning of the fourth, we have a sufficient number of direct and indirect testimonies to enable us to reconstruct the historical and theological development of this local reality to a large extent at least up until the time of the Council of Nicaea.

Part Two

Historical and Social Situation of the Community of Smyrna

Introduction

At the beginning of the Christian era, the city of Smyrna belonged to the very important province of Asia, known as the most populated and richest of the Roman provinces, especially in its western part, where together with Ephesus, Pergamum and other cities, the presence of Christians was highly significant[310].

In particular in the first, second and third centuries, Asia Minor enjoyed a vibrant literary and cultural experience and an intense religious life marked by the movement of the Second Sophistic. We know about the fecundity of Christianity in this part, but also the profound of pagan roots of the area as expressed in sanctuaries of great renown such as that of Artemis in Ephesus or the temple of Asclepius in Pergamum, as also of an imperial cult which claimed a growing importance for itself[311]. For the rest, signs of a strong presence of Jewish communities during these centuries have been revealed to us in recent years through archaeological excavations, with the uncovering of important synagogues, inscriptions and epitaphs, which confirm the presence of Jews already testified to in the ancient texts. These communities would appear to have had a long history and to have appealed to Rome and the local authorities for support and protection[312].

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310 For detailed studies on the socio-cultural environment of Asia Minor, cf. F. Blanchetière, *Le christianisme Asiate aux IIème et IIIème siècles,* Strasbourg 1981, 32 et seqq.; cf. W. Ramsay, *The historical geography of Asia Minor,* London 1990, 171 et seqq; cf. C. Hemer, *The Letters to the Seven Churches of Asia in Their Local Setting,* Michigan 2001, 82–84; cf. N. Sitwell, *The Roman Roads of Europe,* New York 1981, 192 et seqq.; cf. D. Baronowski, *The Status of the Greek cities of Asia Minor after 190 B.C.,* in Hermes 119 (1991), 450–463; A. Jones, *The Cities of the Eastern Roman Provinces,* Oxford 1971; cf. S. Mitchell, *Roman Residents and Roman Property in Southern Asia Minor*, in *Acta of the 10th International Congress of Classical Archaeology*, Ankara-Izmir 1978, cf. M. Sartre, *L'Asie Mineure et l'Anatolie d'Alexandre à Dioclétien,* Paris 1995. As regards the particular history of the city of Smyrna from its foundation to the arrival of the Roman Empire, no better study exists than that of C. Cadoux, especially with regards to the information provided on epitaphs, coins, archaeological vestiges and the quotation from classical sources, cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna*, Oxford 1938.

311 Cf. I. Mazzini, *La medicina nella letteratura latina,* in *Civiltà materiale e letteratura nel mondo antico,* Macerata 1992, 25–27.

312 Cf. P. Trebilco, *The Early Christians in Ephesus from Paul to Ignatius,* Tübingen 2004, 37–50.

In the midst of this multicultural atmosphere, Christianity was gaining ground, not without serious difficulties. At the beginning of the second century, the mere fact of being a Christian was considered as a crime punishable with the death penalty: believers in Christ were dragged before the tribunals under accusation and the pagan and Jewish population took an active part in the condemnation of those Christians who refused to conform to the imperial cult. In different ways, this context of Asia Minor, and in particular of Smyrna, has an influence on the concrete lives of the Christian community, its relationship with non-Christians, and the way of expressing its beliefs and solving its conflicts.

Accordingly, in this second part, we will make reference to the history of the city of Smyrna and to the groups representing this society: pagans, Jews and Christians. Above all, special attention will be paid to reconstructing the history of the Church of Smyrna and the configuration of its leaders. Finally, within the historical and social analysis of the Christian community, we will study its situation with regards to the imperial cult and the persecutions.

Chapter IV: Pagan Smyrna, city of Asia Minor

In this first main section, we will describe the geopolitical coordinates of the history of Smyrna, its foundational myths, the formation of its identity as a city, re-enacting the most important happenings of its pre-Hellenic, Hellenic, Hellenistic, and Roman eras, its most significant administrative, academic and cultural institutions, and the cult of its pagan gods.

1. Geographical location

Smyrna is situated in the ancient region of Asia Minor. By Asia,[313] one of the three parts or regions of the world was indicated[314]. Another term used to refer to this region is Anatolia (Ἀνατολή) which means land "of the East", where the sun rises; in a subsequent period it was also called Romania, land of the Romans, in Arabic Rum. In the more concrete and administrative sense, it indicated an important Roman province[315].

The region of Asia Minor, that today we recognise more or less as the vast geographical territory comprising Turkey, in the first three centuries of the Christian era was subdivided into various provinces, some of senatorial type, while others depended on the Emperor. In the first century A.D., the Senate was responsible for the provinces of Asia and of Lycia-Pamphylia. The former has Ephesus as capital, and the latter Myra. For their part, the provinces of Galatia and of Bithynia-Pontus depended directly on the Emperor[316].

The central mass of Asia Minor is an arid plateau, between 800 and 1500 m above sea level, which is surrounded in the North and South by mountain chains which run into the Aegean Sea. The western part of the peninsula is an irregular landmass formed by the meeting of mountainous systems, giving a complex geology to the whole area. Two rivers, the Meander and the Hermus, are born in the high part and flow into the sea to the West in the indented bays

313 One of the daughters of Oceanus and Tethys was known in mythology by the name of Asia, cf. Hes., *th.,* 359 (ed. A. Rzach, Leipzig, 1913).

314 Cf. Sallust., *bell. Iugur.,* 17, 3. Sometimes it meant one of the two parts, cf. Varro, *LL.,* 5, 3; 5, 5.

315 *Asia dicitur prioris pars Asiae, in qua est Ionia ac provincia nostra,* cf. *Varro LL.,* 5, 3.

316 Cf. A. Di Berardino, *Atlante Storico del Cristianesimo Antico,* Bologna 2010, 136–137.

of the Aegean coast, while between them flows, a stream called Cayster and to the north of them another named Caicus. None of these four tributaries is navigable; however, the valleys they form are fertile, and four of the most important cities of this populous region arise close to their mountains. Miletus lies on the mountain opposite the Meander, Ephesus close to Cayster, not far from Caicus stands Pergamum, while close to the mouth of the Hermus Smyrna may be found.

The turbulent Hermus was venerated by the ancients as a son of the divinity[317]. This river is about 322 kilometres long and is born in "the sacred mountain of Mother Dindimene"[318], today known by the name of *Murad-Dagh*, not far from the heads of certain tributaries of the Meander and flows into the Gulf of Smyrna. Its present-day Turkish name is *Gediz-Chai* because of the village of Gediz which is close to its source.

Near the Hermus and the city of Smyrna is a mountain rising to 1494 m above sea level whose ancient name was Sipylus[319], *Manisa-Dagh* in Turkish, starting from a mountain chain which runs from north of Smyrna to the interior of Lydia. From there towards the gulf of Smyrna, the land is fertile and filled with olive-trees, fruit-trees, walnut-trees and vineyards. Several tributaries of the Hermus flow over this fertile land, one of which is doubtless the torrent Meles which classical tradition identified as the river on whose banks the illustrious poet Homer was born[320]. This tributary became so famous as to be converted into the icon of Smyrna[321], and when the city changed its location to another affluent which passed close to the new settlement, the same name was given to it. Regarding this tributary and the life arising around it, in the second century A.D., the philosopher Aelius Aristides speaks at length, when he describes the city of Smyrna.

> This is the ornament that lies before its doors, instead of an Apollo guardian of the streets, like a hallway into the city, the Meles, the eponymous canal of the Nymphs[322] from its sources down to the sea, so that these enjoy smooth bathing and the Nereids

317 Hesiod also counts it as one of the progeny of Oceanus and Tethys, cf. Hes., *th.,* 343.

318 Cf. Hdt., *hist.,* 1, 80.

319 The Sipylus is a district having a large number of archaeological remains, many of them difficult to identify and date, some of which are prior to the Greek era.

320 Cf. Arist., *Fr.* 1, 277; cf. Ps. Plu., *vit. Hom.,* 1, 3.

321 On the coins of Smyrna, struck under various emperors from Tiberius to Commodus, the Meles was usually represented as a reclining masculine figure holding reeds and grasses, although without the cornucopia which frequently forms part of the insignia of the divine Hellenic rivers, cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna,* Oxford 1938, 15.

322 Eponymous, since the name of the nymphs of the region recurs.

receive it from the hands of Nereus[323] after a short while. The Meles flows, arising likewise from caves, houses, trees and in the midst of its bed, and advancing as far as the sea. Its source, in the part of its springs higher up in the mountain, is circular and similar to a collar, while what follows could be compared to a strait in the sea. At its mouth it is quite quiet, mingling noiselessly with the sea, softening the swell, giving way to the sea as it advances with the winds, following it when it recedes, presenting a single surface of both waters, so that it is impossible to know where they have met. Even children could tell, and it is possible that anyone could see that it is replete with a few fish that are domesticated and serve as table guests for those holding banquets on its shores, dancing to the sound of the flute not only on dry land but also in its space, and flung headlong in their drunkenness against these other guests. The finest of the river's descendants, and who is related to all the cities, is Homer[324], the common educator of Greece and friend of each one of us through paternal inheritance and from childhood. Accordingly I felt it was only right and proper that everyone offered the first-fruits of his words to the sources of the Meles, as if they were the curls of his locks, as the poet said to Sperchius[325], declaiming to the river in favour of Homer[326].

The first city –Old Smyrna–, before the primitive Hittite settlement, was situated in the north-eastern corner of the gulf of the same name. Notwithstanding, after a difficult time for the city, it was rebuilt by Alexander the Great on the hillsides called Pagus, at longitude 27° 9' east and latitude 38° 26' north. Since then, for approximately 23 centuries, there has been the human settlement which today bears the Turkish name of *Izmir.* Strabo stated that the distance between Smyrna and Ephesus was 320 stadia, or around 23 kilometres, and the distance between Smyrna and Sardis was about 29 kilometers as the crow flies[327].

The climate of Ionia, the northern part where Smyrma lies, was celebrated by Herodotus as more temperate than that of the surrounding regions[328], Hippocrates stated that the climate of Asia was more favourable to animal and plant life than that of European Hellas[329]. Aelius Aristides poetically described the climate of the city: "The breezes of spring and summer have a more charming sound than the nightingales and cicadas of the poets, and each one, penetrating through different places, converts the whole city into a glade"[330]. From June to

323 The Mediterranean Sea.
324 According to Strabo, in Smyrna there was a temple dedicated to the poet, cf. Str., 14, 646; cf. Aristid., *or.* 21, 8 and 33, 29.
325 Cf. Hom., *il.,* 23, 148.
326 Aristid., *or.* 17, 14–15.
327 Cf. Str., 14, 1, 2. At present the distance between Smyrna and Ephesus is 22 kilometres.
328 Cf. Hdt., *hist.,* 1, 242, 149.
329 Cf. Hp., *de aere.,* 12.
330 Aristid., *or.* 17, 12.

September, there is practically no rain and the heat is intense, with the temperature frequently reaching 39°C in the day and 33°C at night, modified at times by a wind from the West that the ancients called Zephyr[331] which blows furiously on the coast every now and then.

Due to the volcanic nature of the mountainous region surrounding Smyrna, this part of Asia Minor is extremely vulnerable to the advent of earthquakes. In the course of its history, Smyrna has suffered terrible earthquakes, while minor telluric movements are recorded each year.

2. Legendary origin of the city

Legends dating from the fourth century B.C. narrate that the Hittites possessed in their army courageous women, who acted both as priestesses and soldiers, very much like the Greek Amazons; these not only had a fortress in the region of Pontus, but were also strong in the western part of the Anatolian peninsula, so that legend attributed to them the founding of the cities of Ephesus, Smyrna, Kyme and Myrina, among others[332].

In particular, the origin and meaning of the name "Smyrna" has been obscured by the uncertainty regarding its etymology and by extravagent legends.

Etymologically, the word "Smyrna" is the same as "Myrina", and Myrina is represented as the Amazon which Myrina founded in the Elaitic Gulf, or as the spouse of Dardanus who was honoured with a hillock on the plain of Ilion, or as the spouse of Thoas and eponymous of the city Myrina of Lemnos[333]. Furthermore, the word "Smyrna" has a more ancient form of "Samorna", "Samonia" or "Samorinia" which was the name given to that part south-east of Ephesus[334]. The last such connection, if it exists, could be between the name of the city and an ancient Semitic word which is pronounced in Hebrew "môr" (מור) and as "σμύρνα" in Greek, which indicates the myrrh produced by Arabic plants by the name of "*Balsamodendron myrrha*" or *"Commiphora myrrha"*, which are shrubs or small trees with green leaves and two small lateral leaves[335]. Between the fourth century

331 Cf. Aristid., *or.* 19, 3.

332 Cf. Str., 11, 5, 4.

333 Cf. Hom., *il.,* 2, 811–814; cf. Str., 12, 8, 6.

334 Cf. Str., 14, 1, 4.

335 After the time of the rains an incision is made in the trunk, which exudes a rubbery, bitter, and aromatic resin that is yellow in colour which, once dried, has irregular shapes and a browny-reddish tint. This plant grows spontaneously still in Arabia, Egypt and Abyssinia, belonging to the family of the Terebintaceae or Burseraceae, which exudes a sort of resinous rubber in the form of tears, of bitter taste, aromatic,

B.C. and the fifth century A.D., the city of Smyrna was relatively frequently is known by the alternative spelling of "Zmyrna". In inscriptions of the city, the name appears 141 times with an "S" and 64 times with a "Z".

As regards the legends, in agreement with some of these, the cities of Ephesus and Smyrna received the name of one of the Amazons mentioned earlier[336]. Another legend connects the name of Smyrna with the Anatolian Adonis: Smyrna (or Myrrha) was the daughter of Theias, son of Belus, king of Assyria, who amused himself by committing incest with his father, converting himself into the unhappy mother of Adonis, and afterwards, fleeing from his father's fury, transformed into the myrrh tree[337].

Apart from the legendary origin, fruit of the presence of the Amazons in the western part of the peninsula, another well documented tradition attributes to Tantalus, the foundation of the first city of Smyrna on mount Sipylus. Tantalus, son of Zeus and the oceanic Pluto, king of Phrygia and of mount Sipylus, comes to know her after he has been invited by Zeus to the table of mount Olympus, having revealed the secrets that he heard at the table to human beings. In addition, he had stolen ambrose and nectar, sharing it out to his friends. Thereafter, wishing to return the favour to the gods, Tantalus invited them to a banquet organised on mount Sipylus, but when food for the banquet began to run out, he offered his son Pelops. Finally Zeus, scandalised at such crimes, crushed Tantalus with a rock jutting out from mount Sipylus and destroyed his kingdom. The classic authors assert that the tomb of Tantalus may be found on mount Sipylus[338],

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semi-transparent, red, fragile and bright on breaking, from which what is perhaps the most ancient balsam in the history of mankind is obtained. Its properties are stimulating and anti-spasmodic. The young trees drip the same rubbery resin, but liquid. There are two classes of myrrh, known as 'myrrh in tears' and 'myrrh in luck', the former is of a reddish-brown colour, smells aromatic and tastes bitter, the latter consists of dull brownish masses, mixed with fragments of bark. Both of them have more or less the same medicinal properties and were used by the ancients, cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna,* 31.

336 Cf. Str., 14, 1, 4.

337 This is told by Ovid, cf. Ov., *Met.,* 10, 298–500.

338 Cf. Paus., *Grae. descr.,* 7, 24, 13. Pausanias, a writer from the second century A.D., like a large part of this literary movement, does not possess a well defined personality and context except perhaps his belonging to Asia Minor. His work, product of a concrete formation in the most prestigious cultural centres in Asia Minor, is a fundamental source for philologists and classic historians. The work of Pausanias bears on the political activity of the emperors in the context of Asia Minor and the sociocultural life of Smyrna and Pergamum.

and that precisely there on the mount, according to the testimony of Aelius Aristides, the first city of Smyrna was founded:

> The most ancient city was founded on Sipylus, where it is said[339] are the beds of the gods and the places where the Curetes dance around the mother of Zeus. From the beginning, it was so desired by the gods that the poets say[340] that the gods meet up with the heroes on it when holding a banquet together. The nymphs received that first city, which is now under water, submerged in the lake, it is said[341].

In fact, other classic sources affirm that the city sank into the Naulocus to the north of the Gulf of Smyrna, after being destroyed by the Lydian king Alyattes in about 588 B.C.[342]

Following the destruction of this mythical Smyrna, another city was founded in a new more suitable location on the coast and at the mouth of the river Hermus. According to another legend, the founder was Theseus, also father and mythical king of Athens, who on conquering the Amazons of that region, came back for one of them as his spouse and immortalised her name by conferring it, Smyrna, on the new city[343]. For this legendary twinning, between Athens and Smyrna, when the Athenians expanded through Anatolia, they set up a Greek colony, and to Homer the whole of his cultural patrimony[344].

3. Smyrna in the pre-Hellenic age

In the area where Smyrna arose, there had been a settlement in about 3000 B.C. by the Leleges[345], in the place called *Tepekule* near to present-day *Bayrakli* and *Izmir* in Turkey. The Leleges were some of the first original inhabitants of Greece, the Aegean sea and the south-east of Anatolia[346].

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339 Cf. Hom., *il.,* 24, 615.

340 Cf. Pindar, *Olim.,* 1, 37.

341 Aristid., *or.* 17, 3. It is presumed that the lake in which the city was said to have been submerged was not very large since located on mount Sipylus. The popular identification associates it with the present-day *Karagöl.*

342 Cf. Hdt., *hist.,* 1, 16; cf. Paus., *Grae. descr.,* 7, 5, 1.

343 Cf. Tac., *an.,* 4, 56; cf. Aristid., *or.* 17, 5.

344 Cf. Ps. Plu., *vit. Hom.,* 2.

345 Cf. A. Wayne, *The First Urban Christians: The Social World of the Apostle Paul,* New Haven 1983, 43–44.

346 These people were already present in these regions when the first Indo-European tribes from the Hellenes arrived. During the Bronze Age, the term *lulahi* was in use in the Luwian language, referring to the barbarian peoples. So that "Leleges" came to be an attempt at Greek transcription. Another theory on the origin of this

Subsequently, the region of the Leleges was affected at the time of maximum cultural and political expansion of the Hittite Empire. The Hittites, who settled towards the year 2000 B.C. on the eastern bank of the river *Halys* in the centre of Anatolia, succeeding the Semites from Mesopotamia who were previously in control of this area, developed a culture and built an empire which at the height of its splendour reached as far south as the city of Kadesh and to the West up to the present-day gulf of Smyrna around the year 1380 B.C. with the kingdom of the "Great King" Suppiluliuma. This domination over the shores of the Aegean Sea could take the form of a quasi-colonial settlement or of a sovereignty that was political and of security, or possibly both, through a treaty[347].

Towards the thirteenth century B.C. the power of the Hittite Empire over the western area of the Anatolian peninsula declined and they found themselves forced to retreat towards Syria and beyond the Euphrates, when in the kingdom of the Hittite king Arnuanta, the empire was shaken by a powerful attack of the Egyptians in a coalition which also comprised Libyans, Lycians and Tyrians. Besides, a few decades later, from the West, the Achaeans broke into the region. The valley of the Hermus, the coast and the nearby islands in the Gulf of Smyrna were among the places where some of the happenings, not all legendary, of the Trojan War took place between about 1300 and 1100 B.C., thus converting the region into a connecting-point between Asia Minor and European Hellas.

4. Hellenic Smyrna

In this great and important period of the history of the city and of the configuration of its culture, the creative force of the Greek culture, first the Aeolian

name is that it derives from a king of the same name, called Lelex, according to the etymology offered by the Greek mythographists in order to give names to the tribes which settled in the area. Homer states in the Iliad that the Leleges fought on the side of the Trojans during the Trojan War, cf. Hom., *il.,* 10, 427.

347 A sign of this is the fact that the Minoan and Mycenian cultures did not have any great influence on the West of Asia Minor, at least until the end of the Mycenian age and that Hittite monuments were found together with the outline of highways which linked up Hattusa, capital of the empire, with the West of the Anatolian peninsula, reaching as far as the city of Ephesus. Abundant ruins from this age may still be found in the region. The cult of the mother goddess with Hittite characteristics, a number of acropolyses, tombs and monuments from this culture show the influence of this empire in the area during at least seven centuries. For a comprehensive list and full description of the archaeological vestiges from the surroundings of the region of Smyrna in Hellenic and Hellenistic times, cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna,* 24, 39–45.

and later the Ionian is present besides the enigmatic and all-important work of Homer and the continuous attacks of the Lydians and the Persians from the nearby kingdom of Sardis.

As regards the influence of Greek culture, there is no reason to doubt that the numerous Hellenic cities on the islands and along the western coastline of Asia Minor, from Lesbos to Rhodes, were developed by colonists who left European Hellas as a consequence of the disturbances there[348]. The history of these events narrated by various classic authors, while full of discordant details, coincide fully in this fundamental truth. The first group of emigrants were the Aeolians, who on being expelled from Thessaly by the Dorians, fell back along the various routes of Asia; one group of them, coming from Cyme, arrived as far as the region of Smyrna, at the foot of mount Sipylus, where in about the year 1046 B.C., they founded the new city[349].

After the Aeolians, Smyrna was conquered in about 750 B.C. by the Ionians from Colophon[350]. These, taking advantage of the Aeolians' distraction as they celebrated the feasts of Dionysus outside the city walls, took it by surprise and drove out the whole Aeolian population. Following this occupation, Smyrna began to form part of the Ionian faction which was growing in organisation and development in Asia Minor[351].

In a few short years, the whole of this region of Asia Minor came to be called the Ionian Coast, with a conglomerate of twelve independent cities sharing the same religious and semi-political alliance known as the Pan-Ionian League; these cities were: Phocaea, Clazomenae, Teos, Colophon, Ephesus, Priene, Myus, Miletus, Chios, Samos and perhaps Smyrna, although it is questionable in this last case whether it actually belonged to the League early on, or whether on the

348 On the Greek influence in Asia Minor, cf. G. Glotz, *The Aegean Civilization,* London 1968; cf. C. Roebuck, *Economy and Society in the East Early Greek World,* Chicago 1994.

349 Smyrna was one of the twelve Aeolian cities testified to by the classic authors, cf. Hdt., *hist.,* 1, 149; cf. Paus., *Grae. descr.,* 7, 5; cf. Aristid., *or.* 17, 4.

350 According to Strabo, the Ionians were in fact the first founders of this new city who were earlier displaced to Colophon by the Aeolian invaders. So that the Ionian colonisation of Smyrna was read by Strabo as a just vindication, cf. Str., 16, 1, 4. Tradition affirms that the place of origin of the Ionians was the city of Pylos in the Peloponnese and that, after taking refuge in Athens, they were led by one of the sons of king Codrus, Androcles or Nereus.

351 The Ionian population was formed once the population had been settled in Asia Minor and did not arrive already formed as a cultural unit from Greece as Herodotus states, cf. Hdt., *hist.,* 1, 143, 145–148.

contrary, on account of the way in which it was captured by the Ionians, it was rejected at first by the League and only towards the third century B.C. was it accepted as an official member[352]. Actually, the belonging, or not officially to the Pan-Ionian League did not gravely impede the development of Smyrna, perhaps it saved it from some or other inconvenient alliance to go to war with someone, or deprived it of some commercial agreement; however, in practice it enjoyed all the cultural influence of the Ionian culture, also on account of its privileged position serving as it did as a commercial bridge between Lydia and the Ionian cities[353]. Smyrna, being a part of the Ionian culture, participated in a flourishing cultural development. In agriculture, trade, navigation, art, athletics, religious rituals, philosophy, and literature, the Ionians were the most competent of the Hellenics[354]. All of these cities of Ionian culture spoke their own dialect which later influenced the Attic dialect, creating the Ionian-Attic dialectal group of the great Greek classic writers beginning with Homer.

The Homer question[355], the authorship and compilation of various poems which led to two huge masterpieces, such as are the Iliad and the Odyssey, and the birth in Smyrna of its compiler and in large measure author, is still hotly debated and this is perhaps not the right occasion to deal with it in depth; however, we may at least make certain meaningful considerations. First of all, the dialect in which the Homeric Poems were written has a strong similarity to the dialect of the Ionian cities of Asia Minor, with a certain mixture of Aeolian forms from Thessaly, Boeotia and Lesbos, which reflect the demographic configuration, as we have seen, of the city of Smyrna, though not of it alone.

Secondly, although Smyrna is never mentioned in the Homeric Poems, these speak abundantly of the western region of Asia Minor, making allusions to the river Hermus, mount Sipylus, and other places surrounding the city. After a careful reading of Homer, one may conclude that the region where the poems most probably assumed their present form must be established near or in the Gulf of Smyrna. The external evidence, regarding the life of Homer, confirms that

352 Cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna,* 68–69.

353 Cf. Hdt., *hist.,* 1, 142.

354 The first event in the history of Smyrna which bears a precise date was the city's participation in the 23rd edition of the Olympic Games in the year 688 B.C. when the Ionian from Smyrna, Onomastus, was proclaimed the winner in wrestling, cf. Paus., *Grae. descr.,* 5, 8, 7.

355 A series of problems arising around the poems of Homer are referred to as the *Homer question.* Among the queries most debated are who were its authors, and in what way were they elaborated, cf. A. Lesky, *Historia de la Literatura Griega,* Madrid 2009.

this is so. Around 20 different places have been suggested by the ancients as the poet's birthplace; however, three are most frequently specified, namely Smyrna, Chios and Colophon, while certain famous cities like Ephesus and Miletus do not appear among those that are truly probable. Of the many classical authors who identify Smyrna as Homer's birthplace, it is above all Aristotle who affims that the poet was born on the banks of the river Meles which bathed the city of Smyrna[356] with its water. The tradition of this identification is early and sufficiently persistent to ensure that this affirmation has sound historical bases[357].

The Iliad and the Odyssey probably assumed their final form in the age in which Smyrna was fully under Ionian influence. In fact, starting from that time, both works are received with popular enthusiasm and admiration, generating a justified pride in Smyrna and the other cities of the Ionian fraternity. It is especially the localisation of Homer's home town in Smyrna that interests the Athenians in developing the myth according to which the founder of the city of Smyrna was Theseus, who was also the father of Athens. Only then did Smyrna come to be definitively considered a colony founded by Athens.

In about 685 B.C. the neighbouring kingdom of Sardis was governed by Gyges, first king of the Mermnad dynasty, who made of Sardis a powerful and extremely rich city whose influence extended not only to Asia but into continental Greece itself. The new policy of the kingdom aimed at expanding its influence over the Mediterranean and directed its attacks accordingly against the foremost ports such as Smyrna, Colophon and Miletus[358]. Colophon rapidly fell at the feet of Gyges, who continued to exert pressure on all the Greek cities of Asia Minor, so that their inhabitants sought refuge en masse in Smyrna. For years, Smyrna was the only Greek city of Ionia capable of holding out against the Lydian attacks and even managing to route them[359] in 660 B.C.

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356 Cf. Arist., *fr.,* 2, 196; cf. Ps. Plu., *vit. Hom.,* 1, 3. Cicero, at a later date, in a discourse in the year 61 B.C. mentions the fame of Smyrna as homeland of Homer and the temple which it has erected to him, cf. Cic., *Pro Arch.,* 8, 19.

357 Although the tradition according to which Chios was Homer's birthplace is likewise an early one; nonetheless, it appears to some extent discontinued thereafter, cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna,* 74–75 and 210–211. The Christian tradition through the mouth of the martyr Pionius, likewise assigns Homer's birthplace to Smyrna, cf. *Martyrdom of Pionius*, 4, 2. The same will be stated much later by Isidore of Seville, cf. Isid. Sev., *Etym.,* 15, 1,39 (PL 82, 532).

358 Cf. Hdt., *hist.,* 1, 14.

359 Cf. Hdt., *hist.,* 1, 14.

In spite of the political convulsion of the area, Ionia continued to enjoy important commercial exchanges and a flourishing development of Philosophy in those years. Smyrna, at the end of the seventh century and beginning of the sixth B.C., was once more outstanding for a great man of letters, poet and musician named Mimnermus. This man of culture wrote an epic poem which described the foundation of Smyrna by colonists from Colophon, that we know as *Smyrneis,* and a book of love verses written in elegiac metre[360] named *Nanno,* characterised by a great sensuality and veiled melancholy[361].

The melancholy of Mimnermus' work chances to be consonant with later events. A successor of Giges, Alyattes even further developed the nationalist and expansionist policy of Sardis conquering, subduing and destroying various cities in the West of the peninsula, of which the last to surrender was the city of Smyrna. A number of inhabitants of the city escaped to Colophon, where they were received as citizens. Many died, and women and children were reduced to slavery in the Lydian palaces[362]. The acropolis of the city was dismantled, the city walls destroyed and most of the houses burned[363].

For about 300 years after the conquest by Alyattes, Smyrna existed, not as an organised and independent city, but as a mere group of inhabited centres close to one another. Much of its political and commercial importance was assumed by its neighbour Phocaea, although the Lydians certainly continued to make use of the excellent position of Smyrna's port. After the Lydian power, there arrived towards the year 546 B.C., the crushing force of Persia which with its king Cyrus routed the Lydians. Sardis was converted into the capital of the new Satrapia, the Pan-Ionian League largely fell apart and the little remaining of the city of Smyrna was completely dismantled. For this reason, Smyrna finds itself absent from the chronicles of the Greco-Persian Wars of the fifth century B.C. between Greeks and Persians, and from the Pelopponesian War (431–405 B.C.) between the Athenians and the Spartans. The latter had the Persians as allies at the end of this war, thus enabling the latter to increase their power in Asia Minor.

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360 A classic strophe of two verses, one hexameter and one pentameter.

361 His writings are edited, cf. J. Rodriguez, *El ala y la cigarra. Fragmentos de la poesía arcaica griega no épica,* Madrid 2005.

362 Cf. W. Ramsay, *The Letters of the Seven Churches of Asia,* New York 1904, 85.

363 Cf. Hdt., *hist.,* 1, 16.

5. Hellenistic Smyrna

In spring 334 B.C. Alexander the Great crossed the Hellespont, thus beginning his great campaign against the Persian Empire[364]. Among the first cities to be conquered was Sardis, thus restoring Lydian laws and customs. On the march towards Ephesus, legend says that Alexander halted to go hunting on mount Pagus near to the destroyed Smyrna. Since he was tired, he decided to rest in the shade of a plane tree and, while listening to the sound of the river Meles, which gushed forth from the hill, he fell asleep. It was then that the two goddesses Nemesis appeared to him in his dreams indicating where he was to build a new city by the name of Smyrna. Alexander the Great, surprised, decided to consult the oracle of Colophon to confirm his visions, and the answer he received in distichs was engraved in an inscription displayed in the agora of the third Smyrna: "Thrice, yes, four times blest will those men be Who shall dwell in Pagus beyond the sacred Meles."[365]. Centuries later, Aelius Aristides in an ingenious way, will revert to this legend in order to join the importance of the glory of Smyrna to the importance of Alexandria, "at the hands of the man who founded the two finest and grandest monuments, one in this city, and the other the colonisation of the Nile"[366].

At the time of Alexander's death in the year 323 B.C., the city of Ephesus was the new protagonist of the region, since starting off from it, Alexander had restored the Pan-Ionian League and had launched his most crushing attacks against the cities with pro-Persian oligarchies, setting up democratic governments in them. Later, the internal wars between Alexander's successors caused a good deal of instability in the region until Lysimachus definitively took over almost total power of the same for almost 20 years, in which he increased the rebuilding of many cities, especially Ephesus, and also Smyrna, though always to

364 On the expedition of Alexander and the reasons for the war, cf. M. Sartre, *L'Asie Mineure et l'Anatolie d'Alexandre à Dioclétien,* Paris 1995, 15–20.

365 Cf. Paus., *Grae. descr.,* 7, 5, 2–3.

366 Aristid., *or.,* 21, 4. Although the legend has been discussed by later writers there are certain aspects that may make it in part historical. As is known, Alexander had inherited from his master Aristotle the passion for Homer, so that it is probable that he wished to honour his memory by re-founding his native city. Besides, Pliny, who wrote one century before Pausanias, halfway through the third century B.C. although without making allusion to the legend, refers that the foundation of Smyrna was made by Alexander, cf. Plin., *nat. hist.,* 5, 29. On the contrary, Strabo attributed the foundation of the third Smyrna, not to Alexander, but to his companions Antigone and Lysimachus, who became his successors following the death of Alexander, cf. *Str.,* 14. 1.

a lesser degree than the former, setting up different buildings in them the ruins of which even today are most impressive[367].

Thereafter, the city was dominated by the Seleucids, who guaranteed it a certain independence. Nonetheless, the city kept up continuous fights with the neighbouring cities of Pergamum and Magnesia, both at military level and at that of sports disciplines in which Smyrna played an outstanding role in those years[368]. In the year 188 B.C., the Seleucids were expelled from Ionia and Asia Minor. During the war between Rome and Perseus, king of Macedonia from 172 to 167 B.C., Smyrna and other cities of Asia allied themselves with Rome. This was merely one further step in the friendship and admiration that Smyrna had evinced from early on for the recently emerging power. In fact, a few years earlier, Smyrna had given emphatic expression to her political sentiments towards the Romans by erecting, for the first time in history, a temple to the city of Rome[369].

6. Roman Smyrna

If the Greek genius of Alexander had chosen this unsurpassable new location of the city, joining to the beauty and defensive strength of an acropolis, the good ports by means of which to distribute the products of a fertile land, it was the practical thinking of the Romans which ensured making the best possible use of the resources of its vast territory. Thus the Romans endowed the city with paved avenues, with broad and regular streets, with aqueducts, public baths, and ports in which to anchor boats with their merchandise[370]. The city which extended over all of the coastal strip, seemed to attract the navigator towards its ports so graciously crowned by mount Pagus and the natural wealth of the Sipylus into its embrace.

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367 Lysimachus changed the names of these two cities, calling Ephesus by the name of Arsinoeia in honour of his wife Arsinoe; and Smyrna by the name of Eurydikeia in honour of his daughter Eurydike. On the death of Lysimachus in 281 B.C, due in large measure to his unpopularity, both cities reverted to their original names, cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna,* 96–103.

368 On Asia under the Seleucids, cf. M. Sartre, *L'Asie Mineure et l'Anatolie d'Alexandre à Dioclétien,* Paris 1995, 24–27.

369 Cf. Tac., *an.,* 4, 56.

370 For a careful analysis of the characteristics of the Roman cities in the East, cf. A. Jones, *The Cities of the Eastern Roman Provinces,* Oxford 1971; cf. S. Mitchell, *Roman Residents and Roman Property in Southern Asia Minor,* in *Acta 10th Intern. Congress of Classical Archaeology,* Ankara-Izmir 1978; cf. W. Ramsay, *The Sacred Basis of the Roman Power in Asia Minor,* Aberdeen 1967 2.

Towards the year 126 B.C. the Romans began to design all the features of the new province of Asia, fruit of the strength of its emerging power. They set up Ephesus as its capital and made a whole network of highways connecting it with the neighbouring cities. The wealth due to the rise of Roman trade in the area was not slow in appearing. Smyrna too received territories for having fought at Rome's side and benefitted from an independence protected by the Romans over a long period of time[371].

However, Smyrna's loyalty to Rome came to a halt during the following years, when the king of Pontus, Mithridates VI Eupator, carried his conflict against Rome into Hellas and Asia Minor. Pontus had rapidly grown in power and, after repelling the Roman armada on its frontiers, Mithridates raided the unprotected Roman province of Asia where he declared himself champion of the Hellenics against their Western oppressors. The cities of this province welcomed him with even divine honours. In 88 B.C. Mithridates organised a great massacre of Romans and Italics from Ephesus without distinction of age, sex and race in all the cities of the province and the nearby islands. Smyrna, as shown on the coins bearing the effigy of Mithridates, failed to maintain its by now historic loyalty with Rome[372]. However, in the face of the powerful reaction of Rome commanded by the Roman general Sulla, all the cities of Asia straightway went over to the Roman side, including Smyrna, to the point that, to show their immense admiration for and solidarity with Rome, once Sulla had signed a peace treaty with Mithridates and the Roman troops remained unequipped with suitable clothing for the winter, the inhabitants of Smyrna in the midst of an assembly took off any unessential garments they were wearing with the intention of carrying them without delay to the Roman legions[373]. Even in spite of this gesture of solidarity, Smyrna paid with its liberty its momentary betrayal of the Romans with its liberty, thus losing the advantageous situation of ally of Rome, independent and exempt from taxes. From then on, starting from the peace of the Dardanelles in the year 85 B.C. between Rome and Mithridates VI, Smyrna together with the whole Asian province remained completely under the forceful domination of Rome.

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371 From the year 103 until 92 B.C., the city received various Roman politicians exiled as a result of various circumstances, most of these were generals who had lost certain battles and were forced into exile, seeking refuge in the prosperous and tranquil city of Asia Minor. These included Servilius Caepio, Caecilius Metellus Numidicus and Mucius Scaevola, cf. H. Leclerq, *Smyrne,* in *Dictionnaire d'archéologie chrétienne et de liturgie,* Paris 1953, 1525.

372 Cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna,* 155–156.

373 Cf. Tac., *an.,* 4, 56.

During the civil war which began to mark the change from Republican Rome to Imperial Rome, Asia Minor was the scenario, though not the centre, of continuous battles and the measuring of strengths between Pompey and Julius Caesar. Pompey, who in the beginning enjoyed the support of Asia Minor, was defeated by Julius Caesar in Thessaly in the year 48 B.C. After this, Julius Caesar made for the province of Asia where he won the favour of the whole area by reducing taxes to one third and banishing the republicans. The cities of Asia Minor lost no time in showing their gratitude to the commander, addressing divine praises to him. As supreme head of the Roman state, Julius Caesar promised the free exercise of their religion in the cities of Asia Minor[374].

Thereafter, Octavius repeated the policy of pardon and benevolence with the cities of Asia Minor, adopted years earlier by Julius Caesar, and aware of the grateful memory of the latter, promoted the construction of altars in his memory and to the greatness of Rome in this region[375]. Accordingly, with the rise of Octavius Augustus to power, there began for Smyrna, and the whole Empire, an era of permanent peace and prosperity. The new senatorial province was headed by a proconsul, who had no army at his disposal, but only a small force for policing purposes. Although it was the site of a *conventus iuridicus,* Smyrna was politically inferior to Ephesus, capital of the province, and had to pay tribute to Rome. Nonetheless, it considerably increased its wealth and prosperity thanks to commercial exchanges and the fertility of its soil. In addition, the religious and

374 Brutus and Cassius, the conspirators responsible for the death of Julius Caesar, met in Smyrna in the year 43 B.C. to agree on concrete measures to be taken against Antony and Octavius, Julius Caesar's successors. Following the defeat of the traitors in Philippi and their subsequent suicide, Antony with Octavius began their dispute for total command of the Roman world. Antony, who had taken the eastern part of the latter, established himself in Ephesus during the winter of the year 33 to 32 B.C., where he succeeded in gathering all his troops which were defeated for good one year later by Octavius in the battle of Actium in the year 31 BC.

375 27 B.C. is generally considered to be the year in which the Roman Republic gives way to the Empire. Then it was that Octavius received the new and permanent name of Augustus and when the fresh system of provincial administration was put in hand. The provinces remained divided between the Emperor and the Senate. The Emperor, through his legates, controls the bordering provinces, while the Senate takes responsibility for the rest, subject, however, to the intervention of the Emperor in the case of maladministration or in special circumstances. Asia was a senatorial province from the outset.

educational municipal activity grew considerably, as was expressed concretely in the splendid public buildings it put up[376].

Smyrna always made a show of its loyalty to Rome and to the emperors to attract their favour. After the death of Augustus, great founder of the imperial system in the year 14 A.D., even his successor the austere emperor Tiberius, little given to honours, especially divine ones, gave way before the credentials and arguments presented to him by the Smyrna delegation to found a temple of the imperial cult in his honour[377]. A public competition was held between various cities of Asia Minor, and the Senate had to choose between them. The competition was especially fierce between Sardis and Smyrna. Tacitus is our principal source for verifying the merits vaunted by the cities competing for this privilege and how these referred to the past of their cities:

> Twelve cities competed, of equal ambition, but having different strengths. With no great distance between one and the other, they made reminder of the antiquity of their lineage, of the favours done to the Roman people in the wars against the Persian, against Aristonicus and the rest of the kings… But those of Smyrna, having recalled their antiquity, whether of Tantalus, son of Jupiter, who had founded them, or Theseus of divine stock, or one of the Amazons, passed on to those arguments with which greater credit is gained, namely, the favours done to the Roman people: who were sent a large number of boats not only for wars beyond their frontiers, but also to those being suffered in Italy; that they were the first to set up a cult to Rome during the consulate of M. Porcius (in 195 B.C.), when the power of Rome was great, but not yet arrived at its apogee, since the Punic capital was still on its feet and the kings of Asia were very strong. At the same time they invoked the name of Sulla, since with the army in a critical situation (as a result of the harsh weather and the lack of shelter), once this situation was made known in public assembly, all of those there present took the clothes off their bodies and handed them over to our legions. At these requests, the senators chose Smyrna[378].

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376 Cf. Str., 14, 1, 37. This environment of peace and prosperity, such as had not been experienced for a long time, meant that in the East, even more than in the West, and in Asia particularly, the cult of the figure of the emperor developed apace, as expressed in the celebration of a costly festival in honour of the emperor under his title of Asiarch or High Priest of Asia. On the influence of the Roman Empire in Asia Minor, on its social basis and its politics, cf. W. Ramsay, *The Social Basis of the Roman Power in Asia Minor*, Aberdeen 1967 2; A. Sherwin-N. White, *Roman Foreign Policy in the East,* London 1984.

377 On the imperial cult in Asia Minor and especially the cult of the goddess Roma, cf. C. Fayer, *Il culto della dea Roma,* Pescara 1976.

378 Tac., *an.,* 4, 55–56.

With 400 votes in favour, Smyrna obtained the majority *placet* of the Roman Senate[379]. As from then, the Smyrnaeans, in addition to recollecting the great events of their history and the prestige of their ancestors, reiterated their loyalty to the Empire with pride and stated that they not only possessed the first temple built to Roma, but also a temple in honour of Augustus. Thus a neochoria was established in Smyrna in the year 26 A.D., that is, a concession to put up a temple in honour of Augustus.

In general, during the Julio-Claudian dynasty, Asia Minor enjoyed the favour of the emperors. A special cult was dedicated to Caligula in Miletus[380], while Claudius undoubtedly contributed to renewing the theatre of Smyrna[381]. However, Nero, following the burning of Rome in the year 64 A.D., carried off much of the gold and works of art of the Hellenistic cities of Asia, for the reconstruction of the capital of the Empire, so that without doubt, Smyrna suffered greatly from this imperial expropriation[382].

Smyrna did not play a leading role in the disturbances which broke out on the fall of Nero in the year 68 A.D. and the arrival of Vespasian in autumn of the year 70 A.D. Vespasian rapidly won over the oriental provinces and restored various temples including one in the immediate neighbourhood of Smyrna in honour of Zeus. In the first year of the rule of Titus as emperor, the proconsul of Asia, Ulpius Trajan, father of the man who was later to become the emperor Trajan, built an aqueduct which drew water from the mountains close to Smyrna, carrying it to the West[383].

Under Domitian's government, the city of Smyrna enjoyed good relations with Ephesus, while a similar understanding was reached between it and the cities of Pergamum and Sardis, as is shown by the coins struck at this time which give clear proof of such concord. Domitian's administrative policy was harsh and

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379 Aelius Aristides evoked this event in the history of the city in his discourse following its destruction by an earthquake. He affirmed that this same temple dedicated to Tiberius, Livia and the Senate, which was destroyed as a result of the earthquake, could now be rebuilt using provincial funds, but that the reconstruction of the whole city required the favour of the emperors, cf. Aristid., *or.,* 19, 13.

380 In Miletus, there was a statue of Caligula, on the pedestal of which was a list of the Asian citizens who had patronised this work, including one, Olimpianus Hieronymus from Smyrna, cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna,* 242; cf. D. Baronowski, *The Status of the Greek Cities of Asia Minor after 190 B.C.,* in *Hermes* 119 (1991), 450–463.

381 Cf. M. Rabanal, *La Provincia de Asia según la epigrafía,* Seville 1975, 89.

382 Cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna,* 244.

383 Cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna,* 247–248.

even extreme in various cases, refusing to spare the lives of certain proconsuls suspected of conspiracy[384].

The rise to power of Nerva in the year 96 A.D. ushered in almost a century of good government, with permanent imperial peace, and a high economic and cultural level. In its time, a delegation from Smyrna obtained certain gifts and privileges from the emperor, in particular, a considerable sum of money together with statues or paintings of the Nemesis[385]. For his part, Trajan continued his predecessor's efforts to secure prosperity; however, his efforts to ensure the expansion of the Empire in the East and his wars against the Dacians and the Parthians meant that he did not concern himself overmuch with the pacified region of Asia Minor.

On the contrary, Hadrian showed his predilection for Hellenic culture[386], from the time he came to power in the year 117 A.D. The emperor-traveller visited the province of Asia Minor personally and in pompous style in the winter of the year 123 to 124, was in Ephesus and certainly in Smyrna. The Smyrnaeans decided to adore Hadrian as "Olympic Zeus" and "Saviour of the whole human race" and even erected a temple in his honour, striking coins with the inscription *"Hadriana Smyrna"* and celebrating games in his honour known as *"Olympia Hadriana"*. In return, the emperor granted Smyrna exemption from taxes[387]. We can just imagine the inconvenience and tension that all of this uproar caused for both the Jews and the Christians of the city[388].

Contrary to the foreign policy of Hadrian, his successor, Antoninus Pius, governed throughout his long reign from 138 to 161 without leaving Italy, giving sufficient autonomy to his provincial governors and giving them administrative instructions or good wishes by means of letters, such as the one he addressed to the governor of Asia in Ephesus or the letter he sent to the "Synod

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384 Cf. Suet., *Domitianus,* 8, 2; 10, 2. The problem of Domitian's government in relation to the Christian community will be dealt with hereafter, together with the politics of the other emperors after him on this same aspect, cf. pp. 182–184.

385 On the Nemeses, cf. pp. 113, 195.

386 Cf. M. Rizzi, *Hadrian and the Christians,* Berlin 2010, 62–69.

387 During the time Hadrian spent in Smyrna two famous personages were very close to the emperor: Polemon, a great rhetorician who represented Smyrna in various lawsuits involving Rome, in the constant disputes on privileges and exemptions as between Ephesus, Pergamum and Smyrna. Other personage is Theon, an astronomer, mathematician, and Platonic philosopher.

388 In order to examine in greater depth the development of Judaism and Christianity at the time of Hadrian, cf. M. Rizzi, *Hadrian and the Christians,* Berlin 2010.

of Initiates of Smyrna"[389]. This style of government was much praised by his contemporaries.

Probably, fruit of the years in which foreign policy was handled in such an internal way, Marcus Aurelius, the successor of Antoninus Pius, had to spend all his energies in battles off all the frontiers of the Empire. Accordingly his government was marked by skirmishes with the barbarian tribes in the *Limes Germanicus*, in Gaul, and all along the Danube, and also by the military conflicts arising in Asia as a result of a revitalised empire of the Parthians.

The history of Marcus Aurelius with Smyrna was linked from before his ascent to the imperial throne, when in the year 147 A.D. the Synod of worshippers of Dionysus Briseus wrote him a letter congratulating him on the birth of his first son. Although the child died shortly after birth, Marcus Aurelius thanked the Synod for its amiability. As soon as he became Emperor, he sent another letter to the Synod in response to the congratulations to him on the occasion of his ascension to power in about the year 161[390]. During the reign of Marcus Aurelius, from the famous discourse of Aelius Aristides, pronounced in Pergamum in the year 167 on the harmony of the cities, it may be inferred that the competition and discord between Pergamum, Smyrna and Ephesus for winning the favour of the Emperors and demonstrating their superior lineage, had arrived at breaking point, so that if such bitter rivalry were to continue, in all probability, Rome would take a stronger political initiative in the region, thus relegating the slight independence that such cities still possessed[391].

In the years 175 and 176, Marcus Aurelius was in the East containing the betrayal and the attempt at usurpation of power by Avidius Cassius. To this undertaking, he brought with him his son Commodus who was only 15 years old. On his return from Egypt to Italy, taking advantage of the opportunity that the Emperor was to pass through Asia, Aelius Aristides, it appears at the petition of the magistrates of Smyrna, prepared a fine discourse commending the beauty of the city, to be pronounced on the act of welcome of the Emperor, who with his son was most impressed by the city[392]. This discourse recalls the historic glories of Smyrna, laying special emphasis on its natural and architectural beauty, on the entity of its population, and on its prosperous trade, concluding: "May these

389 Cf. Probably it is the same Synod of worshippers of Dionysus Briseus, cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna*, 272.

390 Cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna*, 273.

391 Cf. Aristid., *or.,* 23, *Oratio de concordia ad civitates Asiaticas.*

392 Cf. Aristid., *or.,* 17, 1–23.

charms never abandon it, or any of the Muses who inundate the cities of men inhabit outside of the city"[393].

In the year 178 A.D. an earthquake of high magnitude, announced some time earlier by other lesser telluric movements, struck Smyrna. A large part of the city remained in ruins. The temple erected to Tiberius among many of the buildings destroyed. It probably also destroyed the school or Senate of Homeric studies (Ὁμηρικὴ γερουσία), with its respective library[394]. With his rhetoric, Aelius Aristides declared that, in comparison with the disaster that had just occurred, "the sack of Troy was child's play"[395].

As was customary and as Smyrna itself had done for Chios, Erithrae, Teos and Halicarnassus[396], all the cities in the neighbourhood lost no time in coming to the aid of the unfortunate Smyrna, suspending their games and contributing with gifts of money and in kind for the rebuilding of the city.

Aelius Aristides not only composed his rhetoric *Monody for Smyrna,* but without consulting anyone, took the initiative and wrote a letter to the emperor Marcus Aurelius and his son Commodus, describing the terrible situation and imploring them to provide funds for the restoration of the city, inviting them in this way to become its new founders, thus eclipsing the greatness of the ancients:

> Now for me, neither Lysimachus, nor Alexander, nor Theseus and the other legends, but your good selves have come to be the founders of the city, you establish it once more from the beginning; so that the whole city in all its aspects, comes to be yours. If you choose to consider it as a veil of princesses, or as a diadem of the emperors, or in any other way you please, save the city thus. What founders or kings would you not eclipse?[397]

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393 Aristid., *or.,* 17, 13. The meeting and dialogue between the sophist orator and the stoic Emperor is recorded by Philostratus, cf. Philostr., *v. s.,* 2, 9. Philostratus was a Greek sophist of the third century A.D. whose identity has still not been completely clarified. The two big works attributed to him and which provide abundant information on the history of Asia Minor are the *Life of Apollonius of Tyana* and the *Life of the Sophists.*

394 The destruction of this study centre would justify the contrast between the sources used by authors before and after the earthquake. An author subsequent to the earthquake like Quintus of Smyrna finds himself impaired by the loss of important library stocks. Pausanias, who wrote prior to the earthquake, on the contrary, made use of these epic sources in his writings. For an analysis of the sources utilised by Quintus of Smyrna, cf. F. García Romero, *Quinto de Esmirna, Posthoméricas*, Madrid 1997, 13–16.

395 Aristid., *or.,* 18, 7.

396 Cf. Aristid., *or.,* 19, 12.

397 Aristid., *or.,* 19, 4.

The letter proved highly successful. Marcus Aurelius immediately decided to restore the city[398]. Together with his son Commodus, they convoked the Senate and gained approval for the city's reconstruction supervised by a senator of pretorian rank, offering the possibility of sending men to rebuild it if the Smyrnaeans were in agreement; ready money was granted, a temporary exemption from taxes and the granting of honours and privileges which likewise succeeded in mobilising private initiative for this cause. The prestige of Aelius Aristides grew in the face of such a positive reaction by the Empire to his petition, coming to be considered as the "founder" of the new city, a title of almost divine character[399].

Within the following two or three years, the city was already practically rebuilt and city life was recovering its normal rhythm. This is when Aelius Aristides, from his place of retirement in the country, wrote another literary work, *Palinody of Smyrna re-established,* rejoicing at the renewed fortunes of the city and congratulating the magistrates on the objectives achieved[400].

On the death of Marcus Aurelius and with the final arrival in power of his son Commodus in the year 180, Smyrna continued its process of revitalisation on the verges of the madness and extravagances of the new emperor. Aelius Aristides wrote another work, probably addressed to Commodus, but which perhaps never reached its addressee. In his work *Gratulatio Smyrnaea,* Aelius Aristides once more tells of the origins of the city and speaks of its beauty, offering a fine show for its guest as soon as he has the opportunity of visiting it.

Shortly after the death of Aelius Aristides towards the year 189 A.D., the crazed emperor Commodus also died in the year 192 A.D. For the Empire his assassination implied a relief on the one hand, but on the other hand, a year of great instability in which five emperors who unsuccessfully attempted to succeed him died, until the general Septimius Severus seized power and imposed order on the situation. In Smyrna, the first games in honour of the new Emperor, the "*Severia*", were held in the first decade of the third century A.D. Of this time, we know the names of the two brothers who were governors of the province and who considered Smyrna as the "First in Asia," probably on account of their successes

398 Cf. Philostr., *v. s.,* 2, 9.

399 Cf. J. Cortés Copete, *Aristides,* vol. 4, Madrid 1997, 43.

400 Cf. Aristid., *or.,* 20. The city, as shown by the archaeological excavations of the early twentieth century, rebuilt among other things the theatre and the forum, cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna,* 281–282. We know from Philostratus that towards the year 237 a statue of Aelius Aristides was set up in the new market of the city, cf. Philostr., *v. s.,* 2, 9. In the Vatican Library we find a statue of Aelius Aristides dating from this period.

in the games of the Ionian League; their names are: Q. Hedius Rufus Lollianus Gentianus and L. Hedius Rufus Lollianus Avitus. In the reign of Severus, we also have news of agreements of understanding between Smyrna and the cities of Caesarea of Cappadocia, Philadelphia and Thyatira.

With the government of Caracalla, successor of Septimius Severus, the situation never again became as solid and prosperous as in the times of Marcus Aurelius. Despite some good news, such as the extension of Roman citizenship to all freemen of the Empire declared in the year 12 A.D., a tendency to decline in all senses was apparent. Even so, and as part of a policy of pacification but without any long-term solutions, Caracalla granted honours to cities like Smyrna. It is probable that during his time, a new temple was built in the city dedicated to the worship of Roma and of Caracalla. The city also made an unusual number of ties of friendship with Pergamum, Laodicea and perhaps with Ephesus, as is shown by the coins struck in this period[401].

Coins likewise continue to testify, in the imperial eras of Heliogabalus and of Alexander Severus, that Smyrna was considered precisely as the "First in Asia". It is in this age, towards the year 218 A.D., that the sophist Philostratus writes his *Life of Apollonius of Tyana* in which he mentions numerous events that occurred in Smyrna during the three previous centuries[402].

With the assassination of Alexander Severus in 235 A.D., after over a decade of government and the last attempt at a civil government of the Empire, the Severan dynasty ended and what was called the third-century crisis began, in which military domination prevailed and with 26 emperors reigning in the next 50 years. During the first half of this century, Smyrna continued to reinforce or made new commercial and political agreements with Thyatira, Tralles, Philadelphia, Troas, Ancyra and Hierapolis, among others. In addition, faithful to its centennial fidelity to Rome, it continues to strike coins bearing the names of the emperors[403].

In the year 249 AD the new emperor Decius engaged all the forces of his brief government in the policy of reinforcing public piety with a programme of renewal of the State religion. Thanks to the *Martyrdom of Pionius* and in the context of the persecution unleashed against the Christians as a result of this policy, we have a lively picture of Smyrna in the year 250[404]. The document describes the

401 On the agreements of understanding reached by Smyrna with other cities, cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna,* 290–293.

402 Cf. Philostr., *Apoll., passim.*

403 Cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna,* 295.

404 Apart from the themes proper to the martyrdom of Pionius and to the polemics between Christians, pagans and Jews, that we will be dealing with hereafter, here

square in which a large part of the story takes place, speaks to us of its columns on the eastern side, of the double doorway giving access to the latter, and of the upper galleries where Jews and Greeks clashed in their eagerness to witness the trial against the martyr[405]. Figures also appear from public life such as the neocorus Polemon[406], who tries, together with Lepidus, a pagan priest[407], to force the accused to eat impure meat in the temple of the Nemesis[408]; the hipparch Theophilus[409] who comes together with his escort to take Pionius from the prison to the square[410]; Terentius, who organised the gladiatorial games and who threatens to send one of the accused to this barbarous show[411]; Proclus Quintilianus, proconsul of Asia, who lives in Smyrna and following the interrogation condemns Pionius to be burned alive[412]. There is mention of the theatre where the assembly wished to bring the guilty parties to continue to listen to the discussion between the neocorus and Pionius[413], and of the stadium where the martyr was finally put to death together with other condemned prisoners[414]. Accordingly, the *Martyrdom of Pionius,* apart from elements proper to Christian life, which we will consider hereafter, reflects for us in an important way, the environment of Smyrna at the time of Decius.

As regards the subsequent convulsed reign of Valerian, in which the Goths advanced towards Bithynia and the Persians captured Antioch, Smyrna seems to have escaped unscathed, and nothing appears recorded in its annals. Neither do we know, at the time of the emperor Gallienus, how Smyrna was affected by the ravages of the eastern part of Asia Minor as a result of the advance of Shapur and the Persian cavalry around the year 260 AD, nor of the Gothic invasion of

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we only wish to stress the mention that this document makes of environments and institutions of the city in this period.

405 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 3, 6.

406 The neochorus is the guardian of the temple of the city. In imperial times, the "neochoria" was an important office, cf. G. Lanata, *Confessione o Professione? Il dossier degli atti dei martiri*, Rome 1986.

407 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 15, 2.

408 Cf. *M. Pion.*, 3, 1; 6, 3.

409 The term ἵππαρχος makes reference to a sort of high official of the police.

410 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 15, 1–7.

411 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 18, 8.

412 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 20, 1–7.

413 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 7, 1. The scene described here is similar to that in *Ac* 19, 20–40 between Paul and the goldsmiths of Ephesus.

414 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 21, 1.

Aegean lands, which even destroyed the temple of Artemis in Ephesus and attacked Athens in the year 267 A.D.

The end of the third-century crisis is brought about by the good government of Aurelian who routed the Alemanni, Goths and Vandals, built the Aurelian walls in Rome and unified the whole of the Empire, capturing the city of Palmyra in 273 A.D. The repercussions of his good government remained in the inscription on stone to be found on the highway between Smyrna and Sardis, which recalls his name and that of his spouse Ulpia Severina[415].

From the death of this emperor until the rise to power of Diocletian in the year 284 A.D. the history of Smyrna is devoid of allusions to important events of this time. Diocletian appointed Maximian as co-emperor and later appointed Galerius and Constantius as Caesars, configuring the system known as a Tetrarchy, and spreading the administration of the Empire geographically between the four governors. On the consequent establishment of new administrative centres in Nicomedia, Mediolanum, Antioch and Trier, places close to the frontiers, he created the biggest and most bureaucratised government in the history of Rome up until then. He reduced the size of the provinces, grouping them into twelve large dioceses, each of which under the control of a vicar. What until then had been the great province of Asia, despite the continuance of Ephesus as its capital, was divided into seven sections. Smyrna was included in the coastal fringe from Assos to the River Meander. This new administration was accompanied by a more oppressive system of taxation and by a grave economic crisis. The features of the administrative change imposed by Diocletian are to be seen around Smyrna in the form of multiple inscriptions that, together with the names of the members of the Tetrarchy, indicated the new frontiers and the distances between the different cities of the region[416].

In the year 301 A.D. Diocletian and Maximian abdicated, and Constantius and Galerius came to be *Augusti*, with two new Caesars. The diocesis of Asia remained under the control of Galerius. Constantius died the following year and his son Constantine was proclaimed *Augustus* by the army. In the battles of the next few years, Constantine acquired great power, while his rivals fell one by one. Following the death of Galerius in the year 311 A.D. Maximinus Daia governed towards the East until he was defeated and supplanted in 313 A.D. by Licinius. Finally, the ultimate victory of Constantine over Licinius in 324 A.D., left him as absolute

415 Cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna,* 299.

416 Cf. M. Rabanal, *La provincia de Asia según la Epigrafía,* Seville 1975, 192.

head of the Empire with all the consequences that ensued and which go beyond the historic frontier laid down for our study.

7. Life and institutions in the city of Smyrna

After the big avatars of the history of the city in pre-Hellenic, Hellenic and Hellenistic times, the sources of Roman and subsequently Christian times agree in singing in unison the beauty and splendour of the city. In about the year 6 B.C., the geographer Strabo states that "now she is the finest of all cities"[417] and according to Philostratus, Apollonius of Tyana circa 50 A.D. claimed that Smyrna was the finest city under the sun[418]. Pliny the Elder alluded to her as the "light of Asia"[419]. In the second century A.D, Aelius Aristides mentions the charms of Smyrna[420] over and over again. The biography on Polycarp, written between the third and fourth centuries, tells of the beauty of the city, and puts this reference into the words of the martyr[421]. This appreciation by the ancients of the city's beauty is generally more linked to its buildings than to its natural surroundings. Each city of antiquity aspired to its buildings with sumptuous artistic decorations being finer than those of other cities, which competed with one another. A large part of the donations to architecturally embellish the city came from private persons and on occasion from the favour of imperial benefactors.

On various occasions, Aelius Aristides alludes to the harmonious unity of the city's architectural appearance: "(Smyrna) has extended over the sea, spreading its flow of perpetual youth, as if it had risen up from the earth all at once, offering a size which is neither forced or pressed, but which in all parts of the city is great and harmonious and its magnitude is a source of beauty"[422]. The rhetorician continues by praising the profusion and splendour of the buildings: "The whole city up to the coast is occupied with gymnasia, agoras, theatres, sacred enclosures, ports and beauties, both natural and man-made, which compete with one another; and nothing is missing either of monumental stamp or of usefulness"[423]. The city's Acropolis, the most populous place, was set on mount Pagus and perhaps for the Roman age there still exists, at least part of the natural

417 Str., 14, 1, 37.
418 Cf. Philostr., *Apollonius,* 4, 6.
419 Plin., *nat. hist.,* 5, 29.
420 Cf. Aristid., *or.,* 45, 33; 23, 19–21; 17, 1, 9–12, 20, 23; 18, 2; 20, 5; 21, 5, 7.
421 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 30, 4.
422 Aristid., *or.,* 17, 9.
423 Aristid., *or.,* 17, 11.

city walls erected by Lysimachus, if not all. Based on the archaeological excavations, there are strong reasons to think that Smyrna expanded towards the East and the North in the Christian era[424].

Certain expressions used by Aelius Aristides and by Philostratus allow us to conjecture that in their days, there was a fine street, called the "Golden Way", which passing "from East to West, runs from temple to temple, from hill to hill, along a single avenue even finer than its name"[425]. Furthermore, Aelius Aristides states that there were "streets of all kinds, some in the depths of the city, and others on its outskirts", including "avenues serving agoras and in four places crossing over one another so as to catch the sun"[426]. The streets are well distributed as far as possible at right angles, and were paved with stone slabs[427]. For his part, Strabo states that the disposition of the streets of Smyrna was octagonal[428].

The water system was sophisticated for the time and at least three aqueducts may be documented at the end of the first century A.D. Close to the southern wall of the city, between mount Pagus and the sea, was the stadium, an oval structure, measuring about 183 metres long by about 36 metres wide. The seats of honour were situated in the central part on the east and enjoyed a magnificent view over the sea[429]. This place was the scenario of the martyrdom of Polycarp[430] and of Pionius[431]. North-west of the acropolis, the city also possessed a Greek theatre built in the times of Lysimachus and subsequently reconstructed probably by the emperor Claudius halfway through the first century AD. Aelius Aristides even speaks of various theatres in his day[432]. The theatre, besides being the place for the staging of shows and musical entertainments, would appear to have been the normal place for public assemblies of citizens and even for sheltering persons from the fury of the crowd[433]. The Odeon, or auditorium of Smyrna, was clearly distinguished from the theatre. This was situated close to the port and contained

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424 This may be inferred from the data provided by Aelius Aristides, a contemporary of Polycarp, cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna,* 174–176. On daily living and the urban societies in Hellenistic Anatolia, cf. M. Sartre, *L'Asie Mineure et l'Anatolie, d'Alexandre à Dioclétien,* Paris 1995, 43–47.

425 Aristid., *or.,* 17, 10; 18, 6; 19, 3; cf. Philostr., *Apoll.,* 4, 7.

426 Aristid., *or.* 17, 11.

427 Cf. Str., 14, 1, 37.

428 Cf. Str., 14, 646.

429 Cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna,* 178.

430 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 8, 3; 9, 1.

431 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 21, 1.

432 Cf. Aristid., 17, 2.

433 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 30, 1; 31, 1; cf. *M. Pion.,* 7, 1.

a painting by the famous fourth-century B.C. painter, Apelles of Colophon[434]. According to Aelius Aristides, Smyrna possessed many baths[435], while Strabo reports that Smyrna possessed a library[436].

The importance of libraries in the Ancient Empire is a characteristic feature of the cities of imperial provinces. They were generally built as an annex to the gymnasium, with the library of Celsus in Ephesus being a classic example. For its part, in Smyrna at least two associations (σύνοδοι) existed which met in gymnasia and possessed libraries: the Homerion (Ὁμήρειον) and the Mimnermeion (Μιμνέρμειον). The former studied the life and work of Homer; while the latter rendered homage to Mimnermus, first representative of the school of Colophon and author of the *Smyrneis,* a poem on ancient Smyrna[437].

The principal attraction of the city was the important school of rhetoric directed in turn by Nicetas of Smyrna, Scopelianus of Clazomenae, Polemo of Laodicea, Aelius Aristides of Mysia, Evodian of Smyrna and Heraclides of Lycia. The school counted on pupils from Lydia, Caria, Mysia, Egypt, Phrygia, Assyria, Cappadocia and Phoenicia[438], and was the principal centre of the "Second Sophistic"[439].

The Second Sophistic was a cultural and literary movement of apogee in the imperial age due to the socio-political circumstances which favoured it, as was the economic bonanza in the East starting from the middle of the first

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434 Cf. Paus., *Grae. descr.,* 9, 35, 6.

435 Cf. Aristid., *or.,* 17, 11; 29, 30; cf. *M. Polyc.,* 13, 1.

436 Cf. Str., 14, 1, 37.

437 Cf. L. Casson, *Libraries in the Ancient World,* New Haven-London 2001, 80–123.

438 The school of Scopelianus, cf. Philostr., *v. s.,* 1, 21, 518. The school of Polemon, cf. Philostr., *v. s.,* 1, 24, 529, 535–537. The school in Smyrna of Heraclides of Lycia, cf. Philostr., *v. s.,* 2, 26, 613.

439 The "Second Sophistic", a term originally coined by Philostratus (cf. Philostr., *v. s.,* 481), has been adopted by modern scholars to describe a historical phenomenon, with implications of the utmost importance for our understanding of the history of the Greek city-states in Asia Minor as from the end of the first century A.D. This describes the emergence of a narrative development of Hellenistic cultural identity which gathered and organised themes and concepts scattered throughout the history of Greek civilisation. This movement is described as "sophistic" in view of the oratory proclaimed as its ideal, whose intellectual antecedents were the sophists. The "Second" believed that no criterion of truth existed capable of deciding on the choice between two opposed and mutually excluding propositions. Consequiently, for the purpose of gaining practical support in favour of one over the other, rhetorical persuasion was the only practical manner of advancing, cf. A. Brent, *Ignatius of Antioch and the Second Sophistic,* Tübingen 2006, 1.

century A.D. The role carried out by the rhetoricians who passed through the school of Smyrna was significant, since many of them were authentic popular stars thanks to their public declamations.

Aelius Aristides was without doubt the most significant of this school, both for the movement and for the city of Smyrna. Aelius Aristides was an obsessively sick man and the central character of sickness impregnated the whole of his work, as highlighted in his *Sacred Discourses* in which he tells of his experiences as a patient and devotee of Asclepius of Pergamum. Notwithstanding, his active public life required great pieces of oratory and eulogies of him such as his *Discourse to Rome.* Aelius Aristides was also sensitive to the tension arising once more in his time between partisans of the rhetorical and the philosophical *paideia*, a question to which he dedicated a number of discourses.

The school of Smyrna was known at an international level, with a number of its pupils or directors had a very close relationship with the Roman emperors. Scopelianus obtained an exemption from taxation for the vineyards of the whole region from Domitian. Trajan granted Polemon the right of travelling throughout the Empire by land and sea without paying taxes and a second neocoria for Smyrna. Polemon was also the companion of the emperor Hadrian in one of his journeys to the East and obtained a donation of ten million drachmas from him for setting up buildings in the city[440]. Aelius Aristides had a close relationship and exchange of correspondence with Marcus Aurelius and probably also with Commodus.

Many famous rhetoricians and sophists made Smyrna their native city. Quintus, an orator from the third or fourth century A.D., author of the *Posthomerica,* was trained there. In his books he, not only aspires to complete the work of Homer, but shows off his knowledge of medicine, giving an exact description of the physical and psychological ailments of wrestlers. It is probable that he also received his medical training in the important medical school of Smyrna, which Galen himself attended for his training[441] and where one of its most distinguished members was Hermogenes[442]. The inscriptions which testify to the continuous presence of physicians in the city offer proof of the powerful cult which the god Asclepius commanded. During the Imperial age, Smyrna was an important centre of teaching and research. We know from literary sources and through the inscriptions, the names of different writers well versed in medicine and scientific subjects such as Marcion, Solon, and Theon of Smyrna. This last,

440 Cf. Philostr., *v. s.,* 1, 531.

441 Cf. L. García Bellester, *Galeno en la socieded y en la ciencia de su tiempo,* Madrid 1972, 31–33.

442 Cf. Str., 12, 8, 20.

who lived at the end of the first century and beginning of the second century, made important astronomical observations, and undertook mathematical and musical studies in his work aimed at understanding the works of Plato in his *Expositio rerum mathematicarum.*

As is well known, for the ancients, the city was their point of existential reference, the place of their citizenship, their recognition of rights, and their protection. Smyrna, like all the cities which had inherited the Greek tradition, granted citizenship not only to the freemen born in their close neighbourhood, but also to those men who were considered deserving of citizenship following distinguished service, sometimes after having been emancipated from past slavery, having won a military or sports victory, resided for a long period of time in the city, or for some other reason. In the age subsequent to Augustus, citizens could obtain citizenship without foregoing their previous one. The lists of all those possessing rights of citizenship were carefully kept[443].

Smyrna adopted the classic method of the distribution of its citizens by tribes, that in times past had as its fundamental criterion race, but which in Roman times had evolved towards more practical criteria such as the place of residence within the same city. We do not know the name of all the tribes of the city of Smyrna, but only three of them which, as frequently happened, bore the name of divinities: Amonis, Artemisios and Metrois[444]. The decisions of the city, while this was relatively free, were in the hands of a Council (ἡ βουλή) which represented the public assembly, although in practice the policies of the city were established by about 100 citizens, as between magistrates, former magistrates and wealthy men[445]. We do not know the way of proceeding of the councils in the cities of Asia in detail, nor in particular of Smyrna. Certain happenings in the life of Aelius Aristides throw light on the way in which the instances of the government of Smyrna proceeded in the days of Antoninus Pius and Marcus Aurelius. From his discourse, we may infer that the magistrates were elected, probably by popular vote, on the basis of a certain number of candidates proposed by their own Council[446].

When Smyrna fell totally under the power of Rome, the majority of laws were not cancelled, although they were placed under the control of the new official power. The supreme official authority was the Roman governor in the whole province. In each city in particular the governmental power of highest level was

443 Cf. J. Jeffers, *The Greco-Roman World of the New Testament Era,* New York 1999, 197–200.

444 Cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna,* 185.

445 Cf. D. Baronowski, *The Status of the Greek Cities,* 450–463.

446 Cf. Aristid., *or.,* 50, 88.

the Magistrate of the peace (εἰρηνάρχης) who in most cases was a general selected by the governor of the province on the basis of a list presented by the Council of the city. Another official is also mentioned: Commander of the cavalry or high official of the police (ἵππαρχος) who, it appears, held the higher responsibilty for public order and finally the public official (δημόσιος) charged with public investigations and executions. Under the direction of these two, there were a number of policemen (διωγμῖται) who made arrests, took care of prisoners, and perhaps carried out sentences[447].

In the Roman era, Smyrna was the capital of one of the *conventi* or juridical districts into which the Roman province of Asia was subdivided[448]. Accordingly, Smyrna juridically dominated the populations of the gulf of Clazomenae, Erythrae, Teos, Phocaea, as also on the mainland, the populations of Magnesia and Hyrcania in the North[449].

Smyrna was located on an important crossroad of land and sea routes, resulting in it being the biggest trade centre in the region after Ephesus. The sea traffic in the Aegean sea to the west, the Bosphorus and the Dardanelles to the North, the traffic from Palestine in the East, and all the trade with Egypt in the South had their point of convergence in this region[450].

The size of the city in the imperial age we are dealing with is difficult to determine. Certainly its population was less than that of Ephesus which was recognised as the fourth largest city in the Empire after Rome, Alexandria and Antioch, with perhaps an estimated population of 200,000 to 250,000 inhabitants[451]. Nonetheless, both Pergamum and Smyrna disputed with Ephesus on certain occasions the title of "First in Asia"[452].

8. Divinities in Asia and in particular in Smyrna

As regards the pagan cult of the province of Asia, leaving on one side the imperial cult, to which we will be devoting a separate chapter, we find three big religious

447 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 7, 1; cf. *M. Pion.,* 15, 4, 6.

448 The subdivision of Asia into its juridical districts with its respective capitals: Adramyttium, Pergamum, Smyrna, Sardis, Ephesus, cf. Plin., *nat. hist.,* 5, 105–126.

449 Cf. Plin. *nat. hist.,* 5, 118.

450 W. Ramsay, *The historical geography of Asia Minor,* 171.

451 Cf. P. Trebilco, *The Early Christians in Ephesus,* 17.

452 Cf. C. Hemer, *The Letters to the Seven Churches of Asia,* 82–84. Likewise the cities of Halicarnassus, Rhodes, and Miletus were considered as great cities; cf. N. Sitwell, *The Roman Roads of Europe,* 192.

centres: the temple of Diana or Artemis in Ephesus, the grandiose Altar of Zeus, and the temple of Asclepius, the last two of which are in Pergamum. Although none of these three temples are located in the city of Smyrna, the influence that their cult aroused in all the inhabitants of the province of Asia is evident, including the inhabitants of this city[453].

As far as the temple of Artemis in Ephesus is concerned, already at the time of Paul Christian, preaching came into direct confrontation with the prestigious cult practised in this sanctuary and with the economic interests related with it[454]. In fact, this temple of vast dimensions and fine architecture, was considered one of the seven wonders of the world, as described by Antipater of Sidon, who drew up the famous list:

> I have set eyes on the city wall of sweet Babylon, on which is a paved road for chariots, and the statue of Zeus by the Alpheus, and the hanging gardens, and the Colossus of the Sun, and the mighty labour of the lofty Pyramids, and the vast tomb of Mausolus; but when I saw the house of Artemis, rising into the clouds, those other marvels lost their brilliancy, and I said: Lo, apart from Olympus, the Sun never looked on anything so grand![455].

The influence of the cult of Artemis extended from the religious to the civic, economic and cultural spheres of the city. It is clear that its fame beyond the province of Asia attracted many travellers and pilgrims who contributed to the prosperity of the city and the region in a large measure. The sanctuary was recognised to possess curative powers and its cult was expressed in prayers, sacrifices, solemn ceremonies, religious processions on the occasion of feastdays, games and festivals. The months of April and May were special in which athletic, theatrical and musical competitions were held[456].

As for the grandiose altar of Zeus in Pergamum, this was the biggest and most impressive building of its kind in the whole of Asia Minor[457]. Its building was commissioned by Eumenes II Soter between 164 and 156 B.C. This altar, with a surfaced area of about 36 × 34 metres, was characterised by its vaste flights of

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453 Cf. I. Mazzini, *La medicina nella letteratura latina,* 28–29.

454 Cf. *Ac* 19, 23 et seqq.

455 Antipater of Sidon, *Anthologia Graeca* 9, 58. The temple stood tow kilometres outside of the city and its size was four times the Parthenon of Athens, cf. P. Trebilco, *The Early Christians in Ephesus*, 20.

456 Cf. I. Mazzini, *La medicina nella letteratura latina,* 32–35.

457 It was discovered by German archaeologists between 1878 and 1886. After eight years of excavations, one third of this altar was sent by a sultan to Berlin and subsequently reconstructed in what would later be converted into the Museum of Pergamum.

steps, its solid columns, and a frieze representing the fight between the giants and gods of Greek mythology. The altar was constructed on the second terrace of the city. The central colonnade had a rectangular courtyard behind it which was the space reserved for sacrifices in which incense was burned and libations offered in honour of the gods[458].

As regards the temple of the god Asclepius in this same city of Pergamum, this was founded by the poet Archias, in gratitude for the favours he had received from the god in the sanctuary of Epidaurus in Greece. In this place, the erudites in medicine used to meet, and it was also a school for physicians. Before being the personal physician of the emperor Marcus Aurelius, Galen studied there and contributed in large measure to the engrandisement of the temple. The pilgrims arrived in large numbers to be treated. They slept the whole night and told their dreams to a priest the following day. The latter prescribed a treatment, often a visit to the baths or to a gymnasium. Since snakes were consecreted to Asclepius, they were often used in the treatment rituals. Non-poisonous snakes were left to creep over the floor of the dormitories where the sick and wounded persons slept[459].

As far as the gods of Smyrna in particular are concerned, in a treaty between Smyrna and Magnesia in the year 241 B.C. Zeus is mentioned as foremost among the gods for those who invoke him; perhaps he was not the most worshipped god in Smyrna, but he was the supreme being, capable of sustaining everything that men do. In Smyrna in particular, Aelius Aristides addresses him as "Zeus of the city"[460] and he had a magnificent temple built on a hill known today as *Deirman-Tepé,* perhaps at the time of Hadrian. However, the emperor Hadrian himself was called by the citizens of Smyrna by titles of Saviour and of Zeus[461].

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458 Cf. W. Ramsay, *The historical geography of Asia Minor,* 175.

459 Cf. I. Mazzini, *La medicina nella letteratura latina,* 37–38. The ruins of the temple are situated 3.5 kilometres outside the city, to the west, cf. W. Ramsay, *The historical geography of Asia Minor,* 178; cf. C. Hemer, *The Letters to the Seven Churches of Asia,* 90–95; cf. A. Giuliano, *Le città dell'Apocalisse,* Rome 1981, 46–49.

460 Cf. Aristid., *or.,* 20, 23.

461 Cf. Aristid., *or.,* 49, 39. There also existed a temple dedicated to Zeus Saviour in the marketplace of the city. In the second century A.D. Smyrna seems to have shared with Miletus, Rhodes and other important cities, the privilege of being invited to participate in the festival and mysteries of Zeus Panamaros, the name by which Zeus was worshipped in Panamara in the region of Caria, cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna,* 203–204.

In Smyrna, Zeus was often linked with Asclepius, accordingly, a statue of Zeus Saviour was erected in honour of Asclepius Healer[462]. Asclepius enjoyed great fortune in Smyrna, especially following the age of Hadrian, many Smyrnaeans received his name from derivatives of Asclepius: Asclepiodorus, Asclepiades, etc. The worship of Asclepius was imported from the neighbouring city of Pergamum, which as stated earlier, boasted an immense sanctuary in his honour. In Smyrna at the time of Aelius Aristides, there was also an Asclepeion, a curative temple, close to the sea near the outer quay,[463] and many plaques in his honour have been found by archaeologists.

Apollo, identified with the Sun, was likewise a god much venerated in Smyrna. A large part of the coins struck in the city bear his image as from the year 400 B.C. until imperial times, while his name too is common among Smyrnaeans. Strabo states that there was a temple to Apollo on the coast between Smyrna and Clazomenae[464], while Aelius Aristides speaks of another temple dedicated to "Apollo guardian of the streets" close to the river Meles[465]. There was also the goddess Cledo, which means "presage", that Pausanias reported earlier of having a temple dedicated to her outside the city walls of Smyrna[466] and of which Aelius Aristides stated that the Smyrnaeans came to listen to the best possible presages[467].

Dionysus was worshipped in Smyrna under the title of Breseus Dionysus. His cult was probably brought to Smyrna by the Aeolian colonists, since it is known to flourish in Lesbos, where the first Aeolian settlements in Asia were established. The name of Breseus denoted a bearded god, in contrast to the usual representation of Dionysus as a youth. Official temple was probably located on the southern hill of the stadium. The worship of Dionysus in Smyrna implied orgiastic celebrations on the hills outside of the city, and more than once, as mentioned earlier, the enemies took advantage of this temporary absence of the citizens to seize the city.

Other Greek gods such as Ares, god of war, Heracles, Hermes the messenger and Eros, god of love; gods of Egyptian origin like Serapis, Horus and Anubis; and even of Persian origin like Mithra, are found, although in lesser quantity, in the ancient inscriptions as addressees of the worship of the Smyrnaeans[468].

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462 Cf. Aristid., *or.,* 42, 4.
463 Cf. Aristid., *or.,* 50, 102; cf. Paus., *Grae. descr.,* 2, 26, 9.
464 Cf. Str., 1, 36.
465 Aristid., *or.,* 17, 14.
466 Cf. Paus., *Grae. descr.,* 9, 11, 7.
467 Cf. Aristid., *or.,* 29, 12.
468 Cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna,* 214.

Niobe, sister of Tantalus, enjoyed a very important local prestige. In his *Posthomerica* Quintus of Smyrna described a natural rock found going down the valley of the Hermus, after crossing the Sipylus, the shape of which reminded the inhabitants of a woman whom the inhabitants, worshipping her, associated with Niobe[469].

In a real sense, the patron goddess or titular deity of the city was no other than the goddess mother of Sipylus, the mount behind the city. Broteas, son of Tantalus, was charged with sculpting the first figure of the goddess mother in the Sipylus[470] and the Sipylene, as she was also called, appears on coins, and was invoked as guarantor of international treaties. Aelius Aristides affirms that her temple, called Metroon, was the finest of the temples,[471] and in her honour, the games known as "Σιπυλεῖα" were organised and the goddess protected the repose of the dead who invoked her. The goddess of fertility, worshipped in Ephesus as Artemis, of whom we have spoken earlier, was undoubtedly in the beginning, a simply local way by the capital of Asia and at times Smyrna itself, of calling the goddess mother. However, above all in Smyrna, this goddess, from the times of Alexander the Great, was called Nemesis in a strange symbiosis with the attributes proper to the goddess mother and those proper to this divinity who embodied vengeance and distributive justice and whose Roman equivalent, in almost everything, was the goddess Envy. The second and third centuries of our era seem to have been the time when the cult of Nemesis flourished most in Smyna. Pausanias mentions the temple of the Nemesis and describes its interior adorned with statues of the goddesses and Charites by Bupalus of Chios[472]. Towards the year 250, the place where the goddess Nemesis was worshipped in Smyrna was the scenario of the confrontation between the magistrates and a group of Christians regarding the sacrifice to the emperor Decius. There the bishop swore the oath to the fortune of the emperor and of Nemesis, while the presbyter and martyr Pionius refused to do so[473].

Lastly, as we mentioned earlier, the devotion to Homer in Smyrna was inestimable. Homer was venerated in a temple and a congregation existed called the "Ὁμηρεία γερουσία" which possessed a library, a gymnasium, and a group of cantores (ὑμνῳδοί). The congregation Ὁμηρεία γερουσία studied the life and

469 Quintus of Smyrna, *Posthomericas,* 1, 294–295 (ed. F. García Romero, Madrid 1997); cf. L. Roller, *In Search of the God Mother of Anatolian Cybele,* Berkeley 1999.

470 Strabo makes a dedicatory notice to the Sipylene, cf. Str., 10, 3, 12.

471 Cf. Aristid., *or.,* 17. 10; cf. *Str.* 14, 646.

472 Paus., *Grae. descr.,* 1, 33, 7.

473 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 6–7, 15–17.

work of the poet and the subsequent epic. Was also probably responsible for the shows put on based on Homeric themes and new epic creations[474].

Together with Homer, the river Meles which, according to tradition saw his birth, was the object of devotion. Both the Meles and the Hermus were rivers which in pagan literature were treated as divinities, although there are no signs on their banks of the building of any temples in their honour.

Without any doubt, the presence of the three small strongholds of pagan religion in this part of Asia Minor –Artemis, Zeus, and Asclepius– plus the strong cult that Smyrna professed to its local gods, constituted a problem for Christian life and the expansion of Christianity. The sanctuary of Artemis held connotations of regional identity and economic prosperity for the inhabitants of the area, the altar of Zeus was a meeting-point of par excellence, the temple of Asclepius enjoyed great fame for its curative powers, the god was invoked as saviour of par excellence, and the gods of Smyrna, with their strong cult were closely linked to the city's cultural and historic identity. We must suppose that the Christian community of Smyrna was not indifferent to this problem which surrounded it[475].

9. Conclusion

The Smyrna of the early centuries of the Christian era is an important city in the Roman province of Asia, situated on the Aegean coast at the mouth of the river Hermus and surrounded by small mountain chains among which mount Sipylus stands out. Over and above the legendary tales on its foundation, clearly at one time its territory pertained to the Hittite Empire and the subsequent settlement in the region of Greek civilisation with all of its cultural, economic and political influence shaping, above all with the arrival of the Ionians from Colophon, the city's identity.

It is at this time that the work of Homer is received with popular enthusiasm and that Smyrna begins to be identified as one of the most probable cradles of the poet. The consolidation of this idea developed the subsequent myth according to which the founder of the city was Theseus, the father of Athens himself, and thus Smyrna came to be definitively considered by the Greeks as a colony founded by Athens.

Following a long period in which Smyrna was practically reduced to small inhabited centres due to the Lydian attacks and the subsequent Persian invasion, which practically reduced the city to small agglomerations, in the year 334 B.C.

474 Cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna,* 209–212.

475 Cf. W. Ramsay, *The historical geography of Asia Minor,* 181.

Alexander the Great changed the destiny of the area and also of the city by successfully inaugurating an amazing age of prosperity and cultural exchange in which Smyrna took part. In line with this influence, the city further developed the legend of its refoundation at the hands of Alexander, ingeniously linking it up with Alexandria.

After the domination of the Seleucids, an age in which the leadership of Ephesus in the region is shaped, followed by Smyrna and Pergamum, the city inaugurated its friendship and political loyalty to Rome, destined to last for long years, with the building of the first temple in history consecrated to the city of Rome.

The arrival of Rome shaped the subsequent town-planning of the city and the administrative organisation of the future Roman senatorial province which had Ephesus as its *conventus iuridicus*. Smyrna, in its historic rivalry with the neighbouring cities, always brought to bear its loyalty to Rome and the emperors to attract its favour, winning privileges such as that of raising a temple in honour of Augustus (neocoria), the tax exemption granted by Hadrian, or the great help supplied by Marcus Aurelius and Commodus in rebuilding the city following the great earthquake of the year 178. This last happening, in which the rhetorician Aelius Aristides took part, made him an almost divine figure in the city, to the point of being considered its new founder at the hands of the emperors, its benefactors.

In his turn, Aelius Aristides was the principal actor in the movement responsible for a great cultural awakening and which thoroughly sensitised the higher social circles, leading to the development of a great literary activity known as the Second Sophistic, based on the city of Smyrna. This movement contributed decisively to the town-planning, scientific and cultural development of the city with its great libraries, theatre, school of medicine and associations dedicated to the study of the great authors in the city's history (Homereion and Mimnermeion). The representatives of this movement exerted an important influence on the politics of various emperors.

Neither was this cultural movement a stranger to religious experience, and the sources indicate that the religious environment neighbouring on Smyrna, like the sanctuary of Artemis in Ephesus, the altar of Zeus and, in particular, the temple of Aesclepius in Pergamum, exerted a profound influence on the religious feeling of the city. Together with Aesclepius, special worship was reserved in the city to Apollo, Dionysius, Niobe and the goddess mother of mount Sipylus. Even Homer and the river which possibly saw his birth were the object of particular devotion. To this pagan religious environment, the imperial cult was added ever more forcefully, to which the city, faithful to its historic alliance with Rome, paid the greatest possible tribute.

Thus in this chapter, we have laid the geopolitical coordinates and described the different and imaginary dimensions which in the course of time forged the pagan identity of the city of Smyrna as expressed in its institutions and cultural and religious practices. In this context, the Jewish and Christian communities had to seek out their space of interaction and development, not without various difficulties.

The claim of universality with which the Christian religion appeared, as it understood itself, could not be tolerant towards any other religious cult, the worship which the Christians paid to the only true God could not be compared with the existence of any other cult. The Christians in their daily lives were consequent with their convictions and were accordingly viewed as declared enemies of the ancient civilisation by surrounding paganism, tinged throughout with religious expressions. In addition, the isolation of the Christians from these cults propagated the obscure rumours attributed to them, such as dissolution in their night-time meetings and the suspected degeneration of religious worship. All of this constituted cultivated ground whence sprung the general disrepute of the Christians, both on the part of pagans and of the Jews themselves, as will be seen hereafter.

Chapter V: Jews and Christians in Smyrna

Hereafter, we will study the convulsed relations between Jews and Christians on the basis of the sources presented in the first part, especially in the letters of Ignatius, the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* the *Martyrdom of Pionius* and the *Life of Polycarp.* Each one of these sources provides different focuses on the relationship between these groups throughout the history of Smyrna in the early centuries of our era. Accordingly, they indicate to us the influence of Judaism on the building of the Christian identity in Asia, the role the Jews had in the persecutions against the Christians in this region of the empire, the apologetics developed by Christianity in the face of Jewish proselytism, and the struggle between both groups to gain the favour of the surrounding pagan population.

For the study of this relationship between Jews and Christians in Smyrna, it will be necessary in the first instance to briefly study the characteristics of Judaism of the diaspora, particularly in Asia Minor, and to make a short recapitulation of the confrontation between Judaism and the Christian faith in the New Testament.

1. Characteristics of Judaism of the diaspora

In the Roman Empire towards the second and third centuries the Jewish population was a considerable group within the population of the Empire[476], and the great majority of them lived more in the diaspora than in Palestine. The Jewish colonies were concentrated above all in the big cities: Rome, Alexandria, Antioch and Ephesus. However, intermediate cities like Smyrna also boasted a significant presence of Jews, perhaps amounting to 15 per cent of the local population[477].

In general terms, the Roman Empire was well disposed towards the Jews of the diaspora, above all with the abundant concessions made to them by Julius Caesar. The first decree of Julius Caesar in favour of the Jews, probably dated 47 B.C., written in Greek and in Latin, refers to Hyrcanus, son of Alexander, the high priest and ethnarch of the Jews. Julius Caesar with the approval of the Senate, recognises the services offered by Hyrcanus to the Empire, both in peace and in war. Mention is made of the help provided by Hyrcanus with his 1,500 soldiers in

476 For a recent study on Judaism in the Roman world, cf. M. Goodman, *Judaism in the Roman World,* Leyden 2007.

477 Cf. Weeks, *The First Urban Christians: The Social World of the Apostle Paul,* London 1983, 34.

the war of Alexandria, and speaks of the personal valour of Hyrcanus[478]. In September of the year 49 B.C. Julius Caesar issues a decree in Ephesus which exempts the Jews from doing military service in Asia Minor on grounds of their religion[479].

In all of the territories, the Jews had the right of residence and could not be expelled[480]. Their cult was declared a *religio licita*[481]. All the communities had their synagogue, which also functioned as a library and a meeting-place,[482] and possessed their own cemeteries[483]. They had permission to freely observe their religious ordinances, such as the *Shabbat,* their festivals, and their dietetic laws. They were exempt from the cult of the Emperor and from military service. In books 14 and 16 of *Jewish Antiquities,* Flavius Josephus gives witness to the alliances between Romans and Jews and to the recognised civic status of the Jewish communities, of their right to observe the shabbat, of the different provision of foods, of the right of association and levying taxes, and of also the freedom to go or not to the courts on Saturday, to appeal to the judges, to the authorities of the provinces and of Rome itself. In many places, the Jewish community formed a recognised organisation with its own administrative, judicial and financial powers. The internal organisation of the Jewish communities was assured by a council of elders, a Palestinian *presbyteroi,* or a hellenistic *gerousia.*

The freedom the Jews enjoyed throughout the Empire also consisted of their active propagandising[484]. The apologetic literature of hellenistic Judaism indirectly testifies to their missionary goal. Many of the converts to Judaism were distinguished persons, such as the butler of the queen of Candace[485]; Azizo, king of Emesa and Polemo, king of Cilicia[486]; the patrician dame Fulvia[487], etc.

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478 Cf. Flav. Ios., *ant. iud.,* 14, 10, 2.

479 Cf. Cf. Flav. Ios., *ant. iud.,* 14, 10, 19. Flavius Josephus also informs us of a message from Lucius Antony to the magistrates of Sardis reiterating the privileges granted to the Jews and makes allusion to their assemblies, cf. Flav. Ios., 14, 10, 17 and 24.

480 The two exceptions were the expulsion of the Jews of Rome under Tiberius and under Claudius, but both were of short duration, cf. Flav. Ios., *ant. iud.,* 18, 3, 5; cf. *Ac* 18, 2.

481 Term coined by Tertullian to describe the special status of Judaism as regards the law in the Empire, cf. Tert., *apol.,* 21, 1.

482 The most famous was that of Antioch, cf. Flav. Ios., *bell. iud.,* 7, 3, 3.

483 In Rome, like the Christians, the Jews buried their dead in catacombs.

484 Cf. *Mt* 18, 15. Certainly this propagandising was not as active as that of the Christians, cf. M. Goodman, *Judaism in the Roman World*, Leyden 2007, 91–114.

485 Cf. *Ac* 8, 26.

486 Cf. Flav. Ios., *ant. iud.,* 20, 7.

487 Cf. Flav. Ios., *ant. iud.,* 18, 3, 5.

Nonetheless, the rites which identified the Jewish communities, above all circumcision, were a partial impediment to their mission among the Gentiles. Accordingly, the requirement of full integration meant that, together with the converts who accepted circumcision, "proselytes", an intermediate class was set up of "adorers" and "god-fearers" which was apparently very large[488]. Flavius Josephus, praising the excellence of the Law, says: "the multitude of humanity itself has had a great inclination to follow our religious observances. There is not a single city of the Greeks or the Ethiopians, in which our customs and our prohibition on food is not observed"[489].

The "god-fearers" proved to be particularly receptive of the Christian mission. Paul met up with them in almost all the cities he visited. In the *Acts of the Apostles,* Paul's evangelising activity follows a regular pattern: he begins his ministry in each new city he visits by preaching in the synagogue: there he met not only the Jews, but also these "god- fearers"[490]. Some scholars have considered this pattern typical of early Christianity. Thanks to certain inscriptions and literature, we know that there were Gentiles "on the fringes" of the Jewish community in many cities of the Empire. Some were attracted by the "virtues" of Judaism, its monotheism, its lofty moral tone and its Scriptures, but were not prepared to convert fully, at times on account of the physical risk and social stigma of circumcision in an adult man. As a place of worship, the synagogue was sufficiently open to permit them to attend, listen, and learn, although they could not be full members of the community. Paul's message, without the requirement for complete observance of the Torah, met the needs of such Gentiles. For the Christian preachers, their knowledge of a single God and their familiarity with the Scriptures converted them into a more attractive and fertile "market" than the pagans for whom a monotheism without images was a problem, and undoubtedly they would have difficulties in understanding the way in which the first Christian writers quoted and interpreted the Scriptures. The synagogue appears here as a germ or a preliminary school which prepares the Gentiles who cannot be fully admitted into it, and offers a bridge towards the Gentile world for the first followers of Jesus[491].

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488 Cf. Flav. Ios., *ant. iud.,* 14, 7, 2.

489 Flav. Ios., *Adv. Apion.,* 2, 11.

490 Cf. *Ac* 3, 14–49.

491 On the synagogue as bridge between Judaism and Christian evangelisation, cf. J. Dunn, *The parting of the ways between Christianity and Judaism and their significance for the character of Christianity,* Harrisburg 1991, 29–33.

2. Judaism in Asia Minor

Flavius Josephus states that the first emigration of the Jews in Asia Minor was at the time of Antioch III the Great, who in order to obviate certain rebellions in Phrygia and Lydia, ordered that 2000 Jewish families should he brought to those regions from Mesopotamia, that these be granted lands and provisions, and that they be held in consideration, permitting them to live according to their laws and customs, thus reinforcing their fidelity to the king[492]. Towards the beginning of the first century B.C. the Jews were fairly numerous in the province of Asia and in the adjacent islands and they possessed a capacity of organisation and a certain power, as is shown by their seizure of the money they had deposited in the island of Cos for the purpose of sending it to Jerusalem and the incitation made to the propraetor Valerius Flaccus to make similar confiscations in Apamea, Laodicea, Pergamum and Adramyttium[493].

Octavius Augustus instructed the proconsul Norbanus Flaccus to permit the Jews to collect and send their money to Jerusalem without impediment; and Norbanus, obediently ordered these instructions to be applied in Ephesus and Sardis, and we may suppose that in Smyrna and other cities too. On the visit of Octavius Augustus and King Herod to Ionia in the years 14 B.C. the Jews were granted new facilitations and tax concessions[494].

It is quite probable that there were Jews coming from Smyrna among the Jews of Asia who met up around the apostles at Pentecost of the year 30[495], and those who discussed with Stephen in Jerusalem towards the year 34[496]. Philo of Alexandria, referring to the period of the year 30 to 35, says that the Jews in each city in Asia were very numerous[497].

The tranquil and prosperous situation of the Jews in the Empire changed dramatically as a result of the rebellions that occurrred in Judaea. In 66 A.D. the first Judaean-Roman war broke out. Vespasian and later his son Titus were sent to wipe out the revolt, destroying Jericho in the year 68, Jerusalem, whose Temple was razed to the ground in 70, and Masada in 73. Following the decisive victory of Rome, a praetor was appointed and the tenth legion was charged

492 Cf. Flav. Ios., *ant. iud.,* 12, 148. According to one of his disciples, Aristotle conversed with a Hellenised Jew of this region, cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna,* 303.
493 Cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna,* 303.
494 Cf. Flav. Ios., *ant. iud.,* 12, 125–127; 147–153.
495 Cf. *Ac* 2, 9.
496 Cf. *Ac* 6, 9.
497 Cf. Philo, *Leg. Gai.,* 33.

with maintaining order, while for its part the Sanhedrin was entrusted with the religious, political and judicial aspects of Jewish life from the city of Yavne. A second revolt took place in the year 115, this time generalised among the Jews of the whole of the eastern part of the Empire, beginning in Cyrene. With the ascent of Hadrian as emperor in 118, the revolt calmed down. Between the years 132 and 135, a third rebellion led by Bar Kokhba broke out. The direct causes of the rebellion and the politics adopted by the Empire to deal with the same are not completely clear still, since there exist, various versions of the facts and the sources reporting them are not totally worthy of credit. The testimony of Dio Cassius is very brief, the *Historia Augusta* is not completely reliable, and the Jewish and Christian sources have without doubt been re-elaborated in subsequent eras, so that it proves difficult to use them for a historical reconstruction of the facts[498]. Recently, new documents have appeared which are claimed to be letters of Bar Kokhba himself[499]. The Roman historian Dio Cassius attributes the revolt to Hadrian's decision to found a Roman city called Aelia Capitolina on the ruins of Jerusalem[500] and to build a temple to Jupiter there[501]. Besides, the *Historia Augusta* states that the cause of the revolt was the prohibition of the ancestral practice of circumcising Jewish male babies. Following the defeat of the Jews, Hadrian dictated various norms for repressing any fresh uprisings: Jerusalem came to be called Aelia Capitolina and the province Syria, Palestine instead of Judaea, Jews were forbidden to live in Aelia Capitolina and to practice their religion. The Jews remained in Galilee, on the Golan Heights and in the south of the ancient kingdom of Judah.

After the fall of the temple of Jerusalem in the year 70 A.D., Asia Minor became one of the favourite areas for emigration from Palestine, largely due to the fact that many cities of this region had previously received specific decrees protecting the rights of the Jews[502]. Probably with the events of the year 70. A new wave of Jews arrived and settled in Smyrna. The letter to the Church of

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498 For a complete and recent analysis of the sources related to the Bar Kokhba revolt and the religious policy of Hadrian, cf. G. Bazzana, *The Bar Kohkba Revolt and Hadrian's Religious Policy,* in *Hadrian and the Christians,* Göttingen 2010, 85–109.

499 The majority of these manuscripts are papyri found in the proximity of the Dead Sea and are today on show in the museum of Israel. For a preliminary analysis of these sources, cf. W. Cockle – H. Cotton – F. Millar, *The Papyrology of the Roman Near East: a Survey,* in *Journal of Roman Studies* 85 (1995), 214–235.

500 *Aelia* as its proper name and *Capitolina* in honour of the Roman god Jupiter.

501 Cf. Dio Cassius, 69, 12, 1.

502 Cf. Flav. Ios., *ant. iud.,* 14, 223–264.

Smyrna which appears in the *Revelation* enables us to glimpse a considerable Jewish community in this city towards the end of the first century.

Despite the strong presence of Jews in Asia Minor in the second century A.D., the events of the year 70 had caused a very grave blow to the relationship of the Jews of the diaspora with the Empire. A Jewish prophet from the Egyptian environment wrote in about the years 117 to 130, prophesying against various cities of Asia Minor, also including Smyrna: "Smyrna, fallen into the abyss, will groan and what was once honourable and famous will be destroyed"[503]. "It will also happen to Smyrna, that it weeps its bard[504], up to the gates of Ephesus, and will perish completely"[505]. These verses reflect the general aversion the Jews felt for the Gentile world at that time. However, in the particular case of the Jews of Asia Minor, it would appear that they did not support the Jewish revolts in Palestine or the revolts of the diaspora initiated in Egypt and Cyrene in the years 116–117, remaining isolated from political confrontations[506].

With the rebellion of Bar Kokhba in 132 and its terrible consequences for the whole of Judaea, it is probable that a new wave of Jews had arrived in Asia Minor, including perhaps some to Smyrna. It is difficult to determine the size of the Jewish population in each city of Asia Minor in the second and third

503 *Oraculi Sibyllini* 5, 122 (ed. M. Monaca, Rome 2008, 137). Book five of the Sibylline oracles is of Jewish origin, coming from Egypt and is generally dated between 80 and 130 A.D., before the Bar Kokhba rebellion in 132. At the time of Marcus Aurelius the writing of this text was probably completed. It begins with a historical sequence in which allusion is made to different emperors, from Caesar to the Antonini (see 1–51), followed by a second section (vv. 52–213) which is the prediction of the Sibyl and the prediction of disasters for mankind. Above all, the disasters are for Egypt those in vv. 54–100 and 179–181, and for Rome in vv. 162–178, likewise announcing the return of Nero. In verse 214, we find a prophesy on the Antichrist and on the function of the Jews in their quality of chosen people. Following a self-mention by the prophetess, the text continues in vv. 286–531 with the announcement of catastrophes and prodigies against the Nations, eschatological prophesies, condemnantion of pagan cults and, in particular, the cult of Isis, and the description of a war of stars and elements of the Zodiac.

504 Perhaps this refers to Homer.

505 *Oraculi Sibyllini* 5, 122 (ed. M. Monaca, Rome 2008, 306).

506 Cf. T. Kraabel, *Paganism and Judaism: The Sardis Evidence,* in *Paganisme. Judaïsme, Christianisme: Influences et affrontements dans le monde antique,* ed. A. Benoit, Paris 1978, 13–33.

centuries, but it seems clear that the presence of the Jewish diaspora in this area of the Mediterranean was very strong[507].

To specify the status of Jews in these Greek cities of the Empire is no easy task either. The Greek cities, in which a significant number of Jews had settled, were important centres through which the Roman Empire built the Mediterranean world. With the success of the campaigns of Alexander the Great, the Greeks established themselves in the conquered colonies, making them typically Greek[508]; however, the history was quite different with the cities of the west of Asia Minor, since these cities were founded by Greeks 1000 years earlier. When these Greek kingdoms fell to the power of Rome, the Romans granted a considerable autonomy of government to these cities precisely since their Hellenistic culture was so deeply rooted in them. These concessions included the right to maintain citizenship in the πόλις, so important for the Greek mentality, a right established by inheritance and not based on birth or residence within the confines of a particular city[509]. Conflict arose when the Jews began to call for equal rights with the non-Jewish citizens of these cities. Their request was not groundless. The Romans had regarded the Jews with favour since the time of Julius Caesar. Later Palestine itself fell under Roman control, but Herod and his family always maintained cordial relations with the Roman emperor. As a result, the Jews had received special rights. This meant that from certain points of view the Jews appeared to be more of Rome's allies than a conqered people[510]. We cannot determine precisely if, technically speaking, all the Jews living in these Greek cities enjoyed citizenship[511]. We may infer that, as in Ephesus, in Smyrna too the Jews were considered citizens and a tribe of the city at least at one time[512]. Basically then, the Jewish communities had a strong presence in Asia Minor in the second and third centuries, and these communities, as we have seen, had a long history and perhaps claimed for themselves an important status within the society of the time.

Another important aspect is the discussion on whether the Judaism of the Roman diaspora was less pure than that of Palestine or of Babylonia. Even before

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507 Cf. T. Robinson, *The Bauer Thesis Examined. The Geography of Heresy in the Early Christian Church,* New York 1988, 113.

508 The most obvious examples are Alexandria and Antioch, the future capitals of the Ptolemaic and Seleucid empires, respectively.

509 Citizenship in the πόλις is a Greek, and not a Roman invention. Only citizens were allowed to take part in the political affairs of the city.

510 Cf. P. Trebilco, *The Early Christians in Ephesus,* 40–45.

511 Undoubtedly many Jews like Paul obtained Roman citizenship, cf. *Ac* 16, 37–39.

512 Cf. Flav. Ios., *Adv. Apion.,* 2, 39.

the last rebellion, the Jewish communities tended to be synchretistic still, maintaining that isolation for which they were bitterly reproached in pagan literature. This syncretism was probably the result of the absence of their spiritual and political centre: the temple and the "land", and of their presence in the midst of a pagan world. Undoubtedly a large part of this crisis of identity was due to Christianity itself which was recognised by many as a movement within Judaism.

Nonetheless, consensus has grown more recently thanks to the archaeological evidence that Judaism in Asia Minor, contrary to other possible parts of the Empire, such as Alexandria, Palestine or Antioch, enjoyed great self-confidence, it was neither syncretistic, nor so introverted and isolationist as not to entertain relations with the cities in which it was present. The Jews played an active part in the life and culture of the city, and possessed very large synagogues, read the Torah, and maintained fidelity to their precepts[513]. The synagogue of Sardis is the most obvious example of the social integration, civic prestige, and economic capacity of Judaism in Asia Minor at this time[514]. The discovery was made by American archaeologists in 1962 who there found this huge ancient synagogue consisting of a basilical building measuring almost 20 by 100 metres capable of containing about 1000 persons. This building, richly decorated, is an integral part of a vast complex complete with baths and a gymnasium in the centre of the city and points to the integration of the Jewish community in this Greco-Roman city. Within the enclosure, over 80 inscriptions have been found[515], of which more than 90% are in Greek, which clearly demonstrates that the language used in daily life by the Jewish community of the diaspora was Greek. In addition, most of the inscriptions allude to the benefactors who contributed to beautifying that place, of which almost half were not Jewish in the proper sense but belonged to the category of "god-fearing" pagans, one of whom even gifted the great Menorah of the synagogue[516].

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513 Cf. S. Mitchell, *Anatolia. Land, Men and Gods in Asia Minor,* Oxford 1993, II, 31–37; cf: J. Barclay, *Jews in the Mediterranean Diaspora: From Alexander to Trajan 323 BCE – 117 CE,* Glasgow 1996, 280–281.

514 Cf. C. Applebaum, *The Social and Economic Status of the Jews in the Diaspora* in *The Jewish People in the First Century,* Philadelphia 1976, 701–727; cf. L. Feldman, *Jew and Gentile in the Ancient World,* New Jersey 1992, 69–74.

515 The inscriptions were finally published in 2001, cf. J. Knoll, *The Greek Inscriptions of the Sardis Synagogue,* in *Harvard Theological Review* 94 (2001), 5–127.

516 P. van der Horst, *The synagogue of Sardis and its Inscriptions,* in *Jews and Christians in Their Graeco-Roman Context,* Tübingen 2006, 49.

The excavation of the great synagogue of Sardis plus the discovery of a list of pagan contributors to a Jewish institution in Aphrodisias[517] are two of the most spectacular examples of the archaeological discoveries of recent years, throwing light on the Jewish presence in the area of Asia Minor and clearly showing the social ascendency of the Jewish community in this region of the Empire. In Sardis, the strong presence of Jews is also indicated in the *Homily on Easter* by Melito of Sardis, who it seems entered into a lively polemics against them[518].

The Jews were usually exempted from making pagan sacrifices because of their economic contribution made through the *fiscus Iudaicus.* The *fiscus Iudaicus* was an annual tax for the temple that the Jews of the diaspora paid during the time of the Second Temple. This tax, following the destruction of the temple in the year 70, was destined by Vespasian to the temple of Capitoline Jupiter in Rome[519]. This decision was an affront to Jewish religious sentiments. Rome collected this tax in an exhaustive manner, especially during the empire under Domitian. In time, this tax satisfied the aspirations of the "divine Rome" in the august person of the Emperor and permitted the Jews not to be obliged to sacrifice to the statue of the Caesar. Accordingly, the *fiscus Iudaicus* was thereafter understood as a fiscal obligation feeding Roman wealth and religious taxation proper[520].

This circumstance was invoked by the Jews in order, very often to be joint protagonists in the persecution against the Christians on various occasions. In Smyrna in particular, this situation is clearly seen both in the case of the martyrdom of Polycarp and in the martyrdom of Pionius[521].

3. The Christian faith face to face with Judaism in the New Testament

We cannot understand the Christian reality of Asia Minor separate from the reality of the Jews. Both are part of the religious life and activity of this corner of

517 P. van der Horst, *Jews and Christians in Aphrodisias in Light of Their Relationships in Other Cities of Asia Minor,* in *Essays on the Jewish World of Early Christianity,* Fribourg-Göttingen 1990, 166–181.

518 Cf. Mel., *pass.,* 72–99 (Sch 123, 100–120).

519 Cf. Flav. Ios., *bell. iud.,* 7, 6, 6.

520 Cf. S. Applebaum, *Economic Life in Palestine,* in *The Jewish People in the First Century,* Assen 1976, 631–700.

521 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 1, 2; 13, 1; cf. *M. Pion.,* 12, 1–9. Tertullian in about the year 220 speaks of the Jewish synagogues as "*fontes persecutionum*", cf. Tert., *scorp.*, 10 (CCL 2, 1089).

the Empire, the life of both is marked by the ubiquity of paganism and also by the characteristics proper to this region which appear quite singular in all of its features.

The polemics between both groups arise from the very birth of Christianity. The oldest anti-Jewish allusion by the Christian faith may be found in Paul in his first letter to the Thessalonians. Here the Apostle praises his Macedonian addressees because they have remained firm in the test, suffering at the hands of their fellow nationals the same things that believers in Judaea suffered from their Jewish fellow nationals, these "are they who killed the Lord and the prophets and those who have persecuted us ourselves. They are not pleasing to God and are enemies of all men, since they prevent us from preaching to the Gentiles that they may be saved; thus they are constantly filling the measure of their sins. But wrath was violently offloaded on them"[522].

For the majority of New Testament writers, the Jews were the most important point of reference for the identify of the new faith. In the fourth gospel, different groups: multitudes, Pharisees, scribes, elders and Sadducees, are absorbed and undifferentiated under the terminology of "Jews". The Gospel of John echoes the anti-Jewish controversy in Jesus's words saying: "you are sons of your father the devil, and wish to carry out the desires of your father"[523]. In *Io* 9, 22, he describes how "the Jews have reached agreement that if someone confessed that Jesus was the Christ, he should be expelled from the synagogue". At the present time, the majority of scholars maintain that this affirmation undoubtedly did not reflect the time of Jesus, but that in which the gospel was written, perhaps in the last decade of the first century. This verse shows that at that time, those who confessed to Jesus found themselves excluded as members or participants in the life of the synagogue, and that it was the Jewish authorities who orchestrated the division between Judaism and Christianity[524].

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522 *I Th* 2, 14–15. Tertullian will say hereafter that the Jewish synagogues are a source of persecutions for the Christians, cf. Tert., *scorp.,* 10, 10 (CCL 2, 1089), cf. W. Braude, *The Church Fathers and the Synagogue,* in *Judaism* 9 (1960), 113.

523 *Io* 8, 44.

524 For a further study on the Jews in John's gospel, cf. C. Barrett, *Il Vangelo di Giovanni e il giudaismo.* Brescia 1980; P. Grelot, *Les Juifs dans l'Évangile de Jean, enquête historique et réflexions théologiques,* Paris 1995. Above all, the article by P. Grech throws light on the conflict between Jews and Christians in Ephesus as reflected in John's Gospel, cf. P. Grech, *La presenza degli ebrei in Efeso nei primi secoli*, in *Atti del IV Simposio di Efeso su s. Giovanni Apostolo*, Rome 1994, 139–146.

Each one of the Synoptic Gospels likewise reveals something of these same tensions expressed in different ways and with different accentuations leaving the question of whether those Christians were still situated within the synagogue, had been expelled from the Jewish community, had cut themselves off, or had simply set up a new group. All of these are questions which could also be included within the case of Jesus himself.

For his part, the very experience of Paul also reflects an ambiguity in this regard. He who could proclaim himself "a Jew and son of Jews"[525], he who became a Jew among Jews in order to win over the Jews"[526] considers all his Jewish heritage rubbish compared to winning Christ, and feels that it is his mission to carry the gospel to the uncircumcised[527]. For Paul, all those who are one in Christ are not Jews nor Greeks[528].

In the Gospel of Matthew, the Lord predicts the suffering of Christians at the hands of the Jews[529] and the tensions with them arrive at their maximum expression when the multitude of the Jews masses and, faced with the imminent condemnation and death of Jesus, exclaims: "May his blood be upon us and upon our sons!"[530].

With the fall of Jerusalem in the year 70 and subsequent events, the stream of Phariseeism became the only voice of Judaism of the diaspora with its Sanhedrin in Jamnia, no longer tolerating its co-religionaries who became Christians. In the '90s, the situation of confrontation between Jews and Christians precipitated with the introduction of the "birkat haminim", a curse on Christians included in the twelfth of the 18 blessings. The text of the Palestinian version says: "For the apostates let there be no hope. And let the arrogant government be speedily uprooted in our days. Let the *nozerim* (Nazarenes) and the *minim* (heretics) be destroyed in a moment. And let them be blotted out of the Book of Life and not be inscribed together with the righteous. Blessed art thou, O Lord, who humblest the arrogant"[531]. This excommunion was not aimed at all Christians, but

525 Cf. *Ph* 3, 5.

526 Cf. *1 Co* 9, 20.

527 Cf. *Gal* 2, 7.

528 Cf. *Gal* 3, 28.

529 Cf. *Mt* 10, 17–21, also cf. *Io* 16, 2.

530 Cf. *Mt* 27, 35, cf. E. Luz, *Le problème historique et théologique de l'antijudaïsme dans l'Evangile de Matthieu,* in *Le déchirement. Juifs et chrétiens au premier siècle,* ed. D. Marguerat, Geneva 1996.

531 We possess two versions, one Babylonian, which mentions the *minim* but not the *nozerim,* and the other Palestinian which curses both: perhaps in the diaspora

only those coming from Judaism, insofar as they were considered apostates[532]. Since the 18 blessings were read out publicly in the synagogue and recited three times a day, a Christian immediately felt the reproach in the eyes of those around him, and if he recited them in private, he still could not help feeling guilty. But a Judeo-Christian would never have thought of abandoning Judaism. In fact, he was convinced that his present faith was the fulfilment of his religion. On the contrary, it was the others who refused to believe and thus excluded themselves from the messianic community. Notwithstanding, the situation was very difficult to manage for some and they returned to Judaism, explicitly or implicitly denying Christianity[533].

At present there is consensus that this blessing does not exclude Christians from the synagogue, or Christianity from Judaism, as was previously thought. However, queries continue: if we are not sure what the synagogue represented in Jewish communitarian life[534], we do not know either what it signified to be excluded from it, if it was possible to share worship or if one were excluded from the community's activities, what happened if a city had more than one "synagogue" as place of worship, and if in such case a Christian could begin to go to some other synagogue. The first Christian communities made formal excommunions to exclude those they considered as heretics from their number. As time went on, they considered such exclusions as universal, transferible between communities, and even having implications with regards to salvation. But it would be mistaken to transfer this manner of thinking to the Judaism of this time, and to suppose that an exclusion from the synagogue had the same implications.

4. The Christians of Asia faced with Judaism

In the second century, the arguments against the Jews by Christians came to be rapidly standardised and predictable, following well established themes and which extended from explicit polemics to a homiletic, exegetic and rhetorical language.

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from Babylonia the danger for the Christians was still not felt, cf. W. Stegemann, *Historia social del cristianismo primitivo. Los inicios en el judaismo y las comunidades cristianas en el mundo mediterráneo,* Estella 2001, 320.

532 Cf. R. Kimelman, Birkat Ha-Minim *and the Lack of evidence for an Anti-Christian Prayer in Late Antiquity,* in *Jewish and Christian Self-Definition,* ed. E. Sanders, London 1981, II, 232.

533 Cf. P. Grech, *Il giudeo-cristianesimo: lo stato della questione,* in *Il Messaggio Biblico e la sua Interpretazione,* ed. P. Grech, Bologna 2005, 243.

534 For a recent and detailed study on the ancient synagogues, cf. A. Runesson, *The Ancient Synagogue from its Origins to 200 C.E.,* Leyden 2008.

In the Egyptian case, the *Epistle of Barnabas*[535] and the *Discussion between Jason and Papiscus*[536] are without doubt the most significant texts on this controversy.

In the environment of Asia Minor, the most extensive work of anti-Jewish nature is undoubtedly the *Dialogue with the Jew Trypho* of the martyr and philosopher Justin. According to Eusebius, the dialogue of these conversations was in Ephesus[537] and probably during the war of Bar Kokhba, which took place there and which is mentioned in chapters one and nine[538]. This work explains the concept Christians have of the Old Testament, how the law of Moses was valid only for a certain time, while Christianity is the new and eternal law for the whole of mankind. Justin gives preference to those passages of the Old Testament which speak of the repudiation of Israel and the choice of the Gentiles. In fact, for Justin, the nations who believe in Christ and follow his law represent the new Israel and the true chosen people of God. In the same way he denounces the persecution of Christians by the Jews[539]. It is clear that the *Dialogue* is not, by any means, an exact reproduction of a real discussion recorded stenographically. But, on the other hand, its dialogued form is no mere literary fiction. There were certainly real conversations and disputes which preceded the composition of the work, possibly with the rabbi Tarfon mentioned in the Mishnah. Eusebius also makes reference to a work of anti-Jewish polemics written by Miltiades during the time of Marcus Aurelius, once more in Asia Minor, but today lost[540].

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535 In it the author tries to explain and prove to his readers the value and meaning of the revelation of the Hebrew Scriptures (Old Testament), affirming, furthermore, that the Jews understood the Law very little, because they interpreted it literally. Three reasons allow us to situate Alexandria as the author's provenance: the continuous use of the allegorical method, the undeniable influence of Philo in the text, and the great esteem which the Alexandrian theologians had towards this treatise in the form of a letter.

536 The work is attributed to Aristo, a Judeo-Christian from Pella in the Decapolis engaged in discussion with the Alexandrian Jew Papiscus. This work was lost, but through news from Origen and Hieronymus we know that the author showed a predilection for the allegorical interpretation of the Old Testament.

537 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 18, 6.

538 For an exploration in greater depth, cf. M. Mach, *Justin Martyr's* Dialogus cum Tryphone Iudaeo *and the development of Christian anti-Judaism,* in *Contra Iudaeos. Ancient and Medieval polemics between Christians and Jews,* ed. O. Limor – G. Stroumsa, Tübingen 1996, 27–48.

539 Cf. Just., *dial.,* 16, 4; 131, 2; 133, 6 (PG 6, 509, 780, 784). Also cf. *I apol.* 31, 5–6; 36, 3 (SCh 507, 210, 224).

540 Cf. Eus., h. *e.,* 5, 17, 1.

Very important is the *Homily on Easter* by Melito of Sardis which reflects the Asian environment in the age of Marcus Aurelius and explicitly formulates the accusation of deicide against the Jews. The Jews, as the prophesies announced, rejected the Lord and killed him and, even though his death was predicted, their responsibility was voluntarily accepted[541].

In the environment of Smyrna, we likewise find the tensions of Jews and Christians in the letters of Ignatius of Antioch, in the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* in the *Martyrdom of Pionius,* and in the *Life of Polycarp,* which we will analyse hereafter.

5. Judaism in the letters of Ignatius of Antioch

It is difficult to think that Ignatius did not have a close knowledge of the Jews. Antioch, the city of which he was bishop, had one of the largest Jewish communities. Flavius Josephus reports that this community attracted many sympathisers, above all by its religious observance[542]. Antioch too appears as one of the fundamental cities in which Christianity develops its own identity compared to Judaism, since it was there that the name of "Christians" was used for the first time[543], and where Peter and Paul had a heated discussion on the Jewish practices imposed on those Gentiles who converted to Christianity[544]. Already in the fourth century, when the Empire was officially Christian, Chrysostom will pronounce various sermons in Antioch *Adversus Iudaeos,* possibly on account of a reflowering of the latter's presence. It is in this context that the long review of the letters of Ignatius could have taken place. Certainly this review, unlike the middle one, contains a very large number of references in obvious polemics with Judaism, which appears as those who have fought against God and have killed the Lord and the prophets[545].

In spite of all this Jewish environment of Antioch, the "Jews" are mentioned only once in the whole *corpus Ignatianum*[546]. Precisely in the letter to the community

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541 Cf. Mel., pass., 72–99 (SCh 123, 100–120), cf. R. Cantalamessa, *I più antichi testi pasquali della Chiesa,* Rome 2009, 50–59.

542 Cf. Flav. Ios., *bell. iud.,* 7, 3, 3; cf. W. Meeks, *Jews and Christians in Antioch in the First Four Centuries of the Christian Era,* London 1978, 1–13.

543 Cf. *Ac* 11, 26.

544 Cf. *Gal* 2, 11–14.

545 Cf. the long review of: *To the Trallians* 11; *To the Smyrnaeans* 2; *To the Tarsians* 3; *To Heron* 2, in J. Lieu, *Image and Reality: the Jews in the World of the Christians in the Second Century,* Edinburgh 1996, 24.

546 It is probable that Ignatius, in passing through Asia Minor on his way to Rome to suffer martyrdom, in writing his letters to the churches of the area, besides

of Smyrna, Ignatius speaks of Jesus who "raises a sign for the centuries by means of his resurrection for his saints and faithful, whether Jews, or pagans, in the single body of the Church"[547]. It is interesting that immediately before this, the text makes reference to the crucifixion of Jesus under the authority of Pontius Pilate and the tetrarch Herod but without assigning any responsibility to the Jews for the death of Jesus. Some commentators of the text affirm that this is perhaps due to the fact that the formula is a possible echo of a primitive profession of Christian faith which contained no allusion, and accordingly Ignatius makes none either[548].

Only in his letters to the communities of Magnesia and Philadelphia, written from Smyrna, does Ignatius explicitly introduce the question of "Judaism" in relation to Christianity. By making an appeal to the unity of the community of Magnesia[549] he puts it on its guard against Judaism: "Do not let yourselves be deceived by the strange doctrines or by the old stories that are useless. Because, if we still live according to Judaism[550], let us confess that we have not received grace. Since the very divine prophets live according to Jesus Christ"[551]. Ignatius uses the expression "do not let yourselves be deceived" when he warns against schism and false beliefs[552], false opinions (ἑτεροδοξία),[553] and empty opinions (κενοδοξία)[554]. It is possible that the vocabulary used by Ignatius in his letters regarding the Jews may have constituted a familiar language for his readers.

For Ignatius, the "continuing to live according to Judaism" or "according to the law" not only means not understanding the implications of the Gospel, but

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highlighting the problems which as a famous guest he perceives in each one of these communities, is influenced by their original environment of Antioch. If this applies for various themes of an ecclesiological character, which we will be commenting on in the third part, it also applies to the perception he expresses of Judaism.

547 Ign., *Smyr.,* 1, 2. This sign raised is the cross, cf. *Is* 5, 6; 49, 22; 62, 10.

548 Ign., *Magn.,* 11; *Trall.,* 9; cf. J. Ayán Calvo, 171.

549 Ignatius, being in Smyrna, is visited by the bishop of Magnesia accompanied by two presbyters and a deacon. By them, he sends a letter to that Church, exhorting it to maintain unity around its young bishop and the presbyters. As appears in other letters of his, Ignatius denies any personal knowledge of the concrete situation of the community, cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 4, 1; *Trall.,* 8, 1. He does this perhaps following a conventional rhetoric, cf. W. Schoedel, *Ignatius of Antioch,* Philadelphia 1985, 10–11.

550 M. Simonetti prefers *dubitanter* another lesson: κατὰ νόμον, in logic with the traditional correspondence νόμος – χάριν, cf. *Seguendo Gesù,* 569.

551 Cf. Ign., *Magn.,* 8, 1–2.

552 Cf. Ign., *Eph.,* 10; *Smyrn.,* 6, 1.

553 Cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 6, 2.

554 Cf. Ign., *Magn.,* 11.

furthermore remaining outside of the salvation that this offers[555]. Further on in the letter, he continues: "Being his disciples, let us learn to live according to Christianity. Since he who is called by a name greater that this, is not of God. It is absurd to speak of Jesus Christ and to live in the Jewish manner. For Christianity did not believe in Judaism, but Judaism in Christianity"[556]. The term Christianity appears here for the first time in Christian literature[557] and in clear opposition to "Judaism"[558]. This apparently paradoxical statement may be explained by the fact that Ignatius has previously affirmed the inspiration of the prophets by Christ. In fact, the gospel message has made explicit what the prophets had announced already and has eliminated what in the old economy was not in harmony with that prophesy and that message.

A similar contrast appears in his letter to the Church of Philadelphia: "If anyone explains Judaism to you, don't listen to him. It is better to hear Christianity from the lips of a circumcised man than Judaism from the lips of an uncircumcised man"[559]. When he refers to 'a circumscised man' there is the possibility that he is speaking concretely of Paul; however, he may be referring in general to the Christian converts from Judaism who were undoubtedly many in Antioch[560]. With reference to the concrete situation of the Christian community of Philadelphia, we deduce from this text that certain Christians of pagan origin were influenced by the Jewish tradition in such a way that their Christian faith was conditioned thereby[561].

For Ignatius, Judaism is a system, as likewise is Christianity. Both are characterised by their own customs, and it is part of our faith in Christ to clearly bear in mind the things that are different in daily life and which make Christianity superior. Having once warned the Magnesians against living in accordance with Judaism and given them the example of the prophets who lived according to Jesus Christ, he asks the Christians not to observe the Shabbat, but rather for all

555 Cf. Ign., *Magn.,* 10, 1; *Rom.,* 3, 3*; Philad.,* 6, 1.

556 Cf. Ign., *Magn.,* 10, 1, 3.

557 Use of the neologism χριστιανισμός is also made by Ignatius in *Rom*., 3, 3 and *Philad*., 6, 1. M. Simonetti believes that this word has probably been coined by Ignatius himself, in contrast to the earlier one testified to Ἰουδαϊσμός, cf. *Seguendo Gesù*, 569.

558 Cf. W. Schoedel, *Ignatius of Antioch,* 186. The term Ἰουδαϊσμός appears for the first time in the Maccabaean context, cf. *2 M* 2, 21; 8,1; 14, 38.

559 Cf. Ign., *Philad.,* 6, 1.

560 Cf. W. Schoedel, *Ignatius of Antioch,* 123–126.

561 Cf. E. Prinzivalli – M. Simonetti, *Seguendo Gesù,* 601.

of them to gather together in celebration on the day of the Lord: "Accordingly, if those who have lived in the old order of things, came to the new hope, not still observing the shabbat but living according to the day of the Lord, in which our life rose by means of Him and his death, … how can we live still without Him?"[562].

Observance of the *Shabbat* is a characteristic proper to Judaism which paganism always identified as such, and accordingly, it is natural that Christianity in seeking its own identity should celebrate its faith on the day of the Lord. In other texts Ignatius shows his interest in Christians meeting regularly to celebrate their faith and not maintaining separate eucharists, perhaps referring to the fact that certain ones of them continued to celebrate on the shabbat[563].

Although these few texts clearly show the conviction of Ignatius that the Christian faith is greater than Judaism, from a complete reading of the Ignatian texts, we may conclude that the adversaries whom Ignatius accuses of corrupting the community and whom he fights without respite are not Jews properly speaking, but Christians influenced by Judaism, who deny the reality of the incarnation and who, accordingly, claim to base themselves on the Old Testament[564]. So that Ignatius' battle, at least as far as we can gather from the sources, was not directly aimed at Judaism, but at judaising Christians.

6. The role of the Jews in the Martyrdom of Polycarp

As we already reported in the first part, the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* is a circular letter of the Church of Smyrna which aims at giving news of the fate of the bishop, written shortly after the martyrdom of its pastor. Despite being a genuine letter[565], decisively formed by the events described, it develops an epistular Christian tradition inscribed in an embryonic veneration of Christian martyrs and accordingly has a clearly didactic and kerygmatic purpose.

The earliest author of the letter or possible subsequent writers, in order to put into effect this didactic and kerygmatic purpose, took the two great martyrial

562 Ign., *Magn.,* 9, 1–2.

563 Cf. Ign., *Magn.,* 4, 1; *Philad.,* 4, 1; *Eph.,* 13.

564 Cf. E. Molland, *The Heretics combated by Ignatius of Antioch,* in *Journal of Ecclesiastical History* 5 (1954) 1–6; cf. L. Barnard, *The Background of St Ignatius of Antioch,* in *Vigiliae Christianae* 17 (1963) 193–206.

565 Scholars vindicate its character of letter, although they see in it the rule and model for the subsequent genre of acts and passions of martyrs. For the defence of the historic existence and nature of the letter, cf. B. Dehandschutter, *The Martyrium Polycarpi: A Century of Research,* in *Aufstieg und Niedergang der römischen Welt,* II, 27/1, Berlin-New York, 1993, 492–497.

narrations of the original community as reference: the passion of Jesus and the martyrdom of Stephen. Accordingly, in the course of the narration of the martyrdom of the bishop, a series of coincidences find their way in: the head of the police is called Herod; Polycarp was betrayed by a member of his own household; he was in the field not far away from the city, at the moment of being detained; they go out to detain him as if he were a common thief; etc.[566]. Accordingly, the interpretation of the role played by the Jews in the narration of the martyrdom cannot lose sight of the writer's intention: in seeking to assimilate the fact to Christ's passion and to the martyrdom of Stephen, he may have presented the participation of the Jews in the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* by emulating the attitude of the Jews in these two New Testament narrations.

The Jews appear explicitly in three moments of the narration of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp.* We find the first text after Polycarp, in reply to the proconsul's questioning, proclaims his Christian confession three times and the herald announces it to the people: "all the crowd of the pagans and Jews resident in Smyrna were filled with uncontrollable anger and shouted out in a loud voice: 'This is the master of Asia, the father of the Christians[567], the destroyer of our gods, he who

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566 Once the Asiarch Philip does not allow the crowd to let loose a lion against Polycarp, since the fighting with wild beasts has come to an end, they then ask that he be burned alive, in order by so doing to make the prophesy dreamed by Polycarp come true, which is also a clear allusion to the divine fulfilment of the Scripture as it appears in the Gospels, cf. *M. Polyc.,* 12, 2–3; cf. *Io* 18, 32. For an enumeration of these and other parallelisms, cf. B. Lightfoot, *The Apostolic Fathers,* 610–611. There are evident parallelisms with Christ's Passion; however, it cannot be claimed that these coincidences are totally artificial. For example, Polycarp does not allow them to hold him down, cf. *M. Polyc.,* 13, 3. This fact is very interesting since, if the whole parallelism which has been claimed with Christ's passion were artificial, he would not have refused this opportunity of relating it up with Christ's crucifixion. H. Delehaye states: "Christ is the model of a Christian; his perfect imitator is the martyr who follows him on the *via dolorosa*. This idea was so familiar to the first generations of Christians that any similarity with the Master, however slight, would immediately be perceived by the bystanders and could not fail to be reported. So that it is not so strange that the Church of Smyrna complacently highlighted the traces of conformity of its pastor with the divine model", cf. H. Delehaye, *Les passions des martyrs et les genres littéraires*, Brussels 1921, 19 (the translation is mine). Even so, it is impossible to exactly determine at which points in the story the narration deliberately echoes the New Testament happenings, and which others are exclusively descriptive of the real situation.

567 This is the first time we find the title of "father" applied to the bishop and in relation with the term used of "master". Years afterwards, "*…qui enim ab aliquo edoctus est*

teaches many not to sacrifice nor worship'"[568]. Certainly this particular "praise" by the Jews and pagans of Polycarp as "master of Asia" should be nuanced, in addition to which we cannot attribute to the Jews the proclaiming of Polycarp as "destroyer of their gods". The mention of the "crowd of pagans and Jews resident in Smyrna" may make reference to the language we find in the *Acts of the Apostles* where the Word of God could be listened to by all the inhabitants of Asia, whether Jews or Greeks[569]. Within the configuration of the narration of the martyrdom is a commonplace: the crowd's condemnation of the accused: in the version of Luke's Gospel it shouts the condemnation of Jesus three times[570] and in the *Martyrdom of Pionius*, subsequent to that of Polycarp but in the same city, the crowd demanding condemnation this time consists of Greeks, Jews and women[571].

A second text affirms that "the multitude immediately collected posts and wood from the workshops and baths, with the Jews particularly lending a hand with the eagerness that characterises them"[572]. Contrary to the serene attitude of Polycarp[573], here the Jews are particularly enthusiastic (μάλιστα Ἰουδαίων προθύμως), the writer underlines that they do this "with the eagerness that characterises them"[574].

The third allusion to the Jews takes place once Polycarp's body has been pierced by a dagger and the Christians have attempted to carry his corpse away in vain. The rival[575] of the people of the just "seduced Nicetas, father of Herod

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verbo filius docentis dicitur, et ille eius pater", Iren., *haer.,* 4, 41, 2. Starting off from the third century, the title of father applied to the bishop will be frequent, cf. P. De Labriolle, *Une esquisse de l'histoire du mot 'Papa',* in *Bulletin d'Ancienne Littérature et d'Archéologie chrétiennes* 1 (1911) 215–220; cf. A. Benoît, *L'actualité des Pères de l'Eglise,* Neuchâtel 1961, 5–6.

568 *M. Polyc.,* 12, 1.

569 Cf. *Ac* 19, 10. 17. cf. also Ign., *Smyrn.,* 1, 2.

570 Cf. *Lk* 23, 18. 21. 23.

571 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 3, 6.

572 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 13, 1.

573 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 13, 2–3.

574 "Ὡς ἔθος αὐτοῖς". In other parts of the narration, the author makes reference using this same expression to the customs followed by other personages: pursuers and riders with their habitual armament go out to arrest Polycarp, cf. *M. Polyc.,* 7, 1; the centurion burns Polycarp's body in the usual way, cf. *M. Polyc.,* 18, 1; the proconsul interrogates Polycarp and suggests to him the oath to the genius of Caesar in the usual way, cf. *M. Polyc.,* 9, 2.

575 The author applies the term βάσκανος to the devil, which does not occur in biblical literature, even if this usage is found in the profane world, cf. G. Bartelink,

and brother of Alce, to request the governor not to give up his body, "may it not be – he said – that they abandon the crucified man and begin to worship this one"[576]. This they said because they were suggesting it and encouraging the Jews to watch over it when we went to take it from the pyre. They did not realise that we will never abandon Christ… So that, when the centurion saw the persistence of the Jews he placed it in the middle and burned it"[577]. At this point in the narration, the Jews appear at the climax of the confrontation against the Christians, they not only suggest and encourage[578] them not to give up the martyr's body, but even keep watch over the pyre with the same intention, while lastly the writer reports the perception of the centurion regarding the Jews' persistence.

As regards this Christian Nicetas who is seduced by the devil to ask them not to give up Polycarp's body[579], it is interesting that likewise Judas in the New Testament is seduced by Satan[580] and in connection with this idea the letter addressed to Smyrna in the *Revelation* is significant when it speaks of the "calumnies of those who call themselves Jews without being so, since in actual fact it is a synagogue of Satan"[581] and in the following verse the warning on the sufferings to come when the devil[582] puts some of them in prison[583].

βάσκανος, désignation de Satan et des démons chew les auteurs chrétiens, in *Orientalia Christiana Periodica* 49 (1983) 390–406.

576 Eusebius of Caesaraea testifies to this same attitude during the persecution of Diocletian in Nicomedia: "As for the imperial servants, after their death, they had been entrusted to the earth with all due honours, but those who consider themselves their masters had them exhumed once more, in the opinion that these too should be thrown into the sea, so that, from their lying in tombs, none should take to worshipping them and considering them –at least so they thought– as gods," cf. Eus., *h. e.* 8, 6, 7.

577 *M. Polyc.,* 17, 1–18,1.

578 "Ὑποβαλλόντων καὶ ἐνισχυόντων", genitive absolute. The verb "ὑποβάλλω" is the same verb that the author uses to describe the demon's enticement of Nicetas.

579 The figure of Nicetas, a Christian seduced by the devil, enables us to draw an interesting picture of a local reality. Nicetas was brother of Alce, to whom Ignatius sends a special greeting in his letter to Smyrna and to Polycarp; furthermore, he was son of Herod, head of the Police. The text states twice that Nicetas is Herod's son. This may merely be a biographical detail, but it may also have a narrative intent when the reader recalls the key role played by Herod in the narration of the passion according to Luke, cf. *Lk* 23, 8–12.

580 Cf. *Lk* 22, 3; *Io* 13, 2. 27.

581 Cf. *Rv* 2, 9.

582 The term used is "διάβολος", as in *M. Polyc.,* 3, 1.

583 Cf. *Rv* 2, 10.

The question of the historical and theological interpretation of the events of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* like many ancient Christian texts, is complicated by the layers of successive editorial versions in light of subsequent historical situations[584]. In particular the editorial work done by Eusebius[585] and the attempt of some other later writer[586] to underline the similarity of the martyrdom of Polycarp with the passion of Jesus impede the work of interpretation. In addition, it may be certain, as some scholars suggest, that the text is elaborated to meet internal debates within the Christian community, such as veneration of relics or the attitude that Christians should adopt when faced with persecution[587], and these internal tensions of the community may be represented in the form of objections and actions apparently carried out by the Jews and by the pagans[588]. Nonetheless, it is clear that the forcefulness of the text expresses the writer's perception towards the Jewish community that was certainly present in Smyrna in the second century, and that this perception expresses a conflict between Jews and Christians.

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584 Note should be taken, as indicated by G. Buschmann in his detailed commentary on the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* of numerous points of contact between this source and Jewish martyrological texts, in particular with *IV Maccabees*, cf. G. Buschmann, *Martyrium Polycarpi. Eine formkritische Studie,* Berlin-New York 1994.

585 Eusebius of Caesarea transmits a shorter text of the work, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 4, 14, 10–15,1. For the study on Eusebius' version and the present state of research on transmission of the text, cf. J. Ayán Calvo, 234–240.

586 It appears that its natural conclusion should be at the end of chapter 20 with the greetings of the scribe and all his family to the Philomelians. Notwithstanding, the document is prolonged with two further chapters, which have frequently aroused suspicion in scholars, since they offer a series of chronological facts and a brief history of the transmission of the text, the contents of which are questionable, cf. J. Ayán Calvo, 234.

587 In the sense of whether they should give themselves up voluntarily or on the contrary, adopt the attitude of Polycarp. Doubtless, some groups of enthusiasts could go in search of martyrdom by giving themselves up voluntarily to the authority; however, these need not necessarily be identified as Montanists. The thesis of S. Ronchey was precisely to identify these groups as Montanists and thus to situate the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* at a very late date, in the fourth century. However this thesis has not convinced most scholars, cf. S. Ronchey, *Indagine sul martirio di san Policarpo,* Rome 1990.

588 Cf. J. Lieu, *Image and Reality: the Jews in the World of the Christians in the Second Century,* Edinburgh 1996, 86–94.

7. Jewish proselytism and the Christian response in the Martyrdom of Pionius

The author of the *Passio,* in the mid third century, informs us that when Pionius and his companions in martyrdom were led into the square, the upper galleries of the latter were packed with Greeks, Hebrews, and women, since they were free of occupations that day on the occasion of the Grand Shabbat[589].

Being already in the square, when the moment to defend himself came, Pionius, in response to the taunts of the crowd, gave a brief warning to the Greeks, reminding them that Homer had never considered it pious to rejoice at the prospect of someone losing his life[590]. Immediately after his brief warning against the Greeks, he pronounced instead a long speech against the Jews. He reminds them of sentences by Moses[591] and Solomon[592] who preach offering help to the enemy and not rejoicing at his fate. He accused them of showing no compassion, by the fact of being his enemies, or of being human beings or victims of an injustice[593]. The

589 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 3, 6. Bearing in mind the character of a great popular feast that the celebration of the "Grand Shabbat" assumes above all in the *Martyrdom of Pionius,* W. Rordorf thinks that that precision indicates, rather than a day of the week, the feast of the *Terminalia,* celebrated in the Roman world in honour of the god Terminus as the last day of the year precisely on 23 February. This hypothesis enables us to understand the simultaneous presence in the games of Greeks, Jews, and women. This coincides with the report by Lactantius, according to which Diocletian, at the instigation of Galerius, singled out "*dies aptus et felix"* to put in hand the great persecution of the year 303 precisely in the *Terminalia, "quae sunt a.d. septimum Kalendas Martias"*, cf. Lact., *mort*., 12; cf. W. Rodorf, *Der Sonntag Geschichte des Ruhe- und Gottesdiensttages im ältesten Christentum,* in *Abhandlungen zur Theologie des Alten und Neuen Testament* 43, Zurich 1962, 245. This theory has been contested by R. Cacitti, who explains the terminology of "Grand Shabbat" in the literature arising in the Church of Smyrna based on a theological and not chronological interest, cf. R. Cacitti, *Grande Sabato, Il contesto pasquale quartodecimano nella formazione della teologia del martirio*, Milan 1994, 19–20.

590 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 4, 4. The sentence to which he alludes is in the *Odyssey* 12, 412 where Homer blames Euryclea because he exults over the murdered suitors: "It is not licit to boast over dead persons". This verse was quoted frequently until it became a proverb, cf. Cic., *ep. Att.,* 4, 12; Plin. Jr., *ep.,* 9, 1, 3; Clem., *str.,* 6, 3, 9 (SCh 446, 77). So that Pionius' words do not necessarily denote a direct knowledge of Homer's poems.

591 Moses quoted as author of the *Pentateuch* and merging *Ex* 23, 5 with *Dt* 22, 4.

592 Solomon quoted as author of the *Proverbs.*

593 The injustice denounced by Pionius and borne by the Christians is persecution. The Christians have not committed any crime justifying the violent actions of the

accusations against the Jews continue with a series of rhetorical questions which insinuate the accusations made against the Christians themselves by the imperial authority:

> To whom have we done wrong? Have we perchance murdered someone? Or do we persecute anyone? Or have we obliged anyone to venerate idols?[594] After making the distinction between involuntary and voluntary guilt[595], Pionius continues listing faults typical of the deuteronomic moral conception of history, according to which the misfortunes of the Hebrew people are the punishment for its infidelity to the Sinai covenant: Who perchance has obliged the Hebrews to sacrifice to Belphegor? Or to feed on the gifts sacrificed to the dead? Or to fornicate with women of strange lineage? Or to make a holocaust of their own sons and daughters to the idols? Or to murmur against God? Or to condemn Moses? To show ingratitude towards their own benefactor? To return in their hearts to Egypt? Or when Moses went up to receive the Law, who obliged them to ask Aaron to "make us gods", and to set up the golden calf? And who perchance obliged them to all the other sins that they committed?[596]

To this, Pionius adds the invitation to his hearers to read from the books of the Judges, of the Kings, and of Exodus of the Hebrews themselves, since these contain their own misfortunes[597].

Afterwards, Pionius told how he had covered the whole country of Judaea and had crossed the Jordan, seeing how even the signs of God's wrath were to be found in that land whose inhabitants had committed the sins of murdering, persecuting, and doing violence to foreigners[598]. His description of the land visited is desolating: smoke and fire on all sides and the Dead Sea incapable of producing

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Roman authority against them. Accordingly, the accusation in rhetorical cascade is that the Jews have no sentiments of humanity towards innocent victims.

594 *M. Pion.,* 4, 9.

595 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 4, 10. He returns to this idea on a further two occasions, cf. *M. Pion.,* 13, 1; 14, 5.

596 *M. Pion.,* 4, 11. Cf. *Iud,* 2, 10–3, 6; *2 K* 17*; Ps* 106. The Christians took up these themes once more, connecting them with the accusation of having murdered the Messiah. Cf. Just., *dial*., 132, (PG 6, 781–784), 1; *M. Pion.,* 13, 2.

597 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 4, 12. Subsequently the idea that the Hebrews retain in their Bible the testimony of their own misfortune is openly expressed in Zeno of Verona, *Tr.,* 1, 9 (PL 11, 259–260). More generally, the preservation of the Hebrew Bible was judged a useful service done to the Christians, Caesareus of Arles calls the Hebrew people (*capsarius chistianorum*), "bearer of books for the Christians", cf. Caes. Arel., *Sermo* 83, 3 (SCh 447, 114–116).

598 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 4, 18. These sins evoke the behaviour of the inhabitants of Sodom towards Lot's guests, cf. *Gn* 19, 4–9.

any sign of life; in the same way he mentions the similar situation of Mount Etna in Sicily, of Lydia, of Lycia and of the islands, all of which is a simulacrum of the forthcoming judgment coming from God through Christ His Word. On account of all of this, he concluded, that the Christians do not prostrate themselves to the pagan gods or in front of the golden statue[599]. This discourse is addressed to confuting the arguments according to which the Jews could confuse (πλανᾶν) the Christians, intimidating them by the repressive measures directed against their religion and by means of which they carried out proselytism in favour of the Jewish cause[600].

Following the interrogation to which Pionius is subjected by the neocorus Polemon and once he has been led to the prison with his companions, the martyr utters exclamations between sobs, comparing among other things his situation to that of Susanna who is threatened by obscene old men who spy on the tender and pure young woman to satiate themselves with her beauty and to shame her with lies[601]. The story of Susanna was also applied to the persecutions by the Asian Hippolytus in his *Commentary on Daniel,*[602] identifying the two obscene old men with the Hebrews and pagans who persecute the Christians. But to tell the truth, the Jews do not appear as persecutors of the Christians in this *Martyrdom*; however, as we have indicated, they are attributed with feelings of hostility towards Christians[603], in addition to which they show a lively curiosity to witness the arrest of the Christians[604].

Thereafter, we find the long discourse contained in chapters 13 and 14 which aims at making a detailed and subtle confutation, for the use of their co-religionaries, of the arguments which evidently the Jewish clergy used to make propaganda between the *lapsi:* Christ is a man and died as a bandit (ὡς βιοθανής)[605] and his resurrection is a work of necromancy (νεκυομαντείαν πεποιηκέναι)[606].

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599 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 4, 18–24. The image of gold may make reference to the emperor's effigy, cf. G. Lanata, *Gli atti dei martiri come documenti processuali,* Milan 1973. 174.

600 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 4, 12.

601 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 12, 5.

602 Cf. Hipp., *Dan.,* 1, 14–15, 20–21, 25 (SCh 14, 96–98; 108–110; 114–116).

603 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 4, 8.

604 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 3, 6.

605 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 13, 3. This is a recurrent argument against the Christians, cf. Just., *dial.,* 10, 3; 32, 1; 48, 1; 49, 1 (PG 6, 495–497; 542; 580–586); *Actus Petri cum Simone,* 23; Or., *Cels.,* 2, 79 (SCh 132, 474–476).

606 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 13, 4. The Jews too are perceived as magicians in Smyrna, cf. *V. Polyc.,* 28, 3. The figure of Polycarp, in its legendary *Vita,* is presented as a man having supernatural powers, cf. *V. Polyc.,* 25; 29, 2. Necromancy is a complex phenomenon with a

Pionius' concern for the *lapsi,* given Jewish opportunism, is evident: "I have received news that the Hebrews invite some of you to the synagogue"[607]. So that the Jews took advantage of the official repression against the Christian minority which in some way came from the same race and the same Jewish scriptural tradition, and which accordingly could be recuperated more easily for Hebrew observance than for the religious ethics and polytheistic mysticism of their pagan persecutors. For this reason, Pionius seems to minimise the scope and consequences of the abjuration made under duress (ἀκούσιον) before the pagan idols, stressing that the *lapsi* may be recuperated for the Church[608], whilst on the contrary, taking care to reaffirm the moral and religious gravity of the voluntary abjuration (ἑκούσιον) made in the synagogue. This is a more serious guilt (μεῖζον ἁμάρτημα), and in addition, unlike the other, it is irremediable (ἀναφαίρετον), since it is equivalent to the sin of blasphemy (βλασφημία) against the Holy Spirit[609].

As we may have noted, the *Martyrdom of Pionius* records not only a progressive disencounter between the Christian and Jewish community, but unlike the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* where the text refers to us only actions by the Jews against the Christians, this source of at least 100 years later, reveals a greater complexity in the relationship of the two communities, arguments come and go, we find the development on the Christian side of a literary genre and a theology of accusation and defence in the face of Jewish proselytism exercised in the midst of the persecution of the Christians, who, at this point in history, are already clearly differentiated from the former by the authorities of the Empire and the mass of the people.

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long history among the Greeks and the Jews. Many elements are distinguished, such as the resurrection of bodies, the evocation of phantoms, the interrogation of a dead person' spirit, cf. L. Robert, *Le martyre de Pionios prêtre de Smyrne. Edité, traduit et commenté,* Washington 1994, 86. Pionius continues his discourse with an argumentative sequence based on the sorceress of Endor who appears in *1 S* 28, arriving at the conclusion that the Hebrew affirmation of having invoked Christ from beyond the tomb cannot be true. In *1 Samuel,* the evocation of the dead Samuel by Saul through the sorceress is told as a real fact, and as such is accepted by the rabbinical exegesis. Nonetheless, Christians do not fully agree among themselves on the reality of this evocation. Justin, Origen, and others accept the literal sense of this story, while John Chrysostom and others doubt that the spirit of Samuel had appeared. Tertullian thought that Saul had been tricked by a demon, cf. K. Smelik, *The Witch of Endor. 1 Samuel 28 in Rabbinic and Christian Exegesis till 800 A.D.,* in *Vigiliae Christianae* 32 (1979), 160–179.

607 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 13, 1.

608 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 14, 16.

609 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 13, 1.

8. Jews and Christians before the civil authority in the Life of Polycarp

Despite the legendary spirit surrounding its lines, the *Life of Polycarp* also offers us an image of the relationship between Jews and Christians in second – and third – century Smyrna.

The commander of the city (ὁ στϱατηγός), being one night in the praetorium, witnessed the possession by a demon of one of his servants, and the Jews arrived on the scene with the intention of performing some incantations (ἐπάδειν αὐτῷ θέλοντες). But the servant attacked them, and although they were numerous, ripped their garments and sent them packing, half naked, and covered with wounds[610]. Finally, thanks to the recommendation of a Christian who happened to be in the commander's house, they called in Polycarp, who it appears successfully carried out the exorcism[611].

The text also refers that when a great fire spread through the whole city in the middle of the night as the result of an oversight in a bakery, the Jews, accustomed to arriving at the scene of the fire[612], with the excuse of helping to put it out, making a show of their usual capacity to extinguish the fire, took advantage of the occasion to try to plunder the city by cunning means[613]. Finally, Polycarp is called in by the authorities, and he by his prayer, and caused the wind to change direction so that the fire was extinguished[614]. Likewise, the bishop is later called on to the theatre for the purpose of remedying the famine that has struck the city; once he manages to stave off the crowd waiting eagerly for a miracle, Polycarp makes for the house of the Lord and there together with the deacons, raises a successful entreaty to God who, in answer to their prayers, sends down rain on the city[615].

Apart from the thaumaturgical nature of the interventions commissioned by the Gentile bureaucracy, headed by the commander of the city, to solve cases of madness or possession by devils, fire and famine in the city, the sequence of these three episodes in the intention of the writer of the *Life of Polycarp* appears

610 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 28, 3; cf. *M. Pion.,* 13, 4.

611 Cf. The final text of this narration presents a gap, but manages to tell us that although Polycarp was a considerable distance from him, the possessed servant shouted out loudly, "Here comes Polycarp, I have to flee", cf. *V. Polyc.,* 28, 4.

612 This statement reminds us of the participation of the Jews in the fire lit for the martyrdom of Polycarp, cf. *M. Polyc.,* 13, 1.

613 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 28, 1–3.

614 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 29, 2.

615 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 30–32.

to be the desire to illustrate, from his point of view, the political implications of the competition between Jews and Christians who, with the elements of religious prestige, struggle to win credit and power in the eyes of the competent authority, or even seek to escape in some way from the suspicion and pressure of the violent and turbulent crowd, performing acts which go down well with the latter. From the narrator's point of view, the text shows that the authorities of the city are better pleased with the services rendered by the Christians and feel a deep distrust for the Jews.

9. Conclusion

After re-examining the circumstances and texts from the origins of Christianity up to the third and fourth centuries, particularly in the region of Asia Minor and above all in Smyrna, we may affirm that the tension between the two communities, Jewish and Christian, is palpable.

In general terms, the Roman Empire was well disposed towards the Jews of the diaspora and thanks to this attitude of the Empire, these were able to develop an active propaganda. Particularly in the region of Asia, the Jewish presence was significant, as is highlighted not only by the testimonies of antique authors but also by recent archaeological findings, and this presence was probably enriched by the waves of emigrants coming from Palestine following the revolts and subsequent fall of Jerusalem at the end of the first and beginning of the second century. Judaism in Asia appeared to distance itself from the political confrontations of the Empire with Judaism in the region of Palestine, and although it could not be accused of being syncretistic, it seems that Judaism in Asia did not prove to be introverted or isolationist towards civil society in the cities where it was present, but on the contrary, seemed to enjoy a certain social ascendency in the area.

In relation to Christianity, the Jews of the diaspora, who were usually Greek-speaking, represented a veritable *trait d'union* between Christians of pagan origin and judaising Christians from the Palestinian setting. Notwithstanding, the Jews of the diaspora insofar as they came gradually to realise the ideological contrast between themselves and the new group, which despite the various characteristics in common, accentuated its specificity presenting itself as a veritable new religion, expelled from the synagogues towards the end of the first century all those who at that point were already defined as Christians, including those of more judaising observance, considering them extraneous to the Jewish religion[616].

616 Cf. M. Simonetti, *Il Vangelo e la storia,* Rome 2010, 27–32.

Despite this gradual separation and differentiation between Jews and Christians, both the New Testament and subsequent Christian literature in Smyrna report that no self-understanding of Christianity in relation to its deepest roots escaped its necessary confrontation with Judaism. An important development of this self-understanding of Christianity as opposed to Judaism would appear to be traced in the letters of Ignatius, in which important differences may be found between the customs which Christians must observe with regard to the Jews. However, although the Ignatian letters clearly show the conviction that the Christian faith is superior to Judaism, it appears that the adversaries whom Ignatius is so persistently fighting are not properly speaking Jews, but judaising Christians.

For their part, in the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* and in the *Martyrdom of Pionius*, it is clear that the social ascendency of Judaism in Smyrna was exploited on various occasions until it became a co-protagonist in the persecution against the Christians. This is expressed by various episodes in which the Jews appear particularly hostile to Christians, and in addition in which they take advantage of the situation of weakness caused by the persecution suffered by the Christians to undertake a powerful proselytism among them. Although these sources may have been elaborated to respond to internal debates within the Christian community, such as the veneration of relics or the polemics with the Montanists, among others, it is nevertheless clear the perception that the editors of these sources had of the Jewish community present in Smyrna clearly conveys a real conflict between Jews and Christians.

Finally, despite the legendary spirit present in the *Life of Polycarp,* the writer's intention, as regards the relationship between Jews and Christians, would seem to be to illustrate, from his point of view, the political and social implications of the rivalry between the two groups, that with the elements of religious prestige attempt to gain credit with the civil authority and acceptation by the mass of the people in third -or fourth- century Smyrna. From the narrator's point of view, the text shows that the civil authorities tend to appreciate the services of the Christians, while they feel distrust for the Jews.

Hereafter, in the following chapter, we will attempt to elaborate a reconstruction of the history of the Christian community of Smyrna, and more particularly of its most outstanding leaders.

Chapter VI: The community of Christians in Smyrna

The fundamental intention of this chapter is to identify the most significant leaders in the Christian community of Smyrna from its foundation up to the Council of Nicaea. The difficulty of such an identification arises not only from the relatively scarce documentation, but from the consequent utilisation of it, starting off from the historical and literary evaluation we have made of the sources presented in the first part.

1. The foundation of the community

The merit of having introduced Christianity into Asia belongs to Paul of Tarsus. His first effort to enter the province from within proved in some way to be frustrated on his second journey[617], so that he decided, instead, to make his way to Macedonia and Hellas in about the year 50. A couple of years later, in spring of the year 52, returning by sea from Corinth to Syria, he made a short stop in Ephesus where he went into the synagogue and started discussing with the Jews. There he left a couple of Jews, Priscilla and Aquila, promising to return later. In Paul's absence, this couple further instructed an Alexandrian Christian called Apollo who subsequently went to Acaya and especially to its capital Corinth[618].

Meanwhile, having arrived in Caesarea[619], Paul probably went to visit the church of Jerusalem[620], passed through Antioch, and later went around one region

617 Cf. *Ac* 16, 6–10.

618 This Alexandrian preacher before meeting Aquila and Priscilla, was already conscientiously taught everything about Jesus, but was only acquainted with the baptism of John. Aquila and Priscilla then explained to him more exactly "the Way", cf. *Ac* 18, 24–28. The news on Apollo has certain features in common with those on the disciples that Paul meets in Ephesus, cf. *Ac* 19, 1–7. Both possessed what might be termed an incomplete Christianity, which may reflect the Christianity of the Church of Alexandria at that time. Besides, the very brief epitome of Paul's activity in Ephesus referred in *Ac* 18, 19–21 safeguards his mission of foundation from the activity of Apollo, which will be mentioned once more in *1 Co* 3, 4–11; 4, 6, as in a certain sense a rivalry with the missionary activity of Paul.

619 This means Caesarea Maritima and not Caesarea of Philippi, since it says that he "disembarked", cf. *Ac* 18, 22.

620 It may be inferred that this means the Church of Jerusalem, since the text says that "he went up" to visit the Church, cf. *Ac* 18, 22.

after the other of Galatia and Phrygia, fortifying the disciples[621]. In the *Acts of the Apostles,* we are told that Paul arrived in Ephesus after he had "crossed the high regions"[622]. If we consider, as may be inferred from *Col* 2, 1, that the men of the valley of Laodicea and Colossae did not see Paul personally, it is possible that Paul's return journey to Ephesus took place after passing through Phrygia either through the valley of the river Cayster or by way of the region of Philadelphia, Sardis and Smyrna, perhaps for the purpose of visiting these important cities.

The *Life of Polycarp,* evaluation of which was made in the first part, begins by speaking of the coming of the blessed Paul to Smyrna in the days of unleavened bread, adjusting for the benefit of this city, the various possibilities in the route followed by the apostle from Galatia and Phrygia as far as Ephesus which tie in with the vague expression "high regions" (ἀνωτερικὰ μέρη) of the *Acts of the Apostles* 19, 1. This *Life of Polycarp*, of which we have affirmed the historic possibility of certain facts, tells us that this visit is believed to have taken place when Paul came down from the region of Galatia, as testified by the ancient manuscripts (ἐν ἀρχαίοις ἀντιγράφοις) found by the author of the *Life of Polycarp*[623]. The narration continues by stating that, in the course of his passing by Smyrna, Paul stayed as a guest in the house of Strataeas, son of Eunice and nephew of Lois, who had been a listener of his in Pamphylia[624], where he had an encounter with the faithful members of the community[625]. Eunice and Lois were also the mother and the grandmother of Timothy respectively[626]. Accordingly, as the author of the *Life* reports, Strataeas was Timothy's brother[627]. It is significant that "Timothy's brother" appears as the first leader of the Church of Smyrna when Timothy, according to a tradition gathered by Eusebius, was the first bishop of the Church of Ephesus[628]. However, it is necessary to be extremely prudent in the historical evaluation of the data presented in the *Life of Polycarp*[629].

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621 Communities already evangelised in *Ac* 16, 6.

622 *Ac* 19, 1.

623 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 1.

624 Paul was in Pamphylia on his first journey, cf. *Ac* 14, 24–25.

625 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 2, 3.

626 Cf. *1 Tm* 1, 5.

627 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 2, 2.

628 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 3, 4, 5. Nonetheless, we should note that Polycrates of Ephesus when he speaks of the Quartodecimanist tradition, appealing to the tradition of John, makes no mention of Timothy in relation to his Church, cf. Polychr., *Ep. Vict.,* in Eus., *h. e.* 5, 24, 2–7.

629 As remarked in the first part, the *Life of Polycarp* contains many legendary elements and at least part of it takes its place within the polemics on the date of Easter,

On his arrival in Ephesus, following his brief passing through the "high regions", Paul found a small community of some twelve men whom he baptised in the name of the Lord Jesus and laid hands on them; these, who had not heard talk of the Holy Spirit and who had only received the baptism of John, were able to talk in tongues and to prophesy[630]. The apostolate of Paul in Ephesus developed during the first three months in the synagogue, however this experience of preaching in a properly Jewish environment ended when many of those who were there remained unpersuaded and spoke badly of the Way, so that Paul decided to break with them and to form a separate group of disciples with whom he organised daily debates in the school of someone called Tyrannus in the course of two further years[631], so that according to what Luke says in a hyperbolic manner, "people from all over Asia, both Jews and Greeks, were able to hear the word of the Lord"[632]. We should not exclude the possibility that the inhabitants of Smyrna may have benefitted from the missionary effort prolonged during these two years. So that, considering these facts as a whole, it is possible that the origins of a Christian community in Smyrna may be dated around the years 53 to 56 in the shadow of Paul's preaching. One sentence of Polycarp's *To the Philippians* enables us to make yet another disquisition: "I did not note or see anything similar in you, as between those worked by the blessed Paul and those you appeared at the beginning of his letter[633]. And in fact all the churches, the only ones that then knew God, glory in you. We, however, still did not know him"[634]. In this phrase, it is clear that there existed a Christian presence in Philippi earlier than

especially the abrupt beginning of the work where this episode of Paul's visit to Smyrna is mentioned.

630 Cf. *Ac* 19, 1–7.

631 Cf. *Ac* 19, 10. However in *Ac* 20, 31, it is said that the time in Ephesus was three years. The accounts may add up if we consider that, basing ourselves on *Ac* 19, Paul spent two years and three months in Ephesus, before making his way to Hellas by way of Macedonia, and there he stayed a further three months, cf. *Ac* 20, 3. Thereafter, he returned by land and arrived in Philippi for Easter, cf. *Ac* 20, 6. These journeys could have lasted four or five months, which would mean that he finally returned to Ephesus in the spring or early summer of the year 54 A.D. Accordingly in his farewell to the presbyters of Ephesus, he reminds them that he has been notifying them on the Christian faith for three years.

632 Cf. *Ac* 19, 10; cf. *Ac* 10, 26.

633 Cf. *Phil.,* 1, 1.

634 Polyc., *ep*., 11, 3.

in Smyrna. We know that this important city of Macedonia was evangelised by Paul on his second journey, between the autumn of 48 and the summer of 49[635].

However, perhaps we should consider that, if we were to take as certain the aforementioned news from the *Life of Polycarp,* with the possibility of a Christianity in Smyrna similar to that of Apollo and the group of the twelve of Ephesus, the community of Smyrna might even have had a slightly earlier origin than Paul's preaching. Nonetheless, doubts on the historical veracity of the facts transmitted in this work make us prudent about such a statement.

According to the *Life of Polycarp,* after the apostle Paul had left Smyrna, Strataeas inherited the task of teaching (διδάσκαλος)[636]. The fact that the author of the *Life of Polycarp* does not refer to Strataeas and his successors as bishop (ἐπίσκοποι), might make us think that he was a historical figure and a true leader of the community of Smyrna in its earliest period, since at the time in which the *Life of Polycarp* was written, from the third century onwards, the interest lies in exalting the figure of the bishop in the community, as likewise the importance of the apostolic succession in the transmission of the true faith[637]. Although doubtless, Strataeas may be a fictitious personage created by the author of the abrupt beginning of the *Life of Polycarp.*

Subsequently, the author of the *Life of Polycarp* promises to make a list of some other names of masters who succeeded Strataeas; however, he did not do so or else this list has never reached us[638]. The name of Strataeas is also mentioned in the *Apostolic Constitutions* in a list of the three first bishops of Smyrna: Ariston the first, then Strataeas son of Lois, and third Ariston[639].

The compiler of the *Apostolic Constitutions,* in case he had wanted to take up the version of the *Life of Polycarp,* gives erroneous information on Strataeas since Lois was the grandmother of Timothy and Eunice was the mother[640]. In

635 Cf. *Ac* 16, 12–40. He once more passed by there in the course of his third journey, in the winter of 44–45, cf. *Ac* 20, 1–2 and at Easter of 56, cf. *Ac* 20, 3–6. After long discussion, scholars have dated Paul's letter *To the Philippians* at between the year 52 and 54 in some captivity of the Apostle in Ephesus, cf. B. Byrne, *Carta a los filipenses,* in *Nuevo Comentario Bíblico San Jerónimo,* Navarra 2004, 305.

636 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 3, 1.

637 Cf. E. Prinzivalli, *Questioni di Storia del Cristianesimo Antico I–IV sec.,* Rome 2009, 167.

638 Cf. *V. Polyc.* 3, 1.

639 Cf. *Const. App.* 7, 46, 8.

640 Cf. *1 Tm* 1, 5.

the same way, this should be true for Strataeas. This error may be the result of a simple disattention, or of the fact that the fourth-century compiler had taken a different source from that of the *Life of Polycarp* which did not refer to Strataeas as Timothy's brother. It seems improbable, though, that the compiler of the *Apostolic Constitutions* showed no interest in linking up the name of this personage with Timothy, since the spirit that characterises this time would appear to be that of creating this type of connection which may not necessarily be historical.

However that may be, discussion remains open on the existence of Strataeas as a very early leader of the community of Smyrna, since the only two sources which give us news of this personage are late ones (third century and fourth century), even though the author of the *Life of Polycarp* has stated that he found this information in "antique archives" of the community.

2. Development of the community and configuration of its first leaders

After the successes of the foundation of the community in Ephesus and the victory of the Pauline mission over the "Jewish exorcists", Paul took the decision of going to Jerusalem[641]. In the same way, in the *Life of Polycarp* 2, 1, the author frames Paul's visit to Smyrna, once he launched into projects for going to Jerusalem.

When Paul left Ephesus in the year 56 bound for Macedonia, taking the most commonly used route, he probably passed by Smyrna, as likewise did his disciples Timothy and Erastus shortly before him[642]. If he passed by there, it would possibly be for the last time, since in the spring of the following year, on his return from Troad, he only spent a short time in Miletus as he did not wish to waste time in Asia, since it was his intention to arrive in Jerusalem for the day of Pentecost[643]. From Miletus, he called together the presbyters of Ephesus and took leave for ever of them with an effusive discourse in which he announces that, following his departure, "Ferocious wolves who will spare no means for attacking

641 Cf. *Ac* 19, 21.

642 Cf. *Ac* 19, 21–22. It should also be noted that in *Ac* 19, 21 following the successes of the foundation of the community in Ephesus and of the victory of the Pauline mission over the "Jewish exorcists", Paul took the decision to go to Jerusalem. In the same way, the *V. Polyc.*, 2, 1, frames Paul's visit to Smyrna, once he launched out on projects for going to Jerusalem.

643 Cf. *Ac* 20, 15–16.

the flock will get in among them, and also individuals who 'will appear divulging falsities, in order to draw the disciples after them'"[644].

Paul's words of concern were soon followed by possible new difficulties. Starting from the year 64, the persecution which broke out by the Roman goverment against the Christians was added. Although it would seem that Nero's persecution was only directed at the Christians of Rome, in any case it created a legal precedent for the provincial governors to proceed against the Christians, either as a result of formal accusations or else of popular revolts.

If *1 Peter* could really be dated at a very early period as certain scholars affirm[645] (from 64 to 67), it would be probable that the effects of this first wave of persecution had arrived in Asia Minor. In fact, *1 Peter,* which vindicates the paternity of Peter, is addressed to the Christians "of the Dispersion", giving the names of five provinces: Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia and Bithynia[646]. As regards its past, it allows us to understand that its addressees are Christian converts from among the Gentiles, without excluding the presence of Judaeo-Christians among them. One of the purposes of the epistle would be to sustain the faith of its recipients in the midst of the tribulations afflicting them[647]. Tribulations seeming to consist of private violence, insults, and calumnies that the purity of life of the converts arouse as a reaction in those whose unregulated conduct they abandoned. Notwithstanding, other authors, such as M. Simonetti are of the opinion that this letter is pseudo-epigraphical and was composed by a member of the Pauline school in Asia at the end of the first century or the beginning of the second century[648]. If this is so, the community of Smyrna would not have been affected by persecution until this time, likewise as the testimony of the *Revelation* indicates.

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644 *Ac* 20, 29–30. For a full commentary on Paul's passing by Miletus on his way to Jerusalem, and his discourse to the presbyters of Ephesus, cf. J. Fitzmyer, *The Acts of the Apostles,* New York 1998, 673–683; cf. J. Zmijewski, *Atti degli Apostoli,* Brescia 2006, 940–1007.

645 Cf. W. Dalton, *Primera Carta de Pedro* in *Nuevo Comentario Bíblico San Jerónimo,* Navarra 2004, 467–468. For a recent study presenting the various arguments in favour and against an early or late dating of *1 Peter* and other aspects of the letter, cf. F. Lapham, *Peter: the Myth, the Man and the Writings. A Study of Early Petrine Text and Tradition,* New York 2004, 117–148; cf. P. Achtemeier, *La prima lettera di Pietro, commento storico esegetico,* Vatican City 2000. Both studies incline for a late dating of the same.

646 *1 P* 1, 1.

647 Cf. *1 P* 2, 12; 3, 16; 4, 4. 12–16.

648 Cf. M. Simonetti, *Paolo nell'Asia cristiana del II secolo,* 128 note 14.

As we have said, we do not know exactly what type of situation of persecution or tribulation *1 Peter* is referring to, but we must say that this writing was gratefully received by subsequent generations. It was probably utilised by Clement of Rome and certainly drawn on in abundance by Polycarp of Smyrna in his letter *To the Philippians*[649], as Eusebius already pointed out[650], which enables us to conclude that *1 Peter* was read in Smyrna and that in their time the Christians there with Polycarp at their head considered his message as a doctrine of authority.

In accordance with a tradition taken up by Eusebius on the basis of a letter by bishop Polycrates of Ephesus to Victor bishop of Rome, a significant number of Christians of Palestine emigrated to the west of Asia Minor[651]. This migration to which Polycrates refers could have taken place at the time of the destruction of Jerusalem in the year 70 under Vespasian and Titus[652]. This would mean that a large part of the Christian community which emigrated was of Judaeo-Christian origin. Whatever the cause of the emigration towards this region, perhaps on account of the stability already at the end of the first century represented by the presence of the Christian community in that area or for other reasons, undoubtedly this wave of Palestinian Christians strengthened the prestige of the Christian community in this area, especially since there were prominent leaders of the Church among them. Paul was already not the only outstanding Christian associated with this region. The apostle John and the mother of Jesus were associated with the city of Ephesus, just as Philip and his daughters were associated with the city of Hierapolis[653].

As far as Smyrna is concerned, the *Apostolic Constitutions,* as mentioned earlier, in an early list of bishops of the church of Smyrna, gives the names of the first three: "and of Smyrna: Ariston (Ἀϱίστων), the first, after him Strataeas, son of Lois, and the third, Ariston (Ἀϱίστων)"[654].

The *Apostolic Constitutions* is a compilation of traditions dating from the end of the fourth century in Antioch in Syria. Here we find the lists of bishops established by the apostles in various churches: Jerusalem, Caesarea of Palestine,

649 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 1, 3 (*1 P* 1, 8); *ep.,* 2, 1 (*1 P* 1, 21); *ep.,* 2, 2 (*1 P* 3, 9); 3, 3 (*1 P* 2, 11); *ep.,* 8, 1 (*1 P* 2, 22–24); *ep.,* 10, 1 (*1 P* 3, 8); *ep.,* 10, 2 (*1 P* 2, 12; 5, 5); *ep.,* 12, 2 (*1 P* 1, 21). Starting with Irenaeus, the letter is explicitly attributed to Peter.

650 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 4, 14, 9.

651 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 3, 31, 2; 5, 24, 2.

652 Cf. W. Bauer, *Orthodoxy and Heresy in Earliest Christianity,* Philadelphia 1971, 89–90.

653 Eus., *h. e.* 3, 39, 5–9.

654 *Const. App.* 7, 46, 8.

Antioch, Alexandria, Rome, Ephesus, Smyrna, Pergamum, Crete, Athens, Laodicea in Phrygia, Macedonia, churches of Galatia and in districts of Asia. In most of the lists we find persons named in the New Testament: Zaccheus, Cornelius, Philemon, Timothy, Gaius, Lucius, Onesimus, etc. Due to its late date, this list should be accepted with extreme caution, calling on our part for a measured appraisal regarding the name of Ariston and the absence of Polycarp[655].

The *Apostolic Constitutions* are the only source giving the name of Ariston (Ἀριστων). However, the absence of Polycarp and instead the inclusion of a second Ariston (Ἀριστων) in the list after Strataeas, makes us think that the name of Polycarp has been replaced intentionally, either because for the compiler the "episcopacy" of Polycarp was beyond the historical term proposed for the compilation, or else his replacement may have been due to his unfortunate Quartodecimanism. The possibility of its being merely an error, or that two Aristons in fact existed is improbable. R. Joly affirms that, in view of the not totally consolidated character of the institution of the episcopacy at that time, it may refer to two periods of leadership by Ariston of the community of Smyrna[656]. Nonetheless, these explanations would appear distinctly forced and doubt still remains regarding the historic nature of the source.

Apart from the replacement or omission of the name of Polycarp in this first list, another interesting feature is the fact of analysing whether this Ariston (Ἀριστων), could or could not be identified with one of the two disciples of the Lord (τοῦ κυρίου μαθηταί), to whom Papias of Hierapolis, companion (ἑταῖρος) of Polycarp[657], makes reference when stating that for his improvement

655 The absence of Polycarp is not the only important absence in the lists. There is no mention either of Anacletus, successor of Linus in Rome. The majority of the lists only give the names of the first three bishops, and the others less than three. As for Ephesus, Timothy appears established by Paul, while John is established by John, cf. *Const. App*. 7, 46, 7.

656 Cf. R. Joly, *Le dossier d'Ignace d'Antioche,* Brussels 1979, 79.

657 Cf. Iren., *haer.,* 5, 33, 4. The term ἑταῖρος refers to the fact that Papias and Polycarp belong to the same generation. Without any doubt, Papias, like Polycarp, belongs to the group of presbyters of Asia who are disciples of John, mentioned by Irenaeus. However, it may be noted that Irenaeus only defines Papias, and not Polycarp, as an 'ancient man'. Given that Polycarp was born in about the year 69, the birth of Papias may have been in about 60. For Eusebius, Papias was certainly older than Polycarp. Eusebius speaks of Papias immediately after Ignatius, Quadratus and Clement of Rome, that is to say, in relation with personages whose zenith must have been more or less in the days of Trajan, between 98 and 117, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 3, 39; while Eusebius speaks of Polycarp in close connection with Justin the Martyr, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 4, 14. 15;

he esteems a more lively and durable voice than what can be obtained from books.

Papias does not say where Aristion (Ἀριστίων) lived, but he associates him with the other disciples, the "presbyter John"[658]. Since John, as we know from other sources, is associated with Ephesus[659], it would seem natural to think that Aristion (Ἀριστίων) may have lived in Smyrna. The slight difference in the orthography of the name is insignificant, and the reasons for identifying both personages appear probable.

In Syria, as from the sixth century, attempts were made to compile the list of the 72 disciples mentioned by *Lk* 10, 1. 17. In various versions of these lists dated in the years between 700 and 1200, the name of Apelles, who is greeted by Paul in *Rom* 16, 10, is included as bishop of Smyrna[660]. He was recognised as one of the 72 disciples by Epiphanius in about the year 375, and also in the Byzantine *Chronicon Paschale*[661] of the year 629. But the assignation of episcopal sees to the various names was later than the first compilation of the list; and certain copies, after the year 800, state that Apelles was bishop of Heraclea or Mediolanum. The late date of these records and the absence of the name of Apelles from all the ancient documents shows quite clearly the purely conjectural nature of the statement that Apelles was bishop of Smyrna.

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cf. E. Norelli, *Papia di Hierapolis, Esposizione degli Oracoli del Signore, I frammenti,* Milan 2005, 41.

658 "And if perchance someone arrived who had also followed the presbyters, I tried to discern the words of the presbyters: by that I mean Andrew, or Peter, or Philip, or Thomas, or James, or John, or Matthew or any other of the Lord's disciples, or I mean Ariston and presbyter John, disciples of the Lord, because I thought that what I got from books would not be of such benefit to me as what comes from a living and lasting voice", cf. Eus., *h. e.* 3, 39, 4. This text has constituted a veritable *crux interpretum* which has given rise to a vast amount of literature, without arriving at any agreement. A good study is that of J. Munk, *Presbyters and Disciples of the Lord in Papias. Exegetics Comments on Eusebius, Ecclesiastical History III, 39*, in *Harvard Theological Review* 52 (1959), 223–243; for E. Norelli, Papias refers to two different processes in this text, the second of which must have taken place at a time when Papias could no longer listen directly to the presbyters, cf. E. Norelli, *Papia di Hierapolis,* 37–48, 253.

659 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 7, 25, 16.

660 Cf. H. Delehaye, *Les passions,* 59.

661 According to the *Chronicon Paschale*, Papias died a martyr in Pergamum in the year of Polycarp's martyrdom in Smyrna, cf. *Chron. Pasch.,* 628. This news attributed to the year 163 A.D. is based on an erroneous reading of Eusebius, cf. E. Norelli, *Papia di Hierapolis*, 48.

The young church of Smyrna, like its peers throughout Asia, had undoubtedly undergone the same process of gestation, first of all around the Jewish synagogue, where Jews and pagans "fearful of God" decided to welcome the Christian message. Then at a second stage, fruit of the growing differentiation between Judaism and Christianity, the new believers began to meet up in a *domus ecclesiae*. The social structure of Christianity in Asia Minor was of corporative nature between the different communities. The early churches were generally small assemblies meeting regularly in the homes of certain of its members to celebrate their faith. Accordingly, it is not difficult to think that in cities like Ephesus or Smyrna, there were many more than one such small communities[662].

As regards the size of the Christian population in Smyrna as in other cities of Asia Minor, it is difficult to give an exact number, suffice it to say that the Christians were numerous, certainly several thousands by the beginning of the second century in the whole of Asia Minor[663]. Undoubtedly, the situation of the Christians in the eyes of civil society was of a strong community and the situation was positive from its own perception, despite the recent persecution by Domitian: they felt themselves to be a strong and growing community, with which an aspostolic tradition was associated.

3. The author of the Revelation and the "angel" of the Church of Smyrna

Let us now go on to consider the presbyter John, contemporary of Aristion, who had dealings with the Christian community of Smyrna, not as a presbyter or bishop, but as the possible author of a book in which is included the first letter or prophetic message of which we have news, addressed to the Church of Smyrna.

The author of the *Revelation* thus introduces himself as John, exiled to the island of Patmos for his faith in Christ[664]. Patmos was a place of exile for political

662 Cf. R. Gehring, *House, Church and Mission*, Peabody 2004; cf. H. Klauck, *Hausgemeinde und Hauskirche in frühen Christentum*, Stuttgart 1981.

663 R. Grant affirms that the size of the Christian population in the Empire is an open question, cf. R. Grant, *Early Christianity and Society,* San Francisco 1977; while B. Lightfoot, for his part, considers that there were hundreds of thousands of Christians in the Empire at the time of Hadrian, cf. B. Lightfoot, *The Apostolic Fathers*, II, 1, 458. Finally B. Reicke thinks that at the end of the first century the Christians of Asia Minor were about 80.000, cf. B. Reicke, *The New Testament Era: The World of the Bible from 500 B.C. to A.D. 100,* Philadelphia, 302–303.

664 Cf. *Rv* 1, 9.

reasons[665]. Exile *(relegatio)* was a punishment reserved to notable persons (*honestiores*) on whom capital punishment was not inflicted. *Rv* 20, 4 speaks of the "souls of those who were decapitated for their witness of Jesus". Decapitation was a capital punishment reserved only to notable persons *(honestiores)* or soldiers. So that the author of the *Revelation* may have been an *honestior.* The author wrote this text around the year 95 at the time of Domitian. This is confirmed by most of the antique Christian authors[666].

Eusebius, on the basis of the information taken from Papias, regarding the existence of two Johns[667], the apostle and the presbyter, offers the hypothesis that the *Revelation* should be attributed to the latter: "It is necessary to pay attention to these facts, because it is probable that it was the second, – if the first is not preferred – who saw the *Revelation* going under the name of John"[668]. The interest of Eusebius in attributing the *Revelation* to the presbyter has a twofold purpose.

First of all, it has to do with the millenarianism present in this book, which at the time of Eusebius is a belief enjoying considerable credence[669]. In the *Revelation,* millenarianism takes its place in a context of powerful aversion to Rome. This nuance is absent from other millenarian authors such as Melito of Sardis or even Papias. In the East, the decisive decision against millenarianism came from the Alexandrian doctors who professed a much more spiritual conception of Christian eschatology. Origen combated the literal interpretation of *Rv* 20–21, and proposed an allegorical interpretation which deprived millenarianism of its biblical foundation[670]. The spread of the Alexandrian culture in the third century caused the progressive decline of the millenarian ideas in the East[671]. For his part, Dionysius kept up a tough polemics with Egyptian communities of millenarian faith[672] and at the end of the century, Methodius repeated the same

665 Cf. Tac., *an.,* 3, 68; 4, 30; 15, 71; Pliny, *Naturalis Historia,* 12, 4; 13, 23.

666 Iren., *haer.,* 5, 30, 3; Clem., *q.d.s.,* 42 (SCh 537, 208–223); Or., *Comm. in Mt.,* 16. 6 (SCh 162); Vict. Petov., *comm. in apoc.,* 10, 11; 17, 10 (SCh 423, 92); Eus., *h. e.* 3, 18. 20. 23; Hier., *vir. ill.,* 9 (PL 23, 673–676); cf. P. Prigent, *L'Apocalypse de Saint Jean,* Geneva 2000, 49–54.

667 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 3, 39, 4.

668 Eus., *h. e.* 3, 39, 6–9.

669 Cf. M. Simonetti, *Il millenarismo in Oriente da Origene a Metodio,* in *Corona gratiarum,* vol. I, Brussels 1975, 37–58.

670 Cf. Or., *princ.,* 2, 11, 2–3 (SCh 252, 397–400).

671 In the fourth century, the millenarianism of Apollinaris of Laodicea still persists, on which we have little information.

672 Eus., *h. e.* 7, 24–25.

ideas, re-elaboratiang them in a spiritual sense[673]. As for Eusebius, an admirer of Origen, for his part he inherited this tradition from the Alexandrian culture which refused to accept millenarianism.

Secondly, insofar as the tradition and authority of Irenaeus permit[674], Eusebius sought to keep the millenarian Papias separate from the apostolic generation:

> Papias himself tells other things as reaching him through unwritten tradition, certain strange parables of the Saviour and his doctrine, and some other things that are even more fabulous. Among these he says that, after the resurrection from the dead, there will be a millennium, and that Christ's kingdom will be established bodily on this earth. I believe that Papias supposes all of this as a result of misrepresenting the explanations of the apostles, not realising that these had said things in a figurative sense and symbolically[675].

Just as, according to Eusebius, Papias has taken the teaching of the apostles through those who have been with them; accordingly Papias belongs to the third generation. This position by Eusebius appears furthermore to be historically correct[676].

Notwithstanding, Eusebius has left open the possibility that the *Revelation* is a canonical text[677], and thus written by the apostle John; or on the contrary, that it is a spurious text[678], which implies it is not by the apostle and should be attributed to the presbyter. Eusebius mentions that in his time some reject the *Revelation,* while others on the contrary include it among the admitted books. However that may be, Eusebius, in the chapter on Papias, mentioned earlier, lays the bases for not accepting millenarianism in both cases. Either because the *Revelation* is by the presbyter John, in which case those who legitimate millenarianism through this writing cannot have recourse to the apostolic authority; or else, if the *Revelation* is by the apostle John, the millenarianism of which Papias is the initiator, was born of an erroneous understanding of the apostolic teachings, due to the fact that Papias was not a direct disciple of the apostle John[679].

Justin identifies the author of the *Revelation* with John, one of the "apostles of Christ"[680]. As for Irenaeus, he knows no other John than the one who is the apostle and evangelist, and accordingly situates Papias in the same generation

673 Cf. Meth., *symp.,* 9, 1–5 (SCh 95, 262–283).
674 Cf. Iren., *haer.,* 5, 33, 4.
675 Eus., *h. e.* 3, 39, 11–12.
676 Cf. E. Norelli, *Papias di Hierapolis,* 43, 242–244.
677 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 3, 25, 2.
678 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 3, 25, 4.
679 Cf. E. Norelli, *Papias di Hierapolis*, 244.
680 Cf. Just., *dial.,* 81 (PG 6, 667–669).

"of presbyters who have seen John, disciple of the Lord"[681]. Accordingly, Irenaeus is convinced that Papias and Polycarp were disciples of the apostle John of Asia, and belong to the same generation[682], and likewise Irenaeus is the first to affirm that both the *Revelation* and the fourth gospel were written by the same John, disciple of the Lord[683]. Hippolytus, Tertullian and Origen were of the same opinion as Irenaeus, perhaps depending on him.

Besides this, however, another important tradition indicates the apostle John, son of Zebedee, one of the Twelve, as a martyr in the year 70. This tradition may be found in Gregory of Nyssa and John Chrysostom. His martyrdom is associated with that of his brother James the Elder. On the basis of this association is the prophesy of martyrdom by Jesus to the sons of Zebedee that "they would drink of the same cup as him and that they would be baptised with the same baptism with which he would be baptised"[684].

Whoever the author of the *Revelation* was, it is clear that he had first-hand knowledge of the reality of each one of the churches to which he addresses his prophetic message. He probably visited them in person, since the seer states that he who speaks walks between the seven golden candelabra[685], and in *Rv* 1, 20, the seven churches are identified with the seven golden candelabra. The order of the seven churches, beginning with Ephesus and ending with Laodicea, points to a precise circular route that the author may have taken to visit the communities.

We may also be certain that the author of the *Revelation* had an ascendency over these churches insofar as he presents himself as a voice authorised to exhort them, encourage them correct them, or congratulate them. The seer speaks on behalf of "him who is, who was and who is to come, from the seven spirits in his presence before his throne, and from Jesus Christ"[686]. His authority is also due to the fact that he "shares in the tribulation"[687] suffered by the Churches.

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681 Iren., *haer.,* 5, 33, 3.

682 Cf. E. Norelli, *Papia di Hierapolis,* 41.

683 Cf. Iren., *haer.,* 3, 11, 1–3; 4, 20, 11.

684 *Mk* 10, 35–40. This episode inspired liturgies in the early centuries and homilies on the occasion of the festivities in honour of these two apostles. John the Apostle was celebrated as a martyr, as indicated in ancient martyrologies such as the Carthaginian Calendar, the *Martyrologium Hieronymiamum* and in Gallican liturgical books. The date of its original commemoration was some days after Christmas, reaffirming that he was in fact counted among the martyrs, cf. M. Boismard, *Le martyre de Jean l'apôtre,* in (Cahiers de la Revue Biblique 35), 1996.

685 *Rv* 2, 1.

686 *Rv*, 1, 4–5.

687 *Rv* 1, 9.

In the case of the church of Smyrna, together with that of Philadelphia, they are the only ones which do not receive any words of *censure* regarding the quality of Christian life they are living from the author of the *Revelation*. We leave the commentary referred to this letter at theological level until the third part of this research; while for now, we wish to study in more detailthe identity of the personage to whom this letter was possibly addressed[688].

The prophetic message of *Rv* 2, 8–11 is addressed to the "angel of the Church of Smyrna" (τῷ ἀγγέλῳ τῆς ἐν Σμύρνῃ ἐκκλησίας). It is difficult to establish the identity of these "angels" to which the letters are addressed.

These angels may be identified as "bishops", in the most archaic sense of the term. The seven angels are identified with the seven stars that the Son of Man holds in his right hand[689]. In chapter one of the *Revelation,* the symbolism of seven stars in the right hand of the Son of Man has a cosmological meaning that alludes to his universal lordship in v. 16; however, in v. 20, the author makes another reading, this time of ecclesiological resonance. Some scholars declare that the angels are concrete human beings: messengers, delegates of the prophets or the bishops[690].

These angels may simply signify, "celestial guardians" of the churches. This is the most common meaning in the biblical tradition. Angels as beings who have the mission of looking after and helping persons and peoples[691]. Each Church may be under the protection of a guardian angel or archangel. In the literature of the Old Testament, the Apocrypha and pseudo-epigraphy, we find the names of seven of them: Uriel, Raphael, Raguel, Michael, Zerachiel, Gabriel and Remiel[692]. Nonetheless, the angels as supernatural creatures cannot be blamed for the shortcomings of their churches. This does not mean that understanding the angels as spiritual beings in these texts is wrong, only that their nominal value does not completely explain their symbolism.

Another consideration may be that these "angels" are the personification of the churches themselves. This hypothesis is strong insofar as all the messages are in the singular, despite being addressed to the communities. Nevertheless, the *Revelation* makes the distinction between angels and churches, identifying

688 For an extended and bibliographically updated commentary on this letter, cf. P. Prigent, *L'Apocalypse de Saint Jean,* 55–58; 113–117; 125–129.

689 Cf. *Rv* 1, 16; 1, 20.

690 Cf. D. Hill, *Prophecy and anti-episcopal Activity,* in *Journal of Ecclesiastical History* 34 (1983), 1–11.

691 Cf. *Da* 10, 13. 20. 21; 11, 1; 12, 1; *Si* 17, 17; *Mt* 19, 10; *Ac* 12, 15.

692 Cf. J. Massyngberde Ford, *Revelation* in *The Anchor Bible*, New York, 1975, 377.

them with the stars and the candelabra, respectively: "This is the explanation of the mystery of the seven stars which you have seen in my right hand and of the seven golden candelabra: the seven stars are the angels of the seven churches, and the candelabra are the seven churches"[693].

Another possibility is that these are literally "human messengers". "Messenger" is the first meaning of ἄγγελος, and the book could, in fact, be distributed through messengers delegated by the churches. However the objection is that is these "angels" are interpreted as simple "messengers", they are not in truth representatives of the community and, accordingly, would not be represented as "stars"[694].

Finally, there could be the possibility that the term is used in a complex and elusive way and that it makes reference to levels different from the existing ones for which no equivalent words exist since each one of these churches had a different organisation and the author of the *Revelation* does not wish to engage with any one in particular. This is above all the thesis of B. Müller who believes that the "angels" are a literary fiction which the author, apparently not familiarised with the ecclesiological structures, was obliged to create to avoid having to address himself to the leaders of the communities directly[695]. However, the thesis of B. Müller is difficult to sustain, since it is evident that the author of the *Revelation* is well acquainted with the situation of each of the churches to which he addresses himself. On the basis of *Rv* 22, 16: "I, Jesus, have sent my angel to make these revelations to you for the sake of the churches", E. Schüssler Fiorenza affirms that the "angels" are visionaries equivalent to the prophets in the communities[696].

It appears improbable that these "angels" are in fact the leading figures of the churches, since in most of the messages, except for Smyrna and Philadelphia, they are loaded with reproaches. It is rather difficult to imagine that the author would confront the leaders of the communities in such a personal way. However,

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693 *Rv* 1, 20.

694 Cf. *Rv* 1, 20.

695 Cf. B. Müller, *Judenchristentum und Paulinismus in Kleinasien*, in *Zur frühchristlichen Theologiegeschichte*, Gütersloh 1976.

696 Cf. E. Schüssler Fiorenza, *Apokalypsis and Propheteia; the Book of Revelation in the Context of early Christian prophecy,* in *The Book of Revelation: Justice and Judgement,* Philadelphia 1985, 133–156. For three particular studies on the theme of the identity of the "angels" in the *Revelation,* cf. L. Stuckenbruck, *Angel Veneration and Christology,* Tübingen 1995, 234–238; cf. C. Hemer, *The Letters to the Seven Churches of Asia,* 32–34, cf. D. Aune, *The "Angels" of the Seven Churches,* in *Revelation 1–5* (World Biblical Commentary, vol. 52), 1997, 108–112.

this does not mean that such leaders do not exist and that they are insensible to the prophetic words of the messages, which were undoubtedly proclaimed in liturgical assemblies: "Happy the man who reads this prophecy and happy those who listen to him if they treasure all that it says"[697]. The author has the hope, or the certainty, that the letters, or the whole book, will be the object of a reading within worship[698].

In conclusion, insofar as the configuration of the leaders of the Church of Smyrna is concerned, we may affirm that the author of the *Revelation* was personally acquainted with the reality of the community of Smyrna and enjoyed ascendency over it and those who directed it. This community, unlike the other churches of Asia Minor, has a good reputation in the eyes of the author of the *Revelation,* although he warns it of the imminent danger of a persecution against it. For the rest, we have no certainty that the "angel" of the Church of Smyrna can in fact be identified with a historic figure.

As regards the author of the *Revelation,* we consider plausible M. Simonetti's thesis that the *Revelation* was composed by an Asiatic writer at the end of the first century or beginning of the second century who had recourse to the name and authority of the apostle John, and despite the fact that the communities to whom he addressed himself could see beyond the pseudonym, these accepted his authority insofar as they considered him the depository and continuator of the authority of the apostle John[699].

4. The bishop Polycarp

Polycarp, certainly the most outstanding figure of the Christian community in the history of Smyrna, must have been born in about the 70s of the first century, since he died a martyr at 86 years of age in about the year 155[700].

The *Life of Polycarp* which shares the characteristics proper to the intellectual and philosophical biographies of Antiquity, like that of Apollonius of Tyana by Philostratus, written a few decades earlier, in about the year 250, offers classic elements of this literary genre such as a mysterious origin of the personage, miraculous happenings, skill in predicting the future, emphasis on the simplicity of usages, in the option for a celibate life, particular devotion to study from an early age, and the description of a physical figure and an admirable character.

697 R*v* 1, 3.
698 Cf. P. Prigent, *L'Apocalypse de Saint Jean,* 86.
699 Cf. M. Simonetti, *Paolo nell'Asia cristiana del II secolo,* 127 note 12.
700 Cf. E. Norelli, *Papia di Hierapolis,* 41.

All of these elements have an ethical purpose and the intention of positioning the personage as a model to be imitated in a concrete community[701]. In the case of the *Life of Polycarp,* this even has the aim of placing the Christian personage above the pagan referents of the age. Accordingly, all the biographical elements on Polycarp given by this source must be analysed. Bearing this in mind, we must doubt the historicity of a large part of them.

The *Life of Polycarp* tells how he arrived as a child in a prodigious way in the city of Smyrna coming from the East[702]. This supposed Eastern origin is apparently intentional on the basis of the author's words further on: "those who live in the East are men to whom wisdom comes naturally, if there be any such, and given to study of the divine Scriptures"[703].

Later on, a pious woman named Callista, in a supposed night vision, received the order from the Lord by means of an angel to go to the gate named Ephesia and buy the child named Polycarp whom two men would sell to her. The woman hurried out from her home and did as the angel commanded. She took the child back home with her, used him in her domestic service and brought him up as a Christian. The child's intelligence, good conduct and piety led her to love him like a son, so that she put him in charge of her goods[704].

In this story, we are told that when the child was bought by Callista, someone called Bucolus was bishop of Smyrna. Throughout the whole story, bishop Bucolus appears as Polycarp's mentor and, on the latter's death, Polycarp is presented as his successor[705]. The *Life of Polycarp* gives news of the place where he was buried, the cemetery of Smyrna situated in front of the royal gate of Ephesus[706], but apart from what is reported in this text, we find no further mention of bishop Bucolus in any other source, so we cannot be sure that he was in fact a historic figure.

On the death of Callista, according to the *Vita,* Polycarp inherited all her property[707]. Thereafter, Polycarp increased in virtue, in devotion and in knowledge of

701 Cf. C. Talbot, *Biographies of Philosophers and Rulers as Instruments of Religious Propaganda in Mediterranean Antiquity,* in *Aufstieg und Niedergang der Römischen Welt* II, 16. 2, ed. W. Haase, Berlin 1978, 1619–1651, especially 1620–1624.

702 Cf. *V. Polyc.*, 3, 2.

703 *V. Polyc.,* 6, 1.

704 *V. Polyc.,* 3, 2–5.

705 *V. Polyc.,* 10, 2–6; 12, 2; 17, 2–4; 20, 2–4.

706 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 20, 4.

707 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 5, 7.

the Scriptures[708], taking care of the needy and living a sober life, with simplicity in his clothing and food[709]. Polycarp appears endowed with prudence of soul, fine deportment and a manly gaze[710]. Due to his shyness, he was filled with shame and blushed when anyone fixed their eyes on his face, and tried to elude and escape from those who arrived to converse with him. For this reason, he lived a very quiet life and did not attend public or famous places. Rather, he stayed at home and went out of town now and then[711]. In the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* it is also said that the martyr fled to a small farm some way out of the city persuaded by the brethren before they came to seize him[712].

The *Life of Polycarp* also refers to the fact that Polycarp embraced celibacy, refusing to impede his religious quest by contracting the inseparable ties that family life entailed[713]. All of thisenews, and especially those concerning the good works of Polycarp, reached the ears of bishop Bucolus, so that he decided to add him to the ranks of the deacons and persuaded him to teach the catechesis[714]. On his inclusion in the ranks of the deacons, the text gives an important liturgical description: bishop Bucolus "was also worthy of covering that head with his hand and blessing that soul with his mouth"[715]. This is a unique testimony on the rite of diaconal ordination in the early centuries, together with the instructions appearing in the *Traditio apostolica.*

As the years passed and Polycarp's first white hairs appeared, bishop Bucolus decided to ordain him a presbyter. As a presbyter he distinguished himself by his reading and explanation of the Scriptures, and on occasion confronting the errors of the Jews, Gentiles and heretics[716]. Before he died, Bucolus conveyed by unmistakable signs his desire for Polycarp to succeed him. On Bucolus' death, Polycarp presided over the offering of bread for him and all the departed[717]. With the bishops gathered from all over the region, they deliberated on the future rector

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708 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 6, 3. As in other *vitae,* the personage shows a particular devotion to study from a young age, cf. Philostr., *Apoll.,* 1, 7.

709 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 6, 4; cf. Philostr., *Apoll.,* 1,8; 1, 31; 1, 35.

710 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 7, 2; in other *vitae,* a description is given of his voice, gestures and appearance, cf. Philostr., *Apoll.,* 1, 17.

711 Cf. Polyc., 7, 1–4.

712 Cf. *M. Polyc.*, 5. 1.

713 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 9, 1–6; cf. Philostr., *Apoll.,* 1, 13.

714 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 11–12.

715 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 11, 2.

716 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 17–20.

717 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 20.

of the Church of Smyrna. Having read the epistles of Timothy and Titus in which the Apostle describes the profile of the future bishop, and having ascertained the unanimous will of the people, they elevated Polycarp to the dignity of bishop despite his many supplications and his wish to forego such an honour[718].

These reports of ordination in the *Life of Polycarp* and the *cursus honorum* of the man himself offer a doubtless series of liturgical elements worthy of consideration of theological character on Smyrna in the third century in which they were probably written; however, we will be making such considerations in the third part[719]. For the moment, it is clear that the elements provided by the *Life of Polycarp,* for reconstructing the profile of this second-century historic figure are difficult to evaluate, since some elements of the life are possibly historical, while others are certainly legendary and yet others are anachronistic. So that these elements must not impinge on the relationship of John with Polycarp, absent in the *Life,* but testified by tradition[720], and which we will prepare to study hereafter.

There exists the late news that when Domitian was murdered in the year 96, the apostle John was released from his exile in Patmos under the government of Nerva[721], and Eusebius states that he returned safe and sound to Ephesus[722], where he survived until after the ascension of Trajan in the year 98[723]. This news, difficult to evaluate historically, would appear to fit in with possible visits by John to the principal cities of the province of Asia as affirmed in the apochryphal *Acts of John.* In them, we read the suggestion made to John in Ephesus by the Christians of Miletus that he should go to Smyrna: "We have stayed a long time in Ephesus. If you see fit we will go to Smyrna, since we have heard that God's great doings have reached as far as there"[724]; his desire to do so; to which John answered: "Men, believe me, it was for your sakes that I stayed on in the city of Ephesus, although I had the intention of going to Smyrna and other cities so that there too the servants of Christ might be converted to Him"[725]; and the official petition sent by the citizens of Smyrna, asking him to visit and preach to them: "While John carried out all these actions in the city of Ephesus, the Smyrnaeans

718 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 21–23.
719 Cf. Cypr. *ep.* 55, 8, 2 (ed. C. Moreschini, 2007, 34).
720 This is a fact sustained by Irenaeus and accepted by Tertullian, Eusebius, Hieronymus, Gregory of Tours, etc.
721 Cf. *Chron. Pasch.,* 251.
722 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 4, 1.
723 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 3, 23, 4; Iren., *haer.,* 2, 22, 5; 3, 3, 4; Clem. *q.d.s.,* 42, 1 (SCh 537, 208).
724 *Act. Io.,* 37.
725 *Act. Io.,* 45.

sent him some delegates, who spoke thus: 'We have heard that you preach a generous God who ordered you not to feel preference for any place. Accordingly, being a herald of this divinity, come to Smyrna and to the other cities so that we can know your God, and knowing him find hope in him'"[726].

Clement of Alexandria, in a work written around 205, tells in great detail, a story on the days John spent in the places around Ephesus after his supposed return from Patmos[727]. The story narrates how John, looking the bishop in the eyes, commended to him a young man, not very tall, of elegant appearance and fiery soul. The bishop took him into his care and baptised him, but later neglected the young man so that the latter fell into bad habits and went away to the mountains to live as a highwaymen, even becoming the head of a band of robbers. When John, on his following visit, heard from the bishop what had happened to the young man, he took his horse and went out to look for him to the place where he found him, and after persuading him with great effort to return to the straight path, finally the young man repented, and John once more led him back to the bosom of the church, where he set a great example of repentance and regeneration. In agreement with Clement, the city where this happened was not far from Ephesus and some even mention its name[728]; however, we are not informed of it.

In the Byzantine *Chronicon Paschale* of the year 628, it appears that this city was Smyrna and that the date of this event was 101. Nonetheless, the lateness of this connection merely serves to show the recurrent tradition of associating John with Asia Minor and the importance of Smyrna in the area[729].

In agreement with Irenaeus, who as a young man lived and listened to Polycarp, the bishop of Smyrna "was not only instructed by apostles and lived with many who had seen the Lord, but was likewise instituted bishop of Asia by apostles, in the church of Smyrna…, and there are those who heard him say that John, the disciple of the Lord, going to Ephesus to bathe and having seen Cerinthus inside, jumped out of the baths all wet and said: 'Let us flee, that the baths also do not tumble down owing to the presence in them of Cerinthus, enemy of truth'"[730]. Writing a little later, towards the year 190, Irenaeus says that he can

726 *Act. Io.,* 55.

727 Cf. Clem., *q.d.s.,* 42, 1–15 (SCh 537, 208–220); this story is also told by Eus., *h. e.* 3, 5–19; cf. V. Grossi, *Nota sulla pastorale giovanile nella Chiesa antica. A proposito di un diverbio tra l'apostolo Giovanni e un vescovo locale asiatico (Clemente Alessandrino,* salvetur *42,1–15),* in *Lateranum* 71 (2005), 313–318.

728 Cf. Clem., *q.d.s.,* 42, 7 (SCh 537, 212).

729 Cf. *Chron. Pasch.,* 251.

730 Irenaeus, *haer.,* 3, 3, 4; the story is also told by Eus., *h. e.* 4, 14, 3–6.

clearly remember how Polycarp "described his relations with John and with the others who had seen the Lord and how he remembered the words of some or other of them; and that was what he had heard from them regarding the Lord, his miracles and his teaching; and how Polycarp, after having received him from these eyewitnesses of the life of the Word, told him everything in harmony with the Scriptures"[731]. Approximately around the year 200, Tertullian, presumibly basing himself on Irenaeus, declares that "the church of the Smyrnaeans affirms that Polycarp was ordained bishop by John"[732]. Gregory of Tours in the sixth century states that "in Asia the persecution broke out and the blessed Polycarp was consecrated to God in the fire, as a very pure holocaust, in the eightieth year of his age, a disciple of John, the apostle and evangelist"[733].

Most of these declarations which link John with both Smyrna and with Polycarp are open to discussion, as appropriate. The author of the *Acts of John* shows a supine lack of acquaintance with the area of Asia Minor, so that his mention of Smyrna in this context may be merely accidental. The *Chronicon Paschale* is a late source. Tertullian and Gregory, presumibly depend on Irenaeus, and Eusebius merely transcribes the letters of Irenaeus in which this news is reported. Apart from that, it is surprising that neither Polycarp's letter *To the Philippians,* nor the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* nor the *Life of Polycarp,* make any mention of John as mentor of the bishop of Smyrna.

Accordingly, the testimony of Irenaeus on Polycarp's connection with John appears to be the only reliable source. In his letter *To Florinus,* Irenaeus referring to him living together with Polycarp, says that he remembers "how he described his relations with John and with the others who had seen the Lord and how he remembered the words of some or other of them", and he goes on to affirm that he had received all of this from "those eyewitnesses of the life of the Word"[734]. Irenaeus does not appear to know any other John than the apostle.

Various arguments have been adduced as possible difficulties in accepting the news given by Irenaeus as certain:

First of all, Irenaeus could have an interest in including this fact of the relationship of Polycarp with John to increase his own credibility as heir to the teaching of a direct disciple of one of the apostles. From 180 onwards, when Irenaeus gives his testimony and develops his doctrine, for doctrinal reasons, against Gnosticism above all, there begins a period of decisive change in Christianity,

731 Cf. Iren., *ep. Flor.,* in Eus., *h. e.* 5, 20, 6.

732 Cf. Tert., *praescr.,* 32, 2 (SCh 46, 130–132); cf. Hier., *vir. ill.,* 17 (PL 23, 667).

733 Cf. Gr. Tur., *h.,* 1, 28.

734 Cf. Iren., *ep. Flor., in Eus., h. e.* 5, 20, 6.

in which each local church is already directed solidly by a bishop, and has an identity of faith, ethics and worship, and an organisation of its own[735]. However, in favour of the testimony of Irenaeus is the fact that the declared relationship of master and disciple between John and Polycarp was a public declaration which might well have been liable to contestation by his gnostic adversaries like Florinus, and yet was not disputed[736].

Secondly, it may be adduced that the ministerial terminology of Irenaeus, at the end of the second century, still remains uncertain, since he uses the terms "presbyter" and "bishop" to indicate the same function: "It is necessary to obey the presbyters who are in the Church because they are the successors of the apostles, as we have demonstrated, and with the succession of the episcopacy they have received the sure charism of truth according to the Father's approbation"[737]. Notwithstanding, it is necessary to note that Irenaeus refers this uncertainty of the terms "presbyter" and "bishop" to when he is specifically speaking of the case of the Church of Rome which is particulaly slow in assuming a structure of strong episcopal arrangement at the end of the second century, which on the contrary, is already widespread in the East[738].

Thirdly, Polycarp's silence regarding John in the letter *To the Philippians* has been objected. Nonetheless, apart from the fact that this is the only writing we still have of the bishop of Smyrna, and possibly in others he may have made explicit allusion to this relationship, the omission regarding John could be explained because this letter was addressed to a community founded by Paul, an authority which Polycarp mentions for obvious reasons[739].

Fourthly, mention is also made of the silence on John in other sources concerning Polycarp. However, such silences are likewise justifiable. In the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* the omission of John, as of any other apostle, may be explained because this source has the aim of telling only the last moments in the martyr's life. Finally, the silence regarding John in the *Life of Polycarp* may be explained by the anti-Quartodecimanism present in the writing which omits the whole relationship of Polycarp with both the defence of the date for Easter of 14 Nisan and with the foundation above all others of that tradition, John and his gospel.

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735 Cf. E. Prinzivalli, *Questioni di Storia del Cristianesimo Antico I–IV sec.,* Rome 2009, 166.

736 Cf. Iren., *ep. Flor.,* in Eus., *h. e.* 5, 20, 4–8.

737 Iren., *haer.,* 4, 26, 2.

738 Cf. M. Simonetti, *Il Vangelo e la storia,* 107.

739 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 3, 2; 11, 2. 3.

For the rest, as we have already said repeatedly, the historical news provided by this source should be accepted with extreme caution.

So that the testimony of Irenaeus would seem to maintain its validity. A relationship of Polycarp with John in Asia Minor is feasible, although not totally demonstrable. A possible visit by John to Smyrna, or by Polycarp to Ephesus, and a "promotion" by John of Polycarp to assume greater reponsibilities in the community may be a plausible hypothesis, though not unquestionably backed up by the sources.

In any case, it is certain that Polycarp came to head an episcopate[740] in Smyrna some time before the visit by Ignatius to this community in about the year 115. During the stay in Smyrna of the bishop of Antioch in Syria, on the way to his martyrdom in Rome, he not only received a cordial welcome from bishop Polycarp and the community, but was visited by bishop Onesimus, the deacon Burrhus, and a further three representatives of the community of Ephesus[741], bishop Damas, the

740 As regards the institution of the Episcopacy in its first centuries scholars such as P. Rebilco, Ch. Trevett and E. Prinzivalli have used the term "monoepiscopacy", distinguishing it from the term "monarchian episcopacy". Understanding by the former, more or less that corresponding to the second century, in which the bishop is little more than a *primus inter pares* and which corresponds to the situation described in the epistolary of Ignatius of Antioch. Whereas, by monarchian episcopacy these scholars have understood the institutionalisation of the pre-eminent position of the bishop, as appears in the works of Cyprian of Carthage, cf. E. Prinzivalli *Questioni di Storia del Cristianesimo Antico I–IV sec.,* 153–154; cf. Ch. Trevett, *A Study of Ignatius of Antioch in Syria and Asia,* Lewiston 1992, 202–203; cf. P. Trebilco, *The Early Christians in Ephesus,* 642 and note 63. M. Simonetti affirms that in a first stage, the praxis of the Jewish synagogues had a strong influence over the institutions of the early Christian community, with the imposition likewise in this context of the presbyteral structure, which assigned the government of a community to a college of elders. This hierarchical structure was at first imposed in the Christian communities having a strong judaising influence, but soon, already by the end of the first century, it was in force in communities of Pauline extraction, although this structure was not destined to last. In communities of Pauline ascendency or where the presence of ethno-Christians was strong, a form of monarchian system was imposed, in the person of the bishop, designated for such office by all the members of the community. This figure of the bishop was in contrast to that of the college of presbyters, separate from it and imposed over it, so as in fact to become the effective leader of the community, enjoying what was in effect monarchian authority. Obviously this take-over would not have been peaceful and the sources enable us to glimpse the situation of conflict created by this process, cf. M. Simonetti, *Il Vangelo e la storia,* 44–45.

741 Cf. Ign., *Eph.,* 1, 3–2, 1.

presbyters Bassus and Apollonius and the deacon Sotion from the community of Magnesia[742], as well as of bishop Polybius from the community of Tralles[743]. From these elements and the subsequent letter of Ignatius *To Polycarp* and the latter's letter *To the Philippians,* we note the existence of an episcopate in Asia Minor, and particularly in Smyrna, which effectively exerted a prime role of leadership in the community. Although it is natural that the gradual imposition of the bishop's figure over the college of presbyters was not without conflicts. In any case, already in the first few decades of the second century in Asia Minor we find set up, even though still contested, an ecclesial organisation stratified in three levels: at the head the bishop, with extensive power though assisted by the cooperation of the college of presbyters, coming under him, and at a lower level the order of the deacons.

The figure of the bishop as delineated in the *Pastoral epistles* may give a good idea of the bishop at the beginning of the second century in Asia Minor[744]. These post-Pauline letters thought to have been written in this period and in the region of Asia Minor[745], probably in Ephesus, propend for a certain ecclesial system. In all the cities, *presbyters* or *elders* had to be appointed having the function of supervisors. Accordingly, this function included supervising the religious and ethical conduct of the members of the community, caring for the needy using their common goods and, above all, ensuring a healthy doctrine. They had to keep what they had received[746], correcting any false masters. A college of presbyters existed, which by the imposition of hands, transmitted a permanent charism[747]. One of the most important functions of the presbyters and deacons was governing and teaching[748].

In any case, the episcopate of Polycarp was in full process of consolidation and maturation at the time of Ignatius' visit. This is clear because Ignatius instructed Polycarp on how to celebrate an assembly worthy of God in which to choose a delegate to be sent to Syria[749]. Likewise, in a letter addressed to the whole church of Smyrna he made the same request[750]. The fact that a delegate is not merely selected by the bishop at least shows that the latter's decisions, in a certain way,

742 Cf. Ign., *Magn.,* 2.
743 Cf. Ign., *Trall.,* 1, 1.
744 Cf. E. Norelli, *Papia di Hierapolis,* 37, note 20.
745 Cf. M. Simonetti, *Paolo nell'Asia cristiana del II secolo,* 127 note 13.
746 Cf. *Ti* 1, 5–9.
747 Cf. *1 Tm* 4, 14.
748 Cf. *1 Tm* 5, 17–18.
749 Cf. Ign., *Polyc.,* 7, 2.
750 Cf. Ign., *Smyr.,* 11, 2. He makes the same request to the church of Philadelphia, asking them to choose a deacon, cf. Ign., *Philad.,* 10, 1.

cannot be taken without consulting the community[751], especially in this case in which the economic contribution of the community was certainly required for sending such a delegate. Even so, for Ignatius, the bishop must be revered as a figure of the Father, and the deacons as the figure of Jesus Christ[752]. For Ignatius, it was not licit to baptise or to celebrate the Eucharist without the bishop[753]. The presbyters must be revered, as the senate of God and as the assembly of the apostles[754], and certain of them could be authorised in the church of Smyrna to preside the Eucharist[755].

Everything referring to the vision of Ignatius on the community of Smyrna and the theological lines to be drawn from the *corpus Ignatianum* will be the object of study in the third part of this research[756]. For the moment, we may conclude that at the time of the visit of Ignatius, Polycarp was the undisputed leader of the community of Smyrna, not without some drawbacks and dangers in the eyes of Ignatius.

This leadership and the definitive support of the episcopacy in Smyrna was consolidated little by little in the following years when Ignatius' doctrine was studied and copied in Smyrna and when Polycarp wrote *To the Philippians,* a letter in which he spoke with authority and advised on questions of a disciplinary nature. Even so, Polycarp addressed himself to the church of the Philippians on behalf of himself and the presbyters who were with him[757]. In the letter, Polycarp counsels the community regarding the case of the presbyter Valens to whom, it seems, an important place in the community had been conferred[758], but who absconded with the money. He also takes advantage of the circumstance and makes the introduction to them of Crescentius and his sister[759].

At a mature age, Polycarp visited Rome as representative not only of Smyrna but of Asia in order to speak of the question of Easter with bishop Anicetus[760]. As noted in the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* by the time of his death, the latter already

751 Cf. P. Trebilco, *The Early Christians in Ephesus,* 642, note 63.
752 Cf. Ign., *Trall.,* 3, 1; *Smyrn.,* 8, 1.
753 Cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 8, 2.
754 Cf. Ign., *Trall.,* 3, 1.
755 Cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 8, 1.
756 Cf. pp. 270 et seqq.
757 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* praef.
758 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 11, 1.
759 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 14.
760 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 4, 14, 5.

enjoyed a special devotion[761] and was recognised as "apostolic and prophetic master, bishop of the catholic Church of Smyrna"[762]. This is the first time that the adjective "apostolic" is attributed to a person, although this adjective should be understood not necessarily in the strict sense of successor of the apostles, but of he who carries out the task proper to an apostle[763].

In conclusion, we may affirm that with Polycarp of Smyrna, the community of Smyrna acquires a firm structure and that the institution of the episcopacy, already existing before the visit of Ignatius to Smyrna, is made good progressively in the course of Polycarp's life, beginning by the self-awareness that the bishop and martyr develops of his ministry throughout his life and of his teaching.

5. The successsors of Polycarp

On his death, Polycarp, once the persecution had passed[764], left a solid community with outstanding figures on the theological plane. Polycarp was the twelfth to suffer martyrdom in Smyrna together with the brothers from Philadelphia. In the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* we also hear of the brave martyr Germanicus[765], one of the twelve martyrs, and a woman called Alce[766], with a Christian faith in contrast with the evident enmity of her brother Herod and of her father Nicetas towards the Christians[767].

Moreover, at the end of the text, two persons are also referred to by name: "You asked us to explain the facts to you in detail, but for the moment we will inform you of the principal one through our brother Marcion… Greetings from those

761 Cf. *M. Polyc*., 13, 2.

762 Cf. *M. Polyc*., 16. 2.

763 Cf. E. Prinzivalli, *Questioni di Storia del Cristianesimo Antico I–IV sec.,* 164.

764 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 1, 1.

765 Cf. *M. Polyc.*, 3, 1; 19, 1.

766 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 17, 2. This personage also appears to be this same Christian woman greeted twice by Ignatius using the same greeting "Alce, a name to me sweet" (Ἄλκην, τὸ ποθητόν μοι ὄνομα), cf. Ign., *Smyr.,* 13, 2; *Polyc.,* 8, 3. It is clear that Ignatius wants to greet her, since in his letter *To Polycarp* he remembers her and includes her later in a comprehensive string of greetings. The name Alce is fairly rare: only twice do we find it in CIG, one of which (CIG 7064) in Smyrna. Following the testimony in *M. Polyc.,* 17, 2, we have in Alce an interesting case of a divided family in the manner of *Mt* 10, 35. However, V. Saxer believes that this is an interpolation, cf. V. Saxer, *L'authenticité du 'Martyre de Polycarpe': Bilan de 25 ans de critique,* in *Mélanges d'archéologie et d'histoire* 94 (1982) 993.

767 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 17, 2.

who are with us and Evaristus, the scribe (ὁ γράψας), with his whole family"[768]. As regards the writing of this letter, it has always been presumed that Marcion was the author, while Evaristus was the scribe. However, B. Dehandschutter has maintained that the author of the letter was Evaristus and that Marcion was merely an eyewitness who endorsed the writing[769].

The theological competence of the author of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* whether Marcion or Evaristus, is unquestionable, and it may be supposed that he occupied a position of leadership in the community, since he acts as spokesman for the whole Church of Smyrna in reporting the events in a circular letter that he sends, first of all, to the Church of the Philomelians in Phrygia, in the hope that this document may be passed on even further by it[770]. We know from the appendix of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* that a copy reached Irenaeus in Lyons, transcribed thereafter by Gaius companion of Irenaeus, and that later in Corinth Socrates transcribed the copy made by Gaius[771].

In the *Life of Polycarp,* Daphnus appears as bishop of Teos[772]. According to this narration, Polycarp visited Daphnus twice at the time of a famine experienced by the local bishop and population, and there he performed miracles, multiplying the food. On his second visit, Polycarp also multiplied the wine; however, brought to an end by the ridicule of a servant girl. This whole picturesque scene is interesting as an illustration of the rural poverty of that time. For the rest, the name of the bishop Δάφνος comes from δαψίλεια which means liberality or prodigality. This figure might be related with the "incomparable Daphnus"[773] whom Ignatius greeted years before when writing his letter to the Church of Smyrna and who in the *Life of Polycarp* appears in some way to be a disciple of Polycarp. Nonetheless, the events in the *Life of Polycarp* should once more be accepted with extreme caution. B. Lightfoot states that Daphnus was probably one

768 *M. Polyc.,* 20.

769 Cf. B. Dehandschutter, *Martyrium Polycarpi. Een literair-kritische studie,* Leuven 1979, 280.

770 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 20, 1.

771 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 22, 2.

772 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 25, 2. Teos is a city only 36 kilometres from Smyrna on the southern coast of the Clazomenae peninsula, the present-day *Urla.* In any case, one difficulty in identifying the place is that the text of the *Vita* states that certain baths called Lebedus were sited there; B. Lightfoot pointed out that Lebedus is a village over 80 kilometres from Teos and thinks that the correct spelling should be Lebadus. Thus, he concludes that perhaps Lebedus is in fact the name of the baths in Teos and not in some other village, cf. B. Lightfoot, *The Apostolic Fathers,* 456.

773 Cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 13, 2.

of the leaders of Smyrna at the time of Ignatius' visit, and that it is from his letter that the author of the *Life of Polycarp* may have taken the name[774].

Another possible disciple of Polycarp seems to have been Crescentius, who was entrusted with carrying Polycarp's letter to the Church of Philippi. J. Rius-Camps has proposed the hypothesis that Crescentius was sent by Polycarp to cover the post left vacant on the defection of Valens, who was probably the bishop of that community or at least one of its presbyters and who ran off with his wife and the community's money[775].

In the *Life of Polycarp* the names of other possible disciples of Polycarp appear. There it is stated that the bishop of Smyrna "likewise established deacons, including one named Camerius, who was the third bishop after him, succeeding Papinius. With him as companion, Polycarp went out into the field, since he was also concerned with the churches scattered among the villages"[776].

The *Life of Polycarp,* makes only this short mention of Papinius, almost as a bridge to thereafter introduce the figure of Camerius, on whom the author gives abundant details in various chapters, telling of the adventures that Polycarp experienced together with this deacon, with both of them surviving even the collapse of an inn, thanks to the fact that an angel woke Polycarp to warn him of the impending danger[777].

For his part, this Papinius, to whom the *Life of Polycarp* devotes just this brief comment, is mentioned as a Quartodecimanist by Polycrates towards the end of the second century within the list that the bishop of Ephesus draws up of the luminaries of Asia. Undoubtedly, Papinius was not martyred since Polycrates makes no mention of this, while he does inform us of the martyrdom of others. Polycrates mentions only the martyrdom of John, of Polycarp, Strataeas and

774 Cf. B. Lightfoot, *The Apostolic Fathers,* 457.

775 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 14. Cf. J. Rius-Camps, *La Carta de Policarpo a los Filipenses, ¿aval de la recopilación "Policarpiana" o credenciales del nuevo obispo Crescente?,* in E. Romero Posé, *Pléroma,* Salus Carnis. *Homenaje a Antonio Orbe.* Santiago de Compostela 1990, 160–161. Insufficient information is forthcoming to positively assert that the community of Philippi had undergone a hierarchical crisis similar to that of Corinth. However it is probable that the community of Philippi had set up a presbyteral structure which lasted right up to the time of Valens, cf. M. Simonetti, *Il Vangelo e la storia, 89.*

776 *V. Polyc.,* 27, 1. B. Lightfoot considers the succession of Polycarp by Papinius followed by Camerius to be perfectly credible, cf. B. Lightfoot, *The Apostolic Fathers,* 564.

777 *V. Polyc.,* 27, 2, 9.

Sagaris[778]. For the rest, the fact that the clearly antiquartodecimanist author of the *Life of Polycarp* hardly mentions Papinius, without giving further details on him, since he was a wellknown Quartodecimanist as we know from Polycrates, may be a proof of the historicity of this personage and of his connection with the Church of Smyrna as the true successor of Polycarp. The *Life of Polycarp*, despite its imaginative happenings, allows us to glimpse the importance of this figure, since even though Quartodecimanist his name is not omitted, although neither is any further news on him provided, and even less reference is made to his affiliation with this liturgical practice.

In its turn, the fact that the *Life of Polycarp* ascribes such importance to Camerius, depicting him as a faithful companion of Polycarp, and the omission that Polycrates makes in his turn of this name amongst the defenders of the Quartodecimanist practice, points to the possibility that Camerius was the first bishop of Smyrna who was not Quartodecimanist.

By the time in which Polycrates writes, in about 190, certain churches of Quartodecimanist tradition may have started to abandon this practice. Tension with the church of Rome could possibly have had effects in certain communities. Irenaeus, who as a young man lived in Smyrna, already by the time he was living on the other side of the Empire, has abandoned the Quartodecimanist practice which undoubtedly he had celebrated in Smyrna together with Polycarp. In Gaul, Irenaeus celebrated "only on Sunday the mystery of the Lord's resurrection"[779]. For his part, Eusebius in the *Life of Constantine* affirms that for the Council of Nicaea the Quartodecimanist practice had already fallen into disuse in many parts of the Empire, and even explicitly mentions among others the diocesis of Asia[780]. So that there are indications that the Quartodecimanist practice in Smyrna had possibly fallen into disuse quite early on, towards the end of the second century, although clearly we have no means of proving this.

The fact that it was Polycrates bishop of Ephesus and not the bishop of Smyrna of the time, who acted as spokesman for the bishops of Asia, suggests this possibility, especially when Smyrna was under Polycarp champion of the Quartodecimanist practice in the period[781]. It is clear that the fact that it was this time the bishop of Ephesus who spoke on behalf of the churches of Asia, and

778 Cf. Polychr., *Ep. Vict.* in Eus., *h. e.* 5, 24, 3–5. Sagaris was a bishop laid to rest in Laodicea, who suffered martyrdom under the consul of Asia Servilius Paulus in about 166 to 168, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 4, 26, 3.

779 Eus., *h. e.* 5, 24, 11.

780 Cf. Eus., *v. C.,* 3, 19, 1.

781 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 24, 16–17.

not the bishop of Smyrna, should not lead us immediately to conclude that this church had abandoned this liturgical practice. It is also true that, of the list of names mentioned, these are all persons who were already dead at that time. So that, since we are certain of the existence of Camerius, it is probable that he was bishop of Smyrna at the time when Polycrates was defending the Quartodecimanist practice and consequently he is not named in the list; however, this does not necessarily mean that Camerius had distanced himself from the antiQuartodecimanist practice.

Certainly, as we have seen, there are at least indications of the possibility that Camerius was the first non-Quartodecimanist bishop of Smyrna, if we consider that one of the intentions of the author of the *Life of Polycarp* is to distance himself from, or at least omit, the relationship of the church of Smyrna with the Quartodecimanist practice, in view of which he dedicated so much space to Camerius in contrast with the passing mention of Papinius. Nevertheless, we find ourselves once more in the presence of only a possibility, without being able to assert it absolutely, since all the indications given are disputable to some extent.

From the names of Papinius and Camerius plus the facts concerning them, together with the invaluable testimony of Irenaeus at the end of the second century when, referring to the teaching of Polycarp and his relationship with the apostles, he states that "to all of this witness is given by all the Churches of Asia and those which until now have succeeded Polycarp"[782], we may infer that the Church of Smyrna after Polycarp's martyrdom continued to consolidate the institution of the Episcopate. Or at least it would appear so up until the time of Camerius, after which – as we will examine hereafter – the Church of Smyrna seems to have entered a period of profound crisis.

A special comment should be made on the figure of Strataeas, martyred in about the year 160, who is mentioned in three ancient documents, two transmitted by Eusebius and the third in the *Life of Polycarp.* The first of these is the controversy of the apologist Apollonius against Montanus which mentions Strataeas as one of the martyrs of that time[783]. The second is the letter of Polycrates to Pope Victor, of which we have already made mention, and which states that Strataeas was a bishop and martyr, coming from Eumenia[784] and whose remains now repose in Smyrna. Polycrates places Strataeas in the group of outstanding

782 Iren., *haer.,* 3, 3, 4; cf. Eus*., h. e.* 4, 14, 5.

783 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 18, 14.

784 Present-day *Çyvril,* 280 kilometres east of Smyrna.

figures who defended the Quartodecimanist celebration of Easter right into his time[785]. Finally, the *Life of Polycarp* makes mention of Strataeas when speaking of the place where Bucolus, the supposed predecessor of Polycarp, was buried: "The body of Bucolus… was laid to rest in the place where the myrtle now grows that sprouted after the burial of the martyr Strataeas"[786]. It should be noted that only the testimony of Polycrates mentions that Strataeas was a bishop. Once more, the absence of this news in the *Life of Polycarp* constitutes one further proof of the aversion to the Quartodecimanist tradition of its author who undoubtedly, as in the case of his passing mention of Papinius, in this case felt obliged to name the personage on account of his historic importance but avoided giving details of his Quartodecimanist tradition. No enlightenment is to be found on the relationship of Strataeas with the Church of Smyrna, nor why his body is buried there and not in Eumenia. Perhaps he was an important leader in Smyrna after Polycarp's death, or might have been transferred to and condemned in that city since Smyrna was bound by a *conventus iuridicus*. The possibility that his mortal remains were transferred from his native city to Smyrna would seem anachronistic, since the transfer of bodies belongs to a later age. Even so, the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* testifies to the honour and veneration in which relics were held in Smyrna, at least as far as those of Polycarp are concerned[787].

6. Missionary Smyrna in the middle of the second century

Apart from all this, the Christian community of Smyrna seems to have been a missionary church and even the mother church of the Church of Lyons. There is a clear relationship of the churches of Asia and Phrygia with the churches of the Rhone valley in Gaul. In about the year 180 A.D. the churches of Lyons and Vienna transmitted the letter to them regarding the martyrs who suffered the persecution of Marcus Aurelius[788]. This letter must have reached Smyrna shortly after the earthquake of the year 177 or 178. Apparently many of these martyrs were of Asiatic and Phrygian origin. One of them was the Roman citizen Attalus, from Pergamum, who was pillar and base of the community among other things[789].

785 Cf. *Eus., h. e.* 5, 24, 4 and 6.
786 *V. Polyc.,* 20, 4.
787 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 18, 1–3.
788 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 1, 1–63; 5, 3, 1–4.
789 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 1, 17. 43–44. 47. 50. 52.

Irenaeus considered himself a direct disciple of Polycarp, and undoubtedly went down in history as the most famous fruit of the Church of Smyrna and one of the most important theologians of the second century. Irenaeus was very likely born in Smyrna some time between 135 and 155 as he himself refers; as a young man he attended Polycarp's school from about 145 to 150[790]. We do not know when he transferred from Asia Minor to Gaul, but, doubtless, this displacement coincided with the first developments of the Christian community of Lyons. Approximately around the year 177, as presbyter of the Church of Lyons, Irenaeus was sent by the community to carry a letter to Pope Eleutherius[791]. This mission saved him from martyrdom during the persecution of Marcus Aurelius in which at least 48 martyrs died, including bishop Photinus who died in captivity[792]. On his return to the city, he received the Episcopate of the Church of Lyons in succession[793], of which he was bishop until his death[794].

During his life as bishop of Lyons, Irenaeus seems to never have lost sight of his relationship with his native Smyrna. In fact, he manages to obtain a copy of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp*[795], bears witness to the churches of Asia and the successor of Polycarp in the orthodoxy of the Church as regards the errors of Marcion and Valentinius[796], defends the Quartodecimanist tradition of the churches of Asia before Pope Victor[797], and authorises the dispatch of the report on the persecution of the Christians in Gaul to them[798].

7. Crisis in the Church of Smyrna at the end of the second century

With the omission regarding the bishop of Smyrna made by Polycrates of Ephesus some time between 190 and 200 when he wrote to Pope Victor on the question of Easter, not only might we infer, as remarked earlier, that the Church of Smyrna ceased to be Quartodecimanist from a certain point onwards, but was not capable

790 Cf. Eus., 5, 20, 4–8.
791 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 4, 2.
792 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 1, 29–31.
793 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 5, 8.
794 Gregory of Tours, in a fairly late testimony, makes mention of the relationship between Polycarp and Irenaeus and of the possible martyrdom of the latter, cf. Gr. Tur., *h.,* 1, 29.
795 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 22, 2.
796 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 4, 14, 5.
797 Cf. Iren., *ep. Vict.,* in Eus., *h. e.* 5, 24, 12–17.
798 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 1, 1–63.

of assuming a leadership in the church of Asia Minor as it had at the time of Polycarp. If we were to add to this omission the death in about 200 of a certain Noetus coming from Smyrna, who had brought about a serious schism in the community and been expelled from it, then perhaps the time has come to analyse who this Noetus was and what role of responsibility he played in the Church of Smyrna.

The succession of the events narrated by Hippolytus[799] which led to this expulsion seem to indicate that Noetus, had first of all acted in not a very edifying way in certain things that he did (ἐκ τῶν ἑτέρων πράξεων), thus blaspheming the Holy Spirit and being expelled from the sacred inheritance (κλῆρος), since he claimed to be Moses, while his brother was Aaron.

We do not know exactly what Hippolytus refers to when he uses the expression "ἐκ τῶν ἑτέρων πράξεων". However, Hippolytus concludes that these apparently not very edifying "other acts" were inspired by an evil spirit. In an environment in which the Montanist movement had re-introduced the polemics on the authenticity of the prophetic charism, the related concept that it is the way of living which distinguishes the true from the false prophet, returned[800]. M. Simonetti, directly relates Noetus' claim to be Moses with the "other acts" to which Hippolytus refers. So that the actions are defined "other" than the subsequent spreading of the doctrine[801].

Insofar as the meaning of the term "κλῆρος", is understood as "clergy", it is already testified to at the time of Hippolytus[802]. However, at this time, the meaning of "inheritance" is also admissible, so that the expulsion of Noetus from the "sacred inheritance" (κλήρου ἁγίου) could also mean his definitive expulsion from the Church.

Considering this situation of strange *behaviour* and attribution of the identity of Moses, Noetus was first of all convoked by the presbyters to appear before the whole community on the basis of a first accusation. Then, it seems Noetus begged to be forgiven, thus avoiding a condemnation. Notwithstanding, shortly after this, Noetus spread his doctrine which stated that "Christ is the Father and that this same Father was generated, suffered and died"[803]. The theological implications of this doctrine of Noetus will be analysed in the third part[804]. For the moment it suffices to say that, in view of these new facts and declarations, the

799 Cf. Hipp., *CN* 1, 1–2, 8.
800 Cf. *Did.* 11, 7–12; Herm., *mand.*, 11, 7–16 (SCh 53bis, 194–197).
801 Cf. *Contro Noeto*, 195–196.
802 Cf. Clem., *q.d.s.,* 42 (SCh 537, 208–223) and Tert., *Monog.,* 12, 1 (SCh 343, 188).
803 Cf. Hipp., *CN* 1, 2.
804 Cf. pp. 307 et seqq.

presbyters once more convoked him to accuse him and condemned him definitively, expelling him from the Church.

This report by Hippolytus was written not long after the said condemnation of Noetus[805]. As regards the college of presbyters, which was the body that twice judged Noetus, it is surprising that Hippolytus makes no mention of the bishop of the community. As we have shown earlier, already from the time of Polycarp onwards, the institution of the Episcopacy was a consolidated reality in this community. Besides, it is clear that Noetus was a figure of importance in the Church, as shown by the fact that the judgments brought against him were made publicly and that his doctrine was immediately accepted by various members of the community[806]. Other sources report that Noetus convoked a group of ten disciples around him including one named Epigonus, who later went to Rome where he propagated this doctrine, which became quite popular through Cleomedes, a disciple of Epigonus, and found favour with bishop Zephyrinus[807]. Hippolytus defines the disciples of Noetus and followers of this doctrine as "Νοητιανοί"[808]. For his part, in the *Elenchos*, Epigonus is defined as "διάκονος" and disciple of Noetus[809].

On the basis of these facts, various scholars such as H. Turner, E. Schwartz, and J. Fischer have suggested that Noetus was a bishop, and even that the other presbyters were also bishops who had come to Smyrna to condemn him[810]. M. Simonetti, on the contrary, gave no credence to this hypothesis, pointing out that neither *Against Noetus* by Hippolytus nor the other sources such as the *Elenchos*, the *Panarion* of Epiphanius, or the *Compendium of Heresies* by Theodoret of Cyrus, mention that Noetus was a bishop. He also affirms that with regards to the fact that Epigonus is defined "διάκονος", the critics have demonstrated

805 Cf. Hipp., *CN* 1, 1.

806 Cf. Hipp., *CN* 1, 1.

807 Cf. *El.,* 9, 2–3, 7; 10, 27; cf. Thdt., *haer.*, 3,3 (PG 83, 403–405). In some parts of Asia towards the end of the second century also a Christian named Praxeas emigrated to Rome and thereafter to Carthage, introducing the Patripasian monarchian heresy. Apparently this happened shortly after Noetus was condemned by the presbyters of Smyrna, cf. Tert., *adv. Prax., passim* (PL 2, 153–196C).

808 Cf. Hipp., *CN* 7, 13.

809 Cf. *El.,* 9, 7.

810 Cf. C. Turner, *The 'Blessed Presbyters' who condemned Noetus,* in *Journal of Theological studies* (1921–1922), 28; cf. E. Schwartz, *Zwei Predigten Hippolyts,* in *Sitzungsberichte der Bayerischen Akademie der Wissenschaften* 3 (1936), 28; cf. J. Fischer, *Die vermutlichen Synoden gegen Noët von Smyrna,* in *Münchener theologische Zeitschrift* 28 (1977), 55.

that the author of the *Elenchos* was not well informed on Noetus. The author of the *Elenchos,* rather than concerning himself with the figure of Noetus, concentrated on the latter's disciples in Rome. For the rest, in the style characteristic of this work which attempts to connect each heresy with a philosophic school of thought, it is affirmed that the doctrine of Noetus was furthermore inspired by the philosophy of Heraclius[811]. For his part, Epiphanius states that Noetus was bishop of Ephesus and he places the death of Noetus and his brother shortly after his condemnation[812]. Finallly, M. Simonetti points out that the hypothesis of these scholars is vitiated as a result of their conviction of identifying the author of the *Elenchos* with the author of *Against Noetus,* which today is totally unacceptable[813].

We are in agreement with the reasons given by M. Simonetti and it is clear that the debate on the identity of the author of the *Elenchos* and *Against Noetus* at some time vitiated the interpretation of both texts. Nevertheless, I would like to insist on only one consideration which in my opinion has not been kept sufficiently in mind regarding the role of Noetus in the community of Smyrna, and that is precisely the omission by Polycrates of Ephesus in his letter to Pope Victor of Rome regarding the name of the bishop of the Church of Smyrna at the time of writing the letter. It seems strange that Polycrates does not mention the name of the bishop whose city is characterised by being Quartodecimanist. As we pointed out earlier, this omission may be understood as that under Camerius probably Smyrna would have abandoned the Quartodecimanist practice, but also, or furthermore, that at the time when Polycrates is writing, Smyrna was undergoing a serious crisis of its episcopate. Both opinions are feasible, although this question of the testimony of Polycrates alone does not confirm either of the two theses. Moreover, as we pointed our earlier, Polycrates exclusively names already dead persons, so as not to be obliged to make mention of the present bishop of Smyrna.

Apart from this, while it is certain that the author of the *Elenchos* does not appear to be very well informed on the situation of Noetus and ascribes more importance to his disciples in the Rome of Pope Zephyrinus, successor of Victor, we should therefore not fail to pay attention to the punctual news that

811 Cf. *El.,* 9, 7.

812 Cf. Epiph. *haer.,* 52, 1.

813 Cf. M. Simonetti, *Contro Noeto,* 40, 43, 197. For further details on the question of the two Hippolytuses, cf. M. Simonetti, *Contro Noeto,* 70–139; cf. M. Simonetti, *Ippolito,* in NDPAC, 2584–2600.

Epigonus is referred to as "διάκονος", in addition to simple disciple of Noetus[814]. If this news is certain, it is plausible that Noetus would have been a bishop, since Epigonus probably would not have been deacon of a presbyter. Besides, although it is is true and significant that no source names Noetus as a bishop, it is equally true and significant, that no source notifies us of who was bishop at the time of these happenings.

However, a further difficulty, granted the possibility that Noetus was bishop of Smyrna is the fact that according to Hippolytus, when for the first time "the blessed presbyters invited him to report before the community and interrogated him", Noetus "denied (being Moses) and said that he did not aspire to postions of authority (τὰς ἀϱχὰς μὴ φϱονεῖν)"[815]. Accordingly, Noetus' claim to be a new Moses was interpreted by the presbyters as an attempt to assume a role of command in the local community: This would lead us to think that, in fact, Noetus could not have occupied the position of bishop at that time.

M. Simonetti thinks that the bishop of Smyrna, in view of the importance of the personage or of the subject to be dealt with, probably did not wish to take the responsibility personally, but wanted to lean on the college of presbyters. Although this hypothesis appears plausible, there remains the same question of the low profile of the bishop of Smyrna throughout this whole situation.

Hippolytus adds that "for some time afterwards, he (Noetus) was sheltered by some persons and joined himself to them in order to make them understand his error"[816]. After the second interrogation, the presbyters, rejecting Noetus' defence and making their profession of faith, expelled him from the Church, "but (Noetus) arrived at such a point of pride that he set up a school (διδασκαλεῖον)[817]. Unfortunately Noetus' defence has not come down to us through other sources. All the same, it is clear that Noetus from the very first moment, before the second interrogation, could count on certain members of the community, and accordingly with his condemnation and the founding of his own school, a schism took place in the community.

In conclusion, we must state that Noetus really was an extremely important person in the Church of Smyrna: despite his negative attitude when facing the presbyters, he aspired to leadership in the community and achieved such a position in part of it, thereby bringing about a schism of considerable proportions.

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814 Cf. *El.,* 9, 7.

815 Cf. Hipp., *CN* 1, 4.

816 Cf. Hipp., *CN* 1, 5. For a comment on the difficult expression in Greek, cf. M. Simonetti, *Contro Noeto,* 197–198.

817 Cf. Hipp., *CN* 1, 8.

The omission of Polycrates and the other witnesses referred to heretofore, at the very least are indications which leads us to think that with the case of Noetus, the institution of the episcopate in Smyrna entered into a grave and unprecedented crisis in the history of the community.

8. Leaders of the community in the third century

The lack of information on the Church of Smyrna for various decades, starting from the beginning of the third century until the year 250, may be due to various circumstances. Perhaps the principal one is the shared history of many communities which lost their written memory during the persecutions. However, such a lack of information could also be due to the difficulty that the community may have encountered in regrouping itself and reorganising following the schism of Noetus. In fact, we have no knowledge of the name of the bishop of the community during the persecution of Decius. Neither does Pionius in his discourses and declarations in the *Martyrdom of Pionius* nor the final editor of the *Martyrdom of Pionius* make any mention of any other bishop apart from Euctemon the apostate and the martyr Polycarp.

The *Martyrdom of Pionius* has handed the name of bishop Euctemon down to us linked with an unfortunate memory of his figure. This bishop was not only one of the many who sacrificed during the persecution, but he insisted in performing the ritual to the letter verging on the ridiculous.

The neocorus Polemon and the commander Theophilus were eager for Pionius to follow the example of Euctemon, head of the community (ὁ πϱοεστώς)[818]. This term is proper of a pagan like Polemon who for obvious reasons does not use the technical term "ἐπίσκοπος". It is clear that the order of Decius to persecute the higher clergy first and foremost before passing on to win over the rest of the Christians was followed in Smyrna[819]. When they dragged Pionius off to the temple of the Nemeses and flung him on the ground before the altar, Pionius beheld the sad scene of his bishop erect beside the altar and with the sacrificial crown on his head[820]. On his return to prison, together with his companions,

818 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 15, 2. This same term is used by Eusebius referring to Hippolytus, probably bishop of a see in Asia, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 6, 20, 2.

819 Cf. Cypr. *ep.* 55, 9 (ed. C. Moreschini, 2007, 36).

820 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 16, 2. The term "εἰδωλολατϱικῶς" is a hapax to which the plausible meaning of "with crown on head" had been given, cf. L. Robert, *Le martyre de Pionios prêtre de Smyrne: Edité, traduit et commenté,* 95; cf. A. Bastiaensen – A. Hilhorst, *Atti e Passioni dei martiri,* Rome 2007[6], 470.

Pionius listened to the report that his bishop had "asked that the Christians be forced to sacrifice, and that he himself had led the lamb to the temple of the Nemeses, and that after having eaten of it, he had desired to take it roasted home with him". And it was said that his perjury came to be so ridiculous that he even swore on the Fortune of the Emperor and of the Nemeses, with the crown on his head, that he was not a Christian and unreservedly denied his faith"[821]. What Euctemon did was a frequent practice among apostates. Certain apostates, in order to indicate their absolute adhesion to the pagan gods, brought their own victims to be sacrificed[822] and even carried away part of them for their families[823].

The sad and ridiculous scene of the bishop of Smyrna, was in contrast with the courage of certain members of the community such as Sabina, Asclepiades, Macedonius, and Limnus, the last of whom was presbyter of the community[824]. These together with Pionius shared the only prison, even though it appears that only Pionius suffered martyrdom. Together with these, mention is also made of Eutyches, of the sect of the Phrygians,[825] and of Metrodorus, presbyter of the Marcionite Church[826].

The activity and influence of Pionius during the years prior to the persecution of Decius must have been very great. Being young, he embraced celibacy and journeyed extensively, covering not only Lydia to the east of Sardis but also the region of the Dead Sea in Palestine[827]. In the *Martyrdom of Pionius,* he appears as a well educated man thoroughly versed in the Scriptures[828], with teaching skills, and successful in achieving conversions to Christianity. He was a clever orator who understood legal processes and sought to obtain the utmost advantage from them for his own benefit and that of his companions[829]. He was well known not only by the Christian community but also by the pagans, who even showed a certain affection for him[830]. Pionius believed in premonitory visions, in Christian exorcism, and in other marvellous happenings[831]. And as a good Christian in

821 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 18, 13–14.
822 Cf. Cypr., *lapsis,* 8.
823 Cf. Cypr., *ep.,* 55, 13, 2 (ed. C. Moreschini, 2007, 38–40).
824 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 2, 1; 9, 5; 11, 2.
825 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 11, 2.
826 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 21, 5–6.
827 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 4, 18, 21.
828 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 4, 12–14.
829 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 16, 6.
830 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 5, 3.
831 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 2, 2; *M. Polyc.,* 22, 3.

Smyrna, he maintained the memory of Polycarp with devotion and met up with others to commemorate the anniversary of his death[832]. It is plausible that a personage of this stature could have written certain works of a theological nature or could have put down part of the history of the community in writing. Although this possibility exists based on the profile of the figure we find in the *Martyrdom of Pionius,* and some have tried to identify him as the compiler of the *corpus Polycarpianum* and the author of the *Life of Polycarp,* we do not have sufficient elements to positively affirm this[833]. He also appears to have once more copied the manuscript of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* which was in a precarious condition as reported in the appendix of that work[834].

9. Smyrna towards the Council of Nicaea of 325

From the persecution of Decius, the whole Christian community emerged fortified, and Smyrna certainly was no exception. It is very probable that a few months after Pionius' death, this story of his sufferings was comprehensively put together by one of the eyewitnesses of the events, and this witness probably was a Christian from Smyrna[835]. Apart from all this work of compilation which could also include Polycarp's letter *To the Philippians,* the *corpus Ignatianum,* and the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* among other writings[836], we have practically no knowledge of the Church of Smyrna until the Council of Nicaea in the year 325.

The persecutions subsequent to that of Decius seem to have left no trace in the history of the community, except perhaps for the name of a Christian from Smyrna called Dioscorides, who having been brought before the governor of the city, declared himself a Christian and was confined for a time in prison, and after a second interrogation on his Christian faith, was executed at the governor's order. The date of the execution was 10 May, but we do not know of what year[837]. An alternative version of this story contains even more details: Dioscorides converted and baptised many pagans, and this was the cause of his arrest. He was whipped before being taken in chains before the governor, who tortured him before putting him in prison, and he was later cruelly whipped at a second

832 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 2, 1.
833 Cf. pp. 73–86.
834 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 22, 3.
835 Cf. pp. 26–27.
836 Cf. pp. 73–86.
837 *Martirologio Romano*, ed. H. Delahaye, Brussels 1940, 182.

stage, when he refused to obey the order to apostatise[838]. The particular facts offered by both versions are scarcely credible historically, but perhaps we may at least affirm that the name of Dioscorides is that of a genuine martyr of Smyrna. Dioscorides is celebrated by the *Roman Martyirologium* on 10 May and the place of the martyrdom is given as Smyrna[839]; however, some later scholars have said that the place of execution must have been Myra, where in fact there is a basilica dedicated to the martyrs Crescentius and Dioscorides. Crescentius and Dioscorides, Paul, and Helladius appear to be celebrated on 28 May but this group was introduced by Baronius and is fictitious[840]. If we provisionally ascribe the martyrdom of Dioscorides to Diocletian, we can set the date of the latter to the year 303 or immediately afterwards.

In the *Roman Martyrologium,* we also find the names of Vital, Revocatus and Fortunatus as martyrs of Smyrna celebrated on 9 January. But the lists are confused and studies have eliminated the historic nature of these martyrs linked with Smyrna since each one appears to be linked to various lists referring to different cities[841].

As regards the bishops of the city, we know nothing more except the name of Eutiques, who was certainly already a bishop some time before the convocation of the Council of Nicaea, which appears in all versions of the lists of bishops[842] as representative of the Church of Smyrna to the first ecumenical council in the year 325 and marking the beginning of a stage of lasting peace for the Church in general and undoubtedly for the church of Smyrna in particular.

10. Conclusion

In all probability, the Church of Smyrna was founded under the wing of Pauline preaching between the years 53 and 56. It is difficult to give total credit to the news presented by the *Life of Polycarp* regarding the figure of Strataeas as one

838 Cf. *Synaxarium Ecclesiae Constantinopolitanae*, ed. H. Delahaye, Brussels 1902, 676.
839 Cf. *Martirologio Romano,* ed. H. Delahaye, 182, 213.
840 Cf. J. Sauget, *Crescente, Dioscoride, Paolo ed Elladio,* in *Bibliotheca Sanctorum* vol. IV, Rome 1964, 284–285.
841 Cf. *Martirologio Romano,* ed. H. Delahaye, 13.
842 Cf. H. Gelzer, *Patrum nicaenorum nomina latine, graece, coptice, syriace, arabice, armeniace,* Leipzig 1995, 32.

of the first masters of the community, as also the existence of a Christianity in Smyrna prior to Paul's preaching. For its part, the leadership of Aristion in the community of Smyrna which in certain sources appears linked with the figure of Papias and the presbyter John is probable but not completely certain.

At the end of the first century the community of Smyrna, as all of Asia, saw itself enriched with the emigration of Christians coming from Jerusalem following the year 70, and towards the year 95, there exists the possibility of an emerging institution of the episcopate present perhaps in the "angel of the church of Smyrna" of *Rv* 2, 8. As for the figure of "bishop" Bucolus gave Polycarp's predecessor in the *Life of Polycarp*, this is not historically certain.

At the beginning of the second century, the institution of the episcopacy acquires greater consolidation with the figure of Polycarp, above all following the passing of Ignatius through Smyrna. With the episcopate of Polycarp the Church undertook an interesting editorial work with the *corpus Ignatianum* and other writings, and a probable missionary impulsion towards the region of Gaul. The names of Alce, Marcion, Evaristus, and above all Irenaeus, appear among the most important disciples of Polycarp.

After Polycarp's death, there is certainty regarding his successors in the episcopal leadership of the community. The name of Papinius as successor of the martyr appears clear. Papinius may have been succeeded by Camerius as possibly the first non-Quartodecimanist bishop of Smyrna. However, the indications supporting this hypothesis are not conclusive.

At the end of the second century, the institution of the episcopacy in the church of Smyrna is diluted in our sources and above all we believe that it is negatively affected by all the happenings around the heresy and schism of Noetus, so that it was not until the middle of the third century that we once more have news of the name of a bishop of the community.

In the *Martyrdom of Pionius,* written after the year 250, we find the sad figure of the apostate bishop Euctemon who undoubtedly had ensured the leadership of the community from some years earlier. Together with him, and in great contrast, other lofty personages such as the presbyters Limnus and Pionius acted as leaders and teachers in the community in the mid-third century.

The death of the martyr Pionius aroused new energies in the community and perhaps the compilation of a large part of its history. The subsequent persecutions left little trace on the life of the community, only the name of the martyr Dioscorides during the persecution of Diocletian. Finally, in the lists of Nicaea the name of Eutiques as representative of the Church of Smyrna appears clearly, and unquestionably he was the bishop of that church from some years prior to the first ecumenical council.

The nature of the Christian faith in Smyrna is of course the principal aim of our study. But before further developing arguments of a theological nature which will be dealt with in the third part, we must hereafter study one challenging historical aspect for Christian life in general and for the community of Smyrna in particular on the basis of the sources we have presented in the first part: the Christian response to persecution and the imperial cult.

Chapter VII: The Christians of Smyrna in the face of the imperial cult

The imperial cult came to be a prominent characteristic of religion in the Asian cities and a source of tension for the development of the Christian communities. Domitian, emperor from 81 to 99, built a temple in his honour in Ephesus, and Hadrian did the same a couple of decades later in the same city. In the north, in the city of Pergamum, Trajan likewise built a temple[843].

Much later, in the same area, temples in honour of the goddess Roma had been set up. The imperial government had welcomed with complacency the construction of each temple as a symbol of the loyalty of its subjects to Rome, and the conquered populations built them quite willingly in most cases, while there was frequently even competition between neighbouring cities to establish who would have the right to build one of these temples[844]. In one such competition, eleven cities were invited to compete for the building of the first temple in Asia, and Smyrna won the competition and built the temple in honour of Tiberius[845]. Smyrna, which was the sea port offering most competition north of the city of Ephesus, built a temple to the goddess Roma for the first time in 195 B.C., which from then on came to be a very powerful, though not the only, centre of the imperial cult in the region[846].

It should not appear strange that the incursion of a Latin divinity was warmly welcomed by the Greek-speaking population of Asia, bearing in mind that Rome did lots to bring stability to the Mediterranean area, above all by guarding against the danger represented by pirates for sea trade in that area, until by the middle of the first century B.C. the area of Asia Minor had become extremely prosperous.

The Christian movement, by refusing to render this symbolic tribute to the emperor, aroused not only the distrust of the imperial government but also of the population conquered by Rome years before, which saw the source of its prosperity in the imperial government. It is clear that the Christians in the urban areas of the Roman Empire, during the period we are dealing with, were the target of discrimination by the pagan population and, above all and increasingly, of criminalisation by Rome as a result of their deviant religious and social behaviour.

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843 Cf. H. Duckworth, *Roman Provincial system,* in J. Foakes, *The Beginnings of Christianity,* vol. I, London 1920, 201–217.

844 Tac., *an.,* 4, 53–56.

845 Cf. pp. 96 et seqq.

846 Cf. B. Lightfoot, *The Apostolic Fathers,* 467–468.

On the basis of the sources presented in the first part, we propose hereafter to make reference to the discrimination and criminalisation suffered by the Christians starting from the year 70 in the province of Asia, and in particular in Smyrna, leaving the other parts of the Empire on one side[847].

1. The Revelation and the persecution of Domitian

In the Revelation, at the end of the first century, it is predicted for the Christians of Smyrna that there will be ten days of tribulation (θλῖψις) and captivity for some of them[848]. The term "θλῖψις" is quite strange to the extra-biblical world. This is the term used to define the anxiety caused by external circumstances[849]. Mention of a great tribulation (θλῖψις μεγάλη) is likewise found in New Testament and subapostolic writings[850]. The concept of an eschatological θλῖψις is strongly influenced by the historic conscience of Judaism. In both rabbinical and apocalyptical texts, it is said that before the messianic reign the Jewish people and also the cosmos, must go through a period of ever harder tribulation[851].

In the letter to the comunity of Ephesus, it is mentioned that the Christians there have suffered for the name of God[852]. The community of Pergamum too is known to have been faithful to the "name" of Christ and for not having denied their faith in him, even in the days of someone called Antipas[853], considered the pro-martyr of Asia. The letter sent to Pergamum immediately after the letter addressed to Smyrna makes us suppose that the conflictive experience of the community and the death of Antipas should be placed, in some way, in relation to the civil authorities. In fact, it is stressed that the community lives where the "throne

847 Before this date, various cases of harassment by the empire or the Jews were reported, suffice it to recall briefly a few of them: Some in Philippi where Paul and Silas were accused by the masters of a crazed slave girl in front of the magistrates governing the city, cf. *Ac* 16, 20 et seqq. In Corinth where Paul appears before Gallion, Roman governor of Acaya, because of an accusation of the Jews, cf. *Ac* 18, 12. In Thessalonica when the Jews dragged Jason, host of Paul and other Christians in front of the authorities of the city, cf. *Ac* 21, 27 et seqq. In Pontus and Bithynia, as confirmed by the trials carried out by Pliny in about the year 117, cf. Pliny the Younger, *Ep.,* 10, 96 et seqq.

848 Cf. *Rv* 2, 9 et seqq.

849 Cf. *2 Co* 1, 8; 6, 4; 8, 2; *Rv* 1, 9; 2, 9. 22.

850 Cf. *Mt* 24, 21; *Ac* 7, 11; Herm., *vis.,* 4, 2. 4 (SCh 53bis, 136).

851 Cf. H. Schilier, θλῖβω, θλῖψις, in GLNT IV, Brescia 1968, 515–542.

852 Cf. *Rv* 2, 3.

853 Cf. *Rv* 2, 13.

of Satan"[854] is, a possible allusion to the cult of the Emperor and its temple. By dint of this possible allusion to the cult of the Emperor in Pergamum, there are those who have wondered whether the death of Antipas was not due to the fact that "he refused to offer the sacrifice before the statue of the Emperor, as we find described in Pliny's famous letter"[855]. The "throne of Satan" is the centre of the attacks for the seer of the *Revelation.* Once more in an experience of confrontation with the authority, it makes us think of the prediction of the captivity to the Church of Smyrna in *Rv* 2, 10: "Do not be afraid of the sufferings that are coming to you: I tell you: the devil is going to send some of you to prison to test you, and you must face an ordeal for ten days". It is also possible that John's stay on the island of Patmos was a consequence of his condemnation to exile[856].

Starting off from what is reflected in the *Revelation,* everything would seem to indicate that the Christians found themselves in a situation of danger, probably under the empire of Domitian. We also have the clear and unmistakable statement of Melito of Sardis, fairly close to the happenings in the area of Smyrna, who, in his *Apologia* to emperor Marcus Aurelius, names Domitian and Nero among the enemies of Christianity[857]. Neither did the proconsul in Asia at the time escape the severity of Domitian in the government of the provinces and his cruelty towards his potential adversaries. He was accused and murdered as a suspected conspirator[858]. Smyrna in the days of Domitian was under the control of an imperial *curator* of consular rank known simply by the name of Rufus. He was entrusted not only with the finances, but with multiple public responsibilities and it appears that he even had a violent confrontation with the famous sophist Nicetas. On Domitian's death in the year 96, the two had a further clash when the emperor Nerva asked the sophist to appear before Rufus to swear allegiance to him; however, Nicetas overcame the official with his oratory and was widely honoured in Smyrna[859].

Since there is no talk of accusations or denunciations in the *Revelation*, the failure of the Christians to participate in the cult of the Emperor may have been the reason which unleashed this conflict. This persecution may have consisted of sporadic actions undertaken by local protagonists, such for example as the

854 Cf. *ibid.*

855 Cf. H. Kraft, *Die Offenbarung des Johannes,* Tübingen 1974, 30.

856 Cf. *Rv* 1, 9. On the problem of John's condemnation to exile, cf. U. Müller, *Die Offenbarung des Johannes,* Gütersloh-Wurzburg 1984, 81.

857 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 4, 26, 9.

858 Cf. Suet., *Domitianus* 8, 2; 10, 2.

859 Cf. Philostr., *v. s.,* 1, 19.

priests of the cult to the Emperor. An attitude of deliberate opposition by the Christians to the cult of the Emperor, as occasion for the conflicts, would correspond to the rigid opposition of the *Revelation* in their confrontations with Rome[860].

Thus then, it is possible that in an indirect way the *Revelation* reflects an accusation against the Christians of ἀσέβεια or *crimen laesae maiestatis.* In favour of this hypothesis would also weigh the comparison of the experiences of the members of the synagogues of Smyrna and Philadelphia with those of the communities of Christians. The tightening in exaction of the *fiscus Iudaicus* under Domitian and the extension of the accusations of ἀσέβεια by the pagans could lead to a dangerous situation for the Christians, in case of conflict against the "Jewish style of living" by the pagans if they were identified as a Jewish sect or as a community proceeding from Judaism which also showed itself critical of the cult of the Emperor[861]. However, unlike the Jews who were exempted from worship of the divinity of the Emperor, to a large extent justified by the specifically ethnic character of their religion, it did not seem opportune to extend these exceptions to the Christians, of whom already many came from a pagan environment and appeared systematically engaged in proselytism. Accordingly, the fact that the Christians refused to recognise the divine character of the Emperor was classed as a crime of *laesae maiestatis,* while their refusal to worship the traditional gods led to their being considered as atheists[862].

2. The persecutions under Trajan and Hadrian

At the beginning of the second century, Pliny, provincial governor of Bithynia, to the north of Smyrna and the other cities of western Asia Minor in about the year 111 or 112, consulted the emperor Trajan on how to proceed when dealing

860 Cf. *Rv* 13; 17; cf. U. Müller, *Die Offenbarung des Johannes,* 257–260.

861 Cf. Flav. Ios., *Bell. iud.,* 7, 46.

862 The news of the historian Dio Cassius would seem of particular importance; according to this, under the emperor Domitian, certain Christians of high social standing, the consul Flavius Clemens and his wife Domitilla were accused and condemned for atheism (ἀθεότης), and with them "many more inclined to Jewish customs", cf. Dio Cassius, 67, 14, 1–2. Not long afterwards, Dio Cassius qualifies the crime of these men as ἀσέβεια. Nevertheless, the scarcity of the documentation we dispose of leaves us with a big margin of uncertainty, above all because in the midst of the struggle against the senatorial aristocracy carried on by Domitian, his actions against Christians of high social standing might have been a pretext for a condemnation basically more of political nature, cf. M. Simonetti, *Il Vangelo e la storia,* 59.

with Christians in certain extreme cases. His dilemma seems to have been whether it is sufficient to persecute them merely for being Christians or whether other crimes had to be proved.

Emperor Trajan's answer seems to confirm that until then there was no general determination to juridically regulate how to proceed against Christians. The Emperor seems to have not laid down a general rule, but merely gives certain indications to solve his difficulties: Christians must not be sought out, and anonymous denunciations should be rejected. Anyone officially accused as a Christian, must have a public hearing; if he denies being a Christian and confirms his negation by invoking the Roman gods, he should not be punished, even though until then he had been a Christian. Only if, on being interrogated he confesses to being a Christian and perseveres in such confession, should he be punished. That is, there was no need to demonstrate the violation of other laws, but the mere fact of being Christian was sufficient for incrimination on behalf of the Empire.

The sources give us few reports on the effect of Trajan's "rescript". We do not know the names of the Christians who lost their lives in the province of Bithynia, nor how many of them were taken to Rome. Only two martyrdoms were ascribed based on names to the period of Trajan from 98 to 117: Simeon, bishop of Jerusalem and successor of James, who was crucified at the age of 120,[863] and Ignatius of Antioch who passing in chains by Smyrna and other cities of Asia Minor was taken to Rome where he was executed, under Trajan still, as Eusebius informs us[864]. The passing of Ignatius of Antioch by Smyrna together with his companions Zosimus, Rufus and others is well documented[865]. In his letter *To the Philippians,* Polycarp too makes allusion to the environment of persecution[866].

During the persecutions, one constant continues to be the fact that application of the edicts issued by the emperors depended on the considerable discretionality enjoyed by the provincial governors or proconsuls. Accordingly, the criminalisation of the Christians will not be homogeneous throughout the Empire.

Thanks to Smyrnaean coins and commemorative plaques, we know the names of some colleagues of Pliny in Asia in the times of Trajan: Pedanius Fuscus Salinator between 98 and 99, and Lucius Baebius Tullius between 102 and 112[867]. Notwithstanding, we have no news of the attitude these proconsuls had

863 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 3, 32, 3. 6.
864 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 3, 36, 3.
865 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 9, 1–2.
866 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 12, 3.
867 Cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna,* 254. The proconsuls were governed by a province with consular jurisdiction and insignia and with distinct functions such as: military

towards Christians, even though in the case of Ignatius, if we are to judge by the communication he was able to establish from Smyrna with other communities, we may possibly deduce that the proconsuls, at least in this case, perhaps for some economic compensation, were not completely hostile towards the prisoner.

As from the second century, the Christian faith came to be considered a foreign religion which corrupted habits, even linked with crimes on occasion and finally, criminal in itself. With the question raised by Pliny to Trajan on whether Christians may already be punished because of this same "name" or whether the existence of crimes linked with the name *(flagitia)* had to be demonstrated, a new dimension in the criminalisation of Christians developed[868]. The believers in Christ were accused because of the *nomen Christianum*[869].

In the days of Hadrian from 117 to 136, this time the proconsul of the province of Asia Minor to which Smyrna belonged, Getulius Serenus Granianus asks for guidelines from the Emperor on the subject of the Christians. The writing in question has been lost, but not so the answer from Hadrian to Serenus' successor, Minucius Fundanus, since Justin included it in the appendix of his *Apologia*[870]. With even greater vigour than Trajan, this emperor rejects anonymous denunciations against Christians and any irascible petitions for their punishment. Only if the denouncer identifies himself, can the Christian accused be brought before the tribunal; and only if proof is brought that the denounced persons have failed to observe the laws can the governor pass sentence according to the seriousness of the crime[871]. According to Justin, Hadrian's position

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power over the army of legionaries for which they were responsible, civic power with the aid of a quaestor responsible for the Public Treasure, of the *publicani* who collected the taxes and of certain judges for civil cases. Under their charge, they had delegates, *legati proconsulis,* who were preceded by a *lictor* and had all the powers conferred on them by the proconsul. The proconsuls who depended on the Senate as in the case of Asia, Africa and Greece, were preceded by various lictors, thus being in a higher category than the proconsuls sent out in the name of the Emperor to Gaul and Syria who were preceded by soldiers only. The proconsuls generally governed the provinces for one year, so that it was difficult to establish a complete list of the same.

868 Cf. A. Sherwin – D. White, *The Letters of Pliny. A Historical and Social Commentary,* Oxford 1966, 696.

869 Cf. Plin. Jr., *ep.,* 10, 96.

870 Cf. Just., *1 apol*., 68, 5–10 (SCh 507, 312–317); Eus., *h. e*. 4, 9. For treatment of the authenticity of the rescript, cf. F. Blanchetiere, *Le Christianisme Asiate*, 80–81.

871 This rescript of Hadrian has been interpreted as the desire for pure and simple confirmation of the rules established by Trajan, cf. K. Baus, *De la Iglesia primitiva a los*

represented a relief for the Christians, who in this way were set free from most of the rules laid down by Trajan. Now Christians could only be punished if it was demonstrated that they had not observed the laws in force in the Empire. In such case, the proof to be brought by the accuser would be reduced to proving that the persons cited by him were Christians. But the proconsul has to impose the punishment "according to the gravity of the crime". It is difficult to understand that for a Roman judge, there may be differences of degree in being Christian. Whence the interpretation that Justin gives to the rescript is the most probable one. To tell the truth, Hadrian does not exclude the possibility of an accusation for the mere fact of being a Christian, but seems to require proof that the accused has infringed a Roman law in order to be punished[872].

It seems that the rescript of Hadrian improved the situation of the Christians. There is no source that mentions even a single martyrdom, real or supposed, in the province of Asia Minor, nor can executions of Christians in other parts of the Empire be attributed with certainty to the reign of Hadrian[873].

3. The persecutions under Antoninus Pius, Marcus Aurelius and Commodus

In the reign of Antoninus Pius from 136 to 161, the mere fact of being Christian continued to be considered a criminal fact, as proved by the martyrdoms which were perpetrated during this time[874]. The best documented martyrdom in this period in the region of Asia is undoubtedly that of bishop Polycarp,[875] who

comienzos de la gran Iglesia, Barcelona 1980, 217. For a recent study on the evolution of Christianity under the reign of Hadrian, cf. M. Rizzi, *Hadrian and the Christians*, Berlin 2010.

872 For a study on the interpretation that Justin, Melito of Sardis, and other Fathers give to Hadrian's rescript, cf. F. Blanchetiere, *Le Christianisme Asiate*, 83–88.

873 We know the names of the proconsuls of Asia Minor during Hadrian's reign: T. Arrius Antoninus and T. Aurelius Fulvus, cf. C. Cadoux, *Ancient Smyrna*, 261.

874 To his appendix to the *Apologia,* Justin adds a story which tells of the execution of three Christians in Rome with details which testify to a first-hand knowledge of the facts: the three were condemned to death by the prefect of the city for their constancy in confessing the faith, cf. Just., *I Apol.,* appendix 2.

875 We know the names of the proconsuls of the province at the time of Antoninus Pius, probably the one at the head of the province at the beginning of the Emperor's mandate was L. Vanuleius Apronianus who governed in 138 and 139 according to the coins struck in Smyrna. We also know the name of T. Vitrasius Pollio who governed from 151 to 152 and of Julius Severus who governed from 152 to 153, cf. C. Cadoux,

together with eleven more Christians from Philadelphia, were condemned to death in Smyrna[876].

The fact remains obscure, since it seems strange that in Smyrna eleven outsiders were martyred along with the bishop of Smyrna. So that certain scholars are of the opinion that only some of them were Philadelphians and the rest from Smyrna[877]. Of these, the young Germanicus stood out for his valour in putting the exploit urged by Ignatius of Antioch into practice and of inciting the wild beast to attack him, thus cutting short this "just and impious" life[878].

The chronological fixing of this martyrdom presents certain difficulties; however, transferring it to the age of Marcus Aurelius, as Eusebius did, requires such a quantity of hypotheses difficult to substantiate, that the traditional opinion that Polycarp died in the reign of Antoninus Pius seems most deserving of credence[879].

In the form of a circular letter, the community of Smyrna tells how these happenings came about. The intention and theological method of the whole explanation is to show the martyrdom of Polycarp as a repercussion of the following of Christ in line with the gospel and to stimulate others to imitate him. At the beginning and end of the narration, there is a praise of martyrs who face up to all kinds of tortures, threats, exhortations and promises aimed at persuading them to apostatise[880].

The events were as follows: The pagans of the city, following the brave example of the young martyr Germanicus, impetuously asked the police officer to seek out the bishop and bring him before the tribunal[881]. Polycarp, at the request of his community, had withdrawn to a farm situated outside of the city. He even changed his

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Ancient Smyrna, 262, 269. The *Martyrdom of Polycarp* transmits to us the name of the proconsul of that time, Statius Quadratus. Someone of that name governed from 154 to 155; however, another proconsul by the name of Quadratus governed from 165 to 166. It also informs us of who the Asiarch was at that time, namely someone called Philip of Tralles. The Asiarch was the authority heading the confederation of the principal cities of the Roman province of Asia. Thus he presided over the judges. Likewise, he was the highest religious authority, so that he is also called the high priest, cf. *M. Polyc.,* 21; cf. B. Lightfoot, *The Apostolic Fathers,* 368–369; 382–383.

876 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 19, 1.

877 Cf. J. Ayán Calvo, 269.

878 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 3, 1; cf. Eus., *h. e.* 4, 15, 5; cf. Ign., *Rom.,* 5, 2.

879 Cf. p. 14.

880 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 1–3; 19–20.

881 The part played by the pagan population in a trial against Christians is particularly clear in this narration, cf. *M. Polyc.,* 3, 2.

place of residence once more in order to stay alive for the good of the community. But a slave betrayed him under torture, and a troop of soldiers was sent to effect his detention. When these arrived, Polycarp behaved with his enemies as a hospitable host, he received them graciously, and withdrew for a couple of hours to pray. Even when they were on their way to the amphitheatre, the head of police did his best to convince him to apostatise; however, this attempt failed. The official the while urged the accused to confess that "Caesar is the Lord"[882]. On their entry into the amphitheatre, a voice from heaven urged Polycarp to be brave. There followed the trial according to the usual method: the proconsul asks him what his name is, tries to make him change his mind using the usual methods, and finally, orders him to swear by the genius of the Emperor. This implied *recognising* the divinity of the Emperor, since the "τύχη" was the special protectress of the Emperor and identified with his personal *genius*[883]. The answer is the same as always "*Christianus sum*", followed by the offer of instructing the proconsul in his faith[884]. Further threats of torture and death not only had no effect, but Polycarp even addressed his accuser, threatening him with the eternal fire of hell[885]. Thereupon pagans and Jews prepare the stake, but since the flames failed to consume Polycarp, an executioner[886] stabbed him[887]. His corpse was burned at the instigation of the Jews, but the Christians gave an honourable burial to his mortal remains[888].

The persecutions continued during the government of the emperor Marcus Aurelius from 161 to 180. Already in the first Christian apologetic, an edict favourable to the Christians was attributed to him[889]. The initial perception of the

882 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 8. However, the Christian could not admit this formula in which he saw the negation of the single lordship of Christ, cf. *1 Co* 8, 5–6. Years later Tertullian will admit that Caesar may be given the title of "lord" providing this is not in the same sense that it should be applied to God, cf. Tert., *apol.,* 34, 1 (CCL 1, 144).

883 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 9.

884 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 10.

885 Cf. *M. Polyc*., 11.

886 The "*confector*" was the person responsible for giving the *coup de grace* to both gladiators and wild beasts.

887 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 12–16.

888 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 17–18.

889 The reason for a similar attitude by this Emperor seems to have been the story of the miraculous rain, which in answer to the prayers of a Christian legion, had prevented the rout of the imperial army in the war waged by the Emperor. Apollinaris of Hierapolis and Tertullian referred to Marcus Aurelius when wishing to demonstrate the injustice of the Roman provincial authorities in proceeding against the Christians, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 5, 1–7; Tert., *apol.,* 5 (PL 1, 339–347).

Christians on this Emperor was favourable, possibly on the basis of his being a philosopher-emperor who proposed to put into practice, as a sovereign too, the Stoic ideal. Nonetheless, the reality was quite different. His personal notes allows us to understand to what point he despised the Christians: basically, he believed that they sacrified their lives to an illusion. That he was not prepared to permit the State religion being endangered by exalted religious sectarians, or by the introduction of previously unknown cults is proved by a rescript of the year 176 or 177, which even though not directed certainly against the Christians, could without difficulty be applied against them by the provincial authorities[890].

This situation is confirmed by a series of particular martyrdoms in various parts of the Empire[891]. The complaints of the Christians which grew under this Emperor and which found an echo in the apologies of Melito of Sardis, Apollinaris of Hierapolis, and the Athenian Athenagoras, two of them from Asia Minor, clearly indicate that the situation of the Christians was becoming more desperate. Melito of Sardis draws the attention of Marcus Aurelius to the public sackings and depredations to which the Christians of Asia were exposed by day and night by miserable wretches such as would not have been committed even by tribes of barbarians. The blame for this was laid on the existence of new edicts, which the apologist cannot however attribute to the Emperor[892]. In the decade 160 to 170, the martyrdom of three oriental bishops should be placed, on which Eusebius gives us reliable news: Publius, bishop of Athens[893], Strataeas, bishop of Eumenia, in Phrygia, but martyred in Smyrna towards the year 166, and Sagaris, bishop of Laodicea, when Servilius Paulus was proconsul of the province[894],

890 Cf. K. Baus, *De la Iglesia primitiva a los comienzos de la gran Iglesia,* 252; cf. J. Beaujeu, *La politique romaine à l'apogée de l'empire, I: La politique religieuse des Antonins*, Paris 1955, 356–358.

891 In Rome, the philosopher Justin is the most prestigious victim of a group of Christians who were executed in about 163 to 167 following a trial directed by the prefect of the city himself, Junius Rusticus. Already Tatian, disciple of Justin, seems to attribute part of the responsibility for the death of these Christians to the intrigues of the pagan philosopher Crescentius, cf. H. Delehaye, *Les passions,* 119–121.

892 Eus., *h. e.* 4, 26, 5–6. Athenagoras too complains in his apologia to the same Emperor that the Christians are harrassed, sacked, and persecuted, and asks him to put an end to the denunciations made against them cf. Athen., *Sup.,* 1 (SCh 379, 70–75).

893 Eusebius transmits the news of a letter from bishop Dionysius of Corinth to the community of Athens, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 4, 23, 2.

894 Discussion takes place on the true name of the Roman official who was proconsul of Asia between 164 and 166, cf. A. Velasco-Delgado, *Eusebio, Historia Eclesiástica,* Madrid 1997, 254, note 226.

in 166[895], two of whom once more came from Asia Minor. For well founded reasons, the martyrdom of a group of Christians from Pergamum as well as Carpus, bishop of Thyatira, and a deacon named Papilus were likewise condemned to die at the stake. The Christian Agathonica, who was at the execution, made a public confession of her faith and flung herself willingly into the flames[896].

The most lively report against the background, circumstances and course of the wave of local persecution under Marcus Aurelius is afforded by the collective letter from the churches of Lyons and Vienne in Gaul to the brethren of Asia and Phrygia narrating the storm which broke over them in the year 177 with the martyrdom of various members of the community[897]. At that time Photinus was bishop of the church of Lyons, assisted by the then presbyter Irenaeus coming from Smyrna, destined thereafter to become his successor. A considerable part of the members of this church originated from the Asiatic East, for example, the Phrygian physician Alexander or Attalus of Pergamum, who was a Roman citizen. The letter fails to specify the number of victims, only a subsequent tradition speaks of about 50 men. The indications provided by these sources show that even in the days of Marcus Aurelius the juridical situation established by Trajan's rescript still continued to exist and the practice ensuing from it under Hadrian.

After Marcus Aurelius, arriving almost at the end of the second century under the government of his son Commodus from 180 to 192, the general situation

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895 These two martyrs are reported to us in a letter from Polycrates, bishop of Ephesus to the bishop of Rome, dealing with the Easter controversy and that Eusebius has preserved for us in his *Historia Ecclesiastica*, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 4, 26, 3; 5, 18, 14; 4, 24, 4–5. Polycrates seems to follow a chronological order; meanwhile, Strataeas was to suffer martyrdom before Sagaris (166), that is in 165 at the latest, possibly in 162, cf. A. Velasco-Delgado, *Eusebio, Historia Ecclesiastica,* 333, note 358.

896 Cf. K. Baus, *De la Iglesia primitiva a los comienzos de la gran Iglesia,* 253.

897 Eusebius included the fact in almost full detail, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 1, 1–2, 8. In the summer of that year, after the representatives of all Gaul had gathered together in Lyons, for the feast of the imperial cult, popular fury suddenly broke out against the Christians, who as in other parts of the Empire here were once more accused of atheism and moral dissolution. Gentile slaves in the service of Christians, in their declarations accused their masters of the most serious crimes so that, within a few days, the cream of both churches found themselves in prison. In the course of the trial, about ten Christians abjured their faith, while the rest were condemned to death and the execution was accompanied by refined tortures. The bodies were not given back to their families; they were burned six days later and their ashes flung into the Rhone.

of persecution continued with similar characteristics except that, thanks to his concubine Marcia, who was close to Christian circles, the situation at least in the capital of the Empire was somewhat alleviated[898]. As far as reports of persecution and martyrdom close to our area of interest are concerned, the only information is on certain executions occurring in Apamea in Phrygia; however, we are not exactly informed on the circumstances for want of sources[899].

The persecution of Christianity under the last two Antonini confirms the persistence of the Empire's attitude to Christianity as laid down under Trajan. Christians are only brought before the tribunals when they are denounced as such to the authority; however, it only takes a profession of Christian faith for them to be condemned with no need to demonstrate the existence of other crimes. For this reason, trials against Christians are only reported sporadically; whereas under these two Emperors, they are invoked more frequently and in a tumultuous way by pagan public opinion, which has turned hostile and shows signs of growing exasperation.

4. The persecutions under Septimius Severus and Maximinus

With Septimius Severus who governed from 193 to 211, founder of the Syrian dynasty, a phase of tranquillity seems to begin for the Christians, favouring their internal and external evolution and development. This is pointed out by certain apologists and is expressed in the fact that various Christians are close to the imperial court and some of the senatorial families profess the Christian faith[900]. In the first years of his government, towards the year 196, the bishops were able to meet up in synods, without impediment, in which they dealt with the date of Easter[901]. Nevertheless, at the beginning of the third century, anti-Christian

898 Marcia had the presbyter Jacintus as master and maintained friendly relations with the Roman community, without it being possible to identify her thereby as a baptised Christian. To her we owe the fact that Commodus arranged for the return of Christians who had been condemned to forced labour in the mines of Cilicia, cf. K. Baus, *De la Iglesia primitiva a los comienzos de la gran Iglesia,* 256. Under Commodus too there were influential Christians at court; on one occasion the Christian Proculus succeeded in curing the Emperor of an illness, while prince Caracalla had a Christian wet-nurse.

899 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 16, 22.

900 Cf. Tert., *scap.,* 3–4 (PL 1, 779–782).

901 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 23–25.

activity is recorded in various parts of the Empire[902], possibly favoured, or even caused, by the particular atmosphere brought about by the festivities on the occasion of the tenth year of the reign of Septimius Severus, since already the powerful sacred dimension of the celebrations may have fed the popular violence affecting the Christians, whose refusal to recognise that sacred dimension of the imperial celebrations was well known[903]. Notwithstanding, no news has reached us of the consequences that this had in Asia.

The reign of Caracalla from 211 to 217 was particularly tolerant and beneficial for Christianity, to the point of being positively esteemed by later Christian writers[904]. Of the brief reign of Heliogabalus from 218 to 222, apart from his project of making the cult of the sun god of Emesa obligatory throughout the Empire, we have no knowledge of his relationship with the Christians. The situation favourable to the Christians was consolidated in the reign of Alexander Severus[905]. With this Emperor who governed from 222 to 235 Christian life was able to unfold in the East, above all in Asia Minor where, almost compensating for the literary vacuum that we have for the region in this period, the multiple, evidently Christian inscriptions dating from this time give some idea of the favourable climate breathed there[906].

After the brief period of Maximinus from 235 to 238 in which the situation changed unexpectedly to persecuting the leaders above all of the Roman

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902 Towards the year 202 the Christian school of Alexandria, which had attracted various Gentiles to the Christian faith, found itself closely watched and many of its masters left the city, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 6, 3, 1; 4, 1, 3. Likewise, African Christianity suffered persecution, with the famous martyrdom of Perpetua and Felicity. Moreover, there were persecutions in Jerusalem, Cappadocia and Antioch.

903 The news given in the *Historia Augusta* according to which Septimius Severus forbade proselytism by the Jews and the Christians is difficult to appraise, partly because the facts given in the *Historia Augusta* are not entirely worthy of credit, cf. M. Simonetti, *Il Vangelo e la storia,* 114–115.

904 Cf. Aug., *civ.,* 5, 17. Certain isolated and particularly cruel persecutions were carried out in Africa by the proconsul Scapula, but were apparently due to his reading of the publication of earlier imperial rescripts on the Christians, which the jurist Ulpian gathered in his writing *De officio proconsulis,* cf. Lact., *div inst.,* 5, 11, 18 (SCh 204, 186).

905 His mother, Julia Mamaea was declared to be a well-wisher of Christianity, and there were many Christians in the court, including Julius Africanus, to whom he entrusted the building of a library next to the Pantheon.

906 At this time too, Christian cemeteries and a place of Christian worship were organised in Dura-Europos, on the eastern borders of the Empire.

Church[907], Philip the Arab came to power, showing himself so favourable to Christianity that it was rumoured that he had been a Christian[908].

5. The persecution of Decius

All this period of relative peace for the Christian faith following the Antonini, with the exceptions of Septimius Severus and Maximinus, came to an end with the great persecution of the emperor Decius who in 249 detained some Christians and in the year 250 executed bishop Fabian, head of the Roman community[909].

By means of an edict issued that same year, Decius invited all the inhabitants of the Empire to take part in a general sacrifice to the gods, in a *supplicatio*. This imploration by all the inhabitants for the well-being of the Empire had the peculiarity of being accompanied by an exhaustive inspection on the enforcement of the edict, certifying the carrying out of the sacrifice by means of a *libellus.* Those who refused to sacrifice should be imprisoned and obliged by the application of tortures to make the sacrifice. The aim of this edict, without precedent in history against Christianity, sought the return en masse of these to the ancient religion of the Empire.

In Smyrna, the martyr Pionius saw his bishop Euctemon beside the altar, with the sacrificial crown on his head, busily occupied in punctually carrying out the ceremony of idolatrous sacrifice[910]. The narration on the five imprisoned Christians of Smyrna, among whom the presbyter Pionius himself was burned alive, is the only echo of the persecution of Decius in Asia. There only exists a legend transmitted by Gregory of Tours on Ephesus regarding seven martyrs, or as they are better known, the "seven sleeping ones", who were martyred by the proconsul Optimus, successor of Quintilianus[911].

The *Martyrdom of Pionius* is, together with the *libelli* conserved on papyrus, one of the most important documentary sources for knowledge of the persecution of Decius. As we already pointed out in the first part[912], Eusebius seems to consider the martyrdom of Pionius contemporary with that of Polycarp, attributing its dating to between the years 161 and 169. Eusebius' dating is certainly erroneous. Eusebius was reading a version of the acts of the martyrdom of Pionius

907 Bishop Pontian and a presbyter Hippolytus were deported to Sardinia.
908 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 6, 34; 7, 10, 3.
909 Cf. Cypr. *ep.* 37, 2; 6, 3–9.
910 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 15, 2; 16, 1; 18, 12.
911 Cf. Gr. Tur., *De gloria martyrum,* 95.
912 Cf. pp. 23–24.

similar to that kept by us, in a collection in which they are joined to the acts of the martyrdom of Polycarp, a sort of small martyrologium of Smyrna, and undoubtedly from there deduced erroneously the contemporaneousness of the two happenings, justified in part, by the synchronism between the anniversary of the death of Polycarp and the arrest of Pionius. Apart from the textual and historical arguments, archaeology favours the dating of the martyrdom of Pionius to the reign of Decius. In fact, many details in the text correspond to the inscriptions and coins dating from the time of Decius[913].

The *Martyrdom of Pionius* offers very precise data on the places where the various phases of the trial took place: the description of the market of Smyrna and the surrounding buildings, above all the two-storied eastern portico with its high columns. This description corresponds to the excavations carried out halfway through the twentieth century by S. Kantar and R. Naumann. In 1927, S. Kantar became the director and founder of the Archaeological Museum of Izmir, a post that he occupied until his death in 1949. Between 1932 and 1941, he was responsible for the first archaeological excavations organised on the site of the ancient city of Smyrna, a task which he carried out in conjunction with the German archaeologist R. Naumann. The opening up of a large part of the agora of Smyrna, which is today an open-air museum in the centre of Izmir, is due to his work. R. Naumann and S. Kantar published the results of their findings for the first time in 1935, with a final version which appeared after the death of S. Kantar in 1950[914].

Likewise, the picture of civic and administrative life obtained from the *Martyrdom of Pionius* is detailed and at the same time put into writing in a spontaneous way without the inventions proper to the falsifiers of subsequent acts of martyrdom. According to the introductory chapter of the text, Pionius is believed to have left an account (σύγγραμμα) on the trial, on which the text which has come down to us is based. H. Delehaye has identified two parts of this report in chapters 10 and 18, where the narration all of a sudden changes from the third to the first person[915]. Throughout the account, we find the clear intention by the final editor to bring closer the figure of Pionius to that of Polycarp, through both historic and textual synchronism[916].

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913 Cf. G. Lanata, *Gli atti dei martiri come documenti processuali,* Milan 1973, 172.

914 Cf. R. Naumann – S. Kantar, *Die Agora von Smyrna,* in *Istanbuler Forschungen* 17, 1950, 87–90.

915 Cf. H. Delehaye, *Les passions,* 31.

916 Cf. M. Simonetti, *Studi Agiografici*, Rome 1955, 20–21.

The interrogation against Pionius, Sabina and Asclepiades, which leads to their imprisonment and trial, was conducted by the neocorus Polemon, together with certain persons who together with him must have constituted the commission for checking the sacrificial ceremonies. The commission had to certify the whole process in order to issue the respective *libellus*: offering of incense, libations, and tasting of the meat of the animals sacrificed[917]. The pre-eminent position of Polemon on the commission may be explained by the growth in the dignity of the office of neocorus. Originally these were simple guardians of the temples, but in the course of the Imperial age, their office acquired greater importance. The neocorus was competent in the trial for preliminary investigations, and in case of reticence to the imperial prescriptions, had to ensure custody of the persons charged.

In *M. Pion.,* 3, 1, it is said that the neocorus Polemon and those accompanying him were entrusted with seeking out and forcing the Christians to sacrifice. The prescription of Decius applied to all the inhabitants of the Empire, and not only the Christians. But when these did not report voluntarily, a day was fixed for them in which they had to do so, and if they failed to report to make the sacrifice, they were implicitly considered as Christians and then sought out[918]. It should be noted that in *M. Pion.,* 4, 1, Polemon suggests to Pionius that he should obey like everyone else, and not like all the Christians, or all his fellow believers.

The answer of Pionius to the interrogation by the neocorus was, in addition to refusing to sacrifice, declining to adore the "golden statue" which may be considered as the statue of the Emperor himself. In the *M. Pion.,* 8, 4, Polemon seems to urge Pionius, since he is not carrying out the prescriptions of the edict, to at least make a sacrifice to the Emperor, as an informal homage to the Nemesis, local divinities in some way equivalent to the gods *publici populi Romani,* thus demonstrating a minimum of goodwill. From the formularies encountered in the Egyptian *libelli,* it does not follow that the edict formally contemplates a sacrifice to the Emperor, but in the processes against Christians it appears that it was the custom to ask it of those charged[919]. In the subsequent interrogation of Pionius this time before the proconsul, no concrete allusion is made to an image of the Emperor[920].

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917 Cf. G. Lanata, *Gli atti dei martiri come documenti processuali,* 75.

918 Cf. Cypr., *lapsis* 3 (CPL 42).

919 Cf. G. Lanata, *Gli atti dei martiri come documenti processuali,* 71.

920 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 19 and 20.

The multitude had an interest in continuing with the show of the interrogation in the theatre[921]. Smyrna must have recently suffered a famine, as is clear from the words proffered to Pionius by the spectators: "You too have suffered hunger with us"[922]. In this situation of tension still existing in the city, any big concourse of persons could end up in a disruption of public order, accordingly, perhaps the general (ὁ στρατηγός), was present at the scene, who first of all, appears incidentally in the proceeding carried through by the commission for checking the ceremonies of the sacrifices, but then afterwards, together with others of similar rank (οἱ ἄρχοντες), he turned up at a second stage, the most violent one, in which he tried to induce Pionius and his companions to abjure[923].

In *M. Pion.,* 9, 1, we pass on to the official recording of the proceedings (γράφοντος τοῦ νοταρίου πάντα) effected by Polemon, in which Pionius and his companions maintained their attitude in a firm manner. If the source of *Martyrdom of Pionius* up until chapter 19 is the σύγγραμμα of Pionius, it is probable that the interrogation has been also placed here on the basis of the memories of the accused and not from the formal proceedings.

Chapters 15 to 18 of the *Martyrdom of Pionius* contain the report of an attempt at out-of-court settlement, to which the accused energetically demanded respect of the legality of the process, which indicated the presence of the proconsul as the next step and not, as Polemon and the commander of the cavalry (ἵππαρχος) Theophilus desired, to continue to induce those on trial to abjure. Pionius, in the face of the insistence of these not to conform to the legal procedure, shouted out: "Respect piety, do honour to justice, show respect for your companions! See that they carry out your laws! They punish us because we do not obey, and you yourselves disobey: they have received the order to punish us, not to force our will"[924].

Of the session of public hearing before the proconsul Quintilianus, the writer of the *Martyrdom of Pionius* gives a report which may be considered to be based on the official proceedings. As regards the hearing and the interrogation, the apparently literal extracts from the dialogue between the judge and the accused are probably due to the consultation of documents on the trial kept in the archives of the city of Smyrna. The imperial bureaucracy took great care of its official proceedings; as from the first century, the presence at the trial of *notarii,*

921 Cf. *M. Pion.*, 7, 1. At the time of Decius we find similar situations described by Cyprian and in the martyrdom of Perpetua, cf. G. Lanata, *Gli atti dei martiri come documenti processuali,* 175.

922 Cf. *M. Pion.*, 10, 8.

923 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 16, 5.

924 *M. Pion.*, 16, 6; cf. *M. Polyc.,* 12, 2.

stenographer-secretaries, ensured the recording of debates and of the sentences passed[925]. Smyrna was one of the cities in the province of Asia visited by the proconsul in his annual tour of judicial hearings[926].

We find that the only person accused is Pionius. It may be that in the eyes of the writer, Pionius occupied the prevalent position in the group and accordingly from a vaster protocol he extracted only the part concerning him; or else in fact only he remained accused, because the administration tended to punish the head, adopting more rigorous procedures and sanctions for those in charge of the Christian organisations. At least this is the impression given by some of the questions posed to Pionius by the proconsul: "Are you his master? Answer: Yes, I am his master"; Question: Master of madness? Answer: Of piety"[927].

Together with the identification of the accused, the proconsul, following the requirement of the edict of Decius, asked Pionius, first of all, if he was prepared to sacrifice to the gods[928]. On the negative reply by the martyr, he proceeded to ask him to which cult or sect he belonged. Pionius declared that he belonged to the catholics (τῶν καθολικῶν). The proconsul's next question: "What kind of Catholics?", may be interpreted in the sense that for the official the word "καθολικός" had the usual meaning of "general" or "universal". Pionius answered that he was a presbyter of the Catholic Church[929]. In the Christian sense, the term "καθολικός" is used already in the second century by Ignatius and by the *Martyrdom of Polycarp*[930]. In the fourth century this designation of the Church became definitive.

Thereafter, the proconsul and the accused passed on to a little counterpoint frequent in anti-pagan polemics regarding not confusing the worship of creatures with worship of the Creator: In the face of the proconsul's accusation that the accused aspired to heaven, Pionius replies that his gaze is addressed to Him who created the air and the sky and everything in them[931].

After Pionius' silence, they passed on to his torture by means of an *eculeus*, which is an instrument in which the victim is suspended so as to stretch his

925 Cf. A. Bastiaensen – A. Hilhorst, *Atti e passioni dei martiri,* 32.

926 Cf. G. Burton, *Proconsuls, Assizes and Administration of Justice under the Empire,* in *The Journal of Roman Studies* 65 (1975), 92–106; on Smyrna in particular, 92–95.

927 *M. Pion.,* 19, 6–7.

928 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 19, 3; 7, 2.

929 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 20, 5.

930 Cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 8, 2*; M. Polyc.,* 8, 1; 16, 2; 19, 2.

931 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 20, 8–13; cf. *Rom* 1, 25 "(men) worshipped and served creatures instead of the Creator".

limbs and which was shaped like a hook[932]. Before pronouncing the final sentence, the proconsul threatened the victim for the last time to abjure, while reproaching him with his haste to die, comparing his scorn of death to that of men who enter in the hope of small gain for the *ludi gladiatorii*. Those men recalled by the proconsul accepted to display their skill as gladiators since they had nothing to lose[933]. At the martyr's final refusal, he was condemned to be burned to death.

On being led to the stadium, Pionius spontaneously took off his clothes, allowing the onlookers to see that his body was still intact despite the torture undergone. His body was placed on the cross and he allowed the soldier to fix it with nails. After that they raised him up on the cross over a pile of firewood[934]. Together with Pionius, a Marcionite priest named Metrodorus who had undergone a separate proceeding, was also burned alive[935]. Whereas no further mention is made of Asclepiades or Sabina[936].

The similarity of the final fate of Pionius to that of Polycarp is undeniable, as are the differences. Both were executed in the stadium, they both spontaneously took off their clothes, were burned alive and their bodies miraculously resisted the flames so that all of those present, Christians and otherwise, reflected on the fate reserved to the just. However, unlike Pionius, Polycarp did not allow them to nail down his body, but merely to tie it to the cross. The Jews did not appear actively in the execution of Pionius, as they do by gathering up wood for the stake in Polycarp's martyrdom and insisting that the Christians should not recover his body. Pionius, at the crucial point, prayed in silence and only uttered a few words: "Lord, receive my soul"; whereas Polycarp pronounced a long prayer. The corpse of Polycarp, after being burned by the centurion, was recovered by the Christians and his bones were deposited in a suitable place for the purpose of celebrating his *dies natalis*. On the contrary, nothing is known of the body of Pionius after it was preserved despite the flames[937].

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932 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 21, 1–2; cf. A. Bastiaensen – A. Hilhorst, *Atti e passioni dei martiri,* 475.

933 Cf. G. Ville, *La gladiature en Occident,* Paris, 1982, 251.

934 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 21, 1–5.

935 Groups of Marcionites still survived even into the third century, as stated by Eusebius regarding the executions carried out in Caesarea of Palestine, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 7, 12.

936 Likewise in a martyrologium the only persons named are Pionius and Metrodorus, cf. *Martyrologium Hieronymianum (Adiectis Prolegomenis) Ex Acta Sanctorum,* ed. I. De Rossi and L. Duchesne, 31.

937 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 21 and 22, cf: *M. Polyc.,* 13–18.

Finally, it is interesting that the description of the body of the martyr Pionius after his execution is very similar to the appearance of the emperor Commodus according to a passage from the historian Herodian[938].

The text of the *Martyrdom of Pionius* says:

> Physically it was clear that he obtained the crown. Because after the fire went out, we ourselves who were there, saw his body like that of an athlete in full form. In fact, his ears were not even deformed, his hair had remained attached to the skin and his chin was shiny and serene like that of a newborn child. A prodigious grace still illumined his countenance; thus the Christians were ever more strengthened in their faith, while the incredulous remained shaken and their consciences intimidated[939].

Herodian's text regarding Commodus states:

> In addition to this ascendency and the fact that he was in the flower of his youth, Commodus was of impressive appearance, with a well proportioned and handsome manly face, his eyes burning and flashing, his hair was naturally arranged and curly, and when he came out into the sunlight it shone so splendidly that certain persons thought that it was gold dust sprinkled over him before his public appearances, although others considered it as something supernatural and said that a celestial halo shone around his head[940].

Herodian is an author delimited for us by his own historical context. His *History* narrates the happenings from the end of the reign of Marcus Aurelius in 180 and ends with the rise to power of Gordian III on the imperial throne in 238. Thus then, this author was able to write, between the governments of Philip, the Arab or of Decius, until the year 253 at the latest. The *Martyrdom of Pionius* was written about ten years later. It is most probable that the author of the *Martyrdom of Pionius* was inspired by Herodian, since it is improbable that Herodian found his inspiration in the *Martyrdom of Pionius,* which was a work of marginal literature, while the pagan author had a considerable number of good examples in Greek pagan literature. In any case, it is probable that both fragments are independent and perhaps are both inspired by an earlier source[941]. In both texts, the bodies of the two personages are in the full bloom (ἀκμή) of their youth. The brilliance around them arouses lively reactions in those who observe them. The beauty and

938 This similarity was highlighted by J. Kozlowski, *The Portrait of Commodus in Herodian's History (1, 7, 5–6) as the Source of Pionius' post-mortem Description in* Martyrium Pionii *(22, 2–4).* in *Vigiliae Cristianae* 62 (2008), 35–42.

939 *M. Pion.,* 22, 3–4.

940 Hdn., *Hist.,* 1, 7, 5–6.

941 Cf. V. Visa-Ondarçuhu, *L'image de l'Athlète d'Homère à la fin du Ve siècle avant J.-C.,* Paris 1999.

splendour of their faces is associated with the divinity ascribed to them by the observers. The juxtapositions of lexicon and syntax are similar. The description of both of them appears almost in the same sequence. In Commodus: eyes, hair, beard; while in Pionius: ears, hair and beard. The differences between the two narrations are easily explainable bearing in mind the context in which each takes its place. Christian martyrial literature must redeem and underline different dimensions from pagan literature[942].

The *Martyrdom of Pionius,* after historically framing in a precise manner the happenings reported, naming the Roman proconsul, the consul emperors, the date and hour according to the Roman calendar, ends with a doxology which suggests that this text was used in the liturgy of the church of Smyrna[943].

Despite the persecution of Decius, its medium-term effects were not those awaited from the politics of the Emperor; already prior to his death on the battlefield in his war against the Goths in the Danubian provinces, the vast majority of the *lapsi* had begun to return to the Church and many of the *libellatici* made further reparation for their fault with valiant witnesses of faith. For the Church, this nonetheless provided the occasion to reflect on its own situation of weakness and constancy in the faith professed, finally leading to a long discussion around the question of penance[944].

6. The persecutions under Valerian, Diocletian and Maximinus Daia

After the following years of tranquillity[945], with the arrival of Valerian to power in 253, a new age of peace seemed at first to be consolidated. At first, Valerian had a favourable attitude to Christians, whom he even welcomed in his own home, as is testified by Dionysius of Alexandria in his letter to Hermammon[946], but later things changed radically and the Emperor, seemingly influenced by the future

942 Cf. J. Kozlowski, *The Portrait of Commodus in Herodian's History (1, 7, 5–6) as the Source of Pionius*' post-mortem *Description* in *Martyrium Pionii (22, 2–4),* in *Vigiliae Christianae* 62 (2008), 38–39. Cf. A. Monaci Castagno, *Pagani e cristiani nello specchio della biografia,* in *La biografia di Origene fra storia e agiografia,* Verucchio 2004, 51–109.

943 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 23.

944 Cf. pp. 291 et seqq.

945 Only interrupted by the persecution in Rome of Cornelius and his successor Lucius by the emperor Trebonianus Gallus.

946 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 7, 10, 3.

usurper Macrinus, saw in the confiscation of Christians' property the possibility of remedying the financial situation of the Empire. The first edict issued by emperor Valerian ordered attacks on the clergy: bishops, presbyters, and deacons were to sacrifice to the gods of the Empire; every minister celebrating the cult or meetings in cemeteries was to be punished by death. Subsequently, another edict dated 258 went even further, ordering the execution of any clergymen who refused to sacrifice, meanwhile the ruling class among the laymen in the church is persecuted along with senators and knights expropriated from their fortunes and honours: refusal to sacrifice meant exile for their wives and the death penalty for them. For the first time, Valerian's edicts already, not only in substance as in the case of the edict of Decius, but explicitly, were directed against the Christians and in them the Church was conceived as a unitary body, thus radically changing the rules in force thus far.

As usual, the application of the edicts depended on the discretionality enjoyed by the provincial governors. The Christians were indiscriminately attacked in some regions, while in others, only the category of Christians indicated in the edicts. With a few exceptions, it appears that the pagan population did not collaborate in this persecution against the Christians, perhaps because their presence was beginning to be accepted as a normal fact in many environments. Notwithstanding, the new persecution, although brief, was surprisingly harsh and bloodthirsty in particular cases[947]. In the region of Asia Minor, Lycia recorded the martyrdom of Paregonius and of the hermit Leo[948]. In the face of this fresh persecution, it seems that the Christians responded with greater courage with few reports of cases of *lapsi*. Perhaps the reflection made following the persecution of Decius had had its effect.

With the rise of Gallienus to power in the year 260, 40 years of prosperity for the Christians began and by means of a rescript, the restitution of their property by the Emperor, thus recognising the existence of the Church not only in fact but by law. This act of far-reaching tolerance allowed the Christians to build many churches without impediment, to propagate Christianity among Greeks and barbarians, and to occupy various posts at court. Although Christian sources present Gallienus in positive terms – for example, Eusebius celebrated this time as an age of glory and freedom for Christianity[949] –, they did not see the attribution

947 Bishop Cyprian of Carthage and other Christians were condemned to hard labour and were thereafter executed, Sixtus II died a martyr in Rome together with his deacons, Dionysius of Alexandria suffered exile, and various executions took place in Tarragona.

948 Cf. P. Allard, *Storia critica delle persecuzioni,* Florence 1935, vol. III, 133–135.

949 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 7, 13; 8, 1, 1–6.

of a new juridical status to Christians in the Emperor's provisions, but considered the enactments merely a personal attitude on the part of the Emperor. However, recent criticism has recognised an important novelty in the rescript of Gallienus perhaps not recognised by the ancient sources on account of the oversimplified presentation of the contraposition of a long period of hostility to the period inaugurated by Constantine[950].

As we may note, the literary sources which have come down to us say little of the struggle between paganism and Christianity during the second half of the third century in the region of Asia. Nonetheless, it appears clear that Christianity had been consistently propagated in this region, so that with the subsequent persecutions of Diocletian and Maximinus Daia, it was highlighted that numerous Christians occupied official posts, including within the court of Nicomedia, and well organised Christian communities existed in the region of Bithynia and in Nicaea, Chalcedon and Bursa. The Christian presence was likewise strong in Galatia, Phrygia, and Pisidia where the bishops came together in synods. Synods were set up in Iconium and Synnada. In Ancyra, a metropolis in Galatia, a synod was organised in 314, the proceedings of which have been kept. Laodicea, metropolitan see of Phrygia, was directed by Sagaris, its famous bishop and martyr, and this province counted on an abundant participation of bishops in Nicaea. In the persecution by Diocletian, a whole city in Phrygia was set on fire because it had become completely Christian by this time[951]. Lycia and Pamphylia participated with various bishops in Nicaea, which gives some idea of the missionary work in that area. So that, in all the regions neighbouring on Asia, the Christian presence appears significant, thus we may consider that it was also so in Asia itself. In fact, as remarked earlier, many sepulchral inscriptions exist throughout Asia Minor dating from the third century, while it seems that the building of Christian temples was likewise widespread. A number of temples exist in the small city of Amasea in Pontus at the time of Licinius and undoubtedly this was far from being the only such case[952]. One might possibly consider that Smyrna in this period enjoyed the same propitious climate for the consolidation of the Christian faith in the city; however, no further information on the community in this period is forthcoming.

Accordingly, in the 40 years before the great persecution of Diocletian, the Christians, especially in Asia Minor, enjoyed freedom of confession, freedom of

950 Cf. M. Simonetti, *Il Vangelo e la storia,* 124.
951 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 8, 11, 1.
952 Cf. Eus., *v. C.,* 2, 1, 2.

worship, and freedom of preaching, all of which allowed believers of all social conditions to publicly proclaim their religious belief, to take part in the Christian liturgy, and to build places of worship. Nevertheless, the Christian religion, which had only relatively recently received the status of a tolerated religion, was still liable to the threat of new reforms in the restructuring of the Empire, which were generally accompanied by aspects connected with religous practice. Accordingly, the change of sentiment of an emperor or the religious favour awakened in society by certain imperial reforms, were sufficient to totally change the situation of the Christians from one moment to the next. The emperor Aurelian himself who governed from 270 to 275, at the end of his life was apparently preparing a new edict against the Christians, which was cut short by his sudden death[953].

General animosity against the Christians stimulated, on the one hand, by the cultured men of paganism such as Porphyry and Hierocles[954], and on the other, by the pagan priesthood which itself felt progressively threatened in its privileges[955], were the hotbed for the most bloody persecution against the Christians about to take place under Diocletian.

After an initial period of vacillation, once he had solved many of the problems of the Empire, such as the security of its frontiers, economic solidarity and political tranquillity[956], Diocletian set about attempting to restore the old Roman

953 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 7, 30, 20–21; cf. Lact., *mort.,* 6 (SCh 39, 84).

954 In their works, Porphyry and Hierocles made a systematic attack on all the principles of Christianity: on the person of Christ, placing him lower than the thaumaturgist Apollonius of Tyana; on the Christian scriptures, highlighting the contradictions contained in them; on the foremost figures of this religion, accusing them of having a low profile, especially Peter and Paul; jeering at their liturgical celebrations; and questioning their claim of being in an exclusive position with regard to the truth. Both authors will be contested by Christians such as Eusebius and Lactantius.

955 Eusebius tells how Diocletian, ever undecided at the prospect of a violent persecution, had apparently sent for an augur to consult an oracle of Apollo in Miletus; it was only the response of the oracle, which was contrary to the Christian religion, that finally decided the Emperor, cf. Eus., *v. C.,* 2, 50–51 (PG 20 1027–1029).

956 Diocletian was acclaimed Emperor by the army. He managed to accede to the throne after a brief confrontation with Carinus, the other son of the emperor Carus, in the battle of the Margus. Diocletian appointed Maximian co-emperor, granting him the title of Augustus of the West in 285. In the year 293, he appointed Galerius and Constantius as Caesars, a title similar to that of prince or heir of the Augustus. This new system, known as the Tetrarchy, or "government by four", implied that the government of the Empire was geographically sliced up between the four rulers.

religion, deliberately acting against the Christians. His first action was a purge of the army by an edict dated 300 in which all soldiers were to sacrifice to the gods or leave the army[957]. However, he did not issue any other sanctions, and the officers of the legions in Asia, considering that the Emperor had benevolent intentions still, did not dare go beyond the instructions received. Lactantius affirms that there was no bloodshed and that exclusion from the army or demotion were the only penalties imposed: "The Emperor's ire stopped here, he did no more against the divine law or against religion"[958].

In the year 303, another edict of a general nature ordered the demolition of all Christian temples and the handing over and burning of holy books with the prohibition of all meetings for celebration of worship. In addition, the Christians were declared disqualified from any juridically valid proceeding within the Empire[959]. This was followed by three more edicts in less than one year, having the persecution of bishops, presbyters, deacons, lectores and exorcists as a direct objective[960]. Thanks to indirect testimonies, we may infer that in Asia many churches were destroyed in Asia, from the care with which, once peace had been restored, the bishops of this area rebuilt in each place[961]. This was also the case of the church of Tyre on which a report has come down to us on the destruction and reconstruction which may be similar to the events in Asia[962].

With the administrative system of the Tetrarchy set in hand by Diocletian, it is clear that each one of the administrative centres applied the intensity of persecution against the Christians in a distinct manner. When the two *Augusti* of that time, Diocletian and Maximinus abdicated, in the ensuing tetrarchies likewise the diversity with which the administrative centres of the Empire continued to carry out their orders against the Christians became apparent. In the western part of the Empire Severus, Constantine and Maxentius were tolerant

957 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 8, 4, 2–3. The Christians were not enemies of military service in itself. What they objected to was taking part in an act of pagan worship, such as that imposed by the imperial cult, ever since the sovereigns had proclaimed themselves sons of Jupiter and of Hercules, cf. Lact., *mort*., 10 (SCh 39, 88–89).

958 Cf. Lact., *mort.,* 10 (SCh 39, 88–89).

959 Cf. Lact., *mort.,* 13 (SCh 39, 91–92); cf. Eus., *h. e.* 8, 2, 4.

960 The first city to feel the effects of the great persecution was Nicomedia, the principal church was destroyed, and after a number of fires in the imperial palaces, the chastisement for the Christians was even greater: many were obliged to sacrifice and there were many executions. All the rest of the Empire followed suit.

961 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 10, 2.

962 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 10, 4, 26.

of Christianity; whereas the eastern part of the Empire suffered the harshness of the persecution under Maximimus Daia and Galerius, the latter being especially cruel at the beginning of his government[963]. Maximinus Daia issued a new edict for rebuilding the destroyed pagan temples and for providing newer, more detailed prescriptions on how to make sacrifices to the gods[964], and sought to expel the Christians from the cities. The tactic adopted by Maximinus Daia consisted of encouraging the Gentiles to present petitions to the Emperor asking him to prohibit Christians from staying in the cities. This proceeding proved successful in many cities in the Empire, since Maximinus answered to every such petition with rescripts granting the grace requested. The cities themselves felt highly honoured by the imperial response and engraved memorials *ad perpetuam rei memoriam,* such as that which is preserved in the small city of Arycanda in Phrygia[965]. Another tactic of Maximinus consisted of defaming the Christians by means of the false *Acts of Pilate,* which were utilised as schoolbooks for children to learn by heart[966].

The edict of tolerance of Galerius in 311 was a document having unprecedented effects, since one of the highest representatives of Roman power revoked the religious policy hostile to Christianity which had applied for over 200 years. The religion of the Christians ceased to be a *superstitio* or *religio illicita* and was tolerantly considered on par with all the other cults by means of a juridical document[967]. However, the edict took some time to become reality throughout the Empire, and in fact, Maximinus Daia openly started up persecutions once more, attacking especially the bishops and other members of the clergy[968].

With the convention of Milan in 313 and the arrival of Constantine to absolute power in the Empire, the situation of the Christians, as is well known, changed radically in their favour, the ecclesiastical goods confiscated were returned to them, and the Church was recognised by the Empire as an independent society.

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963 The martyrdom of the deacon Romanus in Antioch of Syria still exists, revealing the cruelty of Galerius in the persecution, cf. Eus., *m. P.,* 2 (SCh 55, 124–126).

964 Cf. Eus., *m. P.,* 9, 2 (SCh 55, 148).

965 Cf. A. Di Bernadino, *Atlante Storico del Cristianesimo Antico,* Bologna 2010, 144.

966 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 9, 5, 1.

967 Cf. Lact., *mort.,* 34 (SHh 39, 117–118); cf. Eus., *h. e.* 8, 17, 3–10.

968 Dating from this time, the martyrdoms of Peter of Alexandria, Silvanus of Emesa, Basiliscus of Comana and Lucianus, priest of Antioch should be highlighted, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 8, 13, 3–4; 9, 6, 1. Lucianus was taken to Nicomedia and judged by Maximinus Daia in person on 7 January of the year 312, cf. Thdt., *h. e.,* 1, 3 (SCh 501, 144 et seqq.).

With the edict of the year 323, the last vestiges of the persecution of Licinius were wiped out[969]. And thus we come to the beginning of the fourth century, the cut-off time limit for our research.

7. Conclusion

From this synthesis on the imperial cult and the persecutions of Christians in Asia, particularly in Smyrna, from the end of the first century to the beginning of the fourth century, the following conclusions may be drawn.

Before the enforcement of the policies of Trajan, no law existed for juridically regulating the attitude of the Roman Empire towards Christians. The hostile attitude of the pagan population created an environment in which being a Christian was incompatible with the style of life of the Roman Empire. The persecutions which ensued from this fact were of local character only, arising sporadically and directed against the Christians as private persons. In general, they were the outcome of tumults of the pagan population, sometimes supported by the Jewish population, and only then was the need felt for the state authority to intervene. The number of victims continued to be relatively slight.

Under the last two Antonini, Marcus Aurelius and Commodus, the policies established under Trajan were consolidated. Christians are brought before the tribunals when denounced as such to the authority; however, a profession of the Christian faith is sufficient for them to be condemned without any need to demonstrate other crimes. Under Marcus Aurelius it seems that public opinion became more hostile against Christians since they were accused more often.

In the intermittent periods of peace, but never with total juridical security, Christian life in Asia Minor spread powerfully. The systematic and bloody persecutions of Decius, Valerian, Diocletian and Maximinus Daia hit the community hard, but did nor succeed in destroying it; on the contrary, it helped fortify the strength of its spirit and the identity of its religious belief.

The Christians of Asia, and of Smyrna in particular, were very likely victims of these persecutions at any moment in this historical period, although following

969 Galerius in the year 308 granted the title of Augustus to Licinius, who was entrusted with the provinces of Illyria and Pannonia, subsequently consolidating his power in the East. Following a series of defeats to Constantine, he was finally defeated on 18 September of the year 324. During his government, he attempted the last persecutions of Christians in the areas coming under his influence, cf. P. Allard, *Storia critica delle persecuzioni,* 305.

the persecution of Decius, we find no precise sources that report the sufferings of the community of Smyrna.

As we have had occasion to note, apart from the environment hostile to the Christian faith, the causes and consequences of which are difficult to spell out as it appears in the *Revelation* and the whole question of Ignatius and his path of martyrdom, the community of Smyrna has transmitted to us two literary testimonies of first order on its history as regards the persecutions of Christianity by the Empire. Both the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* and the *Martyrdom of Pionius* are valid sources for the facts they provide regarding the way in which the Empire juridically proceeded against Christians, the environment of social nervousness described, the martyrial theology that the Christians of Smyrna developed in them, etc. Each of them reflects in a particular way the experience of the Christians of Smyrna in the circumstance limit of persecution in the times of Antoninus Pius and of Decius, respectively.

At the same time, we have also noted the paucity of news on Smyrna and in general on Asia as far as the other persecutions are concerned. We may consider that, like the Christians in all the rest of the Empire, the Christians in Asia suffered more or less each one of the persecutions in the same circumstances, although as usual, application of the edicts depended on the discretionality enjoyed by the provincial governors. Nonethelesss, perhaps due to these consequences of the persecutions, any such testimonies were lost. Even so, as a result of the general knowledge we have of the persecutions of Christians before the Council of Nicaea, we may state that the Christian community of Smyrna transmitted important testimonies in its writings and, in comparison with other important churches of which we know truly little, considerable material has come into our possession.

Conclusion

Throughout this second part, we have analysed how the region of Asia and in particular the city of Smyrna enjoy a multicultural environment which profoundly influences the reality of the Christians. Smyrna is a city of Greek culture, open to every form of religiosity of Antiquity and surrounded by great pagan sanctuaries which enable us to perceive the openmindedness of the population to the divine mystery, as also the difficulties of a monotheistic confession like that of Christianity in making a space for itself in the midst of this religious market.

Particularly in the second century of the Christian era, the cities of Asia Minor and Smyrna in particular are important enclaves for the Roman Empire, representing its image of prosperity, and at the same time the inevitable and accordingly strategic crossroads of the Empire in its contact with the whole of the East. This period of great economic prosperity is accompanied by a great cultural activity and the phenomenon of the Second Sophistic was especially a veritable cultural awakening that profoundly sensitised the elevated social circles, leading to the development of a vast literary activity, as is clear from the work of the Smyrnaean Aelius Aristides. Clearly, this reality in the pagan context influenced the Christian intellectuals who enjoyed this culturally favourable climate. Proof of this is in the quantity and quality of Christian literature produced in the region between the end of the first and the middle of the second century, including of course the Christian literature addressed to, born, or copied in Smyrna.

Besides, the cities of the region enjoyed the approved policy of Rome and its emperors, but in their turn felt themselves obliged to respond with the imperial cult and with the rule of Roman law in their lands. The Christians, by refuting the imperial cult and indifferent to pagan worship, found themselves immersed in an ever-growing persecution in the midst of the general disapproval of the population.

For its part, Judaism in Asia played an important role in the understanding of itself that Christianity acquired in the region; its presence was strong and in many cases antagonistic to the Christians, as was especially evident in times of persecution.

Throughout its history in these first three centuries, the Christian community of Smyrna bore the persecution and hostility of its surroundings. Thanks to the sources that have come down to us, we can at least record this situation, particularly at the time of Domitian, Antoninus Pius and Decius, although we

cannot exclude that it lived through various other times of grave difficulty. At the internal level too, the community suffered the consequences of the schism and heresy embodied in the figure of Noetus and the scandal of apostasy in the figure of its bishop Euctemon.

Nevertheless, the Christian community proved to be sure of itself, brave under persecution, firm in the faith received, and proud of its apostolic origins. By means of its literature, it reasoned on and confronted the opinions of its adversaries, whether pagan or Jewish, and even invited them to embrace the new faith.

From the beginning, the community of Smyrna found itself enriched in its Christian identity thanks to the influence of the authority and doctrine both of Paul and later of John throughout Asia, as likewise it received new souls and doctrine thanks to the visit of Ignatius of Antioch, attaining outstanding leadership in the Christian communities of Asia with its bishop and martyr Polycarp.

In addition to Polycarp, the Church of Smyrna built up its identity thanks to other distinguished leaders including among them the figures of Marcion, Irenaeus, Limnus the presbyter, Pionius the presbyter and martyr, Dioscorides the martyr, and Eutyches bishop of Smyrna in Nicaea.

Hereafter, we will be studying the reception and interpretation made of the Old Testament and the apostolic traditions in the community of Smyrna, and thereafter we will dwell on certain theological and ecclesial aspects of the community.

Part Three
Theological and Ecclesial Aspects of the Community of Smyrna

Introduction

In this third part we propose, in the first four chapters, to study the presence and use made of Scripture in the sources presented in the first part, especially those concerning the period prior to the establishment of the canon and full acceptance of the Old Testament as patrimony of the church, that is to say, up to the end of the second century. So that, we will first of all study the use and valorisation of the Hebrew Scriptures that Ignatius, Polycarp, and the author of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* made of it. After that, we will study the reception of the tradition of the apostles that these same authors made apparent in their writings, in particular the reception of the Pauline, synoptic and Johannine traditions.

For this undertaking, we will analyse the *corpus Ignatianum* in general, bearing in mind that Ignatius wrote letters to various communities from Smyrna. This rough mix of Scripture and Tradition which Ignatius worked into his letters, must have been taken over and guarded like a treasure by the community of Smyrna, as proven by the fact that it was this community which kept the letters of Ignatius and made copies of them, for the benefit of later generations.

As a fundamental point, we will analyse Polycarp's letter *To the Philippians* in this third part, which is undoubtedly an all-important text since besides being the only one we still have of the bishop of Smyrna, it was written by the head of that community, whence we deduce that the oral and written Christian traditions which Polycarp shows himself to possess were known by the Christians of Smyrna.

Another text of no less importance, which we have already mentioned in connection with the persecutions, is the *Martyrdom of Polycarp.* There too, we will find possible allusions to the Old Testament from the hand of the writer and above all, the oral and written traditions of the community.

We hope that the analysis of the reception of the Old Testament and of the traditions of the apostles, above all the Pauline, the synoptic and the Johannine, will enable us to answer various questions regarding the Christian documents that the community of Smyrna concretely held in the second century, if it possessed any texts of the future New Testament in writing, if it is possible to identify a greater presence of one rather than another apostolic tradition, the importance ascribed to these writings, whether they were documents for community reference endowed with singular authority, whether their importance was the same, less or more than the valorisation made of the Old Testament, and the context in which they drew on these possible writings. We aim to answer these and other

questions on the basis of an analysis of the writings we possess and which derived from the community of Smyrna, largely in the period in which Polycarp was bishop.

In the last two chapters of this third part, in the context of the formation of Orthodoxy compared to various groups and trends, we will analyse the gradual process whereby the content of the faith of the Church of Smyrna takes shape and becomes binding, starting from the development of the *lex orandi* and the *lex credendi.* Finally, we will study the sacramental and spiritual life of the community, concerning ourselves in particular with the conception which the community of Smyrna has of itself as a particular Church and in relation to the other church communities, the configuration of its hierarchical and ministerial structure, the development of reflection on penance, the sacrament of the Eucharist, the celebration of Easter, and the cult of its martyrs. For these two chapters, we will analyse all the sources in our possession on the Church of Smyrna from its foundation up to the Council of Nicaea.

We hope that the study of all of these different theological and ecclesial aspects will permit us to perceive in some way the particular style of the Christian community of Smyrna in the first centuries of its existence.

Chapter VIII: The Old Testament in the Church of Smyrna

After the obvious initial acceptance of the Hebrew Scriptures in the first Christians coming from the Jewish environment, this soon came into tension with the novelty of the message of Jesus and its opening up to the arrival of the Gentiles. The writings of the Church of Smyrna are an example of this situation in the first half of the second century, as also the timid development of an interpretation capable of fully reintegrating by the end of the second century the Old Testament with the patrimony of Christian faith, against the claim of certain heretical groups to cut this tradition down from the root.

Hereafter we will make a brief synthesis of the reception of the Old Testament in the early Christian community[970] and thereafter an analysis of this reception in the writings of the Church of Smyrna in particular.

1. The Old Testament in the early Christian community

The first Christians were Jews by race and education, and accordingly, they had no doubts in accepting the Old Testament as the revelation of God, interpreting it in the same way in which Judaism did in its time, though adapting it to the new requirements of their Christian faith. Nevertheless, the traditional Jewish interpretation of the Old Testament soon entered into tension with the novelty of the message of salvation on identifying the messianic prophesies with the person of

970 Regarding the interpretation of the Holy Scriptures throughout this period of Christianity, we are deeply endebted to the classical study by M. Simonetti, *Lettere e/o allegoria. Un contributo alla storia dell'esegesi patristica,* Rome 1985, 19–20 and of P. Grech*, Problemi di interpretazione dell'Antico Testamento nei primi secoli,* in *Il messaggio biblico e la sua interpretazione,* Bologna 2005, 115–128. Cf. B. McLean, *Citations and allusions to Jewish Scripture in Early Christian and Jewish Writings through 180 C.E.,* Lewiston 1992. Cf. C. Evans – J. Sanders (ed.), *Paul and the Scriptures of Israel,* Sheffield 1993. Cf. R. Bieringer – D. Pollefeyt (ed.), and *Paul and Judaism: crosscurrents in Pauline exegesis and the study of Jewish-Christian relations,* London 2012. In this study, we have designated the Holy Scriptures of the Jewish people with the biblical and traditional expression of "Old Testament" which in itself has no negative connotation. The name of "Old Testament" given to this series of writings, is an expression forged by the apostle Paul to designate the writings attributed to Moses (cf. *2 Co* 3, 14–15).

Jesus himself. The tension of this interpretative novelty is perceived throughout the texts forming the New Testament.

On the one hand, the requirement of deepening the meaning and work of Jesus Christ in relation to the Jewish tradition led various Christians to include the new faith in a religious and cultural frame of strict Jewish observance, in which the old Law maintained all of its validity. For example, in *Mt* 5, 7, when Jesus reaffirms the validity and intangibility of the Law.

On the other hand, this attitude appeared polemical to many Christians coming from environments less tied to the Jewish inheritance, who sought to make the old Law assume a more spiritual than literal dimension and be interpreted in a christological key. Even, in the case of Paul of Tarsus, the ancient covenant was interpreted on two levels, not destroying the historicity of the ancient happening, but adding a new spiritual meaning to it. Such a relationship between the two levels of reading and meaning was defined as *typos* by Paul and such a way of interpreting the Old Testament was destined to prove highly successful, until as time went on, it became converted to the Christian reading of the Hebrew Scripture par excellence.

The paucity of Christian literature of the subapostolic period which we are dealing with bears witness to the continuation of these different attitudes that we find in the New Testament with regard to the interpretation of the Old Testament. Besides, the different forms of literal or typological interpretation are not necessarily closely linked with the Jewish or pagan environment from which given Christian authors proceed.

Following this brief summary, we now prepare to analyse the reception of the Old Testament starting from the sources linked with the Church of Smyrna.

2. The Old Testament in the letters of Ignatius

In his letters written from Smyrna, Ignatius barely quotes the Old Testament. It is noteworthy that the quotations that Ignatius makes from the Old Testament do not exceed ten, and none is concerned with the Law. Furthermore, Ignatius though following Paul in many ways, makes no typology of the Old Testament. Ignatius appears to accept the Scripture, though not very enthusiastically, and some have proposed the hypothesis that he only knew it as a collection of *Testimonia*[971]. Ignatius accepts the divinely inspired character of the Scripture,

971 Cf. H. Riesenfeld poses the question of whether in an ethno-Christian environment such as that of Antioch, at the time of Ignatius the translation into Greek of the whole of the Jewish scripture were possible, cf. H. Riesenfeld, *Reflections on the Style*

because he introduces it with "it is written (γέγραπται)" when he quotes it explicitly; however, there are in fact only three explicit quotations (Ign., *Eph.,* 5, 3*; Magn.,* 12; and *Trall.,* 8, 2), two from *Proverbs* and one from *Isaiah*, plus a certain number of allusions.

Even so, the few allusions to the Old Testament are significant. In *Smyrn.,* 5, 1, he enumerates the Law and the Prophets together with the Gospel. Despite the fact that he appears to balance the Gospel against the Old Testament in *Philad.,* 8, 2 in the following chapter, Ignatius remarks that the Gospel is the consummation of the Old Testament: "The Gospel contains something extraordinary: the coming of the Saviour, Our Lord Jesus Christ, his passion and resurrection. The beloved Prophets announced Him. But the Gospel is the completion of immortality. All things together are good, if ye believe through love"[972].

Although the Old Testament is largely absent in Ignatius and this absence may be interpreted as a certain sign of suspicion by some Christian environments of pagan origin towards the Old Testament, Ignatius cannot be considered as an absolute witness with little appreciation of the Old Testament, especially the Prophets: "Let us love the Prophets too who also announced the Gospel, waited for him (Jesus Christ) and expected him. For having believed in him, they were saved since they were in the unity of Christ"[973].

This appreciation of the Prophets as announcers of Christ and of the new economy of the Church changes the traditional way until then prescribed in the Judaeo-Christian environment of witness of the Scripture. In fact, Ignatius is the first author of whom we have knowledge of who appreciates Christ for the authority of his redeeming work and the Jewish Scripture only insofar as it is a prophecy of it.

3. The Old Testament in Polycarp's letter To the Philippians

It should be noted that the use Polycarp makes of the Old Testament is truly slight, since we find only some possible allusions to it[974]. Ch. Nielsen and W. Kümmel have come to consider that this is perhaps due to a certain Marcionite influence over Polycarp, since he makes no reference to the Old Testament

and the Theology of St Ignatius, in *F.L. Cross (hrsg.),* in *Studia Patristica IV,* Berlin 1969, 320.

972 Cf. Ign., *Philad.,* 9, 2.

973 Cf. Ign., *Philad.,* 5, 2.

974 *Ps* 2, 1, in Polyc., *ep.,* 2, 1; *Pr* 3, 4, in Polyc., *ep.,* 6, 1; *Hier* 5, 4, in Polyc., *ep.,* 11, 2; *Ps* 4, 5, in Polyc., *ep.,* 12, 1.

while instead he quotes texts from the New Testament in abundance[975]. Others think that his slight use of the Old Testament is due to lack of knowledge of the Scripture which he himself, Polycarp, acknowledges at least at the time of writing this letter[976].

However, it is necessary to also bear in mind that Polycarp wrote *To the Philippians* to solve above all the practical problem of the theft made by bishop Valens, not to give a great theological instruction which would imply an abundant use of the Scriptures. Moreover, it is logical to consider that in order to legitimise the authority of his counsels, he would only insist on New Testament traditions, above all in Paul's letter *To the Philippians*, and likewise in *1 Clement,* on account of the authority these two writings already had in the community. The quotation of Paul's writings in this letter seems obvious, since it was he who was the founder of the community to which Polycarp addresses himself. Polycarp also makes use of *1 Peter* above all to emphasise moral aspects. The synoptic tradition is used above all to draw on part of the Sermon on the Mount or that part of *Our Father* dealing with forgiveness of sins. Accordingly, Polycarp used all of this material in the form of a moral exhortation, so that we may say that the selection of texts made by him is due above all to the paraenetic intent which shows more than a predilection for Marcionite theology[977]. This fact suggests that the Christian authors of the second century were able to make their moral exhortations by referring exclusively to the New Testament tradition, without this necessarily implying non-recognition of the authority of the Old Testament.

And lastly, we also find a reference by Polycarp to the prediction made by the Prophets of the Lord's coming in *To the Philippians* 6, 3, which clearly goes against Marcion's point of view with regard to the Old Testament. We cannot conclude that Polycarp expressed himself clearly here against Marcion; however, we may state that the juxtaposition that Polycarp makes in the sense that the Apostles have transmitted the Gospel and the Prophets have announced the coming of the Lord reveals that Polycarp does not discard the Old Testament as a

975 Cf. Ch. Nielsen, *Polycarp and Marcion: A Note,* in *Theological Studies* 47 (1986), 297–299, cf. W. Kümmel, *Introduction to the New Testament,* Nashville 1975, 484.

976 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 12, 1. For its part, the third-century *Life of Polycarp* seems to contradict this supposed lack of knowledge, depicting him as a young man an assiduous student of Scripture; however, on account of its eminently hagiographical nature, this testimony cannot be accepted as reliable, cf. *V. Polyc.,* 6, 1–3; 19.

977 For a good study on the paraenetical characteristics of Polycarp's letter *To the Philippians,* cf. M. Holmes, *The Apostolic Fathers: Greek Texts and English Translations,* 1999.

source of authority. This same juxtaposition between Apostles and Prophets was used in a similar manner by Ignatius[978].

4. The Old Testament in the Martyrdom of Polycarp

It should come as no surprise that the quotations from the Old Testament in this writing are indeed scarce, since the theological purpose of the writing is to make a paragon with events narrated exclusively in the New Testament traditions. As already mentioned, the intention and theological method of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* is to reflect on the Bishop of Smyrna and his following of Christ in line with the Gospel so as to stimulate others to follow suit[979]. The original author of the letter or the possible subsequent editors, in order to put this didactic purpose into effect, preferred to make reference to episodes of the Gospel or to sayings of Jesus rather than resort to passages from the Old Testament. The key to understanding the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* is the imitation, but above all, the interpretation it makes of the passion of Jesus through references to the accounts of the passion appearing in the Gospels, although as we will see hereafter, these references are not necessarily formal quotations from them. It is also interesting to note that the very rare indirect references to the Old Testament which may be found in the acts of the martyrs are used in a similar manner in the *Shepherd* of Hermas, a book of Judaeo-Christian tradition of the Church of Rome. The *Shepherd* and the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* contain these implicit quotations which indicate a closeness to the Psalms and the books of wisdom[980].

Nor can we accuse the author of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* of being a Marcionist on account of not quoting the Old Testament, since as we will see hereafter, the direct or indirect references he makes to the New Testament are not based only on the version of Luke's Gospel or the letters of Paul, preferred and

978 Cf. Ign., *Philad.,* 5, 1–2; 9, 1–2; *Smyrn.,* 5, 1; 7, 2.

979 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 1, 1; 19, 1.

980 *M. Polyc.,* 9, 1, cf. Herm., *vis.,* 1, 4, 3 (SCh 53bis, 86), where the voice out of heaven heard by the martyr alludes to: *Jos* 1, 6. 7. 9; *Dt* 31, 6. 7. 23; *Ps* 26, 14; 30, 25; *M. Polyc.,* 16, 1, cf. Herm., *vis.,* 1, 3, 4 (SCh 53bis, 84–86), where in the prayer raised by the martyr allusion is made to: *1 K* 17, 1; *Jdt* 9, 14; 13, 4; *Ps* 23, 10; 58, 6; *Jdt* 9, 12. It is also clear that the author of the *Shepherd* was acquainted with the Jewish sources that gave rise to the section of the *Two Paths* of the *Didaché*, as well as its relationship with Esdras IV and with the Dead Sea Scrolls, especially with the *Manual of discipline,* cf. J. Ayán Calvo, *Hermas. El Pastor,* Madrid 1995, 27–28.

almost only writings of the Marcionists, but rather we find references to a wider range of New Testament texts.

5. Conclusion

In this way, we might think that the timid allusions to the Old Testament made in the writings of Ignatius, Polycarp, and the author of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* belong to the first phase in a development where the authority of the Old Testament is only implicitly recognised, but without the necessary theological maturity to interpret it and accordingly to defend it from the different attitudes that attempt to overvalue it as in the judaising case, to undervalue it as in the Marcionite case, or to break it down and manipulate it with mythical interests as in the case of the Gnostics.

It is even probable that Polycarp gradually developed a clearcut attitude against Marcion throughout his lifetime, bearing in mind the testimonies of Irenaeus on the meeting between Marcion and Polycarp and the latter's preaching in Rome against the Marcionite and Valentinian gnostic heresies; however with regard to these testimonies by Irenaeus, it is necessary to exercise a certain degree of caution.

So that, just as Christianity in general throughout the second century gradually developed an interpretation of the Old Testament capable of defending it from Marcionite and Gnostic currents, it is probable that a figure like Polycarp was no exception to this development, notwithstanding, we do not possess sufficient elements to affirm this absolutely.

In conclusion, we may state that, from the hand of its bishop, the Church of Smyrna, like various Christian communities during the second century, after certain doubts and no few polemics, ended up by accepting the validity of the Old Testament, on the basis of a typological, that is to say, a christological interpretation, which thereafter for disciples like Irenaeus was broadened and deepened in order to confront the Marcionist and Gnostic ideas. This development of Christianity as regards the Old Testament is what M. Simonetti has described with reference to the second century, and to which we believe that Polycarp and his Church were no exception[981].

981 Cf. M. Simonetti, *Lettera e/o allegoria,* 37.

Chapter IX: The Pauline tradition in the Church of Smyrna

Despite the apparently great success of Paul's evangelising mission by the middle of the first century in the region of Asia, it appears that Paul's authority and doctrine suffered a certain amount of contestation in this region. The Church of Smyrna is a particularly outstanding community for the presence of the Pauline tradition in the writing born of it, amidst the almost general silence recorded by the other communities.

Hereafter, we prepare to make a short summary on the formation of the Pauline tradition in Asia, its presence in the writings of Smyrna and the silence of this tradition in the rest of the region.

1. Formation of the Pauline tradition in Asia

Before the arrival of Paul, a Christianity such as that of Apollo the Alexandrian and certain Judaeo-Christian groups existed in Asia[982]. However, as stated in the second part, the merit of having introduced Christianity in the province of Asia belongs largely to Paul of Tarsus[983]. In the year 52, on his return from Corinth, he made a short stay in Ephesus where he preached in the synagogue and left Priscilla and Aquila there to complete Apollo's instruction in Christianity. On Paul's return to Ephesus from Galatia and Phrygia passing through the high regions and probably through the valley of the river Cayster, he possibly had occasion to visit the cities of Philadelphia, Sardis and Smyrna[984].

On arriving at Ephesus, Paul baptised twelve men in the name of the Lord Jesus and laid hands on them, and they immediately started speaking in tongues and prophesying. Paul's apostolate in Ephesus lasted about three years, first of all in the synagogue and then, due to conflict with the Jews, in the school of Tyrannus. According to Luke, this apostolate extended to the whole province of Asia[985]. Thus, by about 53 to 56, Paul had a personal influence in the Christian

982 Cf. *Ac* 18, 24–28; 19, 1–7.

983 Cf. pp. 143 et seqq.

984 This possibility would seem to corroborate the news given in *V. Polyc.,* 2 regarding Paul's passing through Smyrna where he stayed in the house of Strataeas, brother of Timothy. There according to this news, Paul established Strataeas as διδάσκαλος. However, we have already voiced our doubts regarding this source.

985 Cf. *Ac* 19, 10; 10, 26.

communities of the whole of this area, and doubtless also in Smyrna. From Ephesus too, he wrote letters to a number of the communities he had visited beyond the frontiers of the Asiatic province. In the face of problems raised by a delegation of the community of Corinth, he wrote *1 Corinthians* and probably also *Galatians* and *Philippians,* in the latter case possibly suffering captivity in Ephesus.

After founding the community in Ephesus, he went on to Macedonia and on his return towards Jerusalem sent a message from Miletus to the presbyters of Ephesus taking his leave of them, warning them of the arrival of "ferocious wolves" and of individuals who would appear spreading falsities. Undoubtedly, the *Pastoral epistles* written at the end of the first century or beginning of the second century echo these tensions aroused in Asia following the departure and death of Paul[986].

From his captivitiy in Rome in about the years 61 to 63 Paul probably wrote his letter to the Ephesians. However, the denomination of this letter is not textually guaranteed, since the words "to the Ephesians" were doubtless missing from the original text, although they may be a very ancient addition[987]. Rather, in this letter, Paul addresses himself to believers in general and more particularly to the communities of the Valley of the Lycus, among whom he circulates his letters to the Ephesians and to the Colossians. The letter that the Colossians will receive from Laodicea is without doubt the letter to the Ephesians[988]. The author, probably Asiatic, of *2 Peter,* shows a knowledge of Paul's letters and a favourable attitude towards his person, while recognising that his writings contain things difficult to understand that the ignorant and the weak tend to distort[989].

According to a tradition received by Eusebius, Timothy, disciple of Paul, was the first bishop of the Church of Ephesus[990]. The names of Strataeas and Timothy are likewise mentioned in the *Apostolic Constitutions* in the lists of the three first bishops of Ephesus and Smyrna respectively[991]. This fact, though late and not entirely trustworthy, appears significant, since it links in some way both churches with the Pauline tradition.

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986 Cf. M. Simonetti, *Paolo nell'Asia cristiana del II secolo*, 133–140.

987 Cf. *Ep* 1, 1.

988 Cf. *Col* 4, 16.

989 Cf. *2 P* 3, 15–16.

990 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 3, 4, 5. Titus appears in this same tradition as the first bishop in the churches of Crete.

991 Cf. *Const. App.* 7, 46, 7–8 (SCh 336, 108).

In their turn, Timothy and Titus who collaborated with Paul especially in his mission between the churches of Thessalonica and Corinth, likewise appear linked to the context of the churches of Asia starting from the *Pastoral epistles* addressed to them and, as stated in the first part, were managed in the ecclesial context of this area[992].

Regarding Paul's preaching in Asia, legendary stories also spread, transmitted by the apochryphyal *Acts of Paul,* such as the baptism of the Lion and his defence of Paul against the other wild beasts in the stadium of Ephesus and the spectacular baptism of Artemila and Eubula in the sea[993].

So that, at Paul's death there, already exist a number of Christian communities established in Asia sustained by his authority and his doctrinal testament through his writings, all of which will lead to the formation of a specific Pauline tradition in the region with a clearcut vocation for consolidation. Hereafter, we will see how Paul's authority and doctrine are reflected in the sources specifically concerning the Church of Smyrna.

2. The Pauline tradition in the letters of Ignatius

As far as Paul is concerned, Ignatius of Antioch mentions him only twice in his letters. In *Eph.,* 12, 2, he states that the Christians of that city are companions "in the mysteries with Paul (Παύλου συμμύσται)"; Ignatius speaks of Paul as one who "is holy (τοῦ ἡγιασμένου), celebrated (τοῦ μεμαϱτυϱημένου) and worthy of good fortune" (ἀξιομακαϱίστου). Ignatius wishes to follow in his footsteps (ὑπὸ τὰ ἴχνη εὑϱεθῆναι), an expression which appears to echo Paul himself[994]. The epithets given to Paul by Ignatius are without parallel in Christian literature of the early second century; however, this does not necessarily mean that Ignatius has any special knowledge of the life of Paul. When Ignatius writes that Paul made mention of the Christians of Ephesus in "all of his letters (ἐν πάσῃ ἐπιστολῇ)" this is clearly an imprecision. Nevertheless, Ignatius' aim is not to give his recipients precise information on the frequency of the occurrence of the word *Ephesus* or *Ephesians* in the letters of Paul known to him. Rater he is simply trying to make as close a connection as possible between Paul and the Church of Ephesus.

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992 Cf. pp. 62 et seqq.

993 Cf. *Acta Pauli,* Pap. Bodmer (ed. A Piñero and G. Del Cerro, Madrid 2005, 782–801).

994 Cf. A. Merz, *Die fiktive Selbstauslegung des Paulus: intertextuelle Studien zur Intention und Rezeption der Pastoralbriefe,* Göttingen 2004, 152–153.

Ignatius makes mention of Paul once more, this time together with Peter, in *Rom.,* 4, 3. Following his petition to all the churches not to prevent his martyrdom by showing an inappropriate benevolence towards him, but on the contrary to allow him to be devoured by wild beasts, he writes to the Christians of Rome: "I am not giving you orders (διατάσσομαι) like Peter and Paul. They were apostles; I am a condemned man, they were free; I, until now, a slave". And he goes on: "But if I suffer martyrdom, I will be a freedman of Jesus Christ, and in Him I will be born again free". The text does not reveal any specific knowledge of Paul's letters either. However, the last part of this quotation shows the influence of the language of Paul, and in some way, Ignatius refers implicitly to his authority, although he appears to want to avoid making explicit use of it. We find this reasoning by Ignatius which places Paul together with Peter also in *1 Clem* 5, 4–7. Perhaps Ignatius was not acquainted with this letter, but he possibly knew the tradition regarding the martyrdom of Peter and Paul in Rome.

As regards the theological influence of Paul in the letters of Ignatius, four texts are important: *Eph.,* 18–20, *Magn*., 8–9, *Trall*., 9–10, and *Philad*., 8.

In *Eph.,* 18–20 Ignatius is developing the idea of the "paradox" of the revelation. In 17, 2, this paradox is understood as "the knowledge of God (Θεοῦ γνῶσις) which is Jesus Christ". In 18, 1, he calls the cross a "scandal (σκάνδαλον) for the incredulous, but for us it is salvation and eternal life (σωτηρία καὶ ζωὴ αἰώνιος)". He then goes on to ask three rhetorical questions: "Where is the wise man? Where is the friend of disputes? Where the boast of those deemed intelligent?". It seems clear that this passage was composed under a clear literary dependence on *1 Co* 1, 18–25. The christology of the incarnation expressed in 18, 2 seems to be a reminiscence of the early christological formula quoted by Paul in *Rom* 1, 3–4; nonetheless, Ignatius calls Jesus "our God (ὁ Θεὸς ἡμῶν Ἰησοῦς ὁ Χριστός)", and this goes beyond Pauline christology. In 19, 1, we find an outline of the revelation of clearly Pauline flavour: "and Mary's virginity and her giving birth remained *hidden from the prince of this world.* Thus also did the death of the Lord. Three clamorous *mysteries* which took place amidst the silence of God. How then were they *manifested to the world?*". Paul expresses himself in a very similar way in *1 Co* 2, 6–9. However, the language of the christology of the epiphany in 19, 2, 3 is different from Paul's thought. At the beginning of 20, Ignatius interrupts his line of thought, announcing that he is going to address a "second writing (ἐν τῷ δευτέρῳ βιβλιδίῳ, ὃ μέλλω γράφειν ὑμῖν) on the christological theme" to the Ephesians. In 20, 2, Ignatius makes extensive use of the Pauline terminology, in particular of the formula "in Jesus Christ", including the idea of "living in Jesus Christ" (ζῆν ἐν Ἰησοῦ Χριστῷ). In these three categories of *Eph.,* 18–20, the influence of certain theological categories of Paul on Ignatius appear

clearly; however, this does not authorise us to conclude that Ignatius had made a reading and explicit quotation from his letters.

In *Magn.,* 8–9, Ignatius gives a strong warning against living "according to Judaism (κατὰ Ἰουδαϊσμόν)". In discussion with his opponents, Ignatius uses similar arguments to those used by Paul in *Gal* 3, 1–29, speaking on the justification through faith and not through compliance with the Law. Once more, the theological thought of Ignatius appears similar to that of Paul, although there are no explicit citations.

In *Trall.,* 9, 10, Ignatius attacks a sort of Docetist christology. The Christians in Tralles must not accept any teaching which "separates them from Jesus Christ (χωρὶς Ἰησοῦ Χριστοῦ)". Ignatius refers himself to Christ in 9, 1–2, making reference to a formula of faith: "Jesus Christ, of the line (ἐκ γένους) of David, son of Mary, who was born truly (ἀληθῶς), who ate and drunk, who was truly persecuted at the time of Pontius Pilate, who was crucified and truly died in the sight of celestial, terrestrial and infernal beings. He truly rose again from the dead, after being brought back to life by his Father himself (ἀληθῶς ἠγέρθη ἀπὸ νεκρῶν, ἐγείραντος αὐτὸν τοῦ πατρὸς αὐτοῦ). Ignatius goes on to say that God in his semblance (κατὰ τὸ ὁμοίωμα), will also raise those of us who have believed in Him in Jesus Christ without whom we have no true life". This way of reasoning shows similarities with *1 Th* 2, 3–18 and *1 Co* 15, in both of which texts Paul starts from implicit or explicit quotations of formulas of faith (*1 Th* 4, 14 and *1 Co* 15, 3–5), to arrive at anthropological and ecclesiological consequences (*1 Th* 4, 14b and *1 C*o 15, 12–20), which thereby implies the resurrection. In this context, Ignatius insinuates to us his own destiny with a commentary similar to that of Paul in *1 Co* 15, 32. So that, once more, if not in content but at least in structure, Ignatius' reasoning seems to be oriented by that of Paul.

In *Philad.,* 8, 2, Ignatius informs us of a discussion which he had with certain adversaries, "some (τινες) said: If I cannot find it in the archives (ἐν τοῖς ἀρχείοις), I do not believe in the gospel (ἐν τῷ εὐαγγελίῳ οὐ πιστεύω)". His opponents apparently declared that they only believed in the Gospel if it coincided with "the archives", which may be a possible allusion to the Old Testament. First of all, Ignatius replies assuring them that "it is written (γέγραπται)", which should be understood not only as a reference to a biblical text but in the sense that Scripture should be interpreted in a Christian way. But when Ignatius is challenged by his opponents to show a proof "prove it (πρόκειται)", he changes and lengthens his answer in a different sense: "For me the archives are Jesus Christ, the holy archives are his cross, his death, his resurrection and the faith that stems from him". This life of christological thought is similar to Paul's theological reasoning. This is shown especially in the use made by Ignatius of the word δικαιοῦσθαι at

the end of the paragraph "in which I wish to be justified by your prayer (ἐν οἷς θέλω ἐν τῇ προσευχῇ ὑμῶν δικαιωθῆναι)". Ignatius speaks of his justification in terms that are directly dependent on *1 Co* 4, 4[995].

The first prayer in *Magn.,* 8, 1: "Do not let yourselves be deceived by strange doctrines or old tales that are useless" is similar to the arguments used by the author of the *Pastoral epistles* against the profane fables and old wives' tales, the foolish discussions, genealogies, debates, and disputes on the Law[996].

The ἐπίσκοπος of Antioch and the ἀπόστολος of the Gentiles wrote letters both to communities and to individual Christians. As far as we know, Ignatius was the first Christian author after Paul to write letters in his own name, without having recourse to pseudonyms. However, there were undoubtedly important differences: Paul was the organiser of a "universal mission", the majority of his letters were addressed to churches which he himself had founded. In these writings he gave answers to problems or situations on which he had received information. Paul knew that his authority was recognised in the churches he was writing to, at least in principle. Where this authority might appear to be in doubt or even denied, as in the case of Galatia and in Corinth in the situation described in *2 Co* 10–13, Paul considers that his arguments bear considerable weight. On the contrary, Ignatius had no formal authority over the churches to which he wrote, they were not founded by him and his relationship with them was not a close one.

We may conclude that the letters of the Apostle and his theological ideas are used by Ignatius when and where he considers they are important in order to call the attention of the apostolic authority to back up his own arguments.

3. The Pauline tradition in Polycarp's Letter to the Philippians

The number of allusions to New Testament writings made in Polycarp's *Letter to the Philippians* is evident[997]. Nonetheless, the researches on what New Testament writings the bishop of Smyrna used in this letter have failed to reach

995 Cf. W. Schoedel, *Ignatius of Antioch*, 179.

996 Cf. *1 Tm* 4, 7; *2 Tm* 4, 4; *Ti* 3, 9.

997 From the beginning of the twentieth century, experts have studied this interesting aspect of the letter. For example, F. Funk found 68 reminiscences of passages from the New Testament in Polycarp's letter, cf. F. Funk, *Patres Apostolici,* vol. 1, Tübingen 1913, 573 et seqq.

agreement[998]. This divergence of opinions may have its root in the fact that Polycarp tends to make free use of his sources, to the point that the question arises of whether he made use of New Testament literature or of oral tradition. In fact, we cannot find a single passage that is taken literally from our present-day New Testament canon and, as W. Farmer points out, it would be anachronistic on our part to expect that before the canonical nature of the New Testament had been established, and the ancient authors should quote these works to the letter[999]. The authors of this time made more reference to the apostolic message in general and its authority than to the specific texts.

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998 The research by B. Lightfoot in 1889, the work of the Oxford Committee in 1905, the labour of Harrison in 1936, and Marshall's thesis in 1950 as well as Schoedel's commentary in 1997. B. Lightfoot affirms that there are six explicit quotations from *Matthew*, two from *Mark*, three from *Luke*, two from *Acts of the Apostles*, two from *Romans*, four from *1 Corinthians*, three from *2 Corinthians*, two from *Galatians*, three from *Ephesians*, two from *Philippians*, two from *2 Thessalonians*, three from *1 Timothy*, two from *2 Timothy*, nine from *1 Peter,* and one from *John*, cf. B. Lightfoot, *The Apostolic Fathers. Part II; S. Ignatius. S. Polycarp*, vol. I, New York 1989.
The Oxford Committee used a system of classification in order to make a distinction in the probability of quotations from the New Testament. It classified the books in four classes: A, B, C and D. Class A comprises those books in all probability quoted by Polycarp. Class B the books quite probably quoted by him. Class C, the books quoted with less probability. And Class D, those books having very least probability of being quoted. Accordingly, the Committee showed itself to be much more cautious than B. Lightfoot.
They placed *1 Corinthians* and *1 Peter* in Class A; *Romans, 2 Corinthians, Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, 2 Thessalonians, 1 Timothy,* and *2 Timothy* in Class B; *John, Acts of the Apostles, Hebrews,* and *1 John* in Class C; and *Colossians* in Class D. The Oxford Committee found no certain use of the Synoptic Gospels, only a use of the synoptic tradition, cf. Oxford Society of Historical Theology, *The New Testament in the Apostolic Fathers*, Oxford 1905, iii–v. M. Marshall states that the letter *To the Philippians* quotes 23 New Testament works. This list includes the whole canon except for: *Titus, Philemon, 3 John,* and *Revelation*, cf. M. Marshall, *The Use of the Books of the New Testament by the Early Christian Writers*, 1950, 44. W. Schoedel considers as books probably quoted from: *Matthew, Luke, Acts of the Apostles, Romans, 1* and *2 Corinthians, Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, 1* and *2 Timothy, 1 Peter,* and *1 John*, cf. W. Schoedel, *Polycarp, Epistle of*, in *The Anchor Bible Dictionary*, ed. D. Freedman, New York 1992.

999 "We must realise that before the canonical status of the New Testament books became established it is anachronistic to expect them to be quoted *verbatim*", W. Farmer – M. Farkasfalvy, *The Formation of the New Testament Canon: An Ecumenical Approach,* New York 1983, 169, note 61. From a linguistic analysis, "verbatim" means the exact

Particularly as regards the relationship between Polycarp and the use made by him of the Pauline writings, perhaps the most monographical study is the recent book by K. Berding[1000]. There we once more find the confirmed acceptance of the scholars in general regarding the use made by Polycarp of *1 Corinthians, Romans, Galatians, Ephesians,* and *Philippians.* Polycarp explicitly quotes Paul "*sicut Paulus docet*" in 11, 2, drawing the phrase from *1 Co* 6, 2: "As you know it is the saints who are to judge the world". In 6, 2, where he says: "it is necessary for all of us to report before Christ's tribunal (πάντας δεῖ παϱαστῆναι τῷ βήματι τοῦ Χϱιστοῦ), and for each one to give account of himself (καὶ ἕκαστον ὑπὲϱ αὐτοῦ λόγον δοῦναι)", the influence of Romans 14, 10–12 is clear: "We shall all have to stand before the judgment seat of God (πάντες παϱαστησόμεθα τῷ βήματι τοῦ Θεοῦ). Accordingly, each one will give account of himself (ἕκαστον ἡμῶν πεϱὶ ἑαυτοῦ λόγον δώσει)". In 1, 3, Polycarp begins a quotation from *Ep* 2, 5. 8. 9, using the formula "knowing that (εἰδότες ὅτι)" and in 8. 1, with the same formula, he makes a quotation from *Gal* 6, 7.

A particularly interesting case is the relationship of Polycarp's writing with the letter to the Philippians written by Paul. In 3, 1–2, Polycarp shows us that he is conscious of writing his letter while sheltering behind the Pauline writing.

> Brothers, I am not writing to you on justice on my own initiative, but because you have asked me. Thus neither I nor any person like me can follow closely the wisdom of the blessed and glorious Paul, who, when he was with you, in the presence of the men of that time, taught with exactitude and firmness everything referring to the word of the truth and, when he was absent, wrote you letters: if you pay attention to these, you will be able to use them to build yourselves up in the faith which has been given to you.

The use of certain expressions provide us with powerful evidence that Polycarp knew this Pauline writing: "a worthy behaviour (πολιτευσώμεθα ἀξίως)" cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 5, 2 and *Ph* 1, 27, "they did not strive in vain (οὐκ εἰς κενόν ἔδϱαμον)" cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 9, 2 and *Ph* 2, 16; "enemies of the cross (*inimicis crucis*)" cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 12, 3 and *Ph* 3, 18. Attempts have been made to give various explanations of Polycarp's statement that Paul wrote various letters to the Philippians, when only one is found in the canon. It is thought that this statement should be understood in the singular, since it was frequent to use the plural to designate a

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reproduction of a sentence, phrase, quotation or other sequence of text from one source to another. The words appear in the same place, in the same order, without paraphrase, replacement, or abbreviation of any type, and without making any even trivial change liable to alter the meaning.

1000 Cf. K. Berding, *Polycarp and Paul. An analysis of their literary and theological relationship in light of Polycarp's use of biblical and extra-biblical literature,* Boston 2002.

single letter. Some are also of the opinion that Polycarp is alluding not only to the letter to the Philippians, but also to that addressed to the Thessalonians since both Philippi and Thessalonica were in Macedonia. It may also be considered that from *Ph* 3, 1, Polycarp had deduced the existence of various letters[1001].

It is probable that Polycarp also made use of *2 Corinthians.* In 2, 2, Polycarp referring to Christ, states that "he who raised him from the dead will likewise resuscitate us too", appears to be an allusion to *2 Co* 4, 4; however, this material might also have been taken from an antique confession of faith. Moreover, there are singular expressions shared by both texts: "being armed with the weapons of righteousness (τοῖς ὅπλοις τῆς δικαιοσύνης)", cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 4, 1; and *2 Co* 6, 7, "mindful always of the good before God and men (ϱονοοῦντες ἀεὶ τοῦ καλοῦ ἐνώπιον Θεοῦ καὶ ἀνθϱώπων)" cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 5, 1 and *2 Co* 8, 21, "the truth will be brought out in the law court of Christ (τῷ βήματι τοῦ Χϱιστοῦ)", cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 6, 2 and *2 Co* 5, 10. The evidence that Polycarp made use of *2 Tm* or *2 Th* is not very powerful. Of this latter, we find two similar texts in Polycarp: Polyc., *ep.,* 11, 3 and *2 Th* 1, 4; Polyc., *ep.,* 11, 4 and *2 Th* 3, 15. There is insufficient evidence that use was made of *Colossians* or *1 Thessalonians.*

From these quotations from Paul's writings, we have to conclude not only knowledge of these by Polycarp, but also the use Polycarp makes of Paul as an authority. Clement, Ignatius and Polycarp make use of Paul in a conscious manner, attempting to legitimise themselves in the eyes of their readers by resorting to his authority. Consciously, they recognise him as an apostle[1002], a writer of letters to the churches[1003], and as a martyr[1004] who shares authority with Peter[1005]. In fact, they are the only two apostles whose names are recorded in this letter, as also in Clement and in Ignatius. This proves that Paul, contrary to what A. Harnack or W. Bauer thought, at the beginning of the second century, was not the exclusive property of Gnosticism, nor later only of Marcionism, but on the contrary, ecclesiastic authors in this age clung to Paul as an apostolic and doctrinal authority. Accordingly, the fact that Paul's letters or the apostle's name itself was quoted does not mean that his theological doctrine was completely assimilated. For example, Polycarp in 3, 1–3, makes mention of "justice" and explicitly says that the Philippians have asked him to write to them on just that. Polycarp always speaks of justice in terms of a "commandment of justice", and always places it linked

1001 Cf. J. Ayán Calvo, 215, note 22.
1002 Cf. *1 Clem* 5, 3; Ign., *Rom.,* 4, 3; Polyc., *ep.,* 9, 1.
1003 Cf. *1 Clem* 47, 1; Ign., *Eph.,* 12, 2; Polyc., *ep.,* 6, 2; 11, 3.
1004 Cf. *1 Clem* 5, 5–7; Ign., *Eph.,* 12, 2; Polyc., *ep.,* 9, 1–2.
1005 Cf. *1 Clem* 5, 4; Ign., *Rom.,* 4, 3.

with the ethical or moral theme, save when he speaks in chap 7, 1, of "persevering as sureties of our justice, which are Jesus Christ". So that the type of justice handled by Polycarp is closer to that of *Matthew* and even that of *1 Clement* than to that of Paul. This seems to indicate that in the second century, Pauline theology was less widespread than the apostle's authority in the context of conflicts of an ecclesial nature[1006].

With regard to *1 Peter,* which may be considered in the framework of the Pauline tradition[1007], it is clear that Polycarp made use of it. Eusebius already commented on this as a fact[1008]. The echoes of *1 Peter* are abundant: cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 1, 3 and *1 P* 1, 8; cf. Polyc., *ep., 2, 1* and *1 P* 1, 13. 21; cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 2, 2 and *1 P* 3, 9; cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 5, 3 and *1 P* 2, 11; cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 7, 2 and *1 P* 4, 7; cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 7, 1 and *1 P* 2, 24. 22; cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 10, 1 and *1 P* 2, 17; 5, 5; cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 10, 2, and *1 P* 2, 12.

The evidence that Polycarp did make use of the letter to the *Hebrews* is possible, there are certain allusions: cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 6, 3 and *Heb* 12, 28; cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 12, 2 and *Heb* 6, 20; 7, 3; cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 9, 1, and *Heb* 5, 13.

The abundant presence of allusions to Pauline letters in the work of Polycarp may lead us to think that Polycarp possessed a collection of these works, perhaps in the same way as he had to hand a copy of the *corpus Ignatianum*[1009].

We might also conclude that, although Polycarp does not mention the Holy Spirit, or develop central concepts of Pauline theology such as the union with Christ, sin, etc., the influence of Paul's theology over Polycarp is clear above all, though not only, in the ethical sphere[1010].

One much discussed theme has been the use Polycarp made of the *Pastoral epistles* which are certainly of Pauline tradition[1011]. There are similar linguistic usages but at no time can we prove a direct dependence, but merely say that they take their place in the same ecclesiastical and cultural tradition both with the *corpus Paulinum* and with the circumstances of Polycarp. Undoubtedly, Polycarp

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1006 For a detailed study of the figure of Paul in Asia in the second century, the reader is referred to M. Simonetti's study, *Paolo nell'Asia cristiana del II secolo,* 123–144.

1007 Ibid., 140–142.

1008 Eus., *h. e.* 4, 14, 8.

1009 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 3, 2. Today consensus seems to be forthcoming among scholars that the theory of W. Bauer, according to which Marcion was the first to systematically gather together Paul's letters, must be abandoned. Cf. P. Hartog, *Polycarp and the New Testament*, 234; cf. K. Berding, *Polycarp and Paul,* 188–189, note 5.

1010 Cf. K. Berding, *Polycarp and Paul,* 190.

1011 Cf. pp. 62 et seqq.

and the *Pastoral epistles,* above all *1 Timothy,* make use of material in common for the moral exhortation of the time. In 4, 1, Polycarp exhorts: "Avarice is the root of all evils. Accordingly, since we know that we have brought nothing into the world and can take nothing out of it, let us arm ourselves with the weapons of justice and let us learn, ourselves first and foremost, to walk in the Lord's commandment", while similar allusions may be found in *1 Tm* 6, 1 and *1 Tm* 6, 10. Likewise in 5, 2, Polycarp warns against deacons who are double-tongued: δίλογοι, the same concept as we find in *1 Tm* 3, 8. We may also find a similarity between 12, 3 and the exhortation of *1 Tm* 2, 2 to "pray for kings".

But, beyond determining the use that Polycarp made of the *Pastoral epistles,* it is important to note that, in its characteristic features, the letter *To the Philippians* continues the literary tradition that these represent. In fact, there is a continuity as regards the veneration of tradition, concerning poverty, a strong morality, an allusion to the officials of the Church and the behaviour that the latter should observe, and countering any attempts at schism. Both in the *Pastoral epistles* and in Polycarp, there is a lack of eschatological motivation justifying the ethical behaviour of the Christians to whom it is addressed[1012].

4. The Pauline tradition in the Martyrdom of Polycarp

As we will show hereafter, the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* is found to be more closely related to the passion of Jesus of the Synoptic Gospels and the Gospel of John than to the doctrine and authority of the Pauline tradition.

Nonetheless, the references and reminiscences of the New Testament in the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* are rooted within a vision of the meaning of martyrdom, with the basic Pauline idea of *Ph* 2, 4 of being "the same as Christ Jesus". This is reported by the author of the text as regards Polycarp in 1, 2: "Since he hoped to be delivered up, like the Lord, so that we too should be his imitators (ἵνα μιμηταὶ καὶ ἡμεῖς αὐτοῦ γενώμεθα)" and in relation to the cult of the martyrs in 17, 3: "For we worship Him as Son of God. But we love the martyrs as they deserve, as disciples and imitators of the Lord (μιμητὰς τοῦ κυρίου)".

The most identified quotation from Paul is *1 Co* 2, 9, which is adapted to the context on the beatific gaze of the martyrs towards heaven in 2, 3: (the martyrs) contemplated with the eyes of their heart the things awaiting those who suffer

1012 This was one of the reasons for which H. Campenhausen came to declare that Polycarp was the true author of the *Pastoral epistles,* cf. H. Campenhausen, *Polykarp von Smyrna und die Pastoralbriefe,* Heidelberg 1951, 25–26.

patiently, "*that no eye has seen and no ear has heard, things beyond the mind of man. all that God has prepared for those who love him*".

5. The silences of the Pauline tradition in Asia

Thus far we have stated that at Paul's death, there existed in Asia a tradition of his authority and doctrine with clear prospects of consolidation and that authors of importance such as the author of the *Pastoral epistles, 2 Peter*, Ignatius, Polycarp and the *Acts of Paul* make use of this, although not with the same homogeneity. Nonetheless, various scholars have drawn attention to the surprising silence regarding Paul encountered in Asiatic writers of the second century[1013].

The text which has best highlighted this silence is undoubtedly the letter of Polycrates of Ephesus to Victor of Rome in about 190[1014]. It is surprising that in the long list of personages that the author draws up and which to his mind constitute the Asiatic tradition par excellence, neither the name of Paul nor any of his disciples such as Luke, considered an interpreter of Paul's thought, or Timothy or Titus, appear. Although, in the case of Polycrates, this silence has an obvious cause in the defence of the Quartodecimanist cause before Rome which is sustained by the Johannine tradition, the silence of other Asiatic authors, such as the author of the *Revelation,* Papias of Hierapolis, Melito of Sardis, and the author of the apocryphal *Acts of John,* suggest that this liturgical practice was perhaps not the only reason for intentionally making no mention of the Apostle, since by the very fact of their geographical origin, these authors were necessarily acquainted with Paul's doctrine.

In the case of Justin too, who was born in Palestine but acquired his Christian formation probably in Ephesus, there is no open or explicit mention of the name of Paul, although in his *Dialogue with Trypho,* he shows himself to be acquainted with Paul's letters.

Certain modern authors like E. Dassmann and A. Lindemann have seen no hostility on the part of Papias and Justin in this silence on Paul, including in the case of Papias, perhaps ascribing Eusebius' disregard to the slight intellectual level of Papias[1015]; these authors have affirmed that he had no theological interest

1013 Cf. M. Simonetti, *Paolo nell'Asia cristiana del II secolo,* 123–144. These are two studies among others: E. Dassmann, *Der Stachel im Fleisch. Paulus in der frühchristlichen Literatur bis Irenäus,* Münster 1979; A. Lindemann, *Paulus im ältesten Christentum,* Tübingen 1979.

1014 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 24, 2.

1015 Eus., *h. e.* 3, 39, 11–12.

in Paul, or even that he was incapable of realising the significance of the Pauline theology. Finally, they also think that the fragments of Papias available to us are not sufficient sources to affirm anything regarding the attitude of Papias towards Paul[1016].

Contrary to the opinion of these authors and conscious of the difficulty of interpreting the silences in ancient literature, M. Simonetti draws attention to the impressive plurality of these silences attested in a not very extensive region and within the time range of only a few decades. Analysing the *Pastoral epistles,* he shows how these writings certainly prior to Papias, Melito, *Acts of John,* Justin, and Polycrates already highlighted, though within the Pauline tradition to which they belong, a state of crisis which had affected communities founded by Paul in the region of the Aegean Sea, and this crisis appears to be so grave as to oblige their author to resort to pseudo-epigraphy in order to avail himself of Paul's authority and thus ensure the effectiveness of his message[1017].

The polemical arguments expounded in the *Pastoral epistles* concern the circulation among the communities of Jewish fables (μύθοι) and genealogies which fail to edify the assembly[1018]; teachings of encratistic nature which prohibit marriages and certain foods[1019]; the presumption of certain persons that they possess a gnosis which on the contrary is false (τῆς ψευδωνύμου γνώσεως)[1020]; and the proclaiming of a resurrection which has already occurred[1021]. M. Simonetti affirms that the author of the *Pastoral epistles* is in touch with two groups representing different threats for the communities to whom they are addressed, one of internal type and the other of external type. The former are Christians of Jewish origin who come from outside the community and who in a capillary way teach door to door fables and myths, thus threatening the peace of the community. Whereas there exists a group of Christians who are members of Pauline communities and who interpret the Apostle's message in a radical way with the claim of possessing superior knowledge thanks to the resurrection from death. So that the author of the *Pastoral epistles* represents a moderate form of Paulinism which comes to occupy a polemical position with respect to the external danger from

1016 E. Dassmann, *Der Stachel im Fleisch*, 236–246*;* A. Lindemann, *Paulus im ältesten Christentum,* 290.

1017 Cf. M. Simonetti*, Paolo nell'Asia cristiana del II secolo,* 126, 133.

1018 Cf. *1 Tm* 1, 4; 4, 7; *2 Tm* 4, 4; *Ti* 1, 14; 3, 9.

1019 Cf. *1 Tm* 4, 3.

1020 Cf. *1 Tm* 6, 20.

1021 Cf. *2 Tm* 2, 18.

Judaeo-Christians and the internal danger from of members of the community endowed with a radical Paulinism[1022].

The *Pastoral epistles,* which as we have said are addressed to communities scattered around the Aegean Sea, only complain of the defection of Asia, assuring that everyone there has abandoned Paul[1023]. On the contrary, on the other shore of the Aegean, it seems that the Pauline tradition had no great detractors, as we know through Polycarp's letter to the Church of Philippi and the situation we likewise know of Corinth through *1 Clement.*

1 Peter, which may likewise be inscribed within the Asiatic Pauline tradition if we accept, as M. Simonetti affirms, that the origin of the author who had recourse to pseudo-epigraphy is a Christian from Asia belonging to this tradition, called for the intervention *super partes* of Peter's authority, conscious of the crisis afflicting the Asiatic region with regard to Paul's doctrinal testament. This author, in an intentionally generic and extremely comprehensive message, invited his addressees to concord and irreprehensible behaviour, as a means of overcoming their divisions. M. Simonetti is conscious of the fragility of such a hypothesis, as indeed of the many which have been formulated regarding this New Testament text[1024]. Nevertheless, in the context to which we have referred, this hypothesis appears plausible especially when we know that Peter was not the posssessor of a clearly delineated Christian tradition like that of Paul or of John, but that on the contrary, his personal authority was great and both traditions called on it in order to keep within the bounds of orthodoxy and avoid radicalisms.

Thus we see that, from the death of the Apostle, the Pauline tradition, which seemed destined to undergo a powerful development in Asia, became the object in this region of a grave polemic due to a group which radicalised its positions and which caused the moderate part of the Pauline tradition to oppose it, though not always explicitly. Apart from this, groups of Judaeo-Christians who were

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1022 Cf. M. Siimonetti, *Paolo nell'Asia cristiana del II secolo,* 137–140. On the contrary, P. Trebilco makes no distinction between the two groups, believing it to be a single one. Nonetheless his explanation gives us some idea of the difficulty of harmonising the Judaising elements fighting the *Pastoral epistles* compared to the radical Paulinism also opposed by the latter, cf. P. Trebilco, *The Early Christians in Ephesus,* 235–236.

1023 Cf. *2 Tm* 1, 15.

1024 Cf. M. Simonetti, *Paolo nell'Asia cristiana del II secolo,* 140–142. For two recent studies on *1 Peter,* cf. Lapham, *Peter: the Myth, the Man and the Writings. A Study of Early Petrine Text and Tradition,* New York 2004, 117–148, cf. P. Achtemeier, *La prima lettera di Pietro, commento storico esegetico,* Vatican City 2004.

already present in the Asiatic region and later on those coming from Jerusalem following the year 70 sought to overpower other Christian traditions, attacking or at times simply ignoring the Pauline tradition, not only in its more radical wing but also its more moderate elements. Certain of these traditions superposed on a large part of the Pauline tradition, would seem to have been more linked to the Jewish observances against which Paul had constantly polemised. Nonetheless, it should also be noted that the Johannine tradition made no attempt to attack, directly at least, the person of Paul, as did the extremist Judaeo-Christians, such as those of the *Pseudo-Clementine corpus.*

In the midst of this Asiatic polemics regarding the Pauline tradition, as far as the Church of Smyrna is concerned, we may state that, so far as we know, it was only the Asiatic church reality which made public reference to the person of Paul and his doctrine, amidst the silence of the Asiatic authors subsequent to the *Pastoral epistles.* We note this from Polycarp's letter to the Christians of Philippi, who despite being situated in a different region from the Asiatic polemics, give us no indication that Polycarp was employing a different line from Paul within his own community. Stress should also be laid on the Paulinism of Ignatius of Antioch who, from Smyrna, referred to Paul using unparalleled epithets at the beginning of the second century, in his letter addressed precisely to the church of Ephesus, perhaps the principal scenario of the polemics on Paul's doctrine in Asia. So that Ignatius certainly appears to be in harmony with the good reception of the Pauline tradition displayed by his hosts of the church of Smyrna.

6. Conclusion

In conclusion, P. Hartog's thesis that the Church of Smyrna played an important role in the formation or transmission of a collection of Pauline letters appears probable, although we cannot absolutely assert it[1025]. Just as the Church of Smyrna took the initiative of copying, and at the request of the Church of Philippi of spreading the *corpus Ignatianum,* it could perhaps have undertaken a similar proceeding with at least part of a *corpus Paulinum.*

As we reported earlier, Polycarp made use at least of *Romans, 1 Corinthians, Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians,* and perhaps *2 Corinthians, 2 Thessalonians,* and *2 Timothy.* Possibly, it might be inferred from Polyc., *ep.,* 3, 2 that the bishop of Smyrna was acquainted with a collection of Pauline letters: "since neither I nor any like me could follow closely the wisdom of the blessed Paul, who, when he

1025 P. Hartog, *Polycarp and the New Testament,* 232.

was among you, in the presence of men of that time, taught with exactness and firmness everything regarding the word of the truth and, when absent, wrote letters to you: take heed of these, for thereby you will build yourselves up in the faith he has given you".

In all probability, the Church of Smyrna was one of the first centres for the compiling of a collection of Paul's letters in the Asian context[1026]. Possibly Ephesus may have been the first city to start up a systematic process of collection of the Pauline letters in the shadow of the author of the *Pastoral epistles,* even though as P. Trebilco has pointed out, the possibility that a Pauline school entrusted with this task existed in Ephesus or that the *Pastoral epistles* were composed there remains no more than a hypothesis[1027]. On the contrary, the certainty regarding the use of the doctrine and authority of Paul by persons connected with the church of Smyrna, especially Polycarp, and the active work of the incipient *scriptorium*[1028] of this community, are unparalleled in the Asiatic reality of the first decades of the second century, where the Johannine tradition would seem to have been the most favourably received. For this reason, we may affirm that the Church of Smyrna played an important part in the reception of the Pauline tradition in Asia.

1026 Clement in his letter to the Corinthians, reports that he knows Paul's letter *To the Romans* and *1 Corinthians.* Even Paul himself began the process of sharing his letters among various communities, cf. *Gal* 1, 2; *2 Co* 1, 1b; *Col* 4, 16; *2 Co* 10, 10–11. W. Bauer's theory, on the basis of the witness of the Marcionist Prologues, that Marcion in about the year 140 was the first person to systematically gather together Paul's letters has lately lost much of its force. Undoubtedly, before the bishop of Smyrna, *2 P* 3, 16 and Ignatius in *Eph* 12, 2 gives signs of an acquaintance with Paul's letters.

1027 Cf. P. Trebilco, *The Early Christians in Ephesus,* 94.

1028 Here we mean the concept of *scriptorium* at its most basic level, that is to say, a community where texts are copied by different scribes. This type of experience could have taken place early on in communities like Rome, Antioch, and even Smyrna. On the contrary, for a *scriptorium* in the sense of a more structured organisation, operating for example in a specific place designed and fitted out for this purpose, perhaps we would have to wait until the time of Origen, cf. H. Gamble, *Libri e lettori nella chiesa antica,* Brescia 2006, 165. Cf. p. 68, note 107.

Chapter X: The Synoptic Gospels in the Church of Smyrna

The traditions on Jesus handed down in the Synoptic Gospels do not appear to have encountered greater difficulty in their reception by Asiatic Christianity, which was probably extraneous to its formation. In particular, the writings of the Church of Smyrna appear not averse to general acceptance of the Synoptic Gospels, above all the gospel of *Matthew,* although following the common practice of making reference to his authority and being quoted with great freedom.

Hereafter, we will make a general study of the reception of these Gospels in Asia and thereafter we will consider in detail the possible allusions or quotations from them in the writings of the Church of Smyrna.

1. The Synoptic Gospels in Asia

Regarding the Synoptic Gospels, the general opinion of modern scholars is that they reached their final form between 70–80 A.D. Prior oral and written traditions about the person, teaching, and miracles of Jesus, mixed in and overlapping with one another, depending on the different historical and theological interests of the communities to which they were addressed, converge together in them. The literary relationship of this convergence of traditions in the Synoptic Gospels and their different interpretation has been termed the Synoptic Question. The provenance of the Gospels of Mark, Matthew, and Luke seems to evoke more or less an agreement between scholars who situate their origin in Rome, Palestine and Antioch, respectively. Accordingly, it seems that the role of the churches of Asia in the shaping of these synoptic traditions is only as receivers of the same without any special polemics regarding their acceptance.

Precious, since very ancient, is the testimony of the Asiatic Papias of Hierapolis on the Gospels of *Mark* and of *Matthew* with which he shows himself to be acquainted and accepts[1029]. In his testimony, Papias considers *Mark* as the interpreter of the Gospel preached by Peter, Clement of Alexandria, and later on by Irenaeus of Lyons, the last-named undoubtedly transmitting the teaching received from Asia Minor: they confirm the testimony given by Papias of Hierapolis[1030], and Eusebius of Caesarea, and Hieronymus reported with their

1029 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 3, 39, 15–16.
1030 Cf. Iren., *haer.,* 3, 1,1.

witnesses that this Gospel of Mark was approved for being read in the public worship of the churches[1031].

For his part, although modern authors have stressed the fact that Papias probably confused a Judaeo-Christian apochryphal gospel, attributed to Matthew, with the first canonical Gospel and others believe that Papias may have alluded to those known as λόγια[1032], it is certain that this Asiatic author was exposed to a tradition linked to the name of Matthew. Very many second-century authors had recourse to *Matthew* far more than the other Gospels for grounding Christianity starting off from the teaching of Jesus set down in this first canonical Gospel.

On the contrary, our attention is drawn to the omission of Papias regarding the third canonical Gospel. The redaction of the third Gospel of the *Acts of the Apostles* makes Luke notoriously the interpreter of Paul, and accordingly once more, the omission of Papias might suggest another possible feature of the Asiatic polemics around the Pauline tradition. Nevertheless, despite this silence, all of the various churches by about the year 175 expressed a conformity in the acceptance of this Gospel. The first testimony that we have of a tradition according to which Luke put into writing the Gospel preached by Paul is due to Irenaeus[1033]. We find this idea also in the *Muratori Fragment* and in Tertullian. The latter affirms this tradition in controversy with the Gospel that Marcion fabricated under the pseudonym of Paul and explicitly says that the Gospel of Luke is recommended on account of the fact that it descends from Paul's authority[1034]. With Origen, the problem of the attribution of the third canonical Gospel and its relationship with Paul was overcome, reciting 39 homilies on it. Eusebius, referring to the third canon, observes, "the third is the Gospel of Luke that was praised by Paul and composed by the believers coming from the Gentiles"[1035].

In this context of apparent normal acceptance of the traditions on Jesus recorded in the Synoptic Gospels during the second century, including the region of Asia, with the exception of the silence of Papias on *Luke,* we prepare ourselves to see the possible presence of *Mark,* and *Luke* in the writings concerning the Church of Smyrna.

1031 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 2, 15, 2; Hier., *vir ill.,* 8 (PL 23, 653–657).
1032 Cf. E. Norelli, *Papia di Hierapolis,* 113–114.
1033 Cf. Iren., *haer.,* 3, 1, 1.
1034 Tert., *adv. Marc.,* 4, 2, 4–5 (SCh 456, 70–71).
1035 Eus., *h. e.* 6, 25, 6.

2. The Synoptic Gospels in the letters of Ignatius

There is no doubt that Ignatius knew the Gospel of *Matthew*, since he makes obvious allusions to it at various points in his letters[1036]: *Mt* 19, 12 in *Smyrn.,* 6; *Mt* 10, 16 in Polyc., 2, 2; *Mt* 12, 33 in *Eph.,* 14; *Mt* 15, 13 in *Trall.,*11, 1; and *Mt* 2, 2 in *Eph.,* 19, 1–3. For example, in *Smyrn.,* 1, 1, reference is made to the justice fulfilled in the baptism of Jesus by John with the words: "Jesus Christ baptised by John according to the flesh in order for all justice to be fulfilled by Him (βεβαπτισμένον ὑπὸ Ἰωάννου ἵνα πληρωθῇ πᾶσα δικαιοσύνην ὑπ᾽ αὐτοῦ)", in *Mt* 3, 15, Jesus says, "in this way we should do all that righteousness demands (πρέπον ἐστὶν ἡμῖν πληρῶσαι πᾶσαν δικαιοσύνην)".

On the contrary, the texts in our possession show no clear signs that enable us to conclude that Ignatius was acquainted with the Gospels of *Mark* and *Luke*[1037]. The lack of evidence on the use of the Gospel of *Luke* by Ignatius of Antioch is certainly surprising considering the general opinion on the possible Antiochian provenance of this Gospel.

3. The Synoptic Gospels in Polycarp's Letter to the Philippians

As regards the influence of the Synoptic Gospels in Polycarp's *Letter to the Philippians,* we may undoubtedly find such influence, but not always a direct borrowing from the written text of the Gospels. The influence of these Gospels may be seen when Polycarp makes reference to a body of teaching contained in an oral tradition similar to the Sermon on the Mount and to the early liturgical usage of the Lord's Prayer. In most cases, the possible allusions coincide with expressions and similarities from the Gospel of *Matthew* and with *Luke* to a much slighter degree.

In 2, 3 Polycarp affirms: "Mindful of what the Lord taught us: do not judge others and you will not be judged; forgive and you will be forgiven, be merciful if you wish to receive mercy; insofar as you measure out you will be measured; and he goes on: 'Blessed are the poor and those who are persecuted for justice's sake, for theirs is the Kingdom of Heaven'". There are four sentences in the first

1036 Cf. E. Massaux, *Influence de l'Évangile de Saint Matthieu sur la littérature chrétienne avant saint Irénée,* Leuven 1986, 94–107.

1037 Cf. P. Foster, *The Epistles of Ignataius of Antioch and the Writings that later formed the New Testament* in *The Reception of the New Testament in the Apostolic Fathers,* ed. A. Gregory – C. Tuckett, Oxford 2005, 181–182.

part of the paragraph. The first: "Do not judge others, and you will not be judged (μὴ κϱίνετε, ἵνα μὴ κϱιθῆτε)" is taken word for word from *Mt* 7, 1. The fourth sentence, "to the amount that you measure out you will be measured" is similar to *Mt* 7, 2, except for two small and unimportant changes. The second and third sentences are taken from *1 Clem* 13 but they are slightly changed and seemingly corrected on the basis of the version of *Lk* 6, 36–38. In the second part of paragraph 2, 3, the text appears to be taken from *Mt* 5, 3, 10 and from *Lk* 6, 20. The "makarism" about the poor is without the addition in *Matthew "in spirit* (τῷ πνεύματι)" perhaps due to the fact that in the context of Polycarp's letter, he attempts to advise the community on a concrete economic problem when the presbyter Valens abandoned his responsibility, running off with the money. Thus Polycarp may have corrected the text of *1 Clement,* basing himself on the texts of *Matthew* and of *Luke.* Whereas his use of *Mark* is less clear[1038].

In 6, 2, Polycarp says: "If we ask the Lord to forgive us, we too must forgive others". This sentence has a clear echo of the Lord's Prayer; however, the text presents no verbal parallels either with *Matthew,* or with *Luke,* or with the *Didaché.* Whereas in 7, 2, Polycarp says: "praying God, who sees all, not to lead us into temptation (μὴ εἰσενεγκεῖν ἡμᾶς εἰς πειϱασμόν)". Here a clear allusion is made to the Lord's Prayer of the version found in *Mt* 6, 3: καὶ μὴ εἰσενεγκεῖν ἡμᾶς εἰς πειϱασμόν. Polycarp goes on: "because the Lord said: The spirit is willing but the flesh is weak (τὸ μὲν πνεῦμα πϱόθυμον ἡ δὲ σὰϱξ ἀσθενής)". Here the text is the same as in *Mt* 26, 41 (τὸ μὲν πνεῦμα πϱόθυμον ἡ δὲ σὰϱξ ἀσθενής).

As for the use of the *Acts of the Apostles* made in Polycarp's letter, the question is unclear. There are various possible allusions, none of which are totally sure: cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 2, 3 and *Ac* 20, 35; cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 6, 3 and *Ac* 7, 52; and cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 12, 2 and *Ac* 26, 18. Most of these may be common expressions of kerygmatic language or frequent allusions to passages from the Old Testament at the service of proclamation of the Christian faith.

4. The Synoptic Gospels in the Martyrdom of Polycarp

As we have explained earlier, the intention and theological method of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* is to reflect in the bishop of Smyrna, the following of Christ in line with the Gospel, in order to stimulate others to imitate him[1039]. The original author of the letter or the possible subsequent editors, in order to accomplish this didactic purpose, made reference to episodes from the Gospel

1038 Cf. P. Hartog, *Polycarp and the New Testament,* 181.
1039 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 1, 1; 19, 1.

or to sayings by Jesus, and especially to the account of Our Lord's passion. As already remarked, it cannot be concluded that such coincidences are totally artificial. Even so, it is impossible to establish exactly which moments in the narration deliberately echo the New Testament happenings and which ones are exclusively descriptive of reality.

The key to understanding the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* is the imitation, but above all the interpretation it makes of the story of the passion of Jesus. While it is certain that references to Christ's passion may be found in many places, we cannot speak of formal quotations from the Gospels. Then it would seem, as remarked earlier, that the references and reminiscences of the New Testament in the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* are rooted within a vision of the meaning of martyrdom, with the basic Pauline idea of being "imitators of the Lord"[1040]. The question is whether the author of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* made any use of the written Gospels now included in the canon of the New Testament. We will proceed in the order of the text, drawing attention to possible material that the author may have extracted from today's canonical Gospels[1041].

In the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* 4, the narrator, making reference to the Phrygian Quintus, says at the end of the paragraph: "We do not approve those who give themselves up, because this is not the teaching of the Gospel". The scholars have observed that here we are faced with a practice having clear references to the teaching and example of Christ himself when he ran away from his pursuers and did not wait for them[1042]. However, the directive of *Mt* 10, 23 to flee from persecution explicitly contradicts the behaviour for which Polycarp is praised in 1, 2, namely "he waited to be handed over, like the Lord".

B. Lightfoot suggests that in 5, 2, there is an allusion to *Mt* 26, 2 when Christ prophesies his betrayal "after two days", thus Polycarp too "three days before he

1040 Cf. *M. Polyc*., 1, 2 and 17, 3 with *Philad.,* 2, 4.

1041 We will not dwelll on the long list of constraints, similarities, or parallels. We will merely refer to the most significant ones which appear to offer clear evidence of acquaintance with and use made of the text of the Gospels. For a comprehensive and complete list, see B. Dehandschutter, *Martyrium Polycarpi: Een Literair-kritische Studie,* Leuven 1979; B. Lightfoot, *The Apostolic Fathers,* 610–611.

1042 In *Mt* 10, 23, the Lord says: "If they persecute you in one town, take refuge in the next, and if they persecute you in that take refuge in another. I tell you solemnly, you will not have gone the round of the towns of Israel before the Son of Man comes". In *Io* 7, 1, the evangelist reports that "after this Jesus stayed in Galilee; he could not stay in Judaea, because the Jews were out to kill him", cf. *Io* 8, 59; 10, 39.

was detained, had a vision"[1043]. Polycarp, unlike Jesus, did not predict the time of his betrayal, or his own destiny. However, both Jesus and Polycarp, refer in the prophecy about how they are going to die: the former crucified, and the second "burned alive". The prediction of Jesus on his death is likewise reported in *Mt* 20, 19 with parallels in *Mk* 10, 34 and *Lk* 18, 33; and once more in *Mt* 23, 24. None of these predictions explicitly agrees with what is reported in the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* regarding the bishop's prediction of his own death, so that we may conclude that the writer may be acquainted with an oral tradition on this prophecy of Jesus, but did not explicitly quote a Gospel.

The story indicates that Polycarp's martyrdom was inevitable when one of the young detained slaves, on being subjected to torture, informed against him. The story refers to the fact that Polycarp was handed over by those of "his own household (οἰκεῖοι)"[1044]. Observing the Gospel of *Mt* 10, 36, Jesus declares that "a man's enemies will be those of his own house (οἰκιακοί)". Some have suggested that the story of Polycarp echoes this concrete passage from Matthew, since the term is similar and the idea only appears in this Gospel[1045]. However, the context is a little different and, as noted earlier by E. Massaux, perhaps the expression "to be handed over by one of his own household" was a ready-made phrase[1046]. That is to say, on account of having a single expression in common we cannot necessarily opt for the author's dependence on the Gospel of *Matthew*.

The marked coincidence that the head of police responsible for the arrests of Polycarp was called Herod[1047], like the tetrarch of Galilee and Perea when Jesus was arrested, appears to clearly indicate a reference to the Gospel. However, the only Gospel which gives the tetrarch's name is *Lk* 23, 6–12 where we even find the dialogue between Jesus and Herod Antipas as well as an allusion in *Ac* 4, 27[1048]. Although the Christians of the second century, due to an extended tradition, had clear knowledge of the name of the tetrarch at the time of Jesus, his name only,

1043 Cf. B. Lightfoot, *The Apostolic Fathers,* 610.

1044 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 6, 1.

1045 Cf. M. Holmes, *Martyrdom of Polycarp and the Passion,* 410, in *Trajectories through the New Testament and the Apostolic Fathers*, ed. A. Gregory – C. Tuckett, New York 2005.

1046 Cf. E. Massaux, *The Influence of the gospel of Saint Matthew on Christian Literature before Saint Irenaeus,* Leuven 1992, 48–49.

1047 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 6, 2.

1048 Likewise, Ignatius makes a rapid reference to Herod, "he was truly crucified in the flesh by us under the power of Pilate and of the tetrarch Herod", Ign., *Smyrn.,* 1, 2.

given the absence of any other allusion in the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* to the Gospel of *Luke,* makes it impossible to establish with certainty that the author of the story was acquainted with the third canonical Gospel.

In this same paragraph, 6, 2, it is said that those who hand over Polycarp will suffer the "punishment of Judas". One might once more think that the author echoes *Mt* 27, 5 where he talks about the destiny of Judas who hangs himself; however, *Ac* 1, 18 likewise reports the end of Judas, but this time affirming that "he fell headlong and burst open and all his entrails poured out". Since the narrator does not specifically mention the type of punishment that Judas suffered, it is not possible to determine what source the author is referring to, if in fact he has made any such reference.

In paragraph 7, 1, the author comments that those who went to arrest Polycarp were "pursuing him as if were a bandit (ὡς ἐπὶ λῃστὴν τῳέχοντες)". If we consult in the *Thesaurus Linguae Graecae,* the expression "ὡς ἐπὶ λῃστήν", from the second century B.C. until the second century A.D., this only appears five times. One is that of *M. Polyc.,* 7, 1, while three parallel quotations in the Synoptic Gospels *Mt* 26, 55, *Mk* 14, 48, *Lk* 22, 52 and one in Origen in the *Comm. in Io.,* 28, 14, 113 in clear reference to the synoptic material. So that we can have a high level of certainty that the author of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* made allusion to the synoptic tradition, indeed, we may determine that he took it from a written Gospel due to the verbal identity of the expression, but we cannot determine which of the three Synoptic Gospels he quoted from.

After studying some of the most significant episodes of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* where there tended to be a loan from the Synoptic Gospels, we may say that we cannot determine a specific dependence in any of the texts analysed with absolute certainty. Certainly, there are abundant verbal allusions and conceptual parallels between the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* and the Synoptic Gospels, with the author showing himself to be in clear and profound debt to the evangelical tradition, but we cannot arrive at more definite conclusions. Clearly this does not mean that the writer did not know the written Gospels. Now the fact that the majority of the texts analysed display a certain degree of connection above all with the Gospel of *Matthew* would furthermore seem to be significant.

5. Conclusion

As conclusion of the reception that the Synoptic Gospels had in the writings of the Church of Smyrna, we may state that they reflect in some way the patristic testimonies presented heretofore regarding the universal acceptance of these in most authors of the second century.

The first point arising from analysis of the sources is the presence throughout of the Gospel of *Matthew.* This is found more or less everywhere as an accepted tradition in a factual way even though it may not be referred under the name of the evangelist. The use made of *Matthew* far outweighs any possible allusions to the Gospel of *Luke* and the very few to *Mark.* Thus it may be no exaggeration to affirm that the Christians living at the time going from the end of the first century to the end of the second century came to know the words and acts of Christ through the Gospel of *Matthew*[1049].

The Letter of Polycarp *To the Philippians* would seem to mitigate the traditional view that the first evident use of the written Gospels is in Justin's *Apologia.* We may say that the oral and written traditions at the beginning of the second century run from one side to the other of the Ecumene, being enriched or distorted. At times the Gospels may be accepted or ignored, and anthologies of them may be found in an appropriate, expanded, or improved manner. We can back up this perspective with the testimony of Papias who in this period seems to prefer oral tradition to the written texts[1050]. This practice will later be opposed as from the middle of the second century, when Justin on presenting a saying of the Lord will use the formula "it is written"[1051] and will make reference to having read in the liturgical celebration the "memoirs of the apostles"[1052], undoubtedly found in the Gospel of *Matthew*. Accordingly, the testimony of Papias should not be underestimated and it seems clear that at least at the time when Ignatius and Polycarp wrote their letters, evangelical material was quoted with great freedom.

1049 Cf. M. Simonetti, *Matthew 1–13, Ancient Christian Commentary on Scripture,* Downers Grove 2001, 19.

1050 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 3, 39; Hier., *vir. ill.,* 8 (PL 23, 653–657).

1051 Cf. Just., *dial.*, 49, 100, 105 (PG 6, 489–492; 709–711; 719–721).

1052 Cf. Just., *1 apol.,* 1, 67 (SCh 507, 308–312).

Chapter XI: The Johannine tradition in the Church of Smyrna

The Johannine tradition achieved its consolidation and great success during the second century in Asia Minor. The Church of Smyrna, starting from the testimonies of Irenaeus and other subsequent authors, seems not extraneous to this process. On the contrary, it appears as a protagonist, since its martyred bishop is a direct disciple of John and the community rallying in defence of the Quartodecimanist practice.

Hereafter, we will make a study of the consolidation of the Johannine tradition in Asia Minor, followed by an analysis of the writings of the Church of Smyrna in the second century to identify the reception in this community of the Johannine texts and the tradition attached to them.

1. Formation of the Johannine tradition in Asia

The communities founded in Asia by Paul in the middle and at the end of the first century were impacted by a fresh missionary wave which sheltered under the authority of the apostle John. The characteristics of this movement are reflected in a varied quantity of writings coming within the shadow of this tradition.

First of all, we find the fourth Gospel under the title of *John* which is presented as an interpretation of the figure of Jesus in a mysteric key and which seeks to highlight above all his divine dimension, starting off from the prologue which defines him as Logos, that is to say, the personalised divine Word, God himself, up to the manifestation of his glory through the seven signs, all of which followed by elaborate and profound discourses, ending up with a confession of faith by his listeners[1053]. Together with these discourses addressed to the multitude or to different personages, there are also particular discourses to his disciples in the intimity of the little group where Jesus reveals himself completely to his followers[1054]. For his disciples, headed by Peter, Jesus is not only a prophet or a messiah, but the Holy one of God[1055]. For his part, Jesus affirms that he and his Father are a single being[1056].

1053 Cf. *Io* 1–12.
1054 Cf. *Io* 13–16.
1055 Cf. *Io* 6, 69.
1056 Cf. *Io* 10, 30.

Referring to the author of the Gospel, the exegetes today speak of the "Beloved Disciple" whose name is never spelled out in the Gospel, but who laid his head on the Lord's breast, served as intermediary between Jesus and Peter at the last supper, recognised the Lord after his resurrection, was the disciple beloved of Jesus, to whom he entrusted his mother, and is the one who gave testimony beside the cross, putting it into writing, and a group of early Christians assumed this testimony as true[1057]. This community of believers in Jesus towards the end of the first century seems to have experienced a repulse in the midst of the Judaean diaspora as a result of opening up to disciples of Greek provenance, thus acquiring universalist concepts in their message and a lofty Christology. The defensive concentration of this Christology against "the Jews" and certain elements of ecclesial type produced a rupture in the communion (κοινονία) between these Christians.

This profound crisis in which the Johannine community found itself immersed already at the end of the first century is what we find in the three Johannine letters written by an Elder (πρεσβύτερος), probably the author of the fourth Gospel himself. In the third letter, we are told that one of the centres of this community sought its own autonomy, refusing the authority of the Elder. In the first and second letters, the Elder warns against those who, professing an incipient form of Docetism, refuse to recognise that Christ, Son of the Father, has come as a true man, of water and blood, in mortal flesh, that is, they deny that he became incarnate. Those who remained faithful to a lofty Christology but affirming in their turn the full incarnation of the Word, seemed incapable of combating these secessionist groups on their own, merely having recourse to their own tradition. Thus the appeal to the apostolic primacy of Peter observed in Chapter 21 of John's Gospel may have signified the acceptance by the community of official masters vested with authority, thanks to whom the latter began a gradual assimilation in the context of the churches of more generalised observance[1058], a case similar to that of non-radical Paulinism which likewise appealed to the figure and tradition of Peter. For their part, all of the traditional churches, in line with the lofty Christology of the Johannine community, gradually accepted its texts and traditions, and already by the time of Clement of Alexandria and Irenaeus

1057 Cf. *Io* 21, 24–25. There is a famous study by R. Brown on the reconstruction of the story of the Johannine community, cf. R. Brown, *The Community of the Beloved Disciple,* New York 1979.

1058 Cf. P. Grech, *La comunità giovannea nei cc. 7 e 8 del Vangelo di Giovanni,* and *Il Simone della storia e il Pietro della fede,* in *Il messaggio biblico e la sua interpretazione,* 227–235, 301–310.

the identity of the Beloved Disciple was that of John[1059], brother of James and son of Zebedee, and the place of writing of the Gospel and letters of *John* was Ephesus and Asia Minor.

As regards Ephesus as epicentre of the missionary activity of John and place of the redaction of these texts, none of the latter offers useful facts to support this assertion. On the contrary, the *Revelation*, another great text encompassed by the Johannine tradition, as we have already asserted on various occasions, is clearly identified as a writing originating from Asia Minor. Its author himself, who probably invoked the name and authority of John[1060], in a Greek full of Semitisms, writes in exile from Patmos to seven churches including among them Smyrna. Although the writing differs in many respects from the Gospel and letters of *John,* it has in common his lofty Christology in which he defines Christ as Logos and likewise presents him as a being of divine nature.

The writing takes its place in a fully Judaising religious dimension, which sees the Christian community as the chosen part of Israel, presented as the bride of the Lamb, that is of Christ, as opposed to the great whore, that is Jerusalem, destined to destruction. Due to its literary genre, the writing is difficult to interpret regarding the profound themes such as the coming of Christ, which at times appears already fulfilled while in other places still to come, dispensing throughout the theme of millenarianism expounded in chapters 20 and 21, and the courage of the anti-Roman *animus* of its author[1061], probably aroused by the persecution suffered at the hands of the Empire by the communities he addresses.

The text not only conveys a situation of threat to the communities from outside, but also highlights an internal crisis in these brought about by a group known as Nicolaitans, on whom we possess little information, but who, according to the overall vision of the accusations made by the author of *Revelation,* appear to be Christians who have carried various Pauline postulates to a radical level. The author writes to the communities for the purpose of re-establishing his authority which would appear to be contested by these groups. The Nicolaitans in Ephesus are discredited[1062], but on the contrary, they appear to be warmly welcomed in Pergamum and in Thyatira. In Pergamum, the teaching of Balaam is spreading, tending to induce the Israelites to eat meat consecrated to

1059 Cf. pp. 147 et seqq.

1060 Cf. pp. 151 et seqq.

1061 This anti-Roman *animus* was developed by the Asiatic Hippolytus, in contrast with the obsequious and loyal attitude to the Empire shown by Melito of Sardis.

1062 Cf. *Rv* 2, 6.

idols (idolotites) and to fornication[1063]. In Thyatira, the accusation is addressed against a woman who presents herself as a prophetess, eloquently named Jezebel by the author of the *Revelation,* and who apparently was very successful in seducing Christians, inducing them to eat idols and to fornicate[1064]. It is interesting to note that the adversary of the author of the *Revelation* was a woman. In *1 Co* 11, 5, we find that, despite Paul's not totally open attitude to the role of women in the assembly, there were certain women who were accustomed to taking the floor in community meetings and prophesying. Perhaps a similar situation was present in the Church of Thyateira, to the discomfort of the Judaising Christians.

The attack of the author of the *Revelation* against those who eat meat consecrated to idols, would seem to have its clear origin in the Pauline teaching which affirmed that this meat was not contaminating and that the idol was not a reality, and accordingly, the Christian could have no qualms in eating it always, providing no brother of weak faith were present who might be scandalised at seeing the person eating this type of meat[1065]. This teaching of Paul's contrasted with the total prohibition of the Jewish law, likewise accepted by the Judaising Christians, and it certainly was difficult to totally put it into practice in small communities where everyone knew one another. Doubtless, many Christians radicalising Paul's position, decided to eat that type of meat even in the presence of Christians of Jewish observance. The other accusation regarding fornication (πορνεία), may be understood as linked to the former, since in the Old Testament theology, this concept was linked to the infidelity of the people to its bride Yahweh in the form of idolatry, and accordingly to the fact of eating meat consecrated to idols. So that both accusations, eating meat consecrated to idols and fornication, in the sense of infidelity to God, are fully identified as characteristics of those who are called Nicolaitans and who would appear to have adopted Paul's teaching on the meat of idols in a totally open manner, without paying attention to Paul's proviso about not scandalising any brethren weak in the faith.

About these personages called Nicolaitans, we know very little. Already the ancients found no other possible connection of the name of this group, but Nicholas, the last of the seven men established by the apostles, of whom it was said that he was a proselyte from Antioch[1066]. All the news given by ancient

1063 Cf. *Rv* 2, 14–15. Cf. *Nb* 25, 1 et seqq.; 31, 16.
1064 Cf. *Rv* 2, 20.
1065 Cf. *1 Co* 8 and 10.
1066 Cf. *Ac* 6, 5.

heresiologists, beginning with the catalogue of heresies transmitted by Irenaeus in *haer.,* 1, 22–27, seem to have only the information given in *Ac* 6, 5 and *Ac 2* as reference[1067]. Perhaps Clement shows signs of knowing something more on Nicholas, adjudicating to him a famous sentence: "It is necessary to abuse of meat", and he goes on to state that, in a simplistic and literal way, the followers of the heresy of Nicholas abandoned themselves shamelessly to fornication. Nevertheless, he affirms that he knows that Nicholas had no relations with any other woman than the one he had married; and, of his descendants, the daughters kept their virginithy into old age, and the son stayed on at home[1068].

Apart from this, another accusation of the author of the *Revelation* has to do with the presence in Philadelphia of some who had fallen into the abyss (τὰ βαθέα) of Satan[1069]. Remaining in the context of comparison with radical Paulinism, one could explain the aim of some to have a profound knowledge of God when in reality, according to the author of the *Revelation,* they have obtained a profound knowledge of Satan. It is probable that such Christians have radicalised the concept of "profundity of God" obtained exclusively through the Holy Spirit according to the teaching of Paul in *1 Co* 2, 10.

So that, when attempting to reconstruct a unitarian pattern of the characteristics of the adversaries of the author of the *Revelation,* the fight, already recorded in other Asiatic sources, against a radical Paulinism would appear the most plausible hypothesis[1070].

As we stated earlier, the Johannine tradition arrived in Asia Minor to stay, and even in many aspects, to overlay the earlier Pauline tradition. This is noted by many second-century Asiatic sources which show reluctance to the figure of Paul, or at least, to certain aspects of his doctrine, and are clearly favourable to the figure of John.

The *Acts of John,* Clement of Alexandria, Irenaeus, and Polycrates related John's mission directly with Ephesus and Asia Minor. Polycarp was identified as

1067 Cf. Iren., *haer.,* 1, 26, 3.

1068 Cf. Clem., *str.,* 2, 118, 3 (SCh 38, 123).

1069 Cf. *Rv* 2, 24.

1070 Cf. M. Simonetti, *Paolo nell'Asia cristiana del II secolo,* 131 and 133. However, as M. Simonetti himself points out, some experts think that the *Revelation* is a writing in sympathy with the Pauline doctrine, since no polemics are present around themes which Paul had spoken out against, such as the law, circumcision, observance of the Shabbat, fasting, or the licitness of sacrifices, cf. D. Aune, *The "Angels" of the Seven Churches* in *Revelation* 1–5, (*World Biblical Commentary,* vol. 52), 1997, 165.

an illustrious disciple of John[1071], and extra-biblical traditions of the Apostle were in time localised in this region[1072].

At the level of its theology, the Johannine tradition also saw its acceptance and consolidation in Asia Minor with the development of arguments formulated in the Johannine writings[1073]. Themes such as millenarianism[1074], that is, the belief according to which, before the final judgment, Christ will have established, centred on Jerusalem, the reign of the just resuscitated to reign with him for a 1000 years, in an renewed earth rich in fruits of all kinds, had fervent followers in this region. This is the case of the Judaising Cerinthus, Papias, Justin, Melito and Irenaeus[1075], though each of them from his own perspective.

Cerinthus insisted on the licitness of carnal pleasures and the continuation of Jewish practices[1076]. Papias also had a strongly materialistic conception (σοματικῶς) of Christ's reign of a 1000 years[1077], very possibly on account of a Judaising influence apparently much stronger than that of the author of the *Revelation* himself on this aspect, speaking of this reality in a sober manner and with quite a symbolic outlook which even seems to repel the Judaising materialistic conception so widespread in Asia. Justin too has a materialistic outlook on the millennium, even if he is the first author to maintain his convictions based on the *Revelation,* making what is clearly a deformed reading of the same[1078]. For

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1071 Cf. Iren., *ep. Flor.,* in Eus., *h. e.* 5, 20, 6, cf. Tert., *praescr.,* 32, 2 (SCh 46, 130–131). This news is likewise echoed by Hier., *vir. ill.,* 17 (PL 23, 667–670).

1072 These traditions are the meeting of John with the heretic Cerinthus in the baths, and the story of a young disciple of John who ended up by turning robber. These traditions were localised in Ephesus and Smyrna respectively, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 4, 14, 16; Clem., *q.d.s.,* 42, 7 (SCh 537, 212). The identification of Smyrna, as where the story told by Clement took place, is established later in *Chron. Pasch.,* 251.

1073 Cf. M. Mara, *Presenza della tradizione giovannea nelle prime comunità cristiane,* in *Atti del I Simposio di Efeso su S. Giovanni Apostolo,* Rome 1991, 111–127.

1074 A doctrine also called *chiliasm,* from χίλιοι which means 1000, cf. M. Simonetti, *L'Apocalissi e l'origine del millennio,* in *Vetera Christianorum* 26 (1989) 337–350. E. Prinzivalli, *Il millenarismo in Oriente da Metodio ad Apollinare,* in *Annali di Storia dell'Esegesi* 15 (1998) 125–151; W. Horbury, *Messianism among Jews and Christians in the Second Century,* in *Augustinianum* 28 (1988), 71–88.

1075 Cf. Iren., *haer.,* 5, 33–36.

1076 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 3, 28, 2.4. For an interesting study on the person and doctrine of Cerinthus, cf. C. Hill, *Cerinthus, Gnostic or Chiliast?,* in *Journal of Early Theological Studies* (2000), 135–172.

1077 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 3, 39, 12.

1078 Cf. Just., *dial.,* 113, 3–5 (PG 6, 736–737).

his part, once more from a materialistic point of view like all Asiatics, Irenaeus is the Asiatic author who deals most fully with the theme of the millennium, but drawing on different texts of Scripture, also including the *Revelation*[1079]. In this sense, he did not force an interpretation of the *Revelation,* as Justin did, and interpreted correctly the sequence of facts narrated there, separating the reign of the millennium from the descent of the new Jerusalem by means of an allusion to the final judgment. As for the rest, both in Justin and in Irenaeus, the theme is treated with evident polemical implications against the eschatological spiritualism of the Gnostics.

Another theological theme connected with the Johannine tradition developed above all in Asia Minor was the celebration of the passion of Our Lord on the 14th of the lunar month of Nisan, regardless of the day of the week on which it should fall. Within this liturgical tradition we may identify personages such as the apostle John himself, Philip and his daughters, Strataeas of Eumenia, Sagaris of Laodicea, Papirius, Melito of Sardis, and Polycrates of Ephesus[1080].

All of these facts in favour of the acceptance of the Johannine tradition by the ecclesiastical authors during the second century appear to contrast with the supposed silences regarding the Johannine texts in this same Asiatic ecclesiastical context, with the supposed acceptance accorded to the fourth Gospel by gnostic circles and with the mistrust evinced towards the fourth Gospel and the *Revelation* by certain members of the Roman hierarchy[1081]. This scenario led many scholars to hypothesise a Johannophobia on the part of Orthodoxy. Within this same thesis, many held Irenaeus largely responsible for the change in fortunes of the Gospel of *John* among orthodox authors, overcoming any prejudice against him and converting it into a weapon against the various heretical groups.

This thesis is largely discredited today, as shown by the studies of R. Brown[1082] and C. Hill[1083], among others, who have drawn attention to the influence of this Gospel on authors such as Ignatius, Aristides, Papias, *The Shepherd* of Hermas,

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1079 The doctrine of the millennium may be found in Iren., *haer.,* 5, 28, 3; 5, 30, 4; 5, 33, 4; 5, 34, 2: 5, 35, 1; 5, 36, 3.

1080 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 24, 2.

1081 The first Christian exegetical writing we know of is the *Commentary on John* by the Valentinian gnostic Heracleon in about the year 160, cf. M. Simonetti, *Testi gnostici in lingua latina e greca,* Rome 2009[5], 201–208. On the mistrust evinced by Gaius and the Roman hierarchy to the fourth Gospel and the *Revelation* at the end of the second century, cf. E. Prinzivalli, *Gaio (e Alogi)* in NDPAC (2007), 2029–2030.

1082 Cf. R. Brown, *The Community of the Beloved Disciple,* New York 1979.

1083 Cf. C. Hill, *The Johannine Corpus in the Early Church,* New York 2004.

and the *Epistle of the Apostles,* all of which dating from before 150 and with an extension ranging from Syria, through Asia Minor and Greece to Rome itself. As for Irenaeus being the one who changed the fortunes of the fourth Gospel, overcoming all prejudice against it and winning it over to orthodoxy, this idea is exaggerated, since as we have seen, the Johannine tradition was present throughout the second century in regions such as Asia and in ecclesiastical authors, although undoubtedly with Irenaeus both the variety and extent of the use of the fourth Gospel and the traditions around it and its author were greatly consolidated[1084]. Moreover, we do not find a spirit of defence of the fourth Gospel against the Gnostics in Irenaeus, as if he had to defend its orthodoxy, nor a presentation of it to the ecclesiastics with a view to seeking their approval. What Irenaeus refutes in the Gnostics is the exegesis they make of *John,* not the source they use to inspire their doctrines. Irenaeus makes use of the Gospel of *John,* as an authoritative text which has always belonged to orthodox Christianity.

R. Brown points out that already at the end of the first century the first letter of *John* made it clear that there was an orthodox manner of reading the fourth Gospel, and that the struggle of this epistle against the secessionists further stimulated many writers such as Irenaeus to employ this Gospel against the Gnostics who were spiritual descendants of the secessionists since influenced by the way in which these read the fourth Gospel. So that it was not Irenaeus who saved the Gospel of *John* for the Church, but the author of *1 John* who did so much earlier[1085].

With this overview of the history and reception of the Johannine tradition, we now intend to study this reception in the specific context of the Church of Smyrna for the purpose of analysing what attitudes the community adopted towards the authority of the apostle John, the assimilation of the writings originating from this tradition, and the acceptance of the theological themes proposed by them.

2. Letter to the Church of Smyrna, Rv 2, 8–11

We do not propose here to comment on the missive in all of its details, for which we refer the reader to extensive commentaries and to what has been said earlier[1086]. Here we will deal with the letter only with a view to pinpointing the

1084 Cf. C. Hill, *The Johannine Corpus in the Early Church*, 95–96.

1085 Cf. R. Brown, *The Community of the Beloved Disciple*, 149–150.

1086 Cf. p. 5 et seqq. For a complete detailed study of the letter and biblical and extra-biblical context, cf. C. Hermer, *The Letters to the Seven Churches of Asia,* 57–77;

characteristics of the community to which the author addresses himself and its reception in the message of John the seer.

This letter is the second and shortest of the seven messages that the revealer conveys to John the Seer in his epiphany[1087]. Like all the messages, the letter begins with a formula of prophetic command. The basic model of this formula in the Old Testament is: See and say to X that Y says thus…". Given that John cannot leave Patmos, the order "see" is replaced by "write". The speaker (Y) in each passage is the risen Jesus. So that the prophet, in order to give greater weight to his words addressed to the community of Smyrna, has recourse to the most meaningful prosopopoeia in the Christian canon: "Thus speaks the First and Last, he who died then came to life once more".

Thereafter, the revealer gives proof of his acquaintance with the community of Smyrna. The community is suffering from tribulation and poverty, and in addition the slanders of those who are called Jews but are not, since in reality they are a synagogue (σιναγωγή) of Satan.

The material poverty (πτωχείαν) of the community would seem to be in contrast with its spiritual riches (πλούσιος). This is a commonplace in New Testament literature[1088]; however, it is possible to think that the material or even intellectual poverty was an accusation made against the Christians to whom the prophet addresses himself. Nonetheless, such poverty might have been real, since this situation is not mentioned in any of the other six communities. Most of the experts think that this poverty is due to the impossibility for those intransigent Christians to earn a living in a pagan environment[1089]. However, others have thought that the accusation of being poor refers to their christological faith which recognises the passion of the Son of Man, in contrast with the supposed wealth of a docetist Christology professed by certain Christians there, against whom Ignatius in his letter to this same community will put them on their guard[1090].

The slanders (βλασφημίαν) suffered by those in the community who call themselves Jews but are not may be considered as typical accusations and hostilities on

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P. Pigent, *L'Apocalypse de Saint Jean,* 125–129; D. Aune, *The "Angels" of the Seven Churches of Asia,* 12.

1087 Cf. W. Ramsay, *The Letters to the Seven Churches of Asia,* 12.

1088 Cf. *2 Co* 6, 10; *Jm* 2, 5. In *Rv* 3, 17 the situation is the opposite, since the community of Laodicea thinks itself as rich, when in fact it is poor.

1089 Cf. D. Aune, *The "Angels" of the Seven Churches,* 161.

1090 Cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 13.

the part of the Jews against Christians that we find in other texts[1091]. In Smyrna itself, both the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* and the *Martyrdom of Pionius* clearly point to the active hostility of the local Jews against the Christians[1092]. Nonetheless, it is important to stress that here the term "Jews" is used in a positive sense but that, according to John, those who call themselves Ἰουδαίους do not realise what that term implies. This reinforces the idea that the Christian communities addressed by the prophet largely originate from Judaism. So that it is probable that at the time when the *Revelation* is written, many of these Christians in fact continued to attend Jewish environments proper, such as synagogues, thus avoiding the possible obligation of worshipping the Emperor. Thus in certain situations the Jews would have the option of denouncing such Christians to the authorities, and it is to this practice that the author of the *Revelation* may be referring when he uses the term βλασφημίαν[1093]. Furthermore, when these Jews not only denounced the Judaising Christians to the authorities but refused to accept the Son of God then, as it is clear from the Gospel of *John,* they were considered by the Christians as sons of the devil[1094]. This context explains why the synagogue to which these Jews belong is called synagogue of Satan.

Apart from this, the term βλασφημίαν is used in other parts of the *Revelation* for the same purpose of insulting or speaking irreverently of God[1095]. In this same sense it might also encompass those Christians of the community whose blasphemy would consist of doubting the reality of the Incarnation, as appears in the letters of John.

The tribulation of ten days announced to certain members of the community who will be imprisoned shows that the Christians of Smyrna are preparing to share the same fate as John, likewise persecuted and exiled to Patmos. So that the community of Smyrna is united with the author of the *Revelation* not only in the particularities of his Christian confession, but also in his suffering and fate. Most of the commentaries on this letter draw attention to the linking of the name of the city with the situation of suffering described in *Revelation*[1096]. Personages

1091 Cf. *Ac* 13, 45; Just., *dial.,* 16, 4; 47, 5; 96, 2 (PG 6, 509–511; 576–589; 704).

1092 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 12, 2–3; 13, 1; *M. Pion.,* 4, 8.

1093 Cf. D. Aune, *The "Angels" of the Seven Churches,* 1997, 162. We find the term βλασφημίαν used in this same context in *Ac* 13, 45; 18, 6.

1094 Cf. *Io* 8, 44.

1095 Cf. *Rv* 13, 6; 16, 9; 11, 21.

1096 Cf. W. Ramsay, *The Letters to the Seven Churches of Asia,* 269–270; C. Hemer, *The Letters to the Seven Churches of Asia,* 61–64; D. Aune, *The "Angels" of the Seven Churches,* 1997, 161.

more or less contemporary to this text, such as Apollonius of Tyana and Aelius Aristides, found a special connection between the name of the city and the symbolism of the word σμύρνα also linked with myrrh (μύρον, μύρω). Accordingly, the concepts of burial and resurrection associated with myrrh might be reflected in the portrait of a city of sufferings. In fact, the etymology of this word lends itself in subsequent Christian exegesis to connection with the tomb or sufferings of Christ[1097]. Even in the way in which Christ is represented, as he who was dead but now lives again, an allusion might be seen to the history of the city, since in the local mentality this was represented as she who had arisen once more after difficult times: "the city, as in a play, grows again from its foundations after changing its age, being at one and the same time an old and a new city, as in the story of the Phoenix which is born again from its own ashes"[1098]. Thus, just as the city has been reborn of its ashes, Christ, through the prophet of the *Revelation,* promises the Christian community of Smyrna to give it the crown[1099] of life (στέφανον τῆς ζωῆς) for having remained faithful even unto death.

In conclusion, Smyrna, together with Philadelphia, is the only community which is not the object of reproach by the prophet; instead he praises its spiritual richness, encourages it in suffering, and promises it the crown of life, so that we may consider that these Christians possessed a mentality in line with that of the author of the *Revelation.* That is to say, it was a community which felt itself surrounded by a hostile world, consisting of judaising Christians who felt the pull of their Jewish community of origin on the one hand, and on the other hand, accepted as referent of their Christian faith the authority of John, like him being reticent to the practices of a radical Paulinism. Following this same line, assuming the Johannine tradition, the community of Smyrna also identified itself with the postulates of the Gospel and above all the letters of John and regarded Docetism as an imminent danger for the Christian faith.

3. The Johannine tradition in the letters of Ignatius

As regards the Gospel of *John,* it seems clear that Ignatius was at least influenced by his theology, although it is by no means certain that he made use of it[1100].

1097 Cf. Thdt., *Ps.,* 45, 8 (PG 80, 1203–1205).

1098 Cf. Aristid., *Palinode for Smyrna* 19.

1099 On the popular origin of the metaphorical use of στέφανος in the Hellenistic world, cf. W. Schoedel, *Ignatius of Antioch,* 131.

1100 Cf. P. Foster, *The Epistles of Ignatius of Antioch and the Writings that later formed the New Testament,* in A. Gregory – C. Tuckett, 2005, 159–186.

The allusions to themes developed by Johannine theology in the letters of Ignatius are at least seven: the bread of God[1101], the living water[1102], the door that is Christ[1103], the characteristics of those born of the Spirit[1104], the Son's obedience to the Father[1105], the acceptance of Christ himself as the one who had been sent,[1106] and the unction of Christ and of the Church[1107]. What seems surprising, apart from the different allusions, is the good knowledge of Johannine theology to be found in those parts referring to the Gospel of *Matthew.* For example, when reference is made to the star of Bethlehem in *Eph.,* 19, 1–3:

> A star shone in the sky above all others; and shed an ineffable light. Its newness produced a strange effect, and all the other stars together with the sun and the moon, gathered round the new star. It, notwithstanding, shed the most powerful light of them all. And people were troubled as to where such dissimilar novelty to them could have been born. Whence all kinds of magic dissolved and every cunning artifice faded. Ignorance was eliminated, and by God's manifesting himself to humankind for newness of eternal life, the ancient reign disappeared and what God had prepared began. Thereupon all things were moved, because the idea was to abolish death.

In this passage, we see how Ignatius assumes the eschatology evolved by Johannine theology, "the reign of our God and his Christ" has already become real with the Incarnation, has taken place in Bethlehem. Here too Ignatius speaks of Johannine themes such as the manifest arrival in the flesh, the Word proceeding from the silence of God, and the coming and return of Jesus to the Father.

Although Ignatius' allusions to Johannine theology are apparently clear and one might think that he had been acquainted with this theology in the possible phase of development of this tradition, in Antioch or in Syria, the fact that Ignatius makes no direct mention of John in his letter to the Church of Ephesus, the traditional place of the apostle's mission, cannot fail to surprise us. Even so, undoubtedly this letter is where we find most allusions to themes of Johannine theology.

1101 Cf. Ign., *Eph.,* 5, 2 and *Rom.,* 7, 3; cf. *Io* 6, 33.
1102 Cf. Ign., *Rom.,* 7, 2*; Io.,* 4, 10b 14.
1103 Cf. Philad., 9, 1; cf. *Io* 10, 9.
1104 Cf. Ign., *Philad.,* 7, 1; cf. *Io* 3, 8.
1105 Cf. Ign., *Magn.,* 7, 1 and 8, 2; cf. *Io* 8, 28–29.
1106 *Io* 13, 20, in Ign., *Eph.,* 6, 1.
1107 *Io* 12, 1–8, in Ign., *Eph.,* 17, 1.

4. The Johannine tradition in Polycarp's letter to the Philippians

Polycarp apparently made no use of the Gospel of John in his letter *To the Philippians*. The Lord's promise to raise the believers to new life from among the dead, which appears in *To the Philippians* 5, 2, although it belongs to the Gospel of *John*[1108] and not to the Synoptic Gospels, is common kerygmatic material. All the same, this still appears to be particularly strange considering that Polycarp is associated for Irenaeus and for Eusebius with the apostle John, that the Gospel of *John* is the gospel par excellence of Asia Minor as is revealed by the Quartodecimanist controversy, and that Polycarp himself defended in Rome the celebration of Easter on 14th Nisan by the churches of Asia.

Likewise, no allusion is made to the *Revelation*. This is a disconcerting fact, seeing that it includes the letter to the Church of Smyrna.

As for the use made of John's letters, the only possible strong evidence could lie in the fact that the Johannine letters are the only New Testament writings that use the term "ἀντίχριστος"[1109], and Polycarp is the only Apostolic Father who uses it also and followed by another expression found in *1 John*. In 7, 1 he affirms: "Thus everyone who does not confess that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh is an anti-Christ", going on to say: "he who does not confess the testimony of the cross belongs to the devil (ἐκ τοῦ διαβόλου ἐστίν)", an expression from *1 Io* 3, 8. Now, the testimony of the cross (τὸ μαρτύριον τοῦ σταυροῦ), may make reference to the water and blood which gushed from Christ's side, as suggested by B, Lightfoot, knowing that John says in this connection: "This is testified by one who saw it, and his testimony is valid"[1110]. In 7, 2, he makes reference "to the word which was transmitted to us from the beginning", as a possible reference to *1 Io* 1.

Perhaps this explanation in Polycarp's writings for the absence of allusions to John's authority, to his Gospel and to the *Revelation* lies in the context of the community of Philippi at the time when Polycarp wrote the letter. The community of Philippi was on the other shore of the Aegean sea and was of an especially Pauline character ever since its foundation. Unlike Asia Minor where the Johannine tradition seems to have exerted a great authority, the Johannine writings did not necessarily enjoy the same authority in this area. For the rest, the fact that Polycarp did not use the Johannine writings in this letter does not mean that he was not acquainted with them.

1108 Cf. *Io* 5, 21. 25; 6, 44.

1109 *1 Io* 2, 18; 2, 22; 4, 3.

1110 *Io* 19, 35. Cf. B. Lightfoot, *The Apostolic Fathers,* 334.

5. The Johannine tradition in the Martyrdom of Polycarp

As we have stated earlier, the author of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* proposed to tell the events in accordance with the martyrdom which appears in the Gospel (κατὰ τὸ εὐαγγέλιον μαρτύριον)[1111]. For this purpose, not only do allusions to the Synoptic Gospels appear, above all to *Matthew,* but for their vast majority, such allusions, above all in chapters seven and eight, may be identified with the Gospel of *John* and his theology[1112]. The allusions to the Gospel of *John* framed in a theology and liturgical praxis, such as the celebration of the Quartodecimanist Easter, may provide the oldest testimony of the celebration of the Easter vigil in Smyrna in the second century[1113].

In fact, the whole episode of Polycarp's arrest takes place between "Friday towards supper time" (τῇ παρασκευῇ περὶ δείπνου ὥραν)[1114] and the "Grand Sabbath" (σαββάτου μεγάλου)[1115] when the pursuers led him back to the city, the whole capture lasting one night. The mention of the Παρασκευή at such a critical time as the arrest, and with the theological intention of imitating the Gospel, should perhaps be assessed not only as a mere chronological indication, but an evocation of the climate of that Easter vigil to the close of which, precisely in *Io* 19, 31, reference is made when there appears as New Testament *hapax legomenon* the expression "Grand Shabbat". It is also important to note that the bishop continued to fast the whole time from his arrest on Friday until

1111 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 1, 1; 19, 1.

1112 Cf. G. Luongo, *Bibbia e agiografia: echi giovannei nel* Martyrium Polycarpi, in *Atti del IX Symposio di Efeso su S. Giovanni apostolo*, Rome 2003, 105–122.

1113 This is how R. Cacitti interpreted it, *Grande Sabato, Il contesto pasquale quartodecimano nella formazione della teologia del martirio,* Milan 1994, 52.

1114 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 7, 1.

1115 Various hypotheses have been formulated to explain the meaning of this "Grand Shabbat". It might refer to a Holy Saturday, or perhaps it was a Saturday coinciding with a feast of the Jewish calendar such as the feast of the *Purim*. There may also be a confusion here since the Macedonian month of Xanthicus corresponds to the Roman month of February, but also to the month of April of the Syro-Macedonian calendar, widespread in the East. Whence an Oriental could have interpolated the adjective μέγα, making of it an Easter Saturday. It could also be interpreted as an ordinary Saturday on which the pagans celebrate some special feast. Finally it was also noted that the expression μέγα σάββατον meant Sunday, in contrast to μικρὸν σάββατον which meant Saturday, see J. Ayán Calvo, 255, note 22. To review the *status quaestionis* of the ageold controversy on this expression, cf. R. Cacitti, *Grande Sabato,* 11–38.

his coming to the city on the following day, "Grand Shabbat". While his pursuers instead ate and drank at that hour (ἐν ἐκείνῃ τῇ ὥρᾳ), he retired to pray "in the direction of the east" (σταθεὶς πρὸς ἀνατολάς)[1116]. The micro-Asiatic context testifies to the fact that the glorious coming of the Parousia of Christ was expected from the East[1117].

Polycarp prayed, standing, for a full two hours. This is perhaps not merely an echo of Jesus' prayer at the last supper of *Io* 17, but also, the erect position in prayer recalls the figure of the Christian who as he prays assumes the shape of the cross (σταυρός)[1118].

Together with the situation of prayer and fasting, classic of Judaism, there is also the mention of the place where the pursuers met the bishop: "lying in a small room on the upper floor (ἔν τινι δωματίῳ κατακείμενον ἐν ὑπερῴῳ)". This idea may well be a reference to *Ac* 1, 13, where the apostles returning to their meeting place after the Ascension, make their way to the upper room (εἰς τὸ ὑπερῷον), to await the coming of the Lord and persevering in prayer with a single spirit. This very allusion to the upper room (τὸ ὑπερῷον) as a place of prayer and of celestial visions is found in *Ac* 10, 9 and 20, 8.

Thus then the place (ὑπερῷον), the direction (πρὸς ἀνατολάς), and the symbol (σταυρός) of this type of prayer by Polycarp lead us to a perspective of eschatological type, proper to the liturgy which awaits the παρουσία of the Lord, which is an important characteristic of the Quartodecimanist Easter proper to the churches of Asia.

The expression "supper time (περὶ δείπνου ὥραν)" which is after τῇ παρασκευῇ, may be taken both from *Io* 13, 2 (δείπνου) in a reminiscence of the Last Supper, and from the Synoptic Gospels, *Lk* 14, 17 (τῇ ὥρᾳ τοῦ δείπνου), where it is singularly used in v. 16 (δείπνου μέγα), in relation to the bread which will be eaten in the kingdom of God of v. 15 (μακάριος ὅστις φάγεται ἄρτον ἐν τῇ βασιλείᾳ τοῦ Θεοῦ). One of the fundamental characteristics of the Quartodecimanist Easter seems to be the close relationship between Easter and Parousia, and furthermore with a millenarian accent, as appears to be confirmed among many other Asiatic

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1116 Cf. R. Cacitti, *Grande Sabato,* 47, note 28. The explicit allusion to the *orientis partem* towards which the Christians turn in prayer, may here provide the oldest testimony to it. In fact, this testimony is earlier than that of Clem., *str.,* 7, 7, 43, 7 (SCh 428, 150–152) "Paul turned to the East, raised his hands to heaven and prayed for a long time".

1117 *Epistula Apostolorum* 16, *M. Pion.,* 21, 1; Meth., *symp.,* 11, 285 (SCh 95, 310).

1118 *Odes of Solomon* 27, 1–3: "I have stretched out my hands and sanctified my Lord: since holding out my hands is a sign of Him, and my being erect, the wood straightened".

sources of this tradition, in the *Epistle of the Apostles,* when in answer to the question by the apostles on the time of his second coming, the Lord's reply is: "When one hundredth or one twentieth is fulfilled, between Pentecost and the feast of the Unleavened bread, my Father's coming will take place"[1119]. This characteristic of the Quartodecimanist Easter which relates Easter with the Parousia appears in Polycrates of Ephesus, who at the height of the controversy with Victor of Rome, proclaims that all the martyrs named by him who celebrated Easter on 14th Nisan, including Polycarp, "will rise from the dead on the day of the Lord's coming, when He descends from the heavens in glory and in search of all the saints"[1120].

So that, in the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* not only do we find certain allusions to the Gospel of *John,* but these are used theologically to relate the arrest of Polycarp with the Easter of Christ, understood as "passion", in the most Quartodecimanist sense of the expression, and furthermore, the redaction of this happening possibly has the characteristics of a celebration of the Quartodecimanist Easter, with this narration being converted into what is probably the first testimony we have of this liturgical practice in Smyrna, prior to the testimonies of Irenaeus and Polycrates.

Polycarp's prayer in chapter 14 may also be a testimony to the author's knowledge of the Gospel of John and the *Revelation.* Polycarp addresses himself to God as the Almighty (ὁ παντοκράτωρ), a title appearing in the *Revelation* and no less than six times (*Rv,* 4, 8; 11, 17; 15, 3; 16, 7; 19, 6; and 21, 22). In particular, in *Rv* 15, 2, those who have triumphed over the Beast invoke Almighty God in the same way as Polycarp invokes him, mentioning his hope for the resurrection of eternal life (εἰς ἀνάστασιν ζωῆς αἰωνίου)[1121]. This also reflects the terminology of *Io* 5, 29, εἰς ἀνάστασιν ζωῆς, with the Johannine characteristic of the adjective αἰώνιος added[1122]. Finally, in 20, 2, the author speaks of Jesus as only-begotton (μονογενής). A term coined in the Gospel of *John* in 1, 14. 18, 3, 16. 18 and which also appears in *1 Io* 4, 9.

1119 *Epistula Apostolorum* 17. The allusion to the feast of Pentecost and to that of the Unleavened bread is to Easter, just as the allusion to Pentecost was related to the Parousia in the antique church, cf. Tert., *bapt.,* 19, 2 (SCh 35, 94); Or., *Cels.,* 8, 22 (Sch 150, 222–224), cf. R. Cacitti, *Grande Sabato,* 52–64.

1120 Eus., *h. e.* 5, 24, 2.

1121 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 14, 2. For the use of the term ὁ παντοκράτωρ, in other pre-Nicene writings, cf. J. Batut, *Pantocrator, "Dieu le Père tout-puissant" dans la théologie prénicéenne,* Paris 2009.

1122 This adjective is recurrent above all in *John* and *1 John.* Of the 43 times it appears in the NT, 17 are in *John* and six in *1 John,* and all in relation to a description of ζωή.

As regards the presence of the *Revelation* in the *Martyrdom of Polycarp*, it seems clear that the environment of persecution described throughout the *Revelation,* and in a particular way in *Rv* 2, 8–11 in the letter to the Church of Smyrna, was material of inspiration for the writer of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp.* On the one hand, the mention regarding the slanders of those who call themselves Jews but are not (*Rv* 2, 9), sees its development in the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* when it is they who publicly denounce the bishop (12, 2–3), enthusiastically collect stakes and wood from the workshops to burn him (13, 1), and attempt to prevent the Christians from recovering his body (17, 2; 18, 1). On the other hand, the promise of the crown of life (*Rv* 2, 10), metaphor of a posthumous prize, appears to be realised in Polycarp, who by his martyrdom, has achieved a crown of incorruptibility (*M. Polyc.,* 17, 1). However, although both the theme of Jewish virulence and the metaphor of the crown are common to both texts, it is still true that these same themes are also dealt with in other sources of the same period and the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* is almost 50 years removed from the *Revelation,* so that the mention of these themes could merely be the reflection of a widespread reality and not necessarily a direct dependence on the *Revelation*.

In summary, as far as the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* is concerned, the Johannine tradition is perceived above all in chapters seven and eight which may be the first testimony of the celebration of the Quartodecimanist Easter in Smyrna. The allusions to the Gospel of *John* appear abundant and the terminology in many cases is similar to the Johannine letters and to the *Revelation.*

6. Conclusion

After having compared the second-century sources of the Church of Smyrna with the great authority of the Johannine tradition in the rest of Asia Minor, we may draw the following conclusions.

In the *Revelation,* it appears clear that the community of Smyrna identifies with the theological and disciplinary postulates of the seer John, since it receives no reproaches from the prophet. On the contrary, it seems prepared to share its own destiny amidst a hostile world, and appears reticent to the practices of a radical Paulinism.

In the letters of Ignatius, clear allusions are made to the theology of the Gospel of *John.* However, Ignatius makes no explicit reference to the authority of this apostle. For his part, Polycarp in his letter *To the Philippians* makes no use of the Johannine texts or appeal to the authority of John, despite the strong weight of the tradition which links him as a direct disciple of the apostle.

For its part, the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* appears to take various expressions from the Gospel of *John,* elaborating in a christological context, the narration of the night of Polycarp's arrest against the background of the celebration of Easter. It also probably took the *Revelation,* especially the letter to Smyrna, as a reading key for interpreting the persecution of the Church and the martyrdom of its bishop in about 155.

The reception of the Johannine texts in the Church of Smyrna, although it is perceptible in many cases while in others its absence is justifiable, does not appear very widespread. However, when we find allusions to the Johannine writings in the scarce documentation in our possession, these are used in a theologically meaningful way.

The doctrine on millenarianism, developed in the Christian environment based on *Rv* 20 and 21, and accepted by so many Asiatic authors representing different viewpoints, seems not to be mentioned in Ignatius, Polycarp, and the author of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp.* However, this doctrine will be found by us abundantly dealt with by Irenaeus, who sought to re-elaborate it on the basis of the *Revelation* and with his personal interpretation of the history of salvation, in anti-Gnostic key. In fact, as he himself states, Irenaeus feels himself to be the debtor of a teaching received from Asiatic Christianity. It is probable that in the case of the millenarianist doctrine, this was no exception.

As for the other theme of intertwined Johannine roots in the celebration of Easter on 14 Nisan, we do find a possible allusion in the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* which ratifies the testimony of Irenaeus and of Polycrates regarding the Quartodecimanist celebration in Smyrna. In fact, the bishop's arrest may have taken place in the midst of the celebration of Easter, or even more plausibly, the author of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* within the liturgical character of the document, re-elaborated the bishop's arrest with the characteristics proper to the theology of the Quartodecimanist celebration.

So that, in contrast to the force of the tradition which links the Church of Smyrna, and in particular its bishop Polycarp with the figure of John, the documents in our possession dating from this time do not appear to ascribe any special importance to this connection. All the writings which we possess with certainty originating from the Church of Smyrna in the second century are circumstantial texts, all of them letters, and were not conceived as doctrinal treatises in the strict sense, as were the five books of the *Exposition of the Oracles of the Lord* of Papias, today lost, or Justin's *Apologies* and *Dialogue with Trypho.*

Apart from this, later testimonies than those analysed, still at the end of the second century, clearly link the Church of Smyrna with the Johannine tradition. Both Polycrates and Irenaeus relate Polycarp to the Johannine tradition,

both with the celebration of the Quartodecimanist Easter, and with the figure of John, respectively. Both sources were public documents which were not contested with regards to this connection either by ecclesiastical authors or heretical ones like Florinus. And lastly, it should be pointed out that the relationship between Polycarp and John has been dealt with in depth in the second part of this investigation[1123].

1123 Cf. pp. 157 et seqq.

Chapter XII: The deposit of faith in the Church of Smyrna

The analysis on the reception and interpretation of the Old Testament and of the apostolic traditions that we have just made on the documents surrounding the Church of Smyrna has shown us how a process of gradual assimilation of these sources of authority takes place in the community throughout the second century.

In the framework in which aversion to the Hebrew Scriptures is apparent in the Gnostics and Marcionites, and in which on the contrary the Judaising Christians, of Jewish or pagan origin, underline its importance for an understanding of the new faith, there likewise gradually arises little by little the perception that complete freedom of thought ends up by prejudicing the concord and unity of the community, and accordingly the need is gradually felt to specify the content of the faith and make it binding.

As the fruit of this need and in the context of the late second century, Irenaeus[1124] and other authors like Tertullian[1125] and Clement of Alexandria[1126]

1124 For Irenaeus, the rule of truth is the doctrine preached by the Apostles, transmitted by the succession and taught in churches. It is the criterion which makes it possible to distinguish false interpretations of Scripture from true ones. The rule of truth is a teaching transmitted both by the Scriptures and by Tradition. Irenaeus uses the expression ὁ κανὼν τῆς ἀληθείας or *regula veritatis* about ten times in *haer.,* 1, 1, 20; 1, 15; 2, 40, 1; 3, 2, 1; 3, 11, 1; 3, 12, 7; 3, 15, 1; and 4, 57, 4. Irenaeus uses the term *regula fidei* in exactly the same sense as *regula veritatis,* cf. Iren., *Dem*., 3 (SCh 406, 86).

1125 For Tertullian, the *regula* is a norm, principle or prescription. The philosophical schools and the heresies also have their rules, cf. Tert., *praesc.,* 42, 7 (SCh 46, 149). For Tertullian the word *regula* has two senses. In a first sense, *regula* as fixed tenet, the given content of doctrine. In a second sense, *regula* as doctrine itself, also often identifying it with the faith and the truth, or else combining these two concepts in the genitive with the word *regula,* that is to say, *regula fidei* or *regula veritatis.* However, Tertullian distinguishes between the rule of faith, which implies immutable dogmas such as the Trinity, the Incarnation, the Church, and the rule of truth which encompasses ecclesiastical usages and practices liable to change. Like Irenaeus, Tertullian also affirms that the rule of faith is a teaching transmitted both by the Scriptures and Tradition. However, unlike heresies, which are subsequent, the rule of truth is present from the very beginning of the Gospel. Tertullian uses the expression *regula veritatis* four times, cf. Tert., *apol.,* 47; *adv. Hermog.,* 1; *pud.,* 8, 12; and *adv. Marc.,* 5, 20. He uses the expression *regula fidei* eight times, cf. Tert., *praescr.,* 12, 5; 13, 1; 26, 9; *adv. Marc.,* 4, 2; *Virg. vel.,* 1; *adv. Prax.,* 3; *monog.,* 2; *pud.,* 19, 3; and *ieiun.,* 1.

1126 In Clement of Alexandria the word κανών is frequently used in the sense of criterion or rule of conduct and as a synonym of the technical expression *regula fidei.*

coin the technical expression *regula fidei* or *regula veritatis* which is no abstract concept but consists of effective formulas to meet each circumstance in which the Orthodox Christian faith lays down a binding position on fundamental concepts considered as immutable, in order to distance itself from concrete doctrinal deviations such as Gnosticism, Marcionism, Docetism, Patripasianism, etc.

The *regula fidei* is not merely a formula or a symbol of faith, although very often the symbol of faith is the principal expression of the *regula fidei* since it is part of the live teaching of the Church and expresses the fixed and immutable nuance of the same. The *regula fidei* is the principal and invariable part of the apostolic deposit, the negation or alteration of which constitutes heresy[1127].

To this process of consolidation of a deposit of faith, formed on the basis of the *lex orandi* and the *lex credendi,* the region of Asia and in particular the Church of Smyrna is no exception, so that we prepare to try and glimpse the very reality of the community in its properly confessional aspect, after having first of all considered briefly the construction of the deposit of faith in the New Testament.

1. Confessions of faith in the New Testament

The idea that the members of the community of followers of Jesus must remain faithful to the message transmitted by Him and later his Apostles, maintains its authenticity by not admitting any mixture with strange doctrines, appearing already in the New Testament writings. These writings already contain the reference to the principal articles of faith, or κήρυγμα. These constitute the Gospel and its message, its unique authority as regards the faith, and the conditions of fidelity to its truth, since there already exists in the phase of consolidation, a ready awareness that the Christian faith supposes a normativity, a rule and certain articles of faith that must be proclaimed and defended.

Apart from this, the reference to the Gospel and remaining faithful to the message that the latter transmits is summarised in the word "tradition (παράδοσις)". Already in *1 Thessalonians,* Paul "gave instructions" on behalf of

Once Clement uses the expression ὁ κανὼν τῆς ἀληθείας, cf. Clem., *str.,* 7, 16, 105 (SCh 428, 316). Clement shares in its general lines the conception of Irenaeus on the *regula fidei.* For a thorough study on the *regula fidei* in these as well as other authors such as Novaciano and Origen, cf. D. van den Eynde, *Les Normes de l'Enseignement Chrétien*, Paris 1933, 281–313; cf. P. Grech, *The* Regula fidei *as Hermeneutical Principle Yesterday and Today*, in *Il messaggio biblico e la sua interpretazione*, 145–161.

1127 Cf. D. van den Eynde, *Les Normes de l'Enseignement Chrétien,* 312–313.

the Lord Jesus, and they received his teaching[1128]. By the concept of tradition Paul understands the message of the faith[1129], the rules relative to the internal life of the communities,[1130] and the ideal of Christian behaviour[1131]. The origin of this tradition is the Lord himself[1132]. In *Luke* and in *John.* the idea of tradition is expressed by means of the word "testimony"[1133]. The ultimate origin of this transmission is God himself, who sent his only son and "delivered him unto death for all of us"[1134], and by so doing transmitted it[1135].

This deposit of faith received by means of tradition is expressed very often through primitive symbols of faith which appear throughout the New Testament and which by simplifying things somewhat, according to the contribution of P. Grech and J. Kelly[1136], are present principally as one of three models.

The first model makes use of a formula referring to Christ alone. Jesus is Lord (*Rom* 10, 9; *Ph* 2, 11; *1 Co* 12, 3), Jesus is the Christ (*Ac* 18, 5, 28; *1 Io* 2, 22; *Ac* 8, 36–38), Jesus is the Son of God (*Ac* 8, 36–38). This confession to Jesus may also consist of a more or less developed narrative form. In it, the Jesus happening is told, insisting on the mystery of his death and resurrection, with the proclamations, the κήρυγμα pronounced by Peter in his discourses (*Ac* 2, 14–39; 3, 12–26;

1128 Cf. *1 Th* 4, 1–2.

1129 Cf. *1 Co* 15, 1–5.

1130 Cf. *1 Co* 11, 2; *2 Th* 2, 15; 3, 6.

1131 Cf. *Ph* 4, 9.

1132 Cf. *1 Co* 11, 23.

1133 Cf. *Lk* 24, 48–49; *Ac* 1, 8.22; 2, 32; *Io* 15, 17, 19, 35.

1134 Cf. *Rom* 8, 32.

1135 We find this same idea of tradition in Ignatius, in *Eph.,* 6, 1. "Everyone sent by the Father of a family to his own administration, must be received by us in the same manner as he who sends him", or likewise in *Magn.,* 7, 1: "As therefore the Lord did nothing without the Father, being united to Him, neither by Himself nor by the apostles, so neither do ye anything without the bishop and presbyters." In any case, the term "tradition" continues to be rare in the Apostolic Fathers. Clement urges the Corinthians to conform to the "glorious and venerated rule of our tradition", cf. *1 Clem* 7, 2 (SCh 167, 110): Clement is perfectly aware of the same and of the origin of this movement of sending and transmission: "The Apostles preached the Gospel to us on behalf of the Lord Jesus Christ. Jesus Christ was sent by God. In brief. Christ on behalf of God, and the Apostles on behalf of Christ, so that the one and the other thing took place in an orderly way by the will of God". Cf. *1 Clem* 42, 1–2 (SCh 167–16).

1136 Cf. P. Grech, *Le confessioni di fede in Giovanni,* in *Il messaggio biblico e la sua interpretazione,* 333–342. J. Kelly, *I simboli di fede della chiesa antica. Nascita, evoluzione, uso del Credo,* Bologna 2009, 31–55.

4, 9–12; 5, 29–32; 10, 34–43) or by Paul in his letters, for example: "In the first place I passed on to you what I had been taught myself, namely that Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures; that he was buried; and that he was raised to life on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures; that he appeared first to Peter and secondly to the Twelve" (*1 Co* 15, 3–5; *Ph* 2, 6–11; *Ac* 13, 16–41). These formulas of first proclamation are placed on the lips of those who teach, whereas the concise formulas convey the believer's answer. Above all, these kerygmatic formulations have a doctrinal function, serving as a basis for the catechesis. The concise ones express more formally a confessional function, for which their literary purport is especially appropriate.

At a second stage, there is also the binary formula which comprises mention of the Father and of the Son (or Christ); this supposes the intentional designation of the names of God the Father and of Christ. Each of these is related to its own intervention in the history of salvation. We see this in the following typical formula: "For us there is one God: the Father, from Whom all things come and for Whom we exist; and one Lord, Jesus Christ, through Whom all things come and through Whom we exist", (*1 Co* 8, 6; cf. *1 Tm* 2, 5–6; 6, 13).

Lastly, there is also a ternary formula which enumerates the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. We find this in the greetings of Paul in his letters (*2 Co* 13, 13), or in reference to the different realities of the life of the Church in the unity of a single mystery. For example, as in: "There is a variety of gifts, but always the same Spirit; there are all sorts of service to be done, but always to the same Lord; working in all sorts of different ways in different people, it is the same God who is working in all of them", (*1 Co* 12, 4–6; cf. *Ep* 4, 4). Another origin of this ternary formula appears to be of liturgical or baptismal origin and is that enclosed in the Gospel of Matthew: "Go therefore, make disciples of all the nations: baptise them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. And teach them to observe all the commands I gave you" (*Mt* 28, 19–20). Although this text does not belong to the common apostolic tradition, it will have a decisive influence on the development of baptismal formulas[1137].

Hereafter we will see how these three models of symbols of faith are present in the writings concerning the Church of Smyrna.

1137 In the opinion of O. Cullman, the name of ternary rather than trinitarian formulas should be applied to these last, since the term "Trinity" does not appear in the New Testament, cf. O. Cullmann, *La foi et le culte de l'Église primitive*, Neuchatel, 1963, 91.

2. The lex orandi in the Church of Smyrna of the second century

By making a study of the formulas of faith appearing in our sources presented on the community of Smyrna, we find that Ignatius, Polycarp, and the author of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* make a similar use of the models of confession of faith present in the New Testament.

As regards the simple confessional formula, "Jesus is Lord", we find that this acquires significant relevance when referred to the proclamation "Caesar is Lord" which had a religious value in the pagan world. The testimony given of the faith during the persecution will constitute the privileged context for the meaning of this Christian formula, as is clear in *M. Polyc.,* 8, 2, when those who gathered around the bishop of Smyrna attempted to persuade him to abjure his faith: "They ran out to meet the head of the Police, Herod, and his father Nicetas, who after passing him into their carriage and seating him, tried to persuade him, saying: 'What harm is there in saying: «Caesar is the Lord», in sacrificing and all the rest, and in that way saving yourself?'"[1138].

This simple formula which makes allusion only to Christ, is likewise firmly attested in the letters of Ignatius, although certainly more developed in its elements:

> Be ye deaf therefore, when any man speaketh to you apart from Jesus Christ, He of the line of David, son of Mary, Who was truly born, Who ate and drank, Who was truly persecuted at the time of Pontius Pilate, Who was crucified and truly died in the sight of celestial, terrestrial and infernal beings. He truly rose again from the dead, having been brought back to life by His own Father and, in His likeness, those of us who have believed in Him His Father too will raise again in Jesus Christ, outside of Whom we have no true life[1139].

The Ignatian formula is marked by the stamp of controversy, while repeating the traditional message. The adverb "truly" repeated four times, clearly conveys

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1138 *M. Polyc.,* 8, 2, cf. *Rom* 10, 9; *Ph* 2, 11; *1 Co* 12, 3. The Christian could not admit such a formula in which they saw the negation of the exclusive lordship of Christ, cf. *1 Co* 8, 5–6. Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 17, 3: "Him we worship as Son of God".

1139 Ign., *Trall.,* 9, 1–2: cf. *1 Co* 15, 3–5; *Ph* 2, 6–11; *Ac* 13, 16–41. This text is important in various ways. It reproduces, in a well coined form, the kerygmatic sequence inherited from the New Testament tradition. However, it introduces a number of important novelties. It mentions the virgin birth of Jesus, a fact which was always absent from the kerygmas of the New Testament, but which is included in all the christological credos from then on. Likewise, it picks up the mention which will become classical of "under Pontius Pilate", an indication already present in *Ac* 3, 13 and *1 Tm* 6, 13. Cf. Ign., *Eph.,* 18, 2.

the probable intention to oppose the "docetist" heretics who refuse to believe in Jesus' true humanity. In this way the confession of faith is converted into a "rule of faith" which distinguishes true Christians from those who are not. This insistence of the adverb, required by the circumstances, will not outlive it.

The same characteristics as the foregoing and the same anti-Docetist flavour are evident in this other passage found in the letter of Ignatius to the community of Smyrna:

> I glorify Jesus Christ, God, Who has granted you such wisdom. For I have heard that you have attained perfection in the immovable faith so that you are nailed in the flesh and the spirit to the cross of the Lord Jesus Christ, soundly established in love through the blood of Christ and replete with certainty in our Lord, Who is truly of the line of David, according to flesh, son of God by the will and power of God, truly born of a virgin, baptised by John so that all justice may be achieved through Him, truly crucified in the flesh for us under the authority of Pontius Pilate and the tetrarch Herod to raise a sign for all time through His resurrection for his saints and faithful followers, whether Jews or pagans, in the single body of the Church[1140].

We also find in Polyc., *ep.,* 7, 1 a formula which, although brief, contains the confession of Jesus within the mystery of the Incarnation: "Everyone who does not confess that Jesus Christ came in the flesh, is an anti-Christ"[1141].

As for the binary confessional formula, which confesses to the Father and the Son, we likewise find examples in Ignatius and in Polycarp. Ignatius in *Magn.,* 18, 2 says: "The prophets too were persecuted on being inspired by the grace of Jesus Christ, so that the disobedient should have certainty regarding the existence of a single God, who has revealed himself through his Son Jesus Christ, who is his Word issuing from Silence"[1142].

Polycarp in *ep.,* 12, 2 affirms:

> May the God and Father of Our Lord Jesus Christ and himself Eternal High Priest[1143], Son of God, Jesus Christ, build you up in the faith, in the truth, in all meekness, without anger, in patience, forbearance, constancy and chastity; and give you the inheritance and a part among His saints, and us with you and with all of those who abide beneath

1140 Ign., *Smyrn.,* 1, 1–2: cf. *1 Co* 15, 3–5; *Ph* 2, 6–11; *Ac* 13, 16–41.

1141 Polyc., *ep.,* 7, 1. This formula is concisely expressed and well coined from the first model, but what it proclaims about Jesus is not a title, but the global happening of his Incarnation. This same formula "Jesus Christ who came in the flesh" may be found in the Johannine letters: cf. *1 Io* 4, 2; *2 Io* 7.

1142 This expression denotes certain contacts with gnosis: cf. J. Ayán Calvo, 133.

1143 Cf. *1 Clem* 36, 1; 61, 3 (SCh 167, 158; 200), Ign., *Philad.* 9, 1; *M. Polyc.,* 14.

the sky and have to believe in Jesus Christ, Our Lord, and in His Father who raised him up from the dead.

Also in 2, 1, Polycarp transmits to us a short formula which is binary as well as kerygmatic: "Believing in Him who raised our Lord Jesus Christ from the dead and gave Him glory".

However, for their part, the ternary formulas open up to a more lasting future, of which Ignatius already gives us an example: "Make every effort to remain firm in the teachings of the Lord and of the Apostles, so that everything you do is prosperous in the flesh and in the spirit, in faith and in love, in the Son, in the Father and in the Spirit"[1144].

Apart from this, undoubtedly Polycarp has in mind the traditional teaching, compact in its fundamental structure although plastic in the manner of its verbal formulation. In *ep.,* 2, 1 he says: "Believing in Him who raised Our Lord Jesus Christ from the dead and gave Him glory[1145] and a throne on his right hand[1146]. To Him all heavenly and earthly beings bowed[1147]; every breath serves Him; He will come to judge the living and the dead"[1148].

The structure of this last confession consists of two clauses and the longer element concerning Christology is subordinate to the first one which is shorter. This is probably a fragment which was taught habitually to the converts of the Church of Smyrna and that Polycarp uses in this letter[1149].

Nonetheless, the letter *To the Philippians,* which in a certain way also reflects Polycarp's teaching to his own community of Smyrna, adopts more of an ethical approach, recommending the imitation of Christ, than a doctrinal one, although as we have also seen, he introduces explicit *professiones fidei.*

1144 Ign., *Magn.,* 13, 1. It is interesting that Ignatius returns to this same formula some lines later, but with the invitation to submit to the bishop and likewise to one another "as Jesus Christ did to the Father, according to flesh, and the Apostles to Christ, to the Father and to the Spirit, so that this unity be of the flesh and the spirit", Ign., *Magn.,* 13, 1.

1145 Cf. *1 P* 1, 21.

1146 Cf. *1 Clem* 65, 2 (SCh 167, 204).

1147 Cf. *1 P* 3, 22.

1148 Cf. *1 P* 4, 5.

1149 It is worthwhile laying stress on the fact that here we are faced with various quotations probably taken from *1 Peter* or *1 Clement,* thus indicating the way in which the body of the catechetical tradition was being built up, cf. J. Kelly, *I simboli di fede della chiesa antica,* 109.

For Polycarp, charity and faith in Christ merge. He who believes practises charity, and he who practises charity shows his love "for God, for Christ and for his neighbour"[1150]. Polycarp, in exhorting to live by obeying "the commandments of justice"[1151], reiterates the principles of the faith, recapitulating them in Christ. Faith in Christ is the reason and purpose of virtuous behaviour:

> Thus then, we will persevere without ceasing in our hope and in the sureties of our justice, which are Jesus Christ, Who on the cross raised up our sins in His own body, despite not having committed any sin Himself, nor was any deceit found in His mouth. But He bore everything for our sake, in order that we may live in Him. Accordingly, let us be imitators of His patience and, if we suffer for His name's sake, let us glorify it. Now he gave this example in His own person, and we have believed[1152].

M. Polyc., 14, 1 transmits a prayer placed in the mouth of the bishop of Smyrna immediately before his martyrdom[1153]:

> Lord, Almighty God, Father of your beloved and blessed servant Jesus Christ, through Whom we came to know You, God of the angels, of the powers, of the whole of creation and the whole people of the just, who live in your presence. I bless You because You have judged me worthy of this day and this hour, to be numbered among Your martyrs, in the cup of your Christ, for resurrection of eternal life in the soul and the body, in the incorruptibility of the Holy Spirit. May I today be received with them in Your presence, in generous and grateful sacrifice, just like You, true God Who never fails, You have prepared it in advance, You announced it and You have brought it about. For this and above all things I praise You, I bless You, I glorify You, through Jesus Christ, eternal and heavenly High Priest, Your beloved servant, through Whom all glory be to You with Him and the Holy Spirit, now and for ever more. Amen.

In this prayer we may find a ternary formula headed by God the Father Almighty, Jesus Christ is confessed as eternal and heavenly High Priest, beloved servant of the Father, and the Holy Spirit is qualified as incorruptible and subject to the glory together with the Father and the Son. It is important that he qualifies God the Father as God of all creation, perhaps a clearly anti-Marcionite allusion, in the same way confessing the resurrection of eternal life in soul and body.

This prayer was very likely composed by the writer of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* himself. This prayer may have possibly had a subsequent liturgical use when

1150 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 3, 2.
1151 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 3, 3.
1152 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 8, 1.
1153 For an extensive study on Polycarp's prayer, cf. D. Tripp, *The Prayer of St Polycarp: its setting, its roles and its text,* in *Ephemerides Liturgicae* 104 (1990), 97–132.

commemorating Polycarp[1154]. We cannot exclude the possibility that at least extracts from this letter were read out during the celebration of this memorial, of which undoubtedly this prayer may have occupied a special place[1155].

3. The profession of faith of the presbyters of Smyrna

At the end of the second century, we find in Smyrna the difficult community and doctrinal situation caused by Noetus to which we referred to earlier[1156]. From that confrontation, a profession of faith deserving of special attention has come down to us. Unlike the other confessions of faith that we have found in Ignatius, in Polycarp, and in the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* we find ourselves faced with the only confessional text of an "official" nature contained in our documentation on the Church of Smyrna. This text is "official" in the sense that it is the only truly normative and binding text that we know of.

Although we do not know *ad litteram* Noetus' profession of faith, the profession of faith of the presbyters of Smyrna has come down to us: "We too know truly (ἀληθῶς) a single God, we know Christ, we know the Son who suffered and how he suffered, that he died and how he died, and rose again on the third day; he sits on the right hand of the Father and comes to judge the living and the dead".

By the word "ἀληθῶς", the presbyters of Smyrna distinguish their faith from that of Noetus which they considered erroneous. Thus, the profession of faith of the presbyters is in its turn a *regula fidei,* that is, a series of doctrinal concepts considered immutable aimed at establishing a clear and univocal position in the face of given doctrinal tendencies considered unorthodox[1157].

1154 *M. Polyc.,* 18, 3.

1155 We possess no further information on the liturgical use of the acts of martyrdom in Asia in the early centuries. However we know that in Africa when celebrating the memory of a martyr the acts of the martyr were read out during the ceremony. In fact, personages like Augustine in his sermons on the feast days of martyrs does not recall all the details of the act of martyrdom, but merely alludes to certain episodes, since the acts had already previously been read out in the course of the same ceremony. This African usage differs from the Greek panegyrics of Basil, Gregory of Nyssa, John Chrysostom, etc., which fully record all the details of the martyrdom, precisely because without doubt the reading of the acts was not foreseen. As for Rome, here it was forbidden to read out the acts of the martyr during the liturgy since in many cases these contained various fictitious episodes. Cf. V. Saxer, *Morts, Martyres, Reliques* in *Afrique Chrétienne aux premiers siècles* Rome 1980, 200–208.

1156 Cf. pp. 171 et seqq.

1157 Cf. D. van den Eynde, *Les Normes de l'Enseignement Chrétien,* 312.

In large measure the profession of faith of the presbyters summarises the fundamental concepts that the Church of Smyrna at the end of the second century underlines compared to various doctrinal deviations.

The confession of faith in "a single God", apart from its generically anti-pagan approach, is certainly a declaration by the presbyters of Smyrna, who take pains to proclaim this truth in the face of Gnosticism and Marcionism which shared the fundamental concept of the distinction between the lower god of the Jews, defender of justice and creator of the world, and the supreme and good god, the unknown god that only Christ had revealed to those who believed in Him.

In their turn, the presbyters of Smyrna in their profession of faith distinguish God from Christ ("we know a single God… we know Christ"), specifying of the latter only that which concerns the Incarnation[1158]. In other words, the presbyters of Smyrna reject Noetus' affirmation that God the Father has become incarnate in Christ.

And lastly, the true suffering, death, and resurrection of the Lord once more underlines Christ's true humanity, in contrast to Docetism already present in the Asiatic environment since the end of the first century to the beginning of the second century, earlier combated by Ignatius and Polycarp.

According to J. Kelly, the elements of the profession of faith of the Smyrna presbyters appears to be part of a symbol of faith in use, perhaps for baptisms, by the community at the end of the second century[1159].

Starting off from this study on the confessional formulas used in the community of Smyrna, we can get closer to the reality that they reflect. Those confessions of faith which are addressed to the communities, although they may well issue from liturgical and catechetical circles, likewise have the purpose of maintaining believers firm in a teaching received, which possibly runs the risk of being lost or of retreating into groups either outside or inside this same community: agents external to the community such as pagans and Jews, or tendencies inside the Christian communities already present from the New Testament environment as Judaising Christians and Docetists, situations more or less difficult to pinpoint such as Gnosticism and Marcionism and reactions to the doctrine of the Logos which appears in the eyes of many as damaging to the traditional *theologoumenon* of the singleness of God. Faced with the danger that this teaching may be lost or distorted by such agents, the confessions of faith constitute a

1158 Hippolytus, following the theology of Justin and Irenaeus, in his homily *Against Noetus* will not only allude to the Incarnation of the Logos, but to his pre-existence.

1159 Cf. J. Kelly, *I simboli di fede della Chiesa antica,* 82.

precise *regula fidei* or *regula veritatis* aimed at identifying a Christian faith binding in every particular circumstance.

The confession of faith of the presbyters of Smyrna is a text which, though brief, points as we have seen to clear and binding concepts for the Church of Smyrna, and is a sure and fundamental point of arrival in the doctrinal development of this community.

4. The lex credendi in the Church of Smyrna

In an attempt to even further identify this correlation of strengths within the community of Smyrna, we will examine the conception of orthodoxy and heresy which our authors may handle and the formation of the *lex credendi* of the community.

As for the vision that Ignatius had about the defence of an orthodox faith, we know that its approximation, above all in the letters he addresses to the Church of Smyrna and to Polycarp, is made fundamentally in light of the theme of ecclesial unity. This is what impels him to combat the heresy which is the worst of tricks or evil artifices[1160] whereby Satan attempts to separate believers from the new life which Christ has made possible by his incarnation, passion, and resurrection. If Christ had been anointed, in his turn, to communicate incorruption to his Church, the prince of this world wishes to anoint believers with the pestilent ointment of his doctrine so as in this way to keep them submissive and captive: "Accordingly the Lord took ointment on His head to breathe incorruption into the Church. Do not anoint the fetidness of the prince of this world so that he does not carry you captives far from the life proposed to you as a reward"[1161]. Now the prince of this world makes use of the heresies which with their bad doctrine are what corrupt the faith in God for which Christ was crucified: "Accordingly if those that do these things according to the flesh – he is referring to the adulterers – die, how much more shall this be the case with any one who corrupts by wicked doctrine the faith of God, for which Jesus Christ was crucified!"[1162]

Heresy for Ignatius, as he warns in his letter *To the Smyrnaeans,* is closely connected with spiritual and eternal death, since conversion of the followers of such doctrines is very difficult[1163]. Thus, heretics offer a doctrine which causes

1160 Cf. Ign., *Trall.,* 8, 1; *Philad.,* 6, 2.

1161 Ign., *Eph.,* 17, 1. Cf. A. Orbe, *La Unción del Verbo. Estudios Valentinianos III,* Rome 1961, 5–13.

1162 Cf. Ign., *Eph.,* 16, 2.

1163 Cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 4, 1.

death[1164], they are plants whose fruit is mortal[1165]; they are advocates of death[1166], they die in their disputes;[1167] and will go to the inextinguishable fire[1168]. Ignatius' attitude to heresy is clear and forceful. However, it is not very easy to determine what and how many heretical groups are targeted by Ignatius in all the letters he addresses to the churches of Asia Minor. There is no doubt that, as we have already seen for the confessions of faith, anti-Docetist polemics is present in almost all of them. Besides, in the letters *To the Philadelphians* and *To the Magnesians,* he attacks head on the Judaising tendency to which some members of the communities continue to be linked. This has led scholars to adopt different attitudes. According to J. Donahue and J. Rius-Camps, Ignatius is fighting two clearly differentiated groups, Docetism and Judaism[1169]; C. Trevett even adds another group of itinerant Charismatics who are directly against Ignatius and the idea he has of the episcopacy[1170]. On the contrary, W. Bernard, P. Prigent and H. Bammel think that the Bishop of Antioch is confronting a single group which, based on Jewish categories, in this same way maintained a Docetist Christology[1171]. Finally, E. Norelli identifies only the group of the Docetists as adversaries of Ignatius[1172].

Personally, taking my distance from somewhat rigid schematisms accordingly not easy to conciliate with the development of different communities, each of which had its own particular situation, I am in agreement with the study of

1164 Cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 6, 2.
1165 Cf. Ign., *Trall.,* 11, 1.
1166 Cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 5, 1.
1167 Cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 5, 1.
1168 Cf. Ign., *Eph.,* 16, 2.
1169 Cf. P. J. Donahue, *Jewish Christianity in the Letters of Ignatius of Antioch,* in *Vigiliae Christianae* 32 (1978) 81–93; J. Rius-Camps, *The Four Authentic Letters of Ignatius, the Martyr,* Rome 1979, 40–51; H. Bammel, *Ignatian Problems,* in *Journal of Theological Studies* 33, (1982), 83 et seqq.
1170 Cf. C. Trevett, *A Study of Ignatius, Antioch in Syria and Asia,* Lewiston 1992, 194 et seqq.
1171 Cf. L. Bernard, *Studies in the Apostolic Fathers and their Background,* Oxford 1966, 23–27, P. Prigent, *L'hérésie asiate et l'Église confessante. De l'Apocalypse à Ignace,* in *Vigiliae Christianae* 31 (1977), 1–7.
1172 Cf. E. Norelli, *Ignazio di Antiochia combatte veramente dei cristiani giudaizzanti?,* in *Versus Israel. Nuove prospettive sul giudeocristianesimo,* ed. G. Filoramo – C. Gianotto, Brescia 2001, 229 et seqq.

P. Meinhold[1173] and more recently that of P. Foster[1174], which favour a distinction of the adversaries combated by Ignatius who cannot be reduced to a unity. The situation of Magnesia is not necessarily the same as Philadelphia or Smyrna. Furthermore, bearing in mind the extremist character of Ignatius of Antioch, there is the possibility that he had noticed and exasperated situations which were not so clearly perceived in the daily reality of the Asiatic communities. Each of Ignatius' letters reveals shades characterising the doctrinal tensions which were arising in each one of those communities. So that the situation could be outlined as follows: In Ephesus, although the community appears united and compact around the hierarchy despite the presence of different groups[1175], there were some who criticised the bishop's silence faced with the eloquence of certain possibly itinerant preachers. However these need not necessarily be considered as Gnostics[1176]. In Magnesia charismatic elements existed opposed to the local hierarchy and representing Judaising influences. In Tralles there was a Docetist group and perhaps a certain indifference regarding the role of the bishop in the community[1177]. In Philadelphia the situation was the same as in Magnesia, these may have been groups of Judaising Christians who moreover created a profound division in the community. Finally, in Smyrna, the current against which Ignatius put the community and its bishop Polycarp on guard was above all Docetism, in addition to a part of the community which celebrated the Eucharistic liturgy separately and which did not recognise the bishop's authority or the hierarchical order at three levels. However, we are not in a position to determine whether it was in fact the Docetists who rejected the hierarchical order of the community.

Accordingly, Ignatius seems to only consider Docetism heretical doctrine, or rather, a Docetist Christology which is not necessarily related to Gnosticism nor with Judaism either. The polemics with the Judaisers is probably not

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1173 Cf. P. Meinhold, *Studien zu Ignatius von Antiochien,* Wiesbaden 1979, 19–36.

1174 Cf. P. Foster, *The Epistles of Ignatius of Antioch,* in *The Writings of the Apostolic Fathers,* ed. P. Foster, Oxford 2007, 89 et seqq.

1175 This is fundamentally the conclusion of Trebilco's book, cf. P. Trebilco, *The Early Christians in Ephesus from Paul to Ignatius,* 628–717.

1176 C. Trevett has also recognised the existence of this tendency, cf. C. Trevett, *Prophecy and Anti-Episcopal Activity: A Third Error Combated by Ignatius?,* in *Journal of Ecclesiastical History* 34 (1933) 1–18. He also identifies these elements with the charismatic activities appearing in the *Didaché.*

1177 C. Trevett has characterised the teachings of these heretics as Premontanist, cf. C. Trevett, *Apocalypse, Ignatius, Montanism. Seeking the Seeds,* in *Vigiliae Christianae* 43 (1989) 313–316.

a confrontation with persons outside of the community, but with members or groups integrated into the ecclesial communities and related with the seer of the *Revelation,* members or groups opposed to the teaching and ethics of Paul. Finally, there may have been members of the community – not Docetists or Judaisers – who did not feel comfortable with the development of the communities, since accustomed to a more charismatic and less hierarchical model of Church; they did not accept Ignatius' ecclesial vision, those not in agreement also being people probably originating from Johannine circles[1178]. In this analysis, the theme of the possible collision of apostolic traditions, as between the Johannine tradition widespread among the Judaising Christians and the Pauline tradition which was particularly esteemed by Ignatius and Polycarp fails to hold good. In fact, their common admiration for Paul may have fed the spiritual closeness between Ignatius and Polycarp. However, this does not mean that for both of them, various elements of the Johannine tradition were not considered esteemable.

For his part, Polycarp in his letter *To the Philippians* has a much more serene style than that of Ignatius in combating the possible doctrinal deviations of this community. Nonetheless, in 7, 1, he reproaches those who fail to confess that Christ has come in the flesh and who deny the testimony of the cross (τὸ μαρτύριον τοῦ σταυροῦ). He invites his recipients to abandon the vanity of the multitude and their false doctrines (τὰς ψευδοδιδασκαλίας), to return to the word that was transmitted from the beginning (ἐπὶ τὸν ἐξ ἀρχῆς ἡμῖν παραδοθέντα λόγον ἐπιστρέφωμεν), and to persevere in fasting and in prayer. He who does not confess that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh, who denies the cross and who distorts the word of the Lord in order to satisfy his own passions, denying the resurrection and the judgment respectively, is an anti-Christ (ἀντίχριστός ἐστιν), he is a devil (ἐκ τοῦ διαβόλου ἐστίν), and the firstborn of Satan (πρωτότοκός ἐστι τοῦ σατανᾶ)[1179].

In this passage, it seems clear that Polycarp is alluding to the Docetist currents which, by denying the Incarnation of the Word, frustrate the work of redemption. Accordingly, in the context of Polycarp's letter, and also those of Ignatius, the noun ἀντίχριστος comes to mean the false master and the false brother[1180]. The anti-Christ works in the present, corrupts and deceives, and causes death

1178 Cf. C. Trevett, *A study of Ignatius of Antioch in Syria and Asia,* Lewiston-Queenston 1992, 75–113 and 147–215.

1179 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 7. 1.

1180 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 6, 3.

because he kills the spirit of truth present in the brethren. Accordingly, the only remedy against the "anti-Christs" is to "return to the word which was transmitted to us from the beginning"[1181].

For its part, the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* seems not to make any special mention of guarding against doctrinal deviations and in this sense expresses no provisos against members of the community who may be undermining the faith received. In the personage of Quintus coming from Phrygia, some experts have tended to see an explicitly anti-Montanist element in the narration of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* 4[1182]. In fact, the brief narration of the martyrdom of Germanicus is followed by the failed witness of Quintus, who had forced himself and others to voluntarily fling themselves to the wild beasts and who in the end yields to the proconsul's solicitation by abjuring and sacrificing. Quintus' attitude is not approved by the author of the tale, since offering oneself up spontaneously is not in line with the Gospel teaching.

The episode of Quintus is clearly introduced into the story to deal with a certain type of religious fanaticism. For some, the direct attribution of this narration to a condemnation of Montanism, on account of the mention it makes of the Phrygian origin of the personage and his manifestation of rigorism, appears an excessive attribution given the sum total of the whole letter, since in the case of "Phrygian" being equivalent to "Montanist" in this story, it would be the only explicit allusion to this sect in the whole text. Nonetheless, it is noteworthy that the text mentions the "Phrygian" origin of the personage twice in the same sentence: "But someone called Quintus, a Phrygian (Φρύξ), who had recently arrived from Phrygia (τῆς Φρυγίας), took fright on seeing the wild beasts". This apparent redundancy may effectively point to the identification of the personage with a member of the incipient Montanist movement.

Even so, the fundamental theme of the narration, as mentioned earlier, is the martyrdom κατὰ εὐαγγέλιον and not the confutation of the Montanist doctrine. For the rest, the failed witness of Quintus is in contrast to the courageous witness of Germanicus and precedes the marvellous testimony of Polycarp[1183].

1181 Cf. Polyc., *ep*., 7, 2.

1182 Cf. S. Ronchey, *Indagine sul martirio di san Policarpo,* Rome 1990, *passim,* cf. G. Buschmann, *Martyrium Polycarpi 4 und der Montanismus,* in *Vigiliae Christianae* 40 (1995), 105–145.

1183 H. von Campenhausen has pointed out that chapter tree and chapter five of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* could be combined without difficulty, if chapter four which deals with Quintus did not exist. Nonetheless, in principle we need not necessarily see the allusion to Quintus as the interpolation of a later anti-Montanist,

Besides, M. Simonetti[1184] affirms, though with a certain caution, that the Montanist movement could have different phases of development. Thus, at a first stage, according to a report by Epiphanius, Montanus' preaching could have started in about the year 157, and in these years he appeared to be merely an enthusiast with a very rigid ascesis, but without the connotations of doctrinal deviation which the movement was to acquire thereafter, probably in about 172, the date Eusebius gives for its origin. So that Quintus could possibly be a Montanist contempoary with Polycarp, before the followers of Montanus could be clearly identified as a veritable sect.

On the contrary, in the *M. Pion.,* 11, 2, about a 100 years after the martyrdom of Polycarp, the allusion to the Phrygians as belonging to a clearly identified sect is explicit. Among the Christians locked in the prison together with Pionius we find "a presbyter of the Catholic Church (τῆς καθολικῆς ἐκκλησίας), named Limnus, a woman from the village of Carine and a man from the sect of the Phrygians (ἐκ τῆς αἱρέσεως τῶν Φρυγῶν) called Euthychianus"[1185]. Moreover, the contraposition between the Catholic Church and heresy is clear. The Christians specifically used the Greek term καθολικός to signify a differentiation of the orthodox compared to the heretics. Likewise in *M. Pion.,* 21, 5, there appears together with Pionius a certain "Metrodorus, presbyter of the sect of the Marcionites (τῆς αἱρέσεως τῶν Μαρκιωνιστῶν)". B. Lightfoot[1186] and H. Delehaye[1187] have pointed out that this mention of martyred heretics constitutes a proof of its authenticity, since as a rule the Church refused to recognise heretics as martyrs.

The phenomenon of the New Prophecy, "the Phrygians", or some time later known as "Montanism", began to develop in around the year 160 for reasons unknown to us but which may have depended largely on the millenarianist hopes arising in the region of Phrygia and the neighbouring regions. In fact, it would appear that this tendency awaited the descent on earth of the new Jerusalem, as an indicative sign of the restoration of the millennium in the region of Pepuza. Above all, it was the conviction of these enthusiasts of being directly inspired by the Holy Spirit, rather than the expectation of the Parousia or their rigorous asceticism, that drew the attention of the ecclesiastical hierarchy which saw in this

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cf. H. von Campenhausen, *Bearbeitungen und Interpolationen des Polykarps-martyriums*, Heidelberg, 1957, 18–21.

1184 Cf. M. Simonetti, *Alcune osservazioni sul martirio di S. Policarpo* in *Giornale Italiano di Filologia* 4 (1956): 332–340.

1185 *M. Pion*., 11, 2.

1186 Cf. B. Lightfoot, *The Apostolic Fathers,* 639.

1187 Cf. H. Delehaye, *Les Passions,* 29.

claim a threat to the episcopal hierarchical structure of the local churches not only of Phrygia and Asia, but of other parts of the Empire, such as Rome, Africa and Gaul. So that the hierarchy considered them as false prophets, reproaching them for their ecstasies and their prophetic and charismatic activity. The difficulty in accusing the Montanists of concrete doctrinal deviations caused the hierarchy to agree on a concrete line of behaviour, for which the bishops were convoked in various councils, especially in different parts of Asia[1188], the hierarchical pressure being accompanied by an intense literary activity of polemical tone[1189], so that by about the end of the second century the crisis was already almost over, except for Phrygia and its surroundings where Montanist communities were active until the end of the fourth century.

Within this anti-Montanist literary activity of the third or fourth centuries, we may probably situate the *Life of Polycarp* in the Asiatic area, and specifically in Smyrna. As one of the aspects common to the intellectual biographies of Antiquity, this *vita* also has a polemical intent. In fact, Polycarp is described as preaching against the Montanist doctrine: "Regarding the Holy Spirit and gift of the Paraclete and other charisms, he demonstrated that it is not possible for this to occur outside of the Catholic Church, in the same way that a member cut off from the body has no strength whatsoever"[1190]. This declaration is based on the *regula fidei* granted by Christ himself (ἐδόθη οὖν ἀπὸ τοῦ Χριστοῦ) to Polycarp, which is described as "the Catholic ecclesiatical rule of right teaching (διδασκαλίας ὀρθῆς ἐκκλσιαστικὸς καθολικὸς κανών)"[1191]. Thus, the intention of the author of the *Life of Polycarp* is to emphasise, against the Montanist doctrine, that the Church has exclusive authority over the Spirit.

Likewise, the anti-Montanist strategy adopted by the author of the *Life of Polycarp* in redefining prophecy as visionary and not as enthusiastic is significant, through the frequent mention of visions[1192] and the absolute absence of any prophecy issued by means of possession in a trance or the suspension of intellectual functions, which imply that the supposed prophet emits the message in a state of unconsciousness. Thus, the prophecy is made not when the person finds himself in a disordered state of mind, but when the prophet in

1188 Cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 16, 10.

1189 Thanks to Eusebius we know something of this literary activity and its authors such as Miltiades, Appolinaris of Hierapolis, Apollonius, and the Anonymous Antimontanist, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 4, 27; 5, 16–19.

1190 *V. Polyc.,* 13, 3.

1191 *V. Polyc.,* 12, 2.

1192 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 21, 2.

possession of all his faculties, presumibly as the result of a vision, utters such a prophecy[1193].

And lastly, with regards to the *Life of Polycarp* and the Montanists, the abrupt prologue of the same explicitly condemns the improper Easter practice of the Phrygian heretics who celebrated Easter outside of the time of unleavened bread, and finding it difficult to calculate the 14th of the Hebrew lunar month, apparently fell back on the 14th of the solar month of *Xanthicus* which did not coincide with the antique date for Easter[1194].

Hand in hand with the gradual development of the distinction between an orthodoxy and heretical groups of various denominations (Marcionism, Gnosticism, Montanism, etc.), we find the development in the Christian community of a every greater reflection on the doctrine surrounding the person of Christ. In about the third decade of the second century, Marcion, and above all the Gnostics, had assumed the lofty Christology present both in the Pauline tradition and in the Johannine tradition, re-elaborating on the basis of their conceptions, the concept of Christ the Logos, as a divine entity distinct from almighty God and subordinated to Him. Apart from that, also halfway through the second century, the doctrine of Christ Logos began to be elaborated in the Catholic environment, above all in authors of Asiatic origin, purging it of specifically Gnostic aspects and confessing to Christ as divine Logos, *ab aeterno* immanent in God as His internal word, wisdom and thought generated (emanated, uttered) as a personal entity distinct from Him and subordinated to Him to undertake the creation, government, and salvation of the world and of man. These Catholic authors affirmed that in order to achieve salvation, the Logos came down from heaven and were incarnate in Mary in a real way, contrary to the Gnostic conviction that the body assumed by the Logos was of appearance, or in any case not material (Docetism).

This doctrine of the Logos, developed both by the Catholics and by the Gnostics with their respective doctrinal specificity, caused a reaction towards the end of the second century in the Asiatic environment with Noetus of Smyrna. This

1193 A similar idea appears in Epiph. *haer.,* 48, 2–13, as A. Stewart-Sykes, among others, pointed out. For other possible anti-Montanist allusions in the *Life of Polycarp,* cf. A. Stewart-Sykes, *The Life of Polycarp,* 36–42.

1194 Ps. Chrys., *In s. Pascha, hom.* 7, 9 (SCh 46, 119). This Montanist practice is attested as from the fourth century and resisted right up to the sixth century. Although nothing suggests that such practice had not been developed at the most difficult time in the story of Montanism during the third century, cf. R. Cantalamessa, *La Pasqua della nostra salvezza,* Città Del Castello 2007, 119.

reaction, later defined as Monarchian or Patripasian, sought to safeguard the monotheistic conception of God against the exponents of the doctrine of the Logos. So that the doctrine of Noetus affirmed that "Christ himself is the Father and that the Father himself was generated, suffered and died"[1195] and if then we profess "that Christ is God, certainly the Father is so too, since God is one only. And Christ, he who is God, suffered: accordingly the Father suffered, because he was the Father"[1196].

For his part, Hippolytus, in his homily *Against Noetus* at the very beginning of the third century, considers that Noetus' conviction that he enjoys a particular divine inspiration is produced by an evil spirit. Hippolytus, whose origin is Asiatic,[1197] although we cannot affirm that he is a Smyrnaean, after an introductory exposition of the facts that occurred in Smyrna around Noetus, presents in the first part of his homily, in a hostile tone and with apologetic intent in the anti-Heretical sense, the doctrine of this personage excommunicated by the college of presbyters of Smyrna. Hippolytus makes a sequence of biblical texts adopted by Noetus and goes on to interpret them in the sense contrary to his own attitude which he considers orthodox. The texts quoted are both from the Old and New Testaments. These texts used by Noetus to sustain his doctrinal reasoning assured that God is one only (*Ex* 3, 6; 20, 3; *Is* 44, 6), that God had been seen on earth, where he had talked with men (*Ba* 3, 36–38; *Is* 45, 14–15), that Christ was God (*Rom* 9, 5), so that this single God must be identified with Christ. Finally, Noetus had made use of *Io* 10, 30 and *Io* 14, 9–10 to confirm the identification of Christ with God the Father. In order to combat the Monarchian doctrine of Noetus, Hippolytus reproposes the doctrine of the Logos; however, it was duly adapted to the twofold requirement of combating the ideas of Noetus and at the same time, distancing himself adequately from the Gnostic doctrine, in which respect the *Against Noetus* of Hippolytus boasts an interesting novelty in his way of dealing with this subject[1198].

In the traditional distinction of two moments in the relationship between God and his Logos, the first, immanent–impersonal (thought, wisdom, power

1195 Hipp., *CN* 1, *2*.

1196 Hipp., *CN* 2, 3.

1197 The close stylistic affinity between *CN* 18 and the Quartodecimanist homilies assures us, among other things, of the Asiatic formation and origin of the author, cf. M. Simonetti, *Contro Noeto,* 70.

1198 For a full commentary on the doctrine of Noetus and the reaction to it by Hippolytus, cf. A. Orbe, *Estudios sobre la teología cristiana primitiva,* Madrid, 1994, 71–95, and above all, cf. M. Simonetti, *Ippolito, Contro Noeto,* Bologna 2000.

and will), and the second, a divine entity generated and personally distinct from God, Hippolytus, in an original way and with great finesse systematically disposes the moment of the divine generation of the Logos with his Incarnation, presented as a manifestation to the world of that which was previosly invisible. This Incarnation permits the Son, until then only defined thus by way of prolepsis, now to become the perfect Son (τέλειος). This accentuation of the meaning of the Incarnation in relation to God the Father–Logos Son is accompanied by Hippolytus' insistence on revealing the reality of the flesh assumed by the Logos, capable of undergoing all the limitations of humanity. Accordingly, this assumption of humanity by the Logos and at the same time the uniqueness of the Son and Logos, in contrast to a multitude (πληθύν) of gods, are affirmed by Hippolytus adopting a clearly anti-Gnostic approach. Apart from this, Hippolytus makes a doctrinal elaboration against Noetus more attentive to the doctrine of the Logos which seeks not to allow space for the accusation of Ditheism, still clearly specifying the individual subsistence of God the Father and of his Logos through the application to both of the technical term "person (πρόσωπον)" and at the same time, founding on the concept of power, (δύναμις) its unity, so that we speak of them as one single God.

Finally, the doctrine developed by Hippolytus in his *Against Noetus* was particularly significant by its mentioning of the Holy Spirit, although not always in a harmonious way, thus passing from the binary schema (Father-Son) to the ternary schema and occasionally making use of the term "trinity (τριάς)". This mention of the Holy Spirit together with the Father and the Son used for some time already by the *lex orandi* in the Church of Smyrna and in the whole Christian world, inspired above all by the formula of baptismal faith of *Mt* 28, 19, began only to gradually advance also in the framework of doctrinal reflection (*lex credendi*). It may be that the first hour of the Montanist movement, referred to earlier, stimulated the beginnings of doctrinal reflection on the Holy Spirit in authors like Hippolytus in Asia. However, precisely because more and more charismatic activity was so much appreciated by the followers of Montanus, and these were perceived progressively as a sect, the anti-Montanist reaction paralysed the development of reflection on the Holy Spirit for over a century[1199].

1199 Tertullian in Africa in his book *Adversus Praxean,* likewise developed a doctrine on the Holy Spirit in an important way. Later authors such as Novatian in *De Trinitate* and the author of the *Elenchos,* on the contrary, did not develop this doctrine so much, very likely due to their anti-Montanist reaction, cf. M. Simonetti, *Contro Noeto,* 52 and 60. For the rest, the Monarchian doctrine of Noetus spread in Asia and especially in Rome, with relative success, thanks to Epigonus and Cleomenes

5. Conclusion

With the gradual consolidation of the *lex orandi* of the community, a greater distinction is made between orthodoxy and the heretical groups. In the first half of the second century, the community is threatened by a certain group of Docetist Christians; moreover, a part of the community appears not to recognise the figure of the bishop or the hierarchical order on three levels. The presence of Judaising Christians who may be involved in these situations seems probable. Apart from that, it is difficult to pinpoint the presence or allusion to the Gnostics in the writings of Ignatius or Polycarp. In particular, the noun ἀντίχριστος is used by these authors to define the false master and false brother who goes against the tradition received.

In the second part of the second century and throughout the third there are clear signs of a gradual pinpointing and controversy with Marcionism, and above all, with the New Prophecy movement, in the writings of the community, particularly in the *Martyrdom of Pionius* and in the *Life of Polycarp.* Finally, comes the explicit rejection by the community of Smyrna of the Patripasian doctrine of Noetus which identies the Father with Christ himself, and accordingly as the one who suffered on the cross.

All through this chapter, we have seen how the different models of symbols of faith found in the New Testament are also present in the documentation of the Church of Smyrna and are used in catechetical, baptismal, and liturgical contexts alike, and in contexts of persecution and controversy against pagans, Jews, and heretics. The adverb ἀληθῶς, present in various confessions of faith, points to the anti-Docetist font of these, especially the writings of Ignatius and Polycarp. Of considerable interest, on account of the doctrinal wealth and harmony of the text, is the prayer that the author of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* places on the lips of the bishop of Smyrna before his death.

Particular importance is ascribed to the profession of faith of the presbyters of Smyrna in which the single nature of God is proclaimed in contrast to the Gnostic and Marcionite ideas, while at the same time making a distinction between God and Christ in response to the crisis aroused by Noetus, and to the confession of the true passion, death, and resurrection of the Lord in response

at the time of Zephyrinus and Callixtus. The author of the *Elenchos* in his rivalry with Callixtus, further developed the problems of the relationship between God and Christ in the framework of the single divinity, giving rise to a polemics destined to continue for a long time.

to Docetism. This text, while brief, marks a sure point of arrival in the doctrinal development of the Church of Smyrna, specifying in an official and binding way the fundamental concepts contained in the rule of faith. This confession of faith of normative nature became a symbol of baptismal faith used by the community at the end of the second century and beginning of the third.

Chapter XIII: Sacramental and spiritual life of the Church of Smryna

After studying the gradual configuration of the *lex orandi* and the *lex credendi* of Smyrna in the context of the construction of Orthodoxy in the face of various heterodox movements and tendencies, we propose hereafter to study the sacramental and spiritual life of the community. We are interested in particular in the gradual development of the conception that the community of Smyrna has of itself as a particular Church and in relation to other ecclesial communities, the configuration of its hierarchical and ministerial structure, the development of reflection on penance, and the sacrament of the Eucharist, of Easter, and the cult of its martyrs.

1. The conception of Church and the ministries in the community

Ignatius knew the community of Smyrna better than any of the other communities of Asia Minor to which he wrote, the proof of this being that not only from there did he send various letters to the other communities, but that when writing to the Christians of Smyrna he greets them by name[1200]. Ignatius was generous in his appreciation of the Church of Smyrna. Both letters, one addressed to the community and the other to its bishop Polycarp, are filled with words of praise which refer to the perfection of Christian life lived by the members of that community[1201] and to the dignity of the man in charge of it[1202]. Ignatius praises the fact that the community has not been contaminated by Docetism[1203], that it is filled with all grace (παντὸς χαρίσματος), that it has produced the saint (ἁγιοφόρῳ),[1204] and that it enjoys an unshakeable faith (ἐν ἀκινήτῳ πίστει)[1205]. However, the way in which he warns the community on the Docetist errors that

1200 These include Alce, Tavia and her family, and Attalus and the widow of Epitrophus with her whole family. Burrhus was commissioned by the communities of Smyrna and Ephesus to help Ignatius, by serving as his scribe, cf. Ign., *Smyrn*., 1, 1–2; 12, 1; 13, 1–2; Ign*., Polyc*., 1, 1; 8, 3; Ign., *Philad.,* 11, 1.

1201 Cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 1, 1.

1202 Cf. Ign., *Polyc.,* 1, 1.

1203 Cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 1, 1–2.

1204 Cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 1, 1.

1205 This is in contrast to the faith of the Docetists which will make them incorporeal and phantasmal, cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 2, 2; 5, 3.

imply an aberrant Christology might lead us to think that those who uphold such ideas are preying on the community, or could even be among them: "Accordingly I advise you, beloved, knowing that you too think in this way. But I put you on your guard against wild beasts disguised as men: not only is it necessary for you not to receive them, but, if possible, not meet up with them"[1206].

Ignatius was concerned for Polycarp. In fact, at times Ignatius addresses Polycarp with an air of exasperation as if the latter did not have the right temperament to affirm the dignity of his office. The concern which we glimpse in Ignatius' language is probably influenced by his own experience in Antioch. For Ignatius, it was the bishop's task to promote and maintain unity, warning that divisions are the beginning of evils to come[1207]. It is as if Ignatius saw the danger of a division in the community, since he gives Polycarp abundant advice and warnings: "I beg you to apply yourself to your career… defend your charge with the utmost carnal and spiritual solicitude"[1208], "submit meekly to the most pernicious"[1209], "do not be deceived by those who appear worthy of credit, but teach contrary doctrines. Bear the brunt like a beaten anvil"[1210], "let nothing happen against your will… be firm"[1211]. Thus Ignatius believed it necessary for the whole community to submit to the bishop, the presbyters, and the deacons[1212]. Notwithstanding, it seems clear that a part of the Christians of Smyrna did not do so completely, whence the constant appeal by Ignatius not to hold meetings without the bishop, or do anything without his consent[1213]; in fact, from the warnings of Ignatius, it is clear that part of the community celebrated baptisms and Eucharists without the bishop being present[1214], defended a rigorous asceticism[1215], and omitted the duties of charity for widows, orphans and the oppressed[1216]. Moreover, a representative of this current occupied a high office (τόπος) in the community[1217]. So

1206 Ign., *Smyrn.,* 4, 1.
1207 Cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 7, 2.
1208 Ign., *Polyc.,* 1, 2.
1209 Ign., *Polyc.,* 2, 1.
1210 Ign., *Polyc.,* 3, 1.
1211 Ign., *Polyc.,* 4, 1.
1212 Cf. Ign., *Polyc.,* 6, 1; *Ign., Smyrn.,* 8, 1.
1213 Cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 8, 1.
1214 Cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 8, 2.
1215 Cf. Ign., *Polyc.,* 5, 2.
1216 Cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 6, 2.
1217 W. Bauer presumes that this personage was something like a Gnostic antibishop in Smyrna, not that this was his title but the reality was this, cf. W. Bauer, *Orthodoxy and Heresy in Earliest Christianity,* Philadelphia 1971. 73.

that it is clear that, over and above the thanks for his welcome and the positive aspects he finds, Ignatius was concerned for the community and for its bishop. It is probable that Polycarp, certainly at the time when Ignatius passed through the community, was of a weak temperament or at least did not meet the expectations of the mystic and temperamental Ignatius. It is also probable that not all of the bishops that Ignatius met on his journey to Rome shared his vision of the episcopacy[1218].

The advice and warnings that Ignatius made to Polycarp did not absolutely undermine the admiration that the latter professed for Ignatius. This is shown by his praise of him and the persons accompanying him when he writes his letter *To the Philippians*[1219]. Certainly in this letter we immediately note the way in which Polycarp runs his own community of Smyrna, and the contrast in style between Ignatius and Polycarp. Polycarp's style is more restful, in fact, in contrast to Ignatius who wrote all his letters *a motu proprio,* Polycarp writes this letter only because the community of Philippi requests him to do so[1220]. In Polycarp's style, as we have seen earlier, he draws on oral or written traditions for his advice to the community, doing this in a calm but clear way. Polycarp too asks the community to obey the presbyters and the deacons[1221], but not a single allusion is made to the bishop of the community, nor even any request to obey him[1222]. On

1218 Polycarp in his letter *To the Philippians* with regard to the hierarchy, does not develop a speculative doctrine, limiting himself to inculcate a practical discipline, but more in a moral than a hierarchical sense; on one occasion we find the need felt by him to submit himself to the presbyters and the deacons as to God or to Christ. Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 5, 3.

1219 Ignatius and his companions are referred to as "images of true love", cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 1, 1; 9, 1; 13, 1.

1220 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 3. 1.

1221 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 5, 3.

1222 It is probable that the presbyter Valens who is accused of shady pecuniary dealings had been bishop of that community. This would explain Polycarp's silence on the episcopate. Thus, it appears that the sin of Valens and his wife was exclusively of fiscal nature and not of heresy, for otherwise Polycarp would not have requested that the two once more be considered sick or misguided members, since such an attitude would not tally with the way in which the bishop of Smyrna terms the Docetists "firstborn of Satan", cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 7, 1. J. Rius-Camps considers that Crescentius, who carried Polycarp's letter to Philippi, was the person entrusted with taking over the post abandoned by Valens. J. Rius-Camps, *La carta de Policarpo a los Filipenses,* in *Pléroma Salus carnis. Homenaje a Antonio Orbe, S.J.,* ed. E. Romero Pose, Santiago de Compostela, 1990, 163–164.

the contrary, all of the functions which Ignatius indicates as proper to the bishop are addressed by Polycarp to the presbyters.[1223]

Such unity becomes visible in the hierarchical structure without which there is no Church[1224] nor is it possible to celebrate the Eucharist[1225]. The ecclesial hierarchy as it appears consists of bishops, presbyters, and deacons. The bishops are in Christ's will[1226] and represent God who is the invisible bishop[1227], so that he who deceives the visible bishop[1228] deceives God[1229]. The bishop is obeyed by the presbyter who is presented as the law of Jesus Christ[1230], the assembly of the Apostles,[1231] and senate of God[1232]. The third hierarchical order is represented by the deacons, servants of the Church[1233], to whom the service of Jesus Christ has been entrusted[1234] and who were established by the will of God[1235]. The whole community must obey the bishop, the presbyter and the deacons[1236] to the point that if anyone does anything on the margins of the hierarchy, he or she does not have a clear conscience[1237].

In Ignatius' letter *To the Smyrnaeans* 8, 2 we find the expression "Catholic Church" for the first time in Christian literature; "where the bishop is present, there the community is, just as where Jesus Christ is, there is the Catholic Church". In the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* 16, 2, the community of Smyrna too is identified as the Catholic Church. This expression has given rise to numerous interpretations[1238]: in the geographical sense; in the doctrinal sense of Orthodoxy as opposed to heretical splinter groups, to affirm that the Church conserves intact the doctrine of Christ; in the sense of spiritual communion of the

1223 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 6, 1.
1224 Cf. Ign., *Trall.,* 3, 1.
1225 Cf. Ign., *Philad.,* 4.
1226 Cf. Ign., *Eph.,* 3, 2.
1227 Cf. Ign., *Magn.,* 6, 1; 3, 1–2; *Polyc.,* 1: in this last text Jesus Christ is also presented as bishop.
1228 Cf. Ign., *Eph.,* 1, 3.
1229 Cf. Ign., Magn., 3, 2.
1230 Cf. Ign., *Magn.,* 2.
1231 Cf. Ign., *Magn.,* 6, 1; *Trall.,* 3, 1.
1232 Cf. Ign., *Trall.,* 3, 1.
1233 Cf. Ign., *Trall.,* 2, 3.
1234 Cf. Ign., *Magn.,* 6, 1.
1235 Cf. Ign., *Philad.,* 1.
1236 Cf. Ign., *Eph.,* 2, 2; 4, 1; 5, 3; *Magn.,* 13, 2; *Trall.,* 2, 1–2; 13, 2.
1237 Cf. Ign., *Magn.,* 7, 1; *Trall.,* 7, 2.
1238 Cf. J. Ayan Calvo, 86.

invisible Church which should be imitated by the Church on earth; in the sense of plenitude of the local Church; or as the quality of the Church by means of which reference is made to the absolute perfection and plenitude it possesses. A. de Halleux thinks that all the earlier interpretations designate aspects which, in fact, may be found in the ecclesiology of Ignatius but which none of them claims to express by the expression "Catholic Church"[1239]. Both A. de Halleux and M. Simonetti assure us that the adjective "Catholic" would seem to be a reiterative term to designate the Church in its universality[1240].

Almost a 100 years after the martyrdom of Polycarp, we find an allusion to the Catholic Church in the *Martyrdom of Pionius*. The proconsul Quintilian asked Pionius: "To what cult or sect do you belong?". Pionius' answer is: "To the Catholics". His questioner goes on: "What kind of Catholics?" Answer: "I am a presbyter of the Catholic Church"[1241]. According to A. Hilhorst, the proconsul Quintilian, who probably did not know or was not interested in the internal differences between Christians, on asking what kind of Catholics, will have used the term καθολικός in the sense of "universal"[1242], as Ignatius already would have used it in his letter *To the Smyrnaeans* and as it appears in the *Martyrdom of Polycarp*[1243]. According to M. Mara, this does not mean that Pionius or the writer of the *Passio* were not conscious of the differences between their own faith and that of the Montanists or the Marcionites, but rather that for them, the differences between the distinct groups did not totally destroy the unity of the Church. In contrast to some other anti-Montanist sources[1244], the *Martyrdom of Pionius* does not appear to show any particular antagonism by its protagonist to "Metrodorus, presbyter of the sect of the Marcionites"[1245] or to "Eutychianus, member of the sect of the Phrygians"[1246]. By his attitude, Pionius

1239 Cf. A. de Halleux, "*L'Église catholique*" *dans la Lettre ignacienne aux Smyrniotes,* in *Ephemerides theologicae Lovanienses* 58 (1982) 21–24.

1240 Cf. E. Prinzivalli – M. Simonetti, *Seguendo Gesù,* 613–614.

1241 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 19, 4–5.

1242 Cf. A. Hilhorst, *Martyrium Pionii*, in *Atti e Passioni dei martiri,* ed. A. Bastiaensen, Rome 2007[6], 474.

1243 It seems plausible that Pionius used the term Catholic in the same sense as Ignatius bearing in mind that the letters of Ignatius must have had a great incidence on Smyrna at the time of Pionius.

1244 *Against Cataphrygians* in about 192, cf. Eus., *h. e.* 5, 16, 2.

1245 *M. Pion.,* 21, 5.

1246 *M. Pion.,* 11, 1.

seems to want to assign to his confession of faith alone the specificity of being Christian[1247].

As for the relationship of the Church of Smyrna with other Christian communities in Asia Minor, it is interesting to note that the way in which these related to one another may have possibly been influenced to a large extent by the way in which at civic level the cities of Asia Minor also related up in the course of the second century[1248]. As we have mentioned in the second part, the movement of the Second Sophistic, which had one of its main epicentres in Smyrna with the work of Aelius Aristides, influenced not only the cultural but also the political dynamics of the area. In fact, this movement seems to have reproposed the concept of concord (ὁμόνοια) which characterised the relationship of the ancient city states of Asia Minor in the Hellenic age. So that each city was autonomous and governed itself, and by means of assemblies of citizens (ἐκκλησίαι), approved resolutions, held elections, and sent ambassadors to negotiate treaties and various agreements with other cities considered as their equals. Accordingly, the conceptual key that the Second Sophistic impressed on the emperors close to this movement, such as Hadrian and Marcus Aurelius, among others, was the harmony of mutual acceptation rather than a coercive peace (εἰρήνη – *pax*) such as that imposed by the Roman Empire at its beginnings. Together with the promotion of this political concord between cities with the formation of a league supported by Hadrian, we find the powerful development of a mysteric cult of universal scope aimed at sustaining this social, cultural and political harmony[1249].

For their part, the letters of Ignatius, among other Christian writings, appear to be in part influenced by this harmonious spirit of the Second Sophistic which seeks the secure unity of the social order of the Catholic (in the sense of universal) Church, based on sure theological principles, in a religious and cultual language liable to foster such unity and harmony in certain concrete actions such as the sending of ambassadors to ensure concord (ὁμόνοια) in the communities, as was the petition of Ignatius to the Church of Smyrna. Accordingly, Ignatius loves not only to insist on a stratified ecclesiastical organisation on three levels (bishop, college of presbyters, and deacons), but also one which offers various

1247 Cf. M. Mara, *Dalla* Passio Pionii *un cristianesimo differenziato a Smirna,* in *Atti del X Simposio di Efeso su s. Giovanni Apostolo,* Rome 2005, 180–181.

1248 This idea has been specially studied by A. Brent, *Ignatius of Antioch and the Second Sophistic,* Tübingen 2006, 245–257.

1249 Cf. A. Brent, *Ignatius of Antioch and the Second Sophistic,* 2–3. For a recent study of the relations of Hadrian and his religious policy with regard to Christianity, cf. *Hadrian and the Christians,* ed. M. Rizzi, Berlin 2010.

images in order to underline the harmony which such a structure should foster and its communion with the faithful: the lyre, strings, intonation, concert and symphony.

Ignatius defines himself as "a man who has been entrusted with the task of unity"[1250]. For Ignatius, unity is, above all, a prerogative of God. Very often he repeats that God is unity, and that only in God is this unity to be found in a pure and original state. The unity of Christians is as close an imitation as possible of the divine archetype:

> It is advisable for you to have the same feeling as your bishop, which is precisely what you already do. In fact, your college of presbyters, worthy of the name it bears, worthy of God, is as harmoniously attuned with its bishop as the chords with the lyre… Accordingly, with your concord and your symphonic love, you sing to Jesus Christ. Thus you sing as one in chorus, so that in the symphony of concord, after having picked up the tone of God in unity, you sing in a single voice[1251].

And precisely in the service of unity to the Catholic Church the Christian community of Rome exercises a sort of primacy in love: "In Rome she, worthy of God, venerable, worthy of every happiness… presides in charity, having the law of Christ and bearing the name of the Father"[1252].

For his part, Polycarp respectfully addresses the Church of Philippi, a community beyond the confines of Asia Minor, which appears alien to the maxims of the Second Sophistic and to the images and vocabulary used by Ignatius when speaking of unity. Nonetheless, the news given by Irenaeus, an Asiatic transplanted to Gaul, regarding Polycarp's visit to Rome in the year 154 to the local bishop Anicetus, reports that both bishops preferred to safeguard the communion between the churches rather than dramatise their failure to reach agreement on the question relating to the celebration of Easter. In fact, Polycarp, as representative of the churches of Asia and in a certain way also of the Asiatic residents of Rome who continued with the Quartodecimanist practice in contrast to the Sunday observance of the Church of Rome, was unable to come to an agreement with the local bishop, notwithstanding which both bishops parted on very cordial terms[1253].

1250 Ign., *Philad.,* 8, 1. Ignatius is the first in the Christian context to speak of ἕνωσις and ἑνότης, unity of faith and love among the faithful, unity of flesh and spirit, that is, of humanity and divinity in Christ, unity of Christ with the Father, unity of the faithful with the bishop, and unity of the Church with Jesus Christ, cf. H. Paulsen, *Studien zur Theologie des Ignatius von Antiochien,* Göttingen 1978, 155 et seqq.

1251 Ign., *Eph.,* 6, 1–2.

1252 Ign., *Rom.,* praef.

1253 This news by Irenaeus is transmitted by Eus., *h. e.* 5, 24–16.

The organisation of the Church in the third century remains substantially the same as in the second: each community internally has an episcopal structure and externally a federative one, seeking cohesion through the institution of the council and the progressive leadership of the church located in the capital of each province and accordingly of its bishop. This is the case of Asia at the end of the second century where Ephesus, with its bishop Polycrates, appears to act as spokesman for all the churches of the region to Victor, bishop of Rome. Nonetheless, in contrast with the harmonious ideal between the cities of Asia Minor and indeed between the Christian churches present in them, an interesting witness in the Christian environment reflecting in some way the rivalry between two important Christian communities, Ephesus (associated with John) and Smyrna (associated with Polycarp), similarly to the struggles for status in the civic sphere, which had already existed from ancient times, between them are the so-called *Fragments on Polycarp* ed. F. W. Weidmann[1254]. This parallel vision to the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* contains very particular news in fragment 55v. on the relationship of Polycarp and John. Unlike the *Life of Polycarp,* likewise written in the third century and part of the fourth, which links Polycarp with the figure of Paul, omitting any mention of John, these four fragments make explicit mention of John, although for the purpose of demonstrating that the bishop of Smyrna surpassed his master in merit. The author's intention is to show that the martyrdom of Polycarp took the place of the natural death of advanced old age of the apostle John, his master and mentor. In fact, the text affirms that Polycarp's followers had heard Polycarp say many times that the apostle John had told him (Polycarp) that it was necessary for him to die in the tribunal in order to undergo this substitutive death, since the Lord had granted him (John) to die in his bed.

Clearly this writing was produced within the Church of Smyrna. For why should a writing undertaken elsewhere claim to put Smyrna above Ephesus, making its bishop superior to the Christian bulwark of the neighbouring city both in the way of his dying and by his longevity. In fact, these fragments not only highlight the violent death of Polycarp, but state that he died at the ripe old age of 104. In this way, evidently competing, with the traditional news of John's longevity.

During the third century, there is a consolidation and accentuation of the sacralisation of ministries in the community, especially the figure of the bishop. Thus, the episcopacy gradually becomes the arrival point of a career coveted for

1254 F. Weidmann, *Polycarp and John: the Harris Fragments and Their Challenge to the Literary Tradition,* University of Notre Dame Press 1999.

aspects such as its administrative power and social distinction in the community. A special post in this career is the ministry of the diaconate, which in theory being one degree lower than the presbyterate since it does not imply the faculty of presiding over the Eucharist, in practice acquires great importance on account of its mission of administering the funds and goods of the Church. This ministerial reality of the whole church is specifically worthy of note in the community of Smyrna through the *Life of Polycarp* written towards the end of the third century or beginning of the fourth. This work which seeks to tell, in a legendary way, aspects of bishop Polycarp in the second century giving a description of particular aspects of the institution of the ministries in Smyrna in about the third and fourth centuries. The *Life of Polycarp* describes the supposed ordination of its protagonist as deacon and as bishop, while it gives only the briefest mention of his ordination as presbyter.[1255]

Apart from the description of the diaconal ordination in the *Apostolic Tradition* and in the texts depending on it, we do not know of any similar text in the first five centuries of the history of Christianity other than that offered by the *Life of Polycarp.* Bucolus, Polycarp's supposed predecessor, is qualified as blessed for having been worthy of "covering with his hand that head and blessing with his voice that soul (χειρὶ σκεπάσαι τοιαύτην κεφαλὴν καὶ διὰ φωνῆς εὐλογῆσαι τηλικαύτην ψυχήν)". Although the description of the ritual is brief, it clearly mentions two moments in it, the laying of hands (χειροθεσία) and the recitation of a blessing (εὐλογία).

In the course of the third century, the election of the bishop is divided into two distinct stages. In the first, all the members of the community, by unanimity or majority, designate one of their members. In a second stage, almost immediately afterwards, at least two bishops from neighbouring sees consecrate the bishop designated, transferring to him the charism inherent in his new function. As for episcopal ordination, the *Life of Polycarp* relates that on the Saturday following the death of Bucolus, the bishops and a huge crowd from the surrounding cities gathered. Several individuals had visions which indicated that Polycarp should be chosen as Bucolus' successor in the episcopate. Polycarp, in his capacity of presbyter, read out from the letters of *Timothy* and *Titus*. After this reading, the bishops exhorted and the presbyters preached, while the deacons went to ask the people who they wished to have as their bishop. And all of the people

1255 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 17, 2. For an interesting analysis of these tales compared with other liturgical sources of the early centuries, cf. A. Stewart-Sykes, *The Life of Polycarp,* 50–55.

unanimously answered that they wanted to have Polycarp as "pastor and master". The ecclesiastical board (ἱερατικόν) gave its consent and then Polycarp was elected bishop. After that, as was the custom, the deacons led him away for the laying of hands (χειροθεσία) by the bishops. Once he was seated, those present called upon him, as was the custom, to address a few words to the people, since they declared teaching (διδασκαλία) to be the most important component for the community (κοινωνία).

Following the aspects of this narration, it appears that a large part of this ritual, as suggested by this same text, took the main lines laid down in the *Pastoral epistles* as point of reference. These were above all the laying of hands, the blessing, and the importance of teaching. Whereas, the fact of his sitting down is not included in the *Pastoral epistles* as part of any rite of this type[1256].

Summarising now what we have written in this section, we may say that on the basis of the documents studied, we find that the ecclesiological doctrine of the community of Smyrna is also undergoing a moment of important consolidation throughout the second century. The Church of Smyrna during the episcopacy of Polycarp underwent an important process of consolidation in its ecclesial doctrine and in the role of the ministers of the community, especially its own bishop. Ignatius' visit and the doctrinal heritage of his letters, which seems particularly influenced by the Second Sophistic, marked a fundamental milestone in the conception of Church that gradually developed in the community. We have analysed how the sources subsequent to the letters of Ignatius, are endebted to the latter in important concepts such as the term Catholic Church and the unity of the community itself made visible in the hierarchical structure consisting of the bishop, the presbyters, and the deacons. Apart from that, the dynamics proper to the Church in expansion, meant that very gradually, the role of the ministers in the communities and the liturgical rites instituting them, developed. Of special value for the development of this Ecclesiology, together with the letters of Ignatius, appear to have been the *Pastoral epistles*. Lastly, we have seen how the Church of Smyrna develops an important series of relationships with various Christian

1256 A. Stewart-Sykes has stated that this fact of being seated may be a reminiscence of the election of the members of the Sanhedrin in Jewish practice, cf. A. Stewart-Sykes, *The Life of Polycarp,* 50–55. However, we cannot be sure that in actual fact there is a close link between the community of Smyrna and this Jewish practice, although the presence of the Quartodecimanist practice and the meeting of certain members of the community on Saturday are signs of this possible influence. However, the anti-Jewish tone of the *Life of Polycarp,* as also of The *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* and the *Martyrdom of Pionius* would appear not to back up such a hypothesis.

communities such as Philippi, Antioch, Rome, Philomelium, Gaul and Ephesus, a sign of the interaction and exchange of church experiences and of faith lived within the Christian community, which could not fail to influence positively the formation of its history and its ecclesial identiy.

2. Baptism and penance in the community

The ancient Church invited to unique and decisive conversion and granted those who repented forgiveness of their sins in the single and unrepeatable act of baptism, which also signified the admission of the convert to the Christian community.

In *Smyrn.,* 8, 2, Ignatius mentions baptism as being intimately linked with the figure of the bishop, so that without the latter's presence it is not possible to carry out such an act. We should note that as regards this detail, there is not even the possibility for a delegate of the bishop to be present to validate the ceremony. Further Ignatius in his letter *Polyc.,* 6, 2, clearly inspired by the metaphor of *Ep* 6, 13–17, mentioned baptism as the Christian's shield, just as faith is his helmet, love his lance, and patience his armour.

However, as regards those who are already members of the community of Smyrna but who in particular err due to a doctrine distinct from that received, Ignatius takes quite a strong stand: "I put you on guard against wild beasts in human form (ἀπὸ τῶν θηρίων τῶν ἀνθρωπομόρφων): not only is it necessary for you not to receive them, but further, even not to meet up with them. Only it is essential that you pray for them for their conversion, which is difficult. But Jesus Christ, our true life, has the power to bring this about"[1257].

The not receiving those who disturb the faith received likewise appears as a precept in *2 Io* 10–11; *Ti* 3, 10, *Rom* 16, 7, and in Ignatius' letter itself *To the Smyrnaeans* 7, 2 against those who desist from the Eucharist and prayer, not recognising that the Eucharist is the flesh of Jesus Christ: "It is advisable to have nothing to do any such, either in private or in public". This attitude of Ignatius in respect of the Docetists of Smyrna whom he considers irrecuperable for the community, is possibly a reaction to the failure that he personally experienced in trying to bring such people back to obedience of their bishop and his doctrine. These exhortations of Ignatius to have no dealings with them, on the one hand, tend to accentuate the division and contrasts between the different factions, and also highlight that there was in fact inevitably some communication between

1257 Ign., *Smyrn.,* 4, 1.

these groups in Smyrna since the communities involved were probably not exceedingly large[1258].

A more understanding attitude towards those who err above all morally is shown by Polycarp in his letter, *To the Philippians,* 6, 1–2:

> The presbyters too must be merciful, compassionate with everyone, drawing to the right road any who have gone astray (ἐπιστρέφοντες τὰ ἀποπεπλανημένα), caring for all the weak, not abandoning the widows and orphans and the poor, but rather attending at all times to what is good in God's eyes and the eyes of men, a stranger to all anger, favouritism and unfair judgment, foreign to all avarice, without immediately believing accusations against anyone, or being harsh in judgments, since we are all debtors in sin. So that, if we ask the Lord to forgive us, we too must forgive, since we are before the eyes of the Lord and of God, and we all have to present ourselves before Christ's tribunal and each one give account of himself.

This is perhaps the most eloquent chapter from the pastoral point of view in Polycarp's letter. To the presbyters of the community, he underlines not only the moral requirements which they must have, but also the educational and charitable tasks. The task of correction must be carried out following the example of the good and merciful Father.

In the particular case of Valens, who had fled from Philippi possibly due to pecuniary problems, Polycarp once more shows himself compassionate and well balanced:

> I have been greatly saddened on account of Valens… and his wife, praying the Lord to grant them authentic repentance (*quibus det Dominus paenitentiam veram*). May you too be balanced on this subject and not consider them enemies (*non sicut inimicos tales existimetis*), but call them once more sick and strayed members, so that you save your whole body. Since if you do this, you build yourselves up[1259].

Accordingly, Polycarp awaits the conversion of Valens and his wife and asks the community to behave with moderation, inviting them to use fraternal correction so that the whole community may be healed. However great Valens's fault may be, it is possible to reinstate him in the Church, since he is a sick brother in need of treatment.

If we compare the thought of Ignatius and of Polycarp concerning the readmission of believers "seduced by the prince of all evils"[1260], we see that the latter

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1258 Cf. E. Prinzivalli – M. Simonetti, *Seguendo Gesù,* 610–613.

1259 Polyc., *ep.,* 11, 1–4.

1260 Polyc., *ep.,* 4, 1. In the New Testament, we already find two main tendencies regarding post-baptismal penance. One rigoristic tendency which appears in *Heb* 6, 4–8

would seem to adopt what is certainly a more benevolent and moderate attitude. Nonetheless, the biggest distinction in the treatment of these Christians is referred to the type of fault they have incurred. On the whole, moral faults, even serious ones, would seem to be much more tolerated than the persistence of some in their doctrinal deviations.

Around 100 years later, with the arrival of the emperor Decius to power in the year 249, the whole Church fell victim of one of the most powerful anti-Christian policies ever experienced until then. Decius issued an anti-Christian edict in which he ordered that on an established day, the citizens of the Empire should present themselves before a commission of five members, offering a sacrifice as proof of their veneration of the traditional gods, receiving in exchange a certificate (*libellus*) of having carried out the said act. The adopted process was put into effect forthwith and to each Christian, once convoked, if he could not or would not avoid the test by escaping, the only other possibility remaining to him was to sacrifice or refuse to do so, in which case he was arrested, and following a fresh refusal, might even incur the death penalty. Apart from no few Christians who remained firm in their faith, many others bought the *libellus* and a large part sacrificed, offering victims or eating meat destined for idols. However, those *lapsi*, as those Christians were then known, who by buying the *libellus* had saved their lives (*libellatici*) or who had sacrificed and incensed out of fear of losing their lives (*sacrificati* and *thurificati*), even in the midst of the persecution, addressed themselves to the bishop or the presbyter or someone having a certain degree of hierarchical or moral authority, pleading to be readmitted into the community from which their abjuration had *ipso facto* expelled them. This difficult situation gradually created a new procedure on penitential discipline, which went beyond the exceptional post-baptismal forgiveness of grave sin already present in the *Shepherd* of Hermas. So that this procedure of forgiveness of post-baptismal sins, and especially of the very grave sin of abjuration committed by the *lapsi,* had not yet been dealt with at the theoretical level and there was a great divergence of criteria in the different regions and even among the bishops of the same region, depending on the more or less rigoristic convictions of some or others of them. Although the crisis unleashed by Decius had many consequences in the history of early Christianity and in the development of penitentiary discipline with the

and which thereafter will be followed by Tertullian among others, which does not foresee the repeatability of the forgiveness of sins, and on the contrary, another more merciful tendency which already appears in *1 Io* 1, 9, 5, 16, more accepted by the Church, cf. R. Roitto, *Practices of Confession, Intercession and Forgiveness in 1 Io* 1, 9; 5, 16 in *New Testament Studies* 58 (2012, 235–253).

shock of two conceptions of the Church of Christ as regards the moral quality of its members and its opening up to sinners, here we are interested more particularly in underlining the reflection made in Smyrna by Pionius and by the writer of the *Martyrdom of Pionius*[1261].

The theme of the *lapsi* appears to have been the most important pastoral theme dealt with in the *Martyrdom of Pionius.* The contrast between the *lapsi* and those who remain in the faith seems to be present from the first sentence of the work: "The Apostle urges us to put in common the memories of the saints, knowing full well that the memory of those who lived uprightly and with their whole hearts in the faith strengthens to its imitation those desiring to achieve virtue"[1262]. This sentence makes a contrast not between orthodox and heretics, but between *stantes* and *lapsi.* The *Martyrdom of Pionius* appears to have been written above all to give strength in the faith and to be a part of the discussion on the treatment of the *lapsi* during and following the persecution of Decius. The voice of the martyr Pionius must have been particularly accepted in this community which saw its own bishop Euctemon sacrificing to idols.

Although the text of the *Martyrdom of Pionius* is concentrated on describing the destiny of the most important personages of the community such as bishop Euctemon and presbyter Pionius, it also makes some allusions to the rest of the Christians of Smyrna. In fact, the reaction of the *lapsi* of Smyrna does not seem to have been uniform: while some tried to conceal their shortcoming[1263], others attended the execution of Pionius without fear[1264] while others on the contrary went to visit him in prison[1265]. The latter are qualified by the writer of the *Passio* as devout (εὐλαβεῖς) and of honest conduct (ἐν καλῇ πολιτείᾳ γενόμενοι). Pionius addresses them affectionately as my children (τεκνία μου) and my dearly beloved (τϱυφεϱοί μου)[1266]. Pionius shows especial condescension for those *lapsi* who abjured by dint of force (κατ᾽ ἀνάγκην… σεσυϱμένοι)[1267], unlike other Christians who without being forced in any way but of their own accord decided to

1261 An article which studies, in a particular and full manner, the situation of the *lapsi* in Smyrna is that by W. Ameling, *The Christian* lapsi *in Smyrna, 250 A.D.* (Martyrium Pionii 12–14), in *Vigiliae Christianae* 62 (2008), 133–160.

1262 *M. Pion.,* 1, 1.

1263 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 18, 14.

1264 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 22, 4.

1265 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 12, 2.

1266 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 12, 4.

1267 Cf. *M. Pion.*, 12, 2.

make the sacrifice[1268]. The *Martyrdom of Pionius* seems to have as its fundamental criterion for treatment of the *lapsi,* not the classification of these as between *libellatici, sacrificati* and *thurificati*, but the fact that certain *lapsi* have been constrained to abjuration while, on the contrary, others have sacrificed voluntarily.

So that the attitude of Pionius is not completely clear as regards the type of penance required in order for the *lapsi* in general to be permitted to return to the Church. In fact, this may indicate that the *Martyrdom of Pionius* was written shortly after the martyr's death when reflection on the penance destined for the *lapsi* is still present in the community and the writer of the *Martyrdom of Pionius* seeks to base himself on Pionius' authority to transmit and point out a certain position in the Church of Smyrna, above all illuminating the said reflection in the face of the opportunistic proselytism of the Jews[1269]. In fact, Pionius faced with the implications and consequences of the abjuration of the *lapsi* before the pagan idols by force (ἀκούσιον), affirms that the *lapsi* may be recovered for the Church[1270], and their guilt can be remedied. Whereas Pionius reaffirms the moral and religious gravity of voluntary abjuration (ἑκούσιον) by those Christians who, in the midst of the persecution, pass over to the synagogue, since this is a more serious fault (μεῖζον ἁμάρτημα) and irremediable (ἀναφαίρετον), being equivalent to blasphemy (βλασφημία) against the Holy Spirit[1271].

Another important aspect for reflection is why certain *lapsi* go to visit Pionius in prison. In Christian terms, Pionius was already a *confessor*, or perhaps a *martyr designatus,* not very far from the martyr's crown, since he himself had seen his imminent death in a vision and already before then had also repeatedly refused to sacrifice. Pionius had even explicitly requested the pagan authorities to do their duty and execute him. The *confessores* in this context of the mid-third century were accorded great importance since they tended to fill in the gap left by a hierarchy which very often fled, sacrificed, or was martyred in the face of persecutions. These brave Christians who had refused to abjure and had been taken prisoner while awaiting even harsher ordeals were held in high consideration by the community, and in a particular way, many *lapsi* resorted to them in order to obtain

1268 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 4, 3.

1269 This Jewish proselytism in the environment of persecution generated by Decius appears as a particular reality of Asia Minor in contrast with the reflection on the *lapsi* made by other Christian communities as in Africa where this theme is practically absent, cf. W. Ameling, *The Christian* lapsi *in Smyrna, 250 A.D.* (Martyrium Pionii 12–14), in *Vigiliae Christianae* 62 (2008), 160.

1270 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 14, 6.

1271 Cf. *M. Pion*., 13, 1.

from them remission of their sins and readmission into the community or at least a letter of recommendation which at times almost obliged the local clergy to readmit the Christian *lapsus* once more into the community. A similar situation may have arisen with Pionius since, as we have said, the bishop of Smyrna had abjured so that he remained as a visible authority, not only on account of his hierarchical level as presbyter but above all due to his condition of *confessor.*

As we remarked earlier, we do not know for sure if the *lapsi* who had recourse to Pionius in prison saw their hopes in him for redemption and readmission into the frustrated community. We do not know if Pionius believed himself to possess the authority for this purpose, especially considering that he counts himself among the Christian sinners of the community[1272]. As far as we know he did not claim to have authority to forgive the sins of the *lapsi,* nor did he act as a charismatic leader capable of forgiving abjuration, rather entrusting them to the mercy of God, and meanwhile treating them with kindness. For his part, the writer of the *Martyrdom of Pionius,* although he exalts the figure of Pionius, does not emphasise himself as being a charismatic leader, but above all a teacher. Before the proconsul, Quintilian Pionius presents himself as a "master of piety (διδάσκαλος τῆς θεοσεβείας)"[1273]. Once more in the text, we can perceive the attitude of Pionius and of the writer of the *Martyrdom of Pionius* regarding the state of tension and conflictivity unleashed by the whole problem surrounding the readmission of the *lapsi* to the bosom of the ecclesial community.

In this context, a special mention is due of Sabina, who is likewise presented as a confessor of the faith (ὁμολογήτρια), although the text of the *Martyrdom of Pionius* does not relate her with any situation around the debate on penance in the community. A. Hilhorst is of the opinion that this term of ὁμολογήτρια may have been conferred on her after her death, since this is the case for other personages appearing in the narration. However, it is also plausible that this name had been attributed to her earlier since the writer of the *Martyrdom of Pionius* gives a reason for this attribution, affirming that at the time of the emperor Gordian, Sabina was punished by her mistress Polita because of her Christian faith. In fact Polita had her chained up and sent her to the mountains, where she however received the support of her fellow Christians. Pionius subsequently had her released and accordingly she was living in his household when they were both taken prisoner. Before Sabina's interrogation, Pionius had advised

1272 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 12, 13–16.
1273 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 19, 6.

her to say that her name was Theodota, so that she would not fall once more into the hands of her previous mistress, but on the contrary could die a martyr's death[1274].

In summary, in the first half of the second century, Ignatius and Polycarp show themselves to be more understanding of the moral faults of the Christians of Smyrna than of the doctrinal deviations of certain of them. As for style, Polycarp certainly shows himself more balanced and understanding in his attitude to the faults committed by the members of the Christian community and urges the presbyters to assume the same attitude. For its part, the community of Smyrna towards the middle of the third century, as a result of the persecution of Decius, develops a whole reflection around the problem of the *lapsi,* especially animated not only by a conception of Church where there is room for sinners, but above all on account of the particular situation of the opportunistic proselytism of the Jews in this context in Asia Minor. The community in the gradual development of reflection on penance, came to make important distinctions between those Christians who had abjured by force, need, or of their own will. Finally, the figure of the *confessor,* represented specially by the captive Pionius, is presented in the *Martyrdom of Pionius* not as the charismatic leader capable of absolving or admitting the *lapsi* into the community disregarding the reflection and institutionality that the Church of Smyrna was developing around the theme of penance, but above all, in terms of rhetoric capable of sustaining dialogues against the pagan authorities and the Jews with great sublimity, and within the community as the benevolent master capable of offering a word of encouragement to the repentant *lapsi* and a clear teaching to protect themselves against the accusations of the enemies of the community. The *Martyrium* presents Pionius as a figure of the master rather than the martyr, not only on account of the numerous dialogues and discourses included in the text, but also the way in which Pionius sees himself in relation to Christ: "As far as I am concerned, in order to obey my master, I prefer to die rather than transgress his words and I fight in order not to abandon what I have learned earlier and in turn have taught"[1275].

1274 Cf. *M. Pion.,* 2, 1; 9, 3–4; cf. A. Hilhorst, *Martyrium Pionii,* 454 and 462.

1275 *M. Pion.,* 4, 7; cf. *M. Pion.,* 1, 1–2. On the accent of the *Martyrdom of Pionius* on rhetoric and teaching, cf. A. Monaci, *L'agiografia cristiana antica: testi, contesti, pubblico,* Brescia 2010, 62–64.

3. Easter, Eucharist and cult of the martyrs in the community

In his letters, Ignatius left teachings on the Eucharist[1276], which shortly after he had passed through the community, certainly came to form part of the doctrinal and spiritual heritage of the Church of Smyrna. For Ignatius, the Eucharist is the sacrament of God's love where Christ is really present, it is the privileged place in which unity (ἕνωσις and ἑνότης)[1277] is concretely achieved and expressed with Christ and with the Church[1278]: "Make an effort to attend one single Eucharist, since the flesh of our Lord Jesus Christ is one, just as one is the cup joining us to his blood, the altar is one, and one the bishop together with the presbyter and the deacons, my companions in service"[1279].

In this way, united in charity, guided by the bishop or his delegate[1280], gathered around a single altar[1281], where the bread that is the flesh of the Saviour and the medicine of immortality is broken[1282], the Christians learn to gift their own lives in martyrdom: "I am corn of God and am ground up by the teeth of wild beasts to show myself as a pure bread"[1283].

Addressing himself precisely to the community of Smyrna, he affirms that the Docetists keep away from the Eucharist since they do not recognise the flesh of the Saviour in it. This clear realistic conception of Ignatius means that the flesh with which the Eucharist is identified is the very flesh which has suffered and has

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1276 For an extended comment on the Eucharistic doctrine in Ignatius of Antioch, cf. M. Maritano, *L'Eucaristia nei Padri apostolici,* in *The Eucharist in the Fathers of the Church,* Rome 1998, 33–49, cf. L. Wehr, *Arznei der Unsterblichkeit: die Eucharistie bei Ignatius von Antiochien und im Johannesevangelium,* Münster 1987.

1277 Cf. p. 286, note 51.

1278 Cf. Ign., *Magn.,* 1, 2; 13, 1*; Philad.,* 8, 1.

1279 Ign., *Philad.,* 4, 1.

1280 Cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 8, 1.

1281 Cf. Ign., *Magn.,* 7, 1. At the time of Ignatius, the Christians celebrated for us the Eucharist on an altar, accordingly the expression has a symbolic value, so that to be gathered around the altar or on the altar means being in communion with Christ and with the brethren.

1282 Cf. Ign., *Eph.,* 20, 2.

1283 Cf. Ign., *Rom.,* 4, 1. E. Prinzivalli points out that the image is cited in admiration by Iren., *haer.,* 5, 28, 4 and perhaps re-adapted in *M. Polyc.,* 15, 2 where the bishop of Smyrna, surrounded by the flames, is like bread baking, cf. E. Prinzivalli – M. Simonetti, *Seguendo Gesù,* 589. Contrary to W. Schoedel, A. Brent maintains that Ignatius is in fact inspired by a Eucharistic language, cf. W. Schoedel, *Ignatius of Antioch,* 176; cf. A. Brent, *Ignatius of Antioch and the Second Sophistic,* 123.

been brought back to life[1284]. By contrast, as the Docetists do not believe in the historic "flesh" of the Saviour, logically they do not believe in the "flesh" of the Eucharist.

By not accepting this truth of the Eucharist, the Docetists do not then live the sacrament of charity, as the Eucharist is in its social dimension. Immediately before accusing the Docetists of not recognising the flesh of the Saviour, Ignatius affirms that those who profess a heterodox doctrine "are not interested in charity, or the widow, or the orphan, or the prisoner, or the free, or the hungry or the thirsty"[1285].

For his part, the author of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* in his writing has intentionally established a parallel between the Eucharistic liturgy celebrating the Easter of Christ and the martyrdom of the bishop of Smyrna who, over the fire, as if on an altar, offers himself to Almighty God.

As we stated earlier, chapters seven and eight of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* besides being influenced by Johannine theology, are probably framed in the context of the celebration of the Quartodecimanist Easter, being perhaps the oldest testimony of this liturgical practice in Smyrna[1286].

In fact, Polycarp's arrest takes place over the whole night from "the Friday towards supper time" until "the Grand Shabbat". During this time the bishop, who was present in a room on the upper floor, kept fast and collected himself in prayer turned towards the East standing up for two hours and preparing himself to live out his passion. The expression "supper time (περὶ δείπνου ὥραν)" which appears after τῇ παρασκευῇ, probably evokes the Easter environment of the whole scene in some way reminiscent of the Last Supper and the characteristics of the narration appear to fit in with those of the Quartodecimanist Easter[1287].

It should be noted that the Eucharistic synaxis is apparently absent from the *Martyrdom of Polycarp.* However, considering the liturgical intentionality of the source, it is possible that the writer had seen the celebration of the synaxis in the very sacrifice of the body and blood of Polycarp in the stadium of Smyrna. In the narration of the execution, the bishop is compared with an "illustrious lamb (κριὸς ἐπίσημος)" chosen from a "great flock to be sacrificed (εἰς προσφοράν) as a pleasing holocaust (ὁλοκαύτωμα δεκτόν) to God"[1288]. Once bound over the fire,

1284 Ign., *Smyrn.,* 7, 1.

1285 Ign., *Smyrn.,* 6, 2; cf. *Eph.,* 5, 2.

1286 Cf. pp. 243 et seqq.

1287 Cf. R. Cacitti, *Grande Sabato,* 52–64.

1288 *M. Polyc.,* 14, 1. The martyrial narration may show a dependency on the biblical text of *Da* 3, 39 et seqq. As regards the influence of the book of *Daniel* in early martyrial

the author of the story places a prayer on Polycarp's lips, certainly not improvised but on the contrary well organised, in which he expresses in cultual language elements proper to, though not incipient, of what later will become the Eucharistic anaphoras.[1289] This prayer consisting of an invocation, a blessing, a petition, and a Doxology is the solemn offering up of the bishop judged worthy on that day at that hour to take his place in the number of the martyrs in Christ's cup (ἐν τῷ ποτηρίῳ τοῦ Χριστοῦ)[1290]. Later the martyr is compared to "bread (ἄρτος) being baked" and the aroma of which recalls that of incense or some other precious aroma[1291], while the flames were extinguished by the quantity of blood (πλῆθος αἵματος) which flowed out of his body on receiving the finishing blow from the executioner[1292]. Some scholars consider that the dove (περιστερά) which appears in the scene is also a part of the original text[1293]. In particular, based on *Mt* 3, 11, *Io* 19, 34 and texts of the Quartodecimanist tradition, the tendency has been to consider that the dove, besides alluding to the Holy Spirit, may refer to the water which, together with blood, flows from Polycarp's body, as from Jesus Christ on the cross[1294]. In any case, with or without this last element of the dove, it seems clear that the intention of the writer of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* is to show how the bishop of Smyrna by his martyrdom celebrates and updates the Easter of Our

literature, cf. M. Simonetti, *Qualche osservazione sui luoghi comuni negli atti dei Martiri*, in *Giornale Italiano di Filologia* 19 (1957), 147–155.

1289 We find the version of the oldest Eucharistic anaphora in the *Didascalia of the Apostles,* also known as the *Apostolic Tradition*.

1290 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 14, 1–2.

1291 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 15, 2. For a study on perfume in martyrial literature, cf. A. Lallemand, *Le parfum des martyrs dans les Actes des Martyrs de Lyon et le Martyre de Polycarpe,* in *Studia Patristica* 16/2, Berlin 1985, 186–192. A. Lallemand studies how perfume is the image of the union of the soul with Christ who *participates* in the celestial glory having completed the perfect sacrifice.

1292 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 16, 1.

1293 Based on the version of Eusebius, certain editors do not consider the element of the dove (περιστερά) as part of the original text, cf. H. Grégoire, *La veritable date du martyre de s. Polycarpe, 23 février 177, et le "Corpus Polycarpianum"*, in *Analecta Bollandiana* 69 (1951) 14, V. Saxer, *L'authenticité du "Martyre de Polycarpe": Bilan de 25 ans de critique,* in *Mélanges d'archéologie et d'histoire* 94 (1982) 999. However, other scholars do consider it part of the same, cf. B. Dehandschutter, *Martyrium Polycarpi, Een literair-kritische Studie,* Leuven, 1979; B. Lightfoot, *The Apostolic Fathers,* 390–391.

1294 Cf. R. Cacitti, *Grande Sabato,* 70–72. A. Monaci also is in favour of this interpretation. Cf. A. Monaci, *L'agiografia cristiana antica: testi, contesti, pubblico*, Brescia 2010, 53–54.

Lord so that rather than eat it, he wishes to suffer it. So that, in this text from Smyrna we find the peculiar character of the Quartodecimanist Easter which above all seeks to celebrate liturgically the Passion of Our Lord[1295].

The text continues offering us not only the oldest testimony of the cult of the martyrs[1296], but also the concept of "communion with the martyr" underlying this same cult and which in some way justifies it. When Polycarp was still alive, "each of the believers sought to be the first to touch his skin"[1297], while now these same faithful desire "to enter into communion with his holy flesh (κοινωνῆσαι τῷ ἁγίῳ αὐτοῦ σαρκίῳ)[1298]. The expression of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* 6, 2 in which the bishop, in the destiny awaiting him "will enter into communion with Christ (Χριστοῦ κοινωνὸς γενόμενος)" and the expression of the martyr himself in his prayer about having a part in Christ's cup, seem to clarify the idea that the martyr, on physically sharing in the death of Christ, enters into communion with his paschal mystery, and likewise, through the martyr, the faithful will take part in this communion. However, the writer immediately makes a catechetical precision, underlining that veneration of the martyr Polycarp could never make the faithful abandon their worship of Christ who suffered for the salvation of all those who are saved in the world[1299]. In fact, in this news from the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* we find only the very faintest beginnings of the cult of the saints: the Smyrnaeans do not seek to be protected by Polycarp, calling for his intercession, and the veneration of the martyr is merely an act of affection and of homage.

And lastly, the writer completes his narration, informing of the cremation of the martyr's body and of his funeral rites. Despite the antagonism of the Jews, the body could not be completely dispersed, its bones "nobler than costly precious stones and more tried than gold" were deposited in a suitable place. The place of

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1295 On this relaitonship of the Quartodecimanist Easter with Our Lord's Passion, cf. Ch. Mohrmann, *Pascha, Passio, Transitus,* in *Ephemerides Liturgicae* 66 (1952), 37–52. The study by Ch. Mohrmann systematically considers how that which, in the historic parabola of Jesus, represents the wounding, the fall, the death and the descent, antithetically reverts in the *historia salutis* as healing, resurrection, immortality and ascent.

1296 Cf. C. Burini, *Policarpo di Smirne, Lettera ai Filippesi. Martirio,* Bologna 1998, 161, cf. A. Orban, *Martirio di Policarpo,* in *Atti e Passioni dei martiri,* ed. A. Bastiaensen – A. Hilhorst, Rome 2007[6], 381.

1297 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 13, 2.

1298 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 17, 1.

1299 Cf. *M. Polyc.,* 17, 2.

the *depositio* is not mentioned, so that we may suppose that in the mid-second century, the Christians still had no areas set aside in which to bury their dead. Thus, it is probable that it was interred close to the site of his martyrdom[1300]. For their part, the faithful will gather with "rejoicing and joy" to commemorate that day of the martyrdom for the purpose of making a remembrance (μνήμη) of those who have already ended their battle and for the exercise (ἄσκησις) and preparation (ἑτοιμασία) of those destined to fight in the future. Accordingly, the celebration of the martyr's memory is not only an evocation of the historical fact, but also a moment of teaching and exhortation to the imitation of Christ for the faithful of the community.

For its part, the *Martyrdom of Pionius,* as we have seen with the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* also appears to be imbued with the Quartodecimanist character of the Easter celebration[1301]. In fact, the arrest of the presbyter Pionius, together with Sabina and Asclepiades, happens in the context of a meeting in which these personages are gathered in a house observing a fast for a double feast: a Grand Shabbat which coincides with the anniversary of the martyrdom of Polycarp[1302]. Furthermore, they interrupt the fast in the middle of the night with a singular celebration in which water replaces the wine.

This part of the text of the *Martyrdom of Pionius* appears to be inspired by the events of one century earlier in Smyrna. The commemoration of the feast (γενέθλιος ἡμέρα) of Polycarp assumes, in the liturgy preceded by Pionius, also the theological and martyrial character of the *Martyrdom of Polycarp.* Both the observance of the fasting (νηστεία) of Pionius and the Friday (Παρασκευή) of Polycarp point to the immimence of the festivities of the Shabbat. For its part, the rite in which Pionius and his companions take the holy bread (ἄρτον ἅγιον) together with the water (ὕδωρ) has given rise to different interpretations: A. Hilhorst

1300 Only at the beginning of the third century does Tertullian speak of *areae sepulturarum nostrarum*, cf. Tert., *scap.,* 3, 1 (PL 1, 770), while in the case of Peter and Paul, tradition affirms that they were buried in a place close to where they were martyred.

1301 This is the opinion reached by the studies of B. Lohse, *Das Passafest der Quartadecimaner,* Gütersloh 1953, 43–50, 62–75, 84–89; W. Hüber, *Passa und Ostern. Untersuchungen zur Osterfeier der alten Kirche,* Berlin 1969, 10–11; A. Strobel, *Ursprung und Geschichte des frühchristlichen Osterkalenders,* Berlin 1977, 10; G. Visonà, *Pasqua quartodecimana e cronologia evangelica della Passione,* in *Ephemerides Liturgicae* 102 (1988), 259–315; R. Cacitti, *Grande Sabato,* 41.

1302 This coincidence may possibly have been one established by the author of the *Martyrdom of Pionius.*

and L. Robert think that the bread would be the Eucharist which is brought home to be consumed, while the water is for drinking but should not be understood as replacing the wine[1303]. A. Harnack thinks that the water is used with the same original purpose as the wine[1304]. B. Lohse and R. Cacitti do not exclude the possibility that Pionius may have belonged to Encratistic circles in which abstinence from wine was widespread[1305]. A. Stewart-Sykes opines that this is not a Eucharist proper but rather an agape in memory of the martyr Polycarp in the style of those funerary banquets celebrated beside the tombs of martyrs[1306]. In any case, what is important for us is that a liturgy in memory of Polycarp closes a period of fasting, thus introducing the celebration of the Grand Shabbat[1307].

1303 Cf. A. Hilhorst, *Martyrium Pionii*, in *Atti e Passioni dei martiri,* ed. A. Bastiaensen, Rome 2007[6], 455; cf. L. Robert, *Le Martyre de Pionios prêtre de Smyrne. Edité, traduit et commenté,* Washington 1994, 52. Melito of Sardis, from an Asian and Quartodecimanist environment, let it be understood that wine is used in the Christian Easter, cf. Mel. *pass.,* 80 (SCh 123. 104–106).

1304 Cf. A. Harnack, *Brot und Wasser. Die eucharistische Elemente bei Justin,* Leipzig 1891, 117–144.

1305 Cf. B. Lohse, *Das Passafest der Quartadecimaner,* 84–89; cf. R. Cacitti, *Grande Sabato,* 65. Certainly in Clement, allusion is made to the replacement of wine by water, cf. Clem., *str.,* 1, 19 (SCh 30, 117–121). Epiphanius appears to associate this type of rite with the Quartodecimanist Easter and how it is celebrated in the Ebionitic environment, cf. Epiph. *haer.,* 30, 16, 1.

1306 Cf. A. Stewart-Sykes, *The Life of Polycarp,* 80.

1307 On the specific theme of the Grand Shabbat, the monography by R. Cacitti is that which has studied most thoroughly this detail in the martyrial texts, especially those concerning Smyrna. His research concludes that the interpretation of the "Grand Shabbat" must necessarily take into account the "hagiographical coordinates" present in the texts and sustain them. Accordingly, the Grand Shabbat should not be taken as a mere chronological indication. R. Cacitti concludes that the Grand Shabbat of the Smyrnaean hagiographic cycle synthetically expresses the faith of a Christian community which, in the martyrdom of its own priests, relives, at the culmination of a Judaeo-Christian spiritual tradition, the Easter of the Lord. This through the Passion establishes the model of martyrdom, through the resurrection it associates the martyr with the ultimate reality, making him co-protagonist with Christ in the Parousia of the Kingdom, on the Grand Shabbat, cf. R. Cacitti, *Grande Sabato,* 155–157.

R. Cacitti's thesis offers an interesting though not necessarily definitive key for reading the *Martyrium of Polycarp* and the *Martyrium of Pionius* with regard to the term Μεγάλῳ σαββάτῳ and its relationship with Easter and the Eucharist in the Church of Smyrna. For other theses on the term Grand Shabbat, Cf. p. 135, note 114.

Finally, as far as the *Life of Polycarp* is concerned, it contains various allusions to offerings and rites of Christian meals, some of which may indeed be references to the Eucharist[1308].

In the abrupt opening of the *Life of Polycarp* II, 3, it appears that Paul in his supposed meeting with the community of Smyrna, reminds it of the "offering of the New Testament" which is the "bread and the cup (ἄρτου καὶ ποτηρίου)" and immediately relates this up with the celebration of Easter which must take place "on the days of unleavened bread, but maintaining the new mystery of the passion and the resurrection". Accordingly, the Easter feast is understood in eucharistic terms and the Eucharist defined it as paschal. We likewise find a similar line of thought in the anonymous Asiatic homily of the third century, *In Sanctum Pascha,* where Easter is defined as at one and the same time a holy feast and a spiritual banquet[1309]. This abrupt beginning of the *Life of Polycarp,* which as we remarked probably dates from the fourth century, indicates in some way a further development of some Asiatic circles regarding the understanding of the Easter feast probably influenced by the disciplinary decisions taken in the Council of Nicaea.

Another allusion to the Eucharist is to be found in the context of Polycarp's ordination as a bishop. This takes place over Saturday and the day of the Lord, encompassisng "suitable exhortations and consolations, as well as offerings and actions of grace (προσφορὰς καὶ εὐχαριστίας), filled with rejoicing, and afterwards partaking of the food"[1310]. The text which summarises the happenings of those days appears to distinguish the activities carried out on Saturday (exhortations and consolations) from those on the day of the Lord (offerings, actions of grace, and the partaking of food).

In fact, the *Life of Polycarp* makes various allusions to meetings of the community on a Saturday"[1311]. It should be noted that in this text, the purpose of

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1308 There are two allusions in the *Life of Polycarp,* which certainly appear to refer more to an agape and not properly to the Eucharist. The first reference is found in Polycarp's supposed visit to the house of Daphnus where the latter, out of gratitude to the bishop of Smyrna for a previous miracle in which he had put an end to a famine, makes his guest an offering (προσφορὰν ἐποίησεν) in the presence of many brethren. The host placed in their midst a pitcher of wine and called on the servants to bring in even more wine to fill it up, cf. *V. Polyc.,* 26. The second reference comes a little further on, where returning to the city he meets a widow who offers him a little bird (ὀρνίθιον), cf. *V. Polyc.,* 27, 2.

1309 Cf. *In Sanctum Pascha,* 8 and 49.

1310 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 23, 7.

1311 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 22, 23, 24.

these meetings are the reading of the Scripture and exhortation, and that this day is differentiated from the day of the Lord. In the *Apostolic Constitutions* of the fourth century, Saturday is defined as a day in which the bishop has to encourage in the faith and as a space for meditation on the Law, however making the distinction between Saturday and the day of the Lord[1312]. So that, the use of the Saturday in the *Life of Polycarp* appears close to the description in the *Apostolic Constitutions,* that is, a day for study and familiarisation with the Scripture[1313]. Accordingly, it seems clear that on the occasion of Polycarp's ordination as bishop, the offerings, actions of grace, and partaking of the food actually took place only on the day of the Lord.

And lastly, we find that on the death of Bucolus, supposed predecessor of Polycarp according to the *Life*, after carrying out the rites of his burial, those present offered bread (προσέφερον ἄρτον) for him and the other dead. The author narrates that it was unanimously felt that Polycarp should be the one to make the offering (προσενεγκεῖν)[1314]. This offering takes its place in the context of the banquets held by Christians in the early centuries beside the tombs of martyrs, at the time of their burial or on their anniversary, a custom which may have been extended to other Christians who were not martyrs. Bucolus, according to what the *Life* says, is not a martyr proper; however, he is buried beside the resting place of the martyr Strataeas. The unanimous request for Polycarp to make the offering for (ὑπέρ) Bucolus and the other dead, and Polycarp's attempt to decline to do so, might indicate that such a gesture could be understood as an implicit proclamation of his succession to the dead bishop. However, this banquet need not necessarily be understood as a Eucharist but as an agape.

In conclusion, the theology of the Church of Smyrna on the Eucharist is based on the one hand, on an abundanat doctrine left by Ignatius regarding the Eucharist, above all, though not exclusively, in its dimension of banquet of ecclesial

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1312 Cf. *Const. App.,* 2, 36. 59.

1313 However, W. Rordorf states that it is not possible to prove a direct relationship between these Christian celebrations on Saturdays and the Judaeo-Christian practice, cf. W. Rordorf, *Der Sonntag. Geschichte des Ruhe – und Gottesdienstages im ältesten Christentum,* in *Abhandlung zur Theologie des Alten und Neuen Testaments 43,* Zurich 1962, 142–153. For their part, R. Kraft and A. Stewart-Sykes maintain that this practice is in fact very ancient and considerably influenced by Asiatic Judaeo-Christianity prior to Nicaea. Cf. R. Kraft, *Some Notes on Sabbath Observance in Early Christianity,* in Andrews University Seminary Series 3 (1965), 18–33; cf. A. *Stewart-Sykes, The Life of Polycarp,* 58.

1314 Cf. *V. Polyc.,* 20, 4.

unity around the altar (Christ) and the bishop, where the breaking of the bread, which is the flesh of the Saviour, is in its turn the sacrament of charity in which all the members of the community, orphans, widows, prisoners, freemen, the hungry, and thirsty all take their place.

Then also, this dimension of banquet comes in turn to be complemented by the dimension of the Eucharist as sacrifice of Christ. This sacrificial dimension of the Eucharist, already present in Ignatius too, is greatly reinforced in the context of the celebration of the Asiatic Quartodecimanist Easter, which above all, though not only, insists on the commemoration of the passion of Our Lord (πάσχειν/*passio*) by means of which believers in Christ are set free[1315], making it possible for them to pass from death to life[1316].

Finally, another dimension of the Eucharist is that of memorial. In fact, with the martyrdom of Polycarp, the Easter of the Lord is celebrated and updated in the martyr's sacrifice. Just as the Eucharist is the updating of the actual immolation of the Lord (*memoria passionis eius*), the historic immolation of the martyr is commemorated by the faithful of Smyrna as participation in the paschal mystery of that same Christ. Although in the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* veneration of the martyr is only an act of affection and homage, the memory and celebration of his martyrdom evokes the Lord's passion in a profound way.

Accordinglly, in the gradual development of the history and theology of the community the linking of the Eucharist with the Easter celebration and with the cult of its martyrs appears to have drawn progressively closer.

4. Conclusion

Ignatius' visit and the doctrinal heritage of his letters marked a fundamental milestone in the conception of Church which gradually developed in the community of Smyrna. Its preoccupation for the unity of the community both at a doctrinal and at a sacramental level, renders insistent its call for a necessary ecclesial structure under the guidance of the bishop. The letters of Ignatius, which appear impregnated with the harmonious spirit of the Second Sophistic, seek the unity of the social order of the Catholic Church based on sound theological principles, in a religious and cultual language liable to foster such unity and harmony, and in concrete actions such as the sending out of ambassadors to ensure concord in the communities.

1315 Cf. Iren., *Dem.,* 25.

1316 Ignatius himself in his letter to the Church of Smyrna says that Christ's Passion is our resurrection, cf. Ign., *Smyrn.,* 5, 3.

For his part, Polycarp, having a different personality from that of Ignatius, in his letter to the Church of Philippi reveals the serene and balanced approach with which he directs his own Church. Irenaeus also informs us of Polycarp's conduct in Rome when dealing with the theme of Easter, when despite the lack of agreement with the bishop of that city, both succeeded in safeguarding the communion of the churches.

The federative structure of the Church which gradually develops means that the community resident in Ephesus takes over the leadership of the churches of Asia at the end of the second century. However the rivalry between the community of Smyrna and the community living in the provincial capital, similar to their rivalry in the civic sphere, is highlighted by the way in which each of them seeks to impose on the other the strength of its spiritual tradition and the history of its Christian leaders. Even so, the varied series of relations that the Church of Smyrna deploys with various Christian communities such as Philippi, Antioch, Rome, Philomelium, Gaul and Ephesus, points to the interaction and exchange of ecclesial experiences which undoubteldy influenced the formation of its history and its ecclesial identity.

The consolidation during the third and fourth centuries of the institution of the episcopacy, as point of arrival in a career coveted for its administrative power and social distinction, may be found reflected in the Church of Smyrna in a special way with the *Life of Polycarp.* Here, we likewise find interesting descriptions of the election and consecration of the deacon and the bishop in the community.

As regards the doctrine on penance, Ignatius and Polycarp show themselves more understanding of the moral shortcomings of the Smyrnaean Christians than of the doctrinal deviations of certain of them. Besides which, towards the middle of the third century in Smyrna, reflection around the problem of the *lapsi* is especially animated because of the opportunistic proselytism of the Jews. Furthermore, with a view to establishing different types of penance, the *Martyrdom of Pionius* makes a distinction between those Christians who have abjured by dint of force, need, or of their own will. The figure of the *confessor,* represented by Pionius in prison, does not overlay the reflection and institutionality of the community based on the charismatic leader who decides on absolution of the *lapsi,* but on the contrary, he is presented first and foremost as a kind master who gives encouragment to the *lapsi,* entrusting them to God's mercy, but above all, is capable of teaching his own people a refined doctrine when facing persecutors and the Jewish proselytism.

Finally, the Ignatian doctrine regarding the Eucharist as banquet of unity and true flesh of the Saviour, undoubtedly enriched the doctrine and eucharistic practice of the community of Smyrna. Apart from this, the Eucharist in its sacrificial

dimension, as a commemoration of the Lord's passion, is developed especially in the context of the celebration of the Asiatic Quartodecimanist Easter. And lastly, the Eucharist as memorial which sees the updating of the paschal mystery of the Lord, illumines the interpretation, memory, and celebration of the martyrdom of Polycarp. Although in the *Martyrdom of Polycarp,* veneration of the martyr is merely an act of affection and homage, the remembrance and celebration of his martyrdom evokes in depth the Lord's Passion.

Conclusion

At the beginning of this third part, we set ourselves the task of determining in a first chapter the reception and interpretation of the Hebrew Scriptures in the Church of Smyrna throughout the second century. Also, in the second, third and fourth chapters, we proposed to determine on the basis of an analysis of the reception of the apostolic traditions in Smyrna, what Christian documents this Christian community possessed concretely in the first half of the second century, and whether these documents served as referential sources for the community provided with singular authority. Likewise, we proposed to determine if a greater presence of one apostolic tradition than of another can be identified in the sources studied. For this study we took the second-century documentation on the Church of Smyrna as source of our analysis. Finally, in the fifth and sixth chapters, we decided to study the confession of faith of the Church of Smyrna and the sacramental theology of the community, this time bearing in mind all the sources that concern the Church of Smyrna up to the Council of Nicaea.

In the first place, we noted that despite the few allusions to the Old Testament in the texts of the Church of Smyrna in the first half of the second century, the Church of Smyrna, like various Christian communities during the second century, after an initial reticence, ended up by accepting the validity of the Hebrew Scriptures.

To quote loosely, the custom of Polycarp in his letter *To the Philippians,* shows that he usually quoted from memory, we may find specific quotations but consisting of short expressions; however, in general the tendency is towards a free quotation. He puts together, omits, superposes and alters the order of agreement for his own purposes. Polycarp is the writer in the first half of the second century who quotes or alludes most to books of the future canon of the New Testament. We may state with certainty that he made use of *Romans, 1 Corinthians, Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, 1 Timothy* and *1 Peter;* that probably he made use of *Matthew, 2 Corinthians, 2 Timothy* and *1 John;* and possibly may have made allusion to *Luke, Acts of the Apostles* and *2 Thessalonians.* So that he used at least eleven New Testament compositions. Considering the unity and early dating of the letter of Polycarp, the witness he gives us on writings which will come to form part of the New Testament canon is invaluable. For example, it is the first time that use is clearly made of *Galatians, Philippians, 1 Timothy,* and *1 Peter*; the first time that we find probable evidence of the use of *2 Timothy* or of *1 John*, and perhaps also of *Acts of the Apostles.* If we consider that Polycarp's letter was written

in about 135, the theory that the composition of the *Pastoral epistles* dates from no later than 130 falls by the way[1317], and also that the letters of John were written after those of Ignatius[1318]. Polycarp's letter *To the Philippians* establishes an external *terminus ante quem* for the composition of *1 Peter, 1 Timothy, 2 Timothy, 1 John* and possibly the *Acts of the Apostles.* So that as regards Polycarp, the most outstanding figure of the Church of Smyrna in the second century, we may conclude that he is a witness of first order on the acceptation and use of the books which will subsequently constitute the canon of the New Testament.

For the rest, Polycarp, by making very frequent use of quotations from New Testament writings in which he tries to find a solution to the conflict of the community of Philippi, clearly shows that, both for himself and for the recipients, these Christian writings are sources of authority, to the point that it is not necessary to quote passages from the Old Testament. This fact is of importance because, although we cannot affirm that Polycarp already has an idea of "canon" referred to the New Testament writings, he sees in them a normative authority coming moreover from the Apostles themselves. Now, the Christian texts to which Polycarp ascribes this authority are not only texts of the future canon of the New Testament, since he confers the same degree of authority on *1 Clement*, as is shown by his frequent quotation from it, as also on the letters of Ignatius, affirming that great benefit may be gained from them since they enclose faith, patience and every edification relating to Our Lord"[1319].

In second place, we note that the Church of Smyrna played an important part in the reception of the Pauline tradition and especially in the formation of a collection of Pauline letters[1320], and in the same way in which that community copied and disseminated the *corpus Ignatianum,* it may also have copied and disseminated at least part of a *corpus Paulinum* in an Asiatic environment apparently reluctant to the Pauline tradition in the second century. Certainty regarding use of the doctrine and authority of Paul in personages linked with the Church of Smyrna, especially Polycarp, and the active work of copyists of this

1317 W. Bauer is of the opinion that the *Pastoral epistles* did not exist when Marcion took the decision to revise the Pauline material, cf. W. Bauer, *Orthodoxy and Heresy in Earliest Christianity*, 223.

1318 Cf. S. Johnson, *Asia Minor and Early Christianity*, in *Christianity, Judaism and Other Greco-Roman Cults: Studies for Morton Smith at Sixty*, ed. J. Neusner, Leyden 1975, 115. R. Brown recognises the use of the letters of John in the work of Polycarp, cf. R. Brown, *The Epistles of John,* Garden City 1982, 9.

1319 Cf. Polyc., *ep.,* 13, 2.

1320 P. Hartog, *Polycarp and the New Testament,* 232.

community are without comparison in the Asiatic reality of the first decades of the second century, where the Johannine tradition appeared to be that most favourably accepted.

As regards the reception of the Synoptic Gospels in Smyrna, the omnipresence of the Gospel of *Matthew* is apparent, although this is quoted very freely and not verbatim, far more frequently then any possible allusions to *Luke* and the very rare allusions made to *Mark.* Although nowhere is the personal authority of *Matthew* reported, we may safely say that the Church of Smyrna, as many other communities in the second century, came to know the words and acts of Christ through the Gospel which bears his name.

As far as reception of the Johannine tradition is concerned, it appears clear that Smyrna, from the end of the first century onwards, identified itself with the theological and disciplinary postulates of John, as noted in the letter addressed to this Church in the *Revelation.* Although in the letter of Polycarp *To the Philippians,* the Gospel of *John* or the *Revelation* are apparently not quoted, Johannine theology appears in the letters that Ignatius wrote from Smyrna, emerging with particular force in the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* and in the Quartodecimanist practice of Easter that that Church celebrated and defended including in Rome and on behalf of all the churches of Asia. The news given by Irenaeus regarding the disciple-master relationship between Polycarp and John, and the news of Polycrates who situates Polycarp among the luminaries of Asia in a list of Johannine tradition, are not belied by any ancient document,[1321] but on the contrary are accepted by subsequent tradition.

In third place, as far as the *depositum fidei* of the community of Smyrna is concerned, we have seen the use of symbols of faith in catechetical and liturgical contexts as also in contexts of persecution and controversy in the face of pagans, Jews, and heretics. In a special way, in the earliest hours of the Church of Smyrna, the great doctrinal danger against which the sources studied gave warning is above all Docetism. Apart from this, certain members of the community seemed to not totally recognise the figure of the bishop or the hierarchical order on three levels. However, with the gradual consolidation of the *lex orandi,* a doctrine of faith develops which is binding on the members of the community, while the institution of the episcopate is progressively consolidated. Besides, in the second half of the second century and throughout the third, we find in the sources

1321 Apart from the *Life of Polycarp* which does so implicitly and in a clearly tendential way at the end of the third century or beginning of the fourth, as we pointed out earlier, cf. pp. 24 et seqq.

studied traces of the doctrinal controversies with Marcionism and with the New Prophecy movement, as also the explicit rejection by the community of Smyrna of the Patripasian doctrine of Noetus.

Fourthly, as regards the sacramental life of the community, we may affirm that Ignatius' visit and the doctrinal heritage of his letters were fundamental in the conception of the Church and the sacraments, especially the Eucharist, which gradually developed in the community of Smyrna. Apart from this, Polycarp's serene and balanced attitude marked the way in which he led his Church for a large part of the second century. Thus, the Church of Smyrna gradually came to identify itself precisely as the Catholic Church, interacting actively with other Christian communities (Antioch, Philippi, Ephesus, Philomelium, Rome, Gaul, etc.) within the federative organisation which characterised the Church in the second and third centuries.

Moreover, towards the middle of the third century, reflection around the problem of the *lapsi* in Smyrna was especially animated, among other things, because of the opportunistic proselytism of the Jews. In the same way, the figure of Pionius who serves as *confessor* when the Christians come to visit him in prison, is presented above all as that of a benevolent master who declines to arrogate to himself the power of forgiveness and readmission of the *lapsi* without regard for the reflection and institutionality of the community, but who on the contrary, giving them encouragement and entrusting them to God's mercy, teaches the Christians of Smyrna a refined doctrine when facing persecution and Jewish proselytism.

And lastly, to the doctrine of Ignatius regarding the Eucharist as banquet of unity and true flesh of the Saviour in which all the members of the community take part, is added the sacrificial dimension of the Eucharist, as commemoration of the passion of the Lord within the context of celebration of the Asiatic Quartodecimanist Easter. Finally, the Eucharist as memorial by means of which the paschal mystery of the Lord is updated, illumines the veneration for the martyr Polycarp, while he in turn evokes the passion of Our Lord in a profound way. So that, in the gradual development of the history and theology of the community, the linking of the Eucharist with the Easter celebration and with the cult of its martyrs appears to have come progressively closer.

General Conclusions

On completing our study on the Church of Smyrna from its foundation up to the Council of Nicaea, we may arrive at the following conclusions.

In the first part, as regards the quantity and importance of the documentation necessary to reconstruct the history of the community, we may state that in general, on the community of Smyrna in the early centuries of Christianity, we possess a sufficient number of direct and indirect testimonies which enable us to reconstruct to a large extent the historical and theological development of this local reality. However, the scarcity of documentation regarding the end of the third century and the beginning of the fourth makes it difficult to study this last period. We are unacquainted with the environment of the community immediately prior to the Council of Nicaea, we only know that there this Church was represented by its bishop Eutychius. Some lights on this detail may be thrown by the *Life of Polycarp;* however, as we have repeated on various occasions in the course of this research, this is a source difficult to appraise and only a couple of commentaries on it exist. We believe that this doctoral thesis opens up the need for new and more in-depth studies on this document in particular.

The letter to the Church of Smyrna in the *Revelation* is the first direct source on the history of the Christian community of this city towards the end of the first century or beginning of the second. Thereafter, Polycarp's letter *To the Philippians,* the letters of Ignatius to the community and to the bishop of Smyrna, and the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* offer an internal coherence which makes them a reliable instrument for a historical and theological reconstruction of the community of Smyrna during the beginning and middle of the second century. Equally valuable are all the testimonies of Irenaeus and of Polycrates as representatives of the generation following Polycarp at the end of the second century. For its part, the *Against Noetus* by Hippolytus, above all in its first part, gives us abundant information on the doctrinal and ecclesial conflict which arose in the community at the end of the second century and beginning of the third. The *Martyrdom of Pionius* is an important document which bears witness to the activity of the Church of Smyrna in the midst of the persecution of the middle and end of the third century. The *Index Patrum Nicaenorum*, while concise in the information provided, proves fundamental for establishing that the community of Smyrna, at least up to the Council of Nicaea in 325, counted on a visible head in the person of Eutychius. As for the *Life of Polycarp* and the *Fragments on Polycarp,* despite mixtures of reality and legend, its fragmentary nature or its final version, possibly

subsequent to the Council of Nicaea, these sources allow us to reconstruct in part the hagiographical tradition and another series of features of the community of Smyrna during the whole of the third century and the beginning of the fourth.

As for the indirect sources, their value is very considerable. Of especial value are the other letters of the *corpus Ignatianum* as well as the writings of Aelius Aristides. These last prove invaluable for a historical and cultural reconstruction of the pagan environment in which the Christian community of Smyrna developed during the second century. Apart from that, in the course of our study we indicated other documents which throw important lights on the Asiatic environment in which the community was unfolding. Suffice it to point to the writings around the apostle John, the *corpus Paulinum,* the *Pastoral epistles*, the homilies of Melito of Sardis, the testimony of Papias of Hierapolis, the work of Justin, and the testimonies of Tertullian and Eusebius, among others.

Moreover, we have been very cautious in accepting the theses of C. Hill on the *teaching of the presbyter* and the *catalogue of heresies* transmitted by Irenaeus in *Against Heresies,* reserving even greater scepticism to his thesis on the epistle *To Diognetus.* Lastly, as regards the attempt or attempts made by members of the Church of Smyrna to collect works around the figure of Polycarp, also known as the *corpus Polycarpianum,* we consider that such an effort was highly probable, although the texts do not contain all the necessary elements for determining its history with greater exactitude.

In the second part, as regards the historical and social reconstruction of the cultural environment in which the Church of Smyrna developed, the consolidation of its leaders, and its relationship with surrounding paganism and Judaism, we may conclude as follows. The region of Asia, and Smyrna in particular, enjoyed a multicultural environment which profoundly influenced the reality of the Christians. The region was permeated by a Greek culture and surrounded by great pagan sanctuaries which enable us to perceive the opening of the population to the divine mystery, as also the difficulties of a monotheistic confession like that of Christianity in finding a space for itself in the midst of this religious market.

The western cities of Asia Minor represented the image of prosperity of the Roman Empire while at the same time they were its strategic crossroads in its contact with the whole of the East. The second century was a period of economic prosperity accompanied by a vibrant cultural activity encouraged by the literary movement of the Second Sophistic, sensitising especially the higher classes in the area. Smyrna, with Aelius Aristides at its head, acted as the epicentre of this cultural conjuncture. The quantity and quality of Christian literature, born and copied in Smyrna, in this context, is an indication that the Christians were no strangers to this favourable environment of economic and cultural well-being.

For the rest, the cities of the region were grateful for the political goodwill of Rome and its emperors, feeling themselves obliged to respond with the imperial cult and with the empire of Roman law in their lands. So that the Christian community, rejecting the imperial cult and being indifferent to pagan worship, found itself gradually immersed in an ever greater persecution amid the general disapproval of the pagan population. In addition, the strong presence of Judaism in Asia, which played an important role for the self-understanding of Christianity itself, in times of persecution, showed even more clearly its adversity towards the new religion. In particular, the sources record persecutions of the Christians of Smyrna at the time of Domitian, of Antoninus Pius, and of Decius, although we cannot exclude that the community may have experienced other moments of grave difficulty from this point of view, above all at the end of the third century.

At an internal level, the community suffered a powerful reverse as a result of the schism and heresy embodied in the figure of Noetus at the end of the second century and of the scandal at the apostasy of its bishop Euctemon in the year 250. Nevertheless, the Christian community proved resolute in the faith received, felt proud of its apostolic origins, and gave important testimonies of courage in the midst of the persecutions. By means of its literature, it worked out its options and stood up to the attacks by its pagan and Jewish adversaries.

It is probable that the community had been founded in the shadow of the three years of Paul's preaching in Asia; however, we only possess one certain fact, and that is the existence of Christians in Smyrna towards the end of the first century in the shadow of the authority of the seer of the *Revelation.* Smyrna is the only community together with Philadelphia which does not receive a reproach from the prophet, who on the contrary praises its spiritual wealth, encourages it in suffering, and promises it the crown of life. In this letter, the community of Smyrna appears to be identified with the *forma mentis* of the author of the *Revelation.* That is to say, a community which felt itself surrounded by a hostile world, consisting of Judaising Christians who felt on the one hand some of the laceration from their Jewish community of origin and on the other accepted as referent of their Christian faith the authority of John, being also reticent to the practices of a radical Paulinism.

In the same way, a special influence on the development of the community must have been exerted by the visit at the beginning of the second century by Ignatius of Antioch, and also the prolonged episcopacy of the martyr Polycarp thanks to which the Church achieved a clear leadership in the Christian communities of Asia by the middle of the second century and consolidated its hierarchical structure headed by the bishop.

In addition to Polycarp and his courageous testimony in the face of persecution, the Church of Smyrna built up its identity in the second half of the second century with other distinguished leaders including especially the figures of Evaristus, Marcion and Irenaeus. During the third century, following the ecclesial crisis unleashed by Noetus between the second and third centuries, and despite the scandal caused by the apostasy of bishop Euctemon in the middle of the third century, the community found new spiritual leaders and referents in the presbyter Limnus, Sabina, Asclepiades and Pionius, martyred presbyter and master. Towards the end of the third century, a certain Dioscorides probably suffered martyrdom, and certainly Eutychius was the bishop of Smyrna who represented the community at the Council of Nicaea.

In the third part, in which we have studied certain theological and ecclesial aspects, we have noted that the identity of the Christian community of Smyrna was not forged merely on the basis of casual political, social or religious factors, but in addition and above all by the very nature of the Christian faith which gradually developed as time went on. The confessions of faith that we find already in the New Testament and thereafter in the Church of Smyrna, and which were issued in mainly liturgical contexts, at times as symbols of faith, and the continuous appeals to the authority of the Apostles and their direct disciples are what gradually configure the *depositum fidei* of the Christian community[1322]. This sum total of doctrinal concepts considered immutable and binding, targeted at defining the Christian faith as regards concrete doctrinal deviations, is what we know as the *regula fidei*[1323]. This *regula fidei* is what enables the Church of Smyrna to discern, opt, resist, and celebrate each one of the conjunctures arising throughout its history.

1322 Cf. P. Grech, *Cristianesimo o cristianesimi? Il caso del vangelo di Giuda,* in *Pontificia Accademia Theologica* 6, 2 (2007/2), 521.

1323 This technical expression *regula fidei* or *regula veritatis* coined by Irenaeus and other authors such as Tertullian and Clement of Alexandria, among others, is no abstract concept but effective formulas for every circumstance in which the Orthodox Christian faith takes a firm position on fundamental concepts considered as immutable to distance itself from concrete doctrinal deviations such as Gnosticism, Marcionism, Docetism, Patripasianism, etc. The *regula fidei* is not only a formulary or a symbol of faith, although very often the symbol of faith is the principal expression of the *regula fidei.* To date the study by D. van de Eyne on the *regula fidei* is insuperable, cf. D. van den Eynde, *Les Normes de l'Enseignement Chrétien*, 281–313; cf. P. Grech, *The* Regula fidei *as Hermeneutical Principle, Yesterday and Today*, *in Il Messaggio biblico e la sua interpretazione,* 145–161.

This *regula fidei* was what ultimately permitted the Church to accept and venerate the Old Testament. Despite the few allusions to the Old Testament in the texts of the Church of Smyrna in the first half of the second century, from the testimonies of Irenaeus, we may affirm that from the hand of its bishop Polycarp, the Church of Smyrna, like various Christian communities during the second century, following an initial reticence, ended up by accepting the validity of the Old Testament.

The *regula fidei* defended the institution of the episcopate which vindicated for itself the teachings of the Apostles and which guaranteed the unity of the community itself rendered visible in a hierarchical structure which gradually came to consist of the bishop, the presbyters, and the deacons. As a result of Ignatius' visit and the episcopacy of Polycarp, the Church of Smyrna underwent an important process of consolidation in its ecclesial doctrine and in the role of the ministers of the community. The serene and balanced outlook of Polycarp appeared to be the way in which he guided pastorally his Church for a large part of the second century.

The *regula fidei* permitted the conception of Catholic Church not only in its geographic but also its doctrinal universality. Thus, gradually the Church of Smyrna came to identify itself as part of a wider community interacting actively with other Christian communities (Antioch, Philippi, Ephesus, Philomelium, Rome, Gaul, etc.) within the federative organisation which characterised the Church in the second and third centuries.

This *regula fidei* permitted the reception and co-existence in the Church of Smyrna of both the Pauline and the Johannine traditions, as well as the other New Testament writings, fostering the universality of the Christian message against the biases of the Marcionites. The Church of Smyrna played an important role in the reception of the Pauline tradition, and in the same way in which that community copied and spread the *corpus Ignatianum,* it was also able to copy and spread at least part of a collection of Pauline letters in an Asiatic environment apparently reluctant to the Pauline tradition in the second century. Certainty regarding the use of the doctrine and authority of Paul by personages linked with the Church of Smyrna, especially Polycarp, and the active work of its scribes, are incomparable in the Asiatic reality of the first decades of the second century, where the Johannine tradition appeared to be that most favourably received.

As regards the reception of the Johannine tradition, it is clear that as from the end of the first century, Smyrna identified itself with the theological and disciplinary postulates of John, as we note in the letter addressed to this Church in the *Revelation.* Johannine theology appears in the letters which Ignatius wrote from Smyrna, and emerged with particular force in the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* and

in the Quartodecimanist practice of Easter which that Church celebrated and defended, including in Rome on behalf of all the churches of Asia.

The *regula fidei* continued to appeal to the authority of the Apostles and their direct disciples, thus creating a *depositum fidei* to be transmitted publicly to subsequent generations. In fact, Polycarp, in his letter *To the Philippians,* is the writer of the first half of the second century who quotes or alludes most to books of the future New Testament canon. We may say with certainty that he made use of the letters of Paul and other apostolic writings. Polycarp quotes from *Romans, 1 Corinthians, Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians* and *1 Peter;* that he probably made use of *Matthew, 2 Corinthians, 2 Timothy* and *1 John;* and possibly alluded to *Luke, Acts of the Apostles* and *2 Thessalonians*. The use made by Polycarp of these documents in which he attempts to solve the conflict of the community of Philippi, clearly shows that, both for himself and for his recipients, these Christian writings of public divulgation are a source of normative authority, moreover coming from the Apostles themselves, above all Peter and Paul. Polycarp practically confers this same degree of authority on the letters of Ignatius and on *1 Clement,* as is shown by the frequent quotation and appreciation he makes of them. Moreover, the news by Irenaeus concerning the disciple-master relationship between Polycarp and John, and the news given by Polycrates who places Polycarp among the luminaries of Asia in a list of Johannine tradition, are reports not contested by any ancient document, but on the contrary accepted by subsequent tradition.

In the second half of the second century and throughout the third century, the *regula fidei* enabled an ever clearer distinction to be made between the apostolic doctrine received, which became progressively binding, and heterodox tendencies. In fact, in the sources studied, we find traces of the doctrinal controversies against Marcionism and against the New Prophecy movement, together with the explicit rejection by the presbyters of Smyrna of the Patripasian doctrine of Noetus. On the contrary, as regards the documentation at our disposal, the Gnostic crisis appears to have had less effect on the Christian communities of Asia Minor than elsewhere. We only find one writing originating from this region entitled *Preaching of the Naassenes,* which presents the fundamental Gnostic concept of the divine seed fallen on the material earth with a powerful syncretism of Christian, Jewish, and pagan elements, the last of which especially, of Asiatic origin; likewise, we find a strong anti-Gnostic tendency in the *Epistle of the Apostles,* an apochryphal document which tends to be situated in the second half of the second century. However, as far as the specific documentation of the Church of Smyrna is concerned, none of the sources give signs of a controversy clearly aimed at Gnosticism. For its part, the profession of faith of the presbyters of Smyrna is a fundamental text on the doctrinal development of the community of Smyrna, constituting as it does a binding,

normative, and concrete point of arrival in its brief postulates, aimed at making a clear distinction between the orthodox faith and Gnostic, Marcionite, Docetist and Patripasian doctrinal deviations.

The confession of faith in a single God, apart from the generically antipagan approach, is without doubt a declaration against the fundamental Gnostic and Marcionite concept of the distinction between the inferior god of the Jews, defender of justice and creator of the world, and the supreme and good God, the unknown God that only Christ had revealed to those who believed in Him. In their turn, the presbyters of Smyrna in their profession of faith, distinguishing God from Christ, specify that the latter is he who respects his incarnation, thus rejecting the affirmation of Noetus that God the Father had incarnated himself in Christ. Finally, the true suffering, death, and resurrection of the Lord, once more underlines Christ's true humanity in the face of Docetism, already combated earlier by Ignatius and Polycarp.

The *regula fidei* achieved a balance between prophecy and the institutional offices, between a rigorous morality and openness to forgiveness, and to God's mercy. Apart from the anti-Montanist literary activity of the third or fourth centuries in Smyrna with writings like the *Martyrdom of Pionius* and the *Life of Polycarp,* a good example of this equilibrium is the figure of Pionius who acts as *confessor* when the Christians come to visit him in prison, during the persecution of Decius. His figure is presented above all as that of a kind master who does not arrogate to himself the power of forgiveness and re-admission of the *lapsi* overlooking the reflection and instutionality of the community, but who on the contrary, by giving them encouragement and entrusting them to God's mercy, teaches the Christians of Smyrna a refined doctrine when faced with persecutors and with Jewish proselytism.

The *regula fidei* also gave rise to dialogue at the service of the Christian revelation with Philosophy and Greek culture, encountering a defence against fundamentalism and against fantastic or mythological speculations. In fact, the letters of Ignatius are an example of the interaction of Christian authors with the cultural movement of the Second Sophistic. Resuming the concept of concord (ὁμόνοια) which sought to characterise social and political relations between the cities of Asia Minor in the second century, Ignatius insistently urged unity (ἕνωσις and ἑνότης) of the social order of the Church based on sound theological principles, in a religious and cultural language which would encourage such harmony offering various images for the communion of Christians among themselves and with their bishop: the lyre, chords, intonation, concert, and symphony. Another example of this interaction of Christianity with the Greek culture in Smyrna is the *Life of Polycarp,* which bears witness to the adoption by the Christians of a

genre of intellectual biography following the model of the Greek philosophers towards the end of the third century or the beginning of the fourth.

Martyrdom too is the fruit of the *regula fidei*. Martyrdom is a confession of the historicity of Jesus and of the Church. The community of Smyrna practically built up its identity thanks to its martyrs Polycarp and Pionius. The fight against Docetism taken up by Ignatius and Polycarp in their letters, is backed up by the courage of the various members of the community of Smyrna in the face of persecution, and by the commemoration and affectionate veneration they offer to their martyrs.

The need for prayer, for a sacramental system, and for a *lex orandi* and a *lex credendi* which explain each other are likewise fruit of the *regula fidei*. The Eucharist in the community of Smyrna from the times of Ignatius onwards is celebrated as a banquet of unity around the altar (Christ) and the bishop, and is the sacrament of charity in which all the members of the community, orphans, widows, the poor, prisoners, freemen, the hungry, and the thirsty have their place. In its turn, the sacrificial dimension of the Eucharist, already present in Ignatius too, is considerably reinforced in the context of celebration of the Quartodecimanist Easter which, above all though not exclusively, insists on commemoration of the Lord's passion (πάσχειν/*passio*) by means of which believers in Christ are set free, making it possible for them to pass from death to life. This passing from death to life especially celebrated in the baptismal liturgy is possibly accompanied by some of the symbols of faith of those we mentioned. Particularly meaningful texts for the Church of Smyrna must have been Polycarp's prayer before his martyrdom, which contains elements of an incipient eucharistic anaphora, and the profession of faith of the presbyters of Smyrna which undoubtedly possesses a symbol of faith in the celebration of baptism. Finally, the affectionate veneration of Polycarp's mortal remains are in some way the profound evocation of the very passion of Our Lord. So that, in the gradual development of the history and theology of the community, the connection of the Eucharist with the paschal celebration and with the cult of its martyrs would seem to have grown progresively closer.

In conclusion, it is clear that, over and above the social, political and cultural factors, there exists from the beginning of the foundation of the community of Smyrna, a Christian faith whose centripetal force guaranteed by the written, oral, and liturgical apostolic tradition, gradually forged the history and nature of this particular Church. The believers in Christ, of then as of today, attribute the performative capacity of this centripetal force to the guidance of the Holy Spirit in accordance with the words of Jesus: "I still have many things to say to you, but they would be too much for you now. But when the Spirit of truth comes, he will lead you to the complete truth (*Io* 16, 12–13)".

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